THE LONG SIEGE

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A Novel

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This is a work of historical fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are the products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or events is entirely coincidental.

Age rating: Mature / 18+. This novel contains graphic depictions of warfare and its aftermath, explicit sexual content, violence, and themes intended for adult readers.

Set in a fictional dominion amid the real courts and conflicts of late fifteenth-century Europe.

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CHAPTER ONE

The Ledger of the Dead

The bell at the lower gate was rung by someone who had forgotten its manners. It went on and on, clapper hammering at bronze without the measured cadence of a herald or a toll collector, and Jeanne came up out of sleep with the sound already in her bones, her hand finding the little knife under the pillow before her eyes were open. The fire in the bedchamber had burned to red caves of ash. Rain worked at the shutters. Somewhere in the Haut-Tertre a door opened and shut, opened and shut, and feet went past at the run.

She did not light a taper. She had slept in her linen shift, and she drew on the dark wool gown hanging at the bedpost, the one with no jewels at the collar, the gown for accounts and audiences of complaint. Her fingers did the laces without asking leave of her wits. Her wits were elsewhere, counting: the gate bell meant news from the south; news from the south in the third week of March could only be one kind of news; her father's army had been in the field nineteen days, and the last dispatch, four days old, had said nothing worth saying.

Lisette was already at the door, breathless, a cloak over her arm. "Riders," the maid said. "A dozen, maybe fewer. The marshal's been called, and the chancellor. My lady, the men on the wall say they're riding wounded horses."

Jeanne took the cloak. In the corridor, rushlights trembled in iron sconces and the stone sweated cold. Two guards fell in behind her with torches, their mail chinking. The grand stair turned down past the row of dead dukes carved in the wall, her grandfather among them with his lion's muzzle and his prayerful hands, and she made herself walk at the pace she had been taught: unhurried, visible, the pace of a person to whom haste is a privilege she cannot afford. She had practiced it behind her father's shoulder for ten years. She had never needed it at night, alone, with a bell screaming.

The lower courtyard was a mouth of rain and torchlight. The riders had come through the gate in a clatter that had woken the kitchens and the kennels and the mews, and now they sat their horses like sacks of wet gravel, or slid from them into the arms of grooms. There were eleven where there should have been thirty in a dispatch party. Their surcoats, the Vauréal red and silver, were black with mud and worse than mud. One man's arm was bound in a strip of someone's shirt, and the bandage had stopped being white. Another held his jaw as though he were afraid it would

come off in his hand. The horses hung their heads and steamed, and one had an arrow shaft snapped short in its neck.

Marshal Brive reached the courtyard ahead of her, his white hair sticking up from a nightcap, a cloak thrown over his nightshirt and a sword buckled over the cloak, the sword the one thing he had not forgotten. He had reached the foremost rider and taken him by the shoulder. At the sight of Jeanne on the steps, the old man's face did something it had never done in her memory. It crumpled, and then it rebuilt itself, and both were worse than the crumple.

"My lady," Brive said, and stopped.

The foremost rider got down. He was young, a household knight named Audemer, whom she remembered from the hunting field, clean and laughing and careful always to salute her before he leapt a ditch. He moved like an old man. His left hand was gone at the wrist, the stump dressed and dark, and he crossed the wet flagstones with his right fist pressed to his chest in a salute that cost him his balance.

"Duchess," he said.

No one had ever called her that. The word went through the courtyard like the bell's note through the wall.

She said, "Speak, Audemer."

"At the Roches-Noires, my lady. The nineteenth day of the month, before noon. The French had the pike and the guns where our scouts said there was pasture. My lord charged twice. The second charge went in. The guns were waiting in the carts. I saw him unhorsed. I saw the standard fall. By evening the field was theirs, and what was left of us was running for the fords." His voice had the flatness of a man reading an inventory. "I did not see him die. Three men who did are dead themselves, two on the road home. The Sire de Graçay had the body by sundown. His herald came to the ford under parley. They will give him up for the customary ransom, and the bishop's man has gone with the gold. My lady, the army is gone. The gendarmes are gone, the ordinance company is in pieces, and the French hold the south road."

Rain hissed in the torch flames. A groom was sick against the wall, neatly and quietly, as though politeness survived everything. Jeanne looked at the eleven men and the eleven horses and counted the living the way she counted everything, because counting was the door her mind shut behind itself when the cold came in. Eleven. Nineteen days. A duchy of six walled towns, three restive cities, a hundred and forty parishes, and no army between them and Paris.

"See to the men," she said to Brive. "The surgeons now, the kitchens after, and every horse in my own stables. Audemar, you will give your

account once more, in full, to the chancellor, and then you will sleep if you can. No one else is to speak of this outside the council chamber until I have spoken. On your homage."

Brive looked at her. "My lady, the household will know by dawn."

"The household will know by dawn what I choose to tell it," she said, "which is that my father is dead and his daughter holds the Haut-Tertre. Marshal. The watch is doubled, the gates sealed until first mass, and any man who leaves this courtyard with a rumor loses his tongue and his place, in that order."

It was the first sovereign sentence of her life, and it sounded passably like someone else's, which was all that could be asked. She went back up the stairs at the same pace, past the carved dead, and did not feel her feet on them.

* * *

The corpse came three hours before dawn, in a cart drawn by two oxen and escorted by a French herald under a safe-conduct sealed at the ford. By then the rain had stopped, and the sky over the Ortelle was the color of pewter. Jeanne received the cart in the upper courtyard, with Foulques on one side of her and Dame Oriabel on the other, and the household drawn up in two lines, everyone in

the darkest wool they owned, which in a court of mourning was not dark enough.

The herald was a Gascon with a careful face. He delivered himself of a speech about the honorable treatment of the fallen, which he had clearly made before, and a sealed letter from the Sire de Graçay, which he gave to Foulques and not to her, a small insolence she noted in the ledger she kept behind her eyes. Then the cart's canvas was drawn back.

They had washed him. That was the strangeness. The French had washed the body and closed the eyes and dressed it in a clean white shirt, perhaps because a ransomed corpse fetched its price better when it did not smell, perhaps because some clerk remembered chivalry. The face was not much damaged. A dead man's face, grey and waxen, the strong nose thinner than she remembered, the mouth set in the line it wore over bad accounts. There was a wound at the throat, dark and puckered, and the hands were broken in several places, which the shirt and the winding sheet concealed as far as the wrists.

Jeanne had not touched her father in affection since she was small enough to be lifted onto his saddle. She had touched his ring in homage twice a year, at New Year and at Michaelmas. She touched his hand now. It was as cold and firm as a stone hand in a church, and she kept hers over it

for the length of a Pater Noster, because the household was watching and the herald was watching and the dead man had taught her that everything done before witnesses was government.

"Take him to the chapel," she said. "The embalmers before sunrise. He will lie in state three days, and the requiem will be sung by the bishop himself, and I will pay for every Mass out of the privy purse rather than wait on the treasury. Herald, you will tell the Sire de Graçay that the Duchess of Vauréal acknowledges the return of her father's body and the manner of it. You may tell him also that I keep accounts of every kindness, and every other thing."

The Gascon bowed, less carelessly than he had arrived. The cart creaked toward the chapel door, where the canons were already mustering in their singing clothes, and the first plainchant rose into the raw morning, old and indifferent and steady, the one sound in the world that did not need to be told what to do.

In the stairwell Oriabel's hand found hers and squeezed it hard, and for one breath the whole machinery of Jeanne's composure groaned on its hinges. Then she said, "The council chamber in one hour. Treasurer, chancellor, marshal, master of the ordnance. And bring the southern dispatches, all of them, including the ones my father thought too dull to answer."

* * *

The council chamber of the Haut-Tertre was round, which her great-grandfather had considered modern, and walled with maps and the horn-bound ledgers of three generations. A fire of oak logs had been lit against the damp and was losing. At the long table, under the painted arms of Vauréal, five people sat with the faces of people at a deathbed who have been asked to divide the sheets.

Foulques arranged his papers with the slow precision of a man for whom order was a kind of prayer. Brive sat in steel and silence, having not undressed. The treasurer, a dry little cleric named Maître Colard, had brought four ledgers and a boy to carry them. The master of ordnance, a one-eyed Fleming called Van Brock, smelled of the forge he had been dragged from. Jeanne took her father's chair, the high one with the worn arms, and the room adjusted itself around her like water around a stone.

"First the money," she said, "because every other word we say today is paid for."

Colard did not need to be told twice. He opened the first ledger, and the story came out in his thin, precise voice, the story no battlefield dispatch ever carried. The Roches-Noires campaign had eaten the year's war taxes in advance. The ransom for the duke's body, paid in gold at the ford, had

emptied the privy chest. The ordinance companies that survived were owed two months' pay and would dissolve within the week without it. The garrisons at Mont d'Or and Pont-d'Ortelle were owed longer. Customs receipts at Malemort were down because the river trade had stopped the moment the south road did.

"The ready money in the vaults," Colard said, turning a page as though it might bite him, "is eleven thousand écus, of which three are earmarked for the Dolfin interest due at Easter. Against that, my lady, the monthly cost of putting even a small field army back on its feet is—"

"Twelve thousand," she said. "I have read my father's margins. Go on."

He went on, miserably. The feudal levies could be called but not held past forty days, and the vassals would come, if they came, to measure the new duchess rather than to fight. The Swiss pike company contracted for the spring had not been paid its first installment and was already hiring itself elsewhere. The crown's declaration, the sealed letter Graçay's herald had delivered, invoked an old failure of homage over the three southern fiefs and declared them forfeit to France. It was legally clever, historically dubious, and militarily sincere, which was the only kind of sincerity that mattered.

"Now the towns," Jeanne said.

Foulques took up the thread. The dispatches from the north, left to ripen while the south burned, were a garden of threats. At Sainterre the guilds had held an armed assembly in the cloth hall and drawn up articles: a charter of aldermen, a guild court, fixed tolls, the right to maintain their own militia. The articles came wrapped in professions of grief for the dead duke and loyalty to his daughter, the wrapping so thin it was an insult. At Malemort the port boss Van Maerlant had closed the customs house "pending the security of the river," which meant pending whoever won. At Grisay the forges were still working, because forges always worked, but the preacher Anselm had told a crowd of three thousand that princes were a scourge permitted for the sins of the rich, which was being interpreted in several useful ways.

"And my vassals?" Jeanne said. "The ones with swords."

Brive spoke for the first time. "Hautperthuis has written. Warmly. He is on his way to the Haut-Tertre even now, with a suitable train, to put himself at your service." The old marshal's mouth said the word *suitable* the way a man says *vermin*. "Erquelines has written to no one, which means he has written to the Emperor. The rest are waiting to see whether the French stop at the fords."

"Will they stop?"

The question went around the table and came back to Van Brock, who shrugged his massive shoulders. "Graçay is no plunderer. He will consolidate the south, repair the forts, and wait for the spring roads to dry. He has the Regent's caution and the Regent's books. He will be at Mont d'Or by May with guns if we give him May. If we had an army, my lady, I would say the line of the Ortelle holds. We have eleven men."

Nobody laughed. The fire popped.

Jeanne looked at the maps on the wall, the painted roads and rivers and little ink castles, the whole inheritance her father had spent twenty years soldering together out of marriages and purchases and the careful bankruptcy of his neighbors. She thought of the eleven riders in the wet courtyard. She thought of the waxen hand. She thought of the things that happen to rich duchies with dead dukes and girl heirs, the things her father's own ledgers recorded without sentiment: wards sold, widows cloistered, towns invited to pay for their own conquest.

Then she opened the fresh ledger she had brought with her, the one with the blank vellum pages and the new leather cover, and she wrote the date at the top of the first page in her best hand, the hand her father's clerics had beaten into her: the nineteenth of March, in the year of Our

Lord fourteen hundred and eighty-four, the first day of my reign.

"Write these orders," she said. "The feudal host is summoned to Aubecourt by the twentieth of April, with the quotas as attached, and every lord's response recorded in writing and kept. A fast courier to the Dolfin bank at Sainterre: I will receive the banker himself, not a factor, before the week is out, and he is to bring terms, not condolences. A letter to the guild dean Coppens, in my own hand, granting him safe conduct to the Haut-Tertre to lay his articles before me. He is to be answered politely. Politeness costs nothing and buys time, and time is the only soldier we can currently afford."

She turned the page.

"The marshal will make the defense of the northern roads his study and give me a paper by Friday. The master of ordnance will inventory every gun, barrel, and powder cask in the duchy, including the town walls, and I will know why the Sainterre wall pieces are better than my own. Maître Foulques will prepare the funeral and the homage ceremonies as one occasion, so that every man who comes to weep stays to swear. And the watch will admit no more heralds, French or imperial, before I have read their letters and decided which of them I wish to be seen receiving."

The five men looked at her. Colard's pen hovered. It was Brive who said the thing the room was holding its breath around.

"My lady. All of this holds for a season, perhaps. A duchy without an army is a corpse that has not yet fallen down. There is one garrison within reach that has not been beaten, one lord with a full company and a name that the French respect. The council before Roches-Noires had already opened the question. Your father set it aside. It cannot be set aside now."

She knew what was coming. She had known since the gate bell. She had known, in some room of herself that never slept, for seven years.

"The Duke of Lorraine," Foulques said, very gently, as though gentleness had ever been what she wanted from him. "The treaty of marriage was drafted before your father marched. A defensive league between Vauréal and Lorraine, sealed by your hand and his. His army, my lady. Our money. There is no second answer in this room, and you will find no second answer in Christendom."

The painted arms on the wall seemed to lean inward. Lorraine. The word tasted of iron and wet stone and a closed door in a corridor she had walked past a thousand times. She kept her face the way she had kept her hand on the dead hand, steady and public, and wrote in the new ledger, beneath her orders, one line.

Then she said, "I will consider the Lorraine question, and I will answer it after my father is buried. Is there anything else that will not keep until tomorrow?"

There was not. The council rose, scraping, bowing, gathering its ledgers and its dread. Brive paused at the door and gave her a look she could not read, something between pity and the beginning of respect. Foulques left last, as chancellors do, and his eyes, too, rested on her a moment too long, the eyes of a man keeping a door shut somewhere.

* * *

She dismissed Lisette at midnight and sat alone in her father's chamber, where the servants had not yet found the courage to change anything. His reading spectacles lay on a folded map of the southern fiefs. A cup of wine stood at his elbow, gone sour, and the smell of him still lingered in the hangings: parchment, woodsmoke, the dried herbs he strewed against fleas. She had intended to weep, now that there were no witnesses, and was dismayed to find the tears would not come. Instead she opened the casket at the table's foot and found, beneath the estate rolls, the letters she had written and never sent, tied with a ribbon whose color had gone out of fashion years ago.

She did not untie them. She had not untied them in seven years, and she was not the girl who had tied them. The newest one, written at fifteen in a hand that still believed in the goodness of explanations, she could have recited from memory, every foolish line. She thought of the word *Duchess*, spoken in the wet courtyard by a man with one hand. She thought of the line she had written in the new ledger, the line beneath the orders, which no one else had seen.

It said: *What cannot be refused must be made to serve me.*

She retied the casket, locked it, and put the key on its chain around her neck, where it lay cold between her breasts beside her mother's crucifix. Outside, the cathedral bell began at last, and then the bells of the lower town answered it, tower after tower, rolling south across the river toward the army that no longer existed and the border that no longer had an army on it. She blew out the taper and sat in the dark for a while, listening to her inheritance ring.

Then she lit another, went back to the table, and began, in the margin of her father's map, to plan a funeral and a marriage and a war, in the order in which they would be made to pay for one another.

* * *

They buried Hugues de Vauréal on the twenty-second of March, in the vault beneath the cathedral choir, in the company of his father and his father's father and the wife he had not been able to save. The bishop sang the requiem in a voice like a damp viol, and the church was so full that the aldermen of the lower town stood against the pillars with the scullions, and the smell of wet wool rose to the vaults and fought the incense.

Jeanne knelt closest to the bier, in black from throat to ankle, a veil of the finest and most public kind. Behind her the great houses arranged themselves in order of ambition, which in a reign twelve days old had not yet hardened into order of rank. She could feel them sorting themselves the way she felt draughts, without turning: Hautperthuis had arrived the previous evening with forty horsemen and a face of borrowed grief, and knelt now where she could see his gloved hands folded on the stone. Erquelines had sent a nephew and an excuse. The lesser lords filled the nave like a jury. In the side chapel, plain among the jeweled mourners, stood the envoys who had ridden hard through the rain: the imperial, the French, the Venetian, three kinds of vulture in three kinds of velvet, come to measure the corpse's daughter.

The chants washed over her. *Requiem aeternam dona eis, Domine.* She had known the words since she was seven and had sung them, badly, for a

favorite falcon. She watched the candles bend in the breath of the church and thought, with a clerk's shame, about candle wax, which was up a farthing the pound since the river trade failed, and about the twelve altar candles burning here, and the cathedral's right to bill the privy purse for them. She thought about her father under his pall of red and gold, smaller than the duke inside it, and about the broken hands.

At the moment of the elevation, when every knee went down and every head bowed, she looked up. It was a small, private sacrilege, the kind a child commits in the certainty that God has larger concerns. The painted window above the choir showed the old dukes of Vauréal processing toward Christ with their charter rolls in their hands, all of them clean and certain and unacquainted with gunfire. Her father was not up there yet. His glass had not been commissioned. There was no one to commission it now but her.

Outside, after the interment, the crowd pressed close in the square, the lower town come out to see what a twenty-two-year-old duchess looked like. She had expected silence or, worse, sympathy. What she got was the flat, measuring stare of people deciding whether to pay their taxes. A fishwife in the front rank, arms folded under her apron, looked Jeanne over as she might look over a stall, and found the goods uncertain. Jeanne met her eyes and did not look away, and after a

moment the woman's face did something complicated, and she bobbed her knees, the smallest possible curtsy, the kind that could be denied later.

Jeanne mounted the horse they had brought, a quiet grey mare rather than the great war destrier her father would have used, and spoke the words Foulques had written and she had rewritten three times. She did not shout. She had been taught that a voice lowered into silence carries farther than a voice raised over noise, and the square went quiet to hear her.

"My father is with his fathers. His lands are not orphaned, his towns are not widowed, and his people are not forfeit. I will hold what he held, and I will keep his peace, and I will keep his justice. Go home, and say the duchess said so."

It was short. It was perhaps inadequate to the moment. It was also, as Brive admitted to her afterwards over bread and hot spiced wine in the guardhouse, the first thing said in the duchy since the Roches-Noires that did not smell of panic.

* * *

The private grief came at last in the cathedral vault, when the public day was done and the canons had banked their candles and only Oriabel waited at the stair foot. Jeanne had asked to be

left, and against every rule of her household she had been obeyed.

The vault smelled of old stone and old death, the family dead stacked in their lead and marble, her mother's sarcophagus small against her father's new one. She knelt on the cold step between them, and for a while nothing happened, and then everything happened at once, in the ugly, choking, unladylike way real grief has, the kind no court can use. She wept for the father who had taught her Latin by making her translate treatises on siegeworks, who had never once praised her to her face, who had ridden away with an army and come home in a cart. She wept for the girl who had once believed that being loved and being ruled were different things. She wept until there was nothing left in her but the stone and the dark and the sound of her own breathing.

Then she blew her nose on a linen handkerchief of the finest kind, folded it, put it away, and said aloud to the two sarcophagi, "I have no more time for this."

It was not true. Grief was not a creditor who went away unpaid. But it could be made to wait, like the Dolfin bank, like the French, like every other claimant at the gate. She climbed the stairs into the last grey light of the evening, where Oriabel waited without questions and Lisette waited with a cloak, and the three women crossed

the courtyard through a fine rain that was becoming, by some small mercy, snow.

At the door of the council chamber she stopped. Through the oak she could hear the low murmur of her council assembling early, Brive's soldier's rumble, Foulques's dry whisper, the rustle of Colard's ledgers. Somewhere beyond the walls a horn sounded from the river road, long and official, the horn of a great lord arriving with a train.

Hautperthuis, probably. Or the imperial envoy's second audience. Or the answer from Sainterre, or the next demand from Paris, or the next bill. It did not matter which. They were all the same visitor, wearing different cloaks, and they would all be shown in to the same round room, and they would all find the same woman in the high chair.

Jeanne settled her veil, put her hand to the latch, and went in to receive them.

CHAPTER TWO

The Vultures' Congregation

The rule of a dead duke's daughter, Jeanne discovered in her second week, consisted largely of sitting down. She sat in the round chamber for councils, in the hall for audiences, in the chapel for offices she did not have time to attend to properly, and at the long table in her father's chamber for the ledgers she kept instead of sleeping. Her knees ached. Her back ached. The ring of the duchy, too large for her finger on a chain at her belt, knocked against the table edge when she wrote and left a little bruise above her hip.

On the first day of April, when the snow had gone and the Ortelle was running high and brown with meltwater, she sat in the round chamber to receive the vultures in their proper order, which Foulques had arranged on a single sheet of paper according to the rank of their masters and the degree of danger they represented, these being two different sums.

"The French first," the chancellor said, arranging the paper precisely under her hand. "Insolence should be received early, while your

patience is fresh. The imperial after, to show him he is not first. The Venetian third, since he will care more about the quality of the wine than the order of his audience. The guild deputation last and separately, in the lower hall, never at this table. Do not let the merchants grow accustomed to this room."

"And Hautperthuis?"

"Gui is not an envoy, my lady. He asks for a private audience, and he shall have one, in the solar, at the end of the day, when witnesses can be arranged without seeming to be. I have taken the liberty of inviting Dame Oriabel to be choosing linens in the adjoining chamber."

Jeanne looked at him. Foulques's face was the face he kept for documents: smooth, noncommittal, faintly tired. She had known him all her life. He had confirmed her, corrected her Latin, and on one never-spoken-of morning seven years ago had appeared in the solar at dawn with four guards and a face like a shut door. She trusted his mind and had long since stopped asking after his heart, which she assumed he kept in a strongbox somewhere with the older treaties.

"Very well," she said. "Send in the Frenchman."

* * *

The herald's name was de Pleine-Selve, and he came with a clerk and two men-at-arms and an

expression calibrated to suggest that everyone present was already, in some technical sense, a rebel. He wore the royal arms on a tabard so new the silk still creaked, and he carried the Regent's letter in a velvet case as though it were a relic.

He read the letter aloud, which was an insult in itself, since everyone in the chamber could read. It was a handsome document. It regretted the death of "our well-beloved cousin the late duke," noted the ancient tenure by which the three southern fiefs were held of the French crown, rehearsed at length the failures of homage and the "treasonable correspondence maintained with the Emperor's ministers," and concluded by declaring the said fiefs forfeit and absorbed, their inhabitants released from their allegiance, their new mistress summoned to Paris to make what submission she might before the king's grace was withdrawn.

When the reading was done, the room held the particular silence of men waiting to see whether a twenty-two-year-old woman would weep, rage, or faint.

Jeanne held out her hand. "The letter, if you please. I keep originals."

De Pleine-Selve hesitated, then gave it up. She read it herself, slowly, turning the pages with the finger she did not wet, while the silence aged. Foulques had taught her the uses of silence at

thirteen: it is a tax on the other party's nerve, and most people overpay.

"The tenure argument," she said at last, "is the work of a clever clerk with a weak case. The homage for the southern fiefs was last performed by my grandfather and remitted by crown charter in 'fifty-nine for two generations, a document registered at the Parlement of Paris. My father's homage fell due last Michaelmas. He was in the field against rebels armed from French arsenals, a fact your own masters will not enjoy seeing argued in open court. There is therefore no failure that is not first their own breach."

She laid the pages flat.

"As for correspondence with the Emperor, every lord in Christendom corresponds with every other lord in Christendom; the crime exists, if it exists, only in the choosing of recipients, and the choosing of recipients is policy, not treason. You may tell Madame la Régente that her letter is received, that its law is bad, and that its Latin is good, and that I will answer it in writing through my chancellor within the month. You may also tell her that if the Sire de Graçay crosses the fords before that answer reaches Paris, she will find the cost of the fiefs considerably higher than their value. Good day, herald."

De Pleine-Selve opened his mouth, found nothing in it that improved on her arrangement of

the facts, bowed with the slight stiffness of a man revising his estimate of the merchandise, and went out. Brive exhaled through his nose like a warhorse.

"Your father," he said, "would have thrown him into the garderobe tower."

"My father had an army," said Jeanne. "I have a month. Next."

* * *

The imperial envoy came in smelling of rosewater and walked as though the floor were a diplomatic floor and might give way. Herr von Zollern was a Swabian knight of forty with a scholar's brow and an empty purse, which last Jeanne knew because Dolfin's factors financed half the Empire's embassies and kept no secrets that earned interest. He brought greetings from the Most Invincible Emperor Frederick, guardian of the peace of Christendom, defender of the churches, and a quantity of other titles that took the better part of a minute to unroll.

The offer, when it came, was silk over air. The Emperor, grieving to see a noble lady exposed to the predations of the French, was prepared to extend his protection: an imperial garrison for the northern towns, an imperial commissioner at the duchess's council, the payment, eventually, of troops, and in the fullness of time a suitable

marriage with an illustrious prince of the Empire, whose name would be supplied in a later dispatch.

"Garrisoned," Jeanne repeated. "By which I understand the towns would receive imperial soldiers at their own charge, under imperial captains, while the troops remain unpaid until the fullness of time."

"Madame, the imperial liberality—"

"Is proverbial. The towns would also, I think, be required to take the imperial eagle on their gates, and the commissioner at my council would hold a veto in the Emperor's name, and the illustrious prince, whoever he proves to be, would administer my inheritance as his own. I have seen what imperial protection did for the towns of the Upper Rhine. Two of them are still paying for it."

Von Zollern's smile did not leave his face, which was how she knew it had never been a smile. "The alternative, madame, is France. The eagle does not eat what it shelters. The lily does."

"The eagle," said Jeanne, "also does not arrive when it is called. I will consider your master's friendship, which I value, and I will write to him in terms of the warmest respect. I cannot receive garrisons, commissioners, or princes, illustrious or otherwise, while my father is scarcely cold. You understand the proprieties."

He understood them perfectly; the proprieties were the only thing anyone in his trade ever understood. He bowed, perfumed the air a final time, and departed. Brive, who had been counting on his fingers, said, "That is two proposals of marriage in one morning, and the day is young."

"One proposal," said Jeanne. "The French one came with a forfeit. Next."

* * *

Zaccaria Dolfin came without a clerk, which was the first mark of the man. He was forty-eight, lean and dark and beautifully dressed in the Venetian manner, a single pearl at his ear and a ring on every finger that was doing work, not decoration. He smelled of eastern spices and clean linen. He bowed like a man who had bowed to doges and sultans and found them much of a muchness, and he accepted wine with the air of a man preparing to grade it.

"Duchess," he said, in French with only the ghost of an accent, "I will not offer you condolences. Condolence is a coin struck for people who cannot be of use. Permit me instead to offer arithmetic."

From his sleeve he produced a folded sheet, covered not in the flourishes of a court clerk but in the tight, mercantile hand of the Rialto. It was her duchy's financial condition, estimated, as far as

she could see in two glances, to within five hundred écus of Colard's secret ledgers.

"Your ready cash, eleven thousand. Your Easter obligation to my house, three thousand. Your surviving garrisons, four months from mutiny. A new field army, twelve thousand the month before it fights at all. The French crown's cost for the Roches-Noires army, paid through the Lombards of Paris, roughly ninety thousand, of which perhaps sixty remains in the field. The Emperor's promises, priced at what they have fetched on the market these ten years, nothing at all." He folded the sheet away. "I state these things because flattery between borrowers and lenders is a tax on both."

Jeanne drank her own wine, which he had not yet graded, and watched him over the cup. "Your terms, Messer Dolfin. You did not ride two days through a war to admire my accounts."

"A loan. Forty thousand écus, in gold, in three installments, the first within the week. Security: the customs of Malemort and the Sainterre cloth duty for six years, administered by a joint board on which my house holds one seat of three. Interest at fourteen percent, which is generous given the cannon currently pointed at the collateral. A further clause: should the duchy's government change by conquest, my house retains its liens against the revenues regardless of the government. The French will honor that clause,

Duchess. They have no choice; they borrow as I do."

"Fourteen percent is usury."

"It is the market. The Church will call it a service fee, for which I will pay the appropriate dispensations. Your own grandfather paid sixteen."

"He complained of it to his deathbed."

"A deathbed is the one place a Venetian banker is popular. Men forgive us their own debts there." Dolfin leaned forward, and for the first time the polished manner gave way to something like genuine counsel. "Madame, I will tell you what I tell every ruler with a good cause and a bad army. Do not borrow enough to lose. Borrow enough to win, and win quickly, because interest is the only army in the world that grows stronger every night. You need a husband with soldiers more than you need my gold. You need both, which is why I am here. The Lorraine treaty is the best instrument your council has produced in twenty years. Sign it, and my house will lend. Refuse it, and I will still lend, against the same liens, at eighteen percent, because the customs are good even under a conqueror. I am a patient man and a patient creditor. Choose."

He set down his cup, having graded it with a small, almost imperceptible nod.

Jeanne was quiet for a moment. In the ledger behind her eyes she wrote: *he wants the treaty because Lorraine's roads secure his trade route. He is not on my side. He is on the side of the road. That makes him reliable, as roads are reliable.*

"I will give your house its answer with the others," she said. "But you may tell your partners in Venice that the Duchess of Vauréal does not intend to lose, and therefore does not intend to pay eighteen percent."

He smiled then, a real smile, brief and white. "Then I will tell them fourteen. Good day, madame. It has been a genuine pleasure; most audiences at this hour are conducted in tears."

* * *

The guildsmen came last, in the lower hall, as Foulques had ordained, six of them in the long sober gowns of city office, their boots polished to a defiance of the mud outside. Maître Coppens led them. Sixty years old, broad and grey and slow-moving, with the hands of a man who had worked a loom before he worked a guildhall, he looked like a farmer and thought like a pope.

He knelt, rose, and presented the articles engrossed on parchment, with the seals of the Sainterre guilds depending from it in a row like plump red fruit. Jeanne read them in front of him,

taking her time, the hall full of guards and clerks and the deliberate theater of power.

The articles asked for a great deal: an elected council of aldermen, a city court with jurisdiction over trade and labor, a fixed toll schedule that the duchess could not alter without the council's consent, the city's own trained militia under its own officers, and a general amnesty for the assemblies of the past month. In exchange, the guilds offered renewed allegiance, a war contribution, and the keeping of the peace in the northern towns.

"You understand," Jeanne said, "that what you ask for is a charter, and that the granting of charters is the one act by which a ruler may be quietly dismembered while the bandages are applied by the patient himself."

Coppens did not flinch. "Madame, what we ask for is what the cities of Flanders took with pikes and what your grandfather sold us by the yard at twice the price. We would rather buy. Buying leaves both parties standing."

"It leaves me standing shorter."

"It leaves you standing, madame. There are men in Sainterre who will tell you that a duchess without an army is a clerk with a seal. Willem de Key has said it in the cloth hall, to four thousand men, and he did not say it unkindly. He said it as

arithmetic." The old guildsman's eyes were steady. "I am here because I believe a charter keeps the peace and de Key believes a charter is only the first wall to come down. Between us, madame, you have perhaps six weeks before his arithmetic becomes the city's."

Jeanne rolled the parchment. "I will answer the articles in writing. I give you my word the answer will be an answer, not a delay dressed as one. In the meantime, Maître Coppens, you will tell your guilds that the duchess does not negotiate with armed assemblies, and you will tell de Key that if the cloth hall fills again with pikes, the first man to answer for it will be the dean of the guild, which is to say yourself. I am told you keep excellent order. Keep it."

It was a threat and a confidence in one sentence, and he heard both. His bow, when he made it, was deeper than the envoy's had been.

When the hall had emptied, Foulques said at her shoulder, "You were excellent with the Frenchman. You were wise with the German. With the Venetian you were magnificent. With the guildsman, madame, you were a ruler."

"I was a ruler who refused nothing and granted nothing."

"That is what ruling is, at the beginning." He hesitated over his papers, a hesitation so unlike

him that she looked up. "The last audience remains. And after it, my lady, there is the Lorraine question, which will not survive another week unanswered. The duke's own courier arrived this morning. He is not sending a proxy."

"What do you mean?"

"I mean, madame, that the Duke of Lorraine is riding to Aubecourt himself. He will be at the gates inside of ten days."

* * *

The solar had been arranged for grief and softened for seduction, though no one would have been so coarse as to call it that. A fire of applewood, candles against the afternoon gloom, the best tapestry on the wall, the one showing the hunt of the white stag rather than the one showing the siege. Oriabel was indeed in the adjoining chamber, audible in small domestic clashes of linen presses, and two of Jeanne's women sat near the window with their sewing, present as furniture is present.

Gui de Hautperthuis came in black, which suited him, and knelt with the elegant gravity of a man who had practiced the gesture in two reigns. He rose tall at forty-five, his beard threaded with grey, his eyes light and clever and set in a face whose sorrow looked almost genuine. He had been, Jeanne remembered, one of the handsomest

men of her father's generation. He had also, her father's ledgers said, been late to every battle and early to every tax exemption, and the ledgers were not given to flattery.

"Madame my cousin." His voice was low and warm, pitched for a deathbed. "I have buried my own wife, and I know the particular winter of these first weeks. If I had a hundred lives, I would spend the first of them in keeping this house from adding to your burdens."

"My burdens are the duchy's, cousin. They cannot be kept, only carried. Sit."

He sat, accepted wine, and did not drink it, a man too sensitive for his appetites. For ten minutes he was perfect: he spoke of her father with the precise affection of a kinsman who had genuinely admired him without liking him; he described the mourning in his own lands; he asked after her sleep, her appetite, the cathedral's arrangements, all of it with the tenderness of an uncle and none of an uncle's rights. Then, by a road as smooth as a paved causeway, he arrived at himself.

"The vassals are frightened, madame. Frightened men do foolish things, as the Sainterre assembly shows. What they need is a visible hand, a sword at the council table, a name they know. I do not seek office. I seek to serve. But if the council were to name a guardian of the marches, a

constable for the duration of these troubles, I would not refuse the labor. Your father would have wanted someone of the blood to stand between you and the importunate."

There it was, laid on the table like a ripe fruit: the constableship. A constable commanded the armies. A constable with the blood of the old dukes in his veins, admitted to the council and the fortresses, became, in a season or two, the man to whom the towns sent their keys and the envoys their letters. She had watched her father explain this very mechanism to her at fourteen, over a dish of pears, using another ambitious lord as the example.

"My father," she said, "kept the constable's office vacant for eleven years because he said a sword at the council table soon learns to point at the chair. I believe I will honor his judgment. The marshal has the military council; I have the seal; between us we shall muddle through. But I am grateful for the offer, cousin. Such offers are rare. So is the forty-man train you brought with you. The Haut-Tertre has rarely housed so many of your people at once."

A flicker, gone almost before it arrived, the candle of his self-love guttering in a draught. Then the warm smile was back, adjusted. "A kinsman's precaution, madame. The roads are not safe for a small party."

"No. They are not." She set down her cup. "Which is why I have a service to ask of you rather than an office to give. Your lands lie closest to the fords. I should like the Hautperthuis tenants to repair the road between Pont-d'Ortelle and the border, at your charge, and to provision the fort there through the summer. A work of peace, cousin, and a visible one. The whole marches will see the name of Hautperthuis on every sack of grain."

It was brilliant and he knew it. Refusal looked like disloyalty; acceptance put his money and his tenants at the service of her fortress and bound his interest to the road he might otherwise have opened to the French. For a long moment the light eyes went cold, and she saw the man under the performance, calculating the cost. Then he bowed his head.

"The duchess does me honor. It shall be done."

"Good. Then we are both served." She rose, ending it. "Give my greetings to your household. And cousin — the repairs by Easter. I keep accounts of promises as of everything else."

When he had gone, Oriabel drifted through the connecting door on the feet of a woman who had been listening at it. "He wanted the army."

"He wanted the chair. The army was merely the key."

"Will he do the road?"

"He will do half of it and bill me for the whole, and he will write to Paris before the month is out. Have Lisette's people watch his couriers. I want names, not suspicions."

* * *

Night came early in April, or she had grown older. The council had dined and gone; the household had performed its evening rituals of coals and curtains and prayers; the Haut-Tertre settled around her the way a great animal settles, full of small creaks and distant warmth. Jeanne sat in her father's chamber with the Lorraine treaty spread under the lamp, and Foulques's commentary beside it in the chancellor's careful hand.

It was a dry document and a desperate one, and she read it as she read everything, twice: once for what it said, once for what it wanted.

It said: a defensive league and a marriage between Jeanne, Duchess of Vauréal, and Thiébaut, Duke of Lorraine. It said the spouses would retain full and separate sovereignty in their own dominions, neither reigning in the other's lands. It said Lorraine would maintain, at Vauréal's expense, a field force of twelve hundred lances and three thousand foot for the duration of the French war. It assigned her a dower of revenues in

Lorraine, and him a lifetime interest in a ring of Vauréal border manors, reverting to her crown on his death. It said the children of the marriage would inherit both houses. It said, in a clause Foulques had marked in the margin as *without precedent in our favor*, that in the event of her death without issue, Vauréal would pass according to its own succession law and never into the keeping of the Lorrainer.

What it wanted was simpler than all of that. It wanted her money and his soldiers on the same side before Graçay dried the spring roads. It wanted a son to solder two patchwork dominions into something France could not swallow in a mouthful. It wanted, in the oldest language of her trade, a gate between two houses, and the gate was her body, and everyone had signed except the gate.

She thought of the boy she had known. The grammar of the treaty kept turning, in her ungovernable mind, into the grammar of another document, seven years old: a boy's face in the torchlight of this same palace, carefully empty, saying words he had learned the way one learns a part. She had not spoken his name aloud in this chamber since. She made herself speak it now, into the lamp-lit silence, just above a whisper, to prove it had no power.

"Thiébaut."

It had power. It had all the old power, and she hated it for that, the way one hates a door that will not stay shut.

Ten days. He was on the road with his twelve hundred lances' worth of promises and his careful treaty and his seven years of silence, riding toward the Haut-Tertre, and she would have to meet him at the gate in her father's place and give him her hand in front of every vulture in Christendom, and not one of them would know that the hand being given had once, at fifteen, been promised differently in a storm.

She folded the treaty along its creases and put it into the casket with the unsent letters, because that was where documents of that kind belonged. Then she drew the fresh ledger back across the table and wrote the day's entry: four audiences, one loan in prospect, one charter to answer, one constable refused, one road bought, one marriage to be made to serve her.

At the bottom of the page she added a line smaller than the rest, the line no clerk would ever copy.

He is coming. Be the duchess first. The girl can be dealt with afterwards.

CHAPTER THREE

The Old Wound

The muster field lay two leagues south of Aubecourt, where the river bent around a flat green plain that had been used for the assembling of armies since her grandfather's time. Jeanne rode out to see it on a bright cold morning with Brive at her left hand and an escort of twenty lances, and she asked the old marshal for the truth before they were halfway there.

"The truth, my lady, is that the truth will depress you."

"I have been depressed by better men. Ride level and speak."

He grunted, which with Brive passed for laughter, and gave her the musters as they came in. The great vassals sent their formal replies in the hands of formal messengers: quotas acknowledged, dates hedged, illnesses discovered, border duties remembered. Of the feudal host due by the twentieth of April, perhaps half would appear, and of that half a quarter were tenants dragged from plows with bills and hunting spears. The household men-at-arms were the steel in it, three hundred of them, plus the survivors of Roches-Noires filtering home in pairs and trios, hollow men who flinched at thunder. No cavalry

worth the name. No guns beyond the wall pieces. No pike, because the Swiss contract had died unpaid, and a duchy that did not keep pikes in 1484 was a duchy that had not yet understood what century it was dying in.

They reached the ridge above the field. Below them, tents the color of old teeth straggled along the river, smoke rose from a hundred small fires, and a company of muddy infantry was being put through its evolutions by a hoarse sergeant, wheeling badly and catching its own billhooks. A trumpeter practiced the same four notes until even the horses looked weary.

"My father would have known this field's number at a glance," Jeanne said.

"Your father also lost the last army this field produced." Brive reined in beside her, and his old face was not unkind. "Do not mistake me, madame. I loved him, after my fashion. But he loved a charge the way other men love wine, and the French set the table for him. The next army of Vauréal will be an army of contracts and cannon, not of chivalry. Which is why your council is right about Lorraine, and why you know it, and why the knowing does not help."

She did not answer. Below them the trumpeter began again. On the road north, a cart turned in at the field gate, and another, and a file of mounted men with a banner she could not read. The host

was coming, such as it was, rolling toward her across the green plain whether she was ready or not.

"Ride back," she said at last. "I have old rooms to walk through."

* * *

She went to the east wing after dinner, on foot, with only Lisette behind her, as though she were a girl again and not the reason two hundred carpenters were hammering the lower town into barracks. The east wing held the nurseries and the schoolroom and the long gallery where the children of the court had been allowed to make noise at stated hours. It was given over now to storage: old furniture under dust sheets, a broken falcon's perch, a cradle she recognized.

The ward had come in the year she turned four. She remembered him first as a noise, a boy's shout in the quiet courtyard, and then as a fact: the Duke of Lorraine's son, nine years old, handed over at the bridge of Pont-d'Ortelle in exchange for a peace her father had no intention of keeping longer than suited him. Thiébaut had been small for his age then, and stiff in new clothes, and he had cried on the first night in a room where someone could hear him, which was the schoolroom chimney, and Jeanne, who had been awake for reasons of her own, had heard him

through the flue. She had told no one. It was the first secret they shared, though he did not know it for two years.

He grew into the place the way a sapling grows in a courtyard crack, determined and unconsulted. Her father's court raised him on the cheap, as wards are raised: fed at the lower table, taught with the ducal children because a clerk was already being paid, drilled in the yard by the same master-at-arms, forgotten at feast days and remembered whenever a treaty needed a signature. By the time Jeanne was seven he was twelve, long-legged and grave, and he had appointed himself her particular sentinel. He showed her where the stable cat had her kittens. He explained the siege diagrams in her father's books when the clerk's Latin went too fast. He taught her to skate on the frozen canal in the hard winter of '72, holding her wrists, and when she fell he fell with her so that she would not be the only one laughing.

The scar at her eyebrow came from the wall of the lower garden, which they had climbed together to watch a burning barn. She had been eleven, he sixteen. The coping crumbled; he caught her, which saved her neck, and the edge of the stone caught her brow, and he had carried her to the surgeon white and silent and swearing in a dialect of Lorraine French she had never heard him use. Her father had beaten him for it, formally, with a

riding cane, in front of the guard, because a ward who endangered the heiress needed a lesson visible to the household. She remembered the sound of it, and the way Thiébaut had not made a sound himself, and the way he had smiled at her afterwards in the corridor with the sweat still on his face, as though the thing that mattered was that she had stopped crying.

"Careful," Lisette said behind her, low. Jeanne realized her hand was pressed to the scar.

The gallery ended at the door of the old solar, the small one, the one no one used now because the new one with the Italian windows had been built when she was thirteen. The key was in the lock. It turned easily; the room smelled of dust and old velvet and something else, some ghost of woodsmoke and boy. The tapestries were gone to safer walls. The hearth was cold. The window looked over the orchard where they had stolen apples, and the wall beyond, and the road south.

She made herself remember the rest.

* * *

She was fifteen. The storms of that November came one after another, three days of rain so hard the Ortelle rose and the lower town flooded its cellars, and the court was shut indoors with its embroideries and its dice and its boredom. She and Thiébaut had been changing for a year by

then, the easy comradeship of children thickening into something that embarrassed the other courtiers and entertained them. He was twenty, nearly a man, nearly the end of his wardship, and the question of his return to Lorraine sat in every room he entered like a creditor by the fire.

They had talked, before, in the careless way children talk forever, of what they would do when he went home. That month the talk changed. She had begun to notice the shape of his hands and the exact color of his eyes, which were hazel and turned green in certain weather, and he had begun to watch her in doorways and stop mid-sentence when she came in. Neither of them had the vocabulary for it. They had only the old friendship and the new fire and the terrible confidence of the young that their case was unlike any case that had ever existed.

On the third night of the storms, the household went early to bed. She found her way to the old solar because she could not sleep, and he was already there, by the window, wrapped in a cloak against the draught, watching the lightning. She said his name. He turned, and she saw on his face the same astonishment she felt, that the other person should be there, as though the world had for once arranged itself on their side.

What passed between them there was nothing the court could have hanged anyone for, and

everything it could have ruined them with. They sat on the old chest beneath the window, under one cloak, and talked until the rain thinned, and somewhere in the talk they said the words. That they would not be parceled out. That his duchy and her duchy and her father's treaties and the Emperor's marriages were not the owners of the two people in this room. That he would speak to her father when the time came, or that they would find another way, and she said she would give up the inheritance before she would be given with it, and he said she must never say that, never, not even here, and she said it again to make him laugh. He kissed her. It was the first kiss for both of them, clumsy and reverent and long, and then they kissed again, more surely, and the lightning lit the dusty room in white flashes, and at some point, clothed and clasped under the cloak, they slept.

Dawn came grey and pitiless. The door opened. It was Foulques, then forty-eight and already the duke's right hand, with four guards of the watch behind him and a face she did not recognize, a face like the face of a man watching a house fall. She would learn later that a sewing woman had seen the two candles and remembered the price of information. Thiébaut stood up at once, shielding her with his body, and said the one sentence she held onto for seven years: "This is my doing. She is innocent of everything but kindness."

Foulques did not answer him. He said, "The duke will see you both in the great hall after terce. Dress as you are. Do not speak to one another." And the guards took him away, and the women took her away, and the solar door was locked behind them.

* * *

The great hall had been full. That was the thing. She had expected judgment in a chamber, and found instead the whole court in its best clothes, the vassals who were at the Haut-Tertre, the clerics, the ladies, the knights, the servants at the back with their frightened eyes, an audience assembled as though for a mummery. Her father sat in the high seat under the arms of Vauréal, and his face was the face she knew from accounts of the executions he attended: attentive, impartial, bored.

Thiébaut stood in the center of the hall without a guard near him, which was worse than a guard. He had been made to put on his finest tunic, the Lorraine one with the alérions, as though the occasion were ceremonial. He looked at her when she came in, and then, with an effort she could feel across the room, he looked away.

Her father spoke first, pleasantly, about honor and wardship and the price of confidence. Then he

asked Thiébaut, in the tone of a man discussing the weather, what he had to say for himself.

And Thiébaut said the words.

She had rehearsed the memory so often that the edges had gone soft, like the edges of a coin carried too long, but the words themselves never softened. He said he had been flattered by the child's infatuation and had not the gravity to put a stop to it sooner. He said nothing had happened that touched her honor, which was true, in the way a knife's edge is true. He said he had made no promises, held out no hopes, intended nothing; that he was grateful for the bread of Vauréal and would never presume on it; that boys and girls in a closed court would invent affections as closed rooms invented draughts; that he renounced any claim, suit, or understanding, present or future, between his house and the heiress of Vauréal, and would hold himself ready to depart for Lorraine at the duke's pleasure.

He called her a child. In the great hall, before everyone, he called the night in the solar a child's infatuation, and himself its amused and patient object, and not once did he look at her while he did it, and she stood at the front of the hall with every eye in Christendom on her face and understood that she had been the only person in the solar who meant a single word that had been said there.

Her father nodded, as though the answer were satisfactory and the matter closed. He made a little speech about the duchess's daughter being above such foolishness and the propriety of a speedy departure. The court murmured its relief. Thiébaut rode out before vespers with two servants and an escort to the border, and she watched from the east window of the gallery, and he did not turn once, not at the gate, not on the road, not where the road bent by the willows.

She had been fifteen. She had learned in one morning that love was a thing that could be performed backward, and that the safest place in the world for a person's secrets was inside herself, because no one else's keeping had ever been worth the rent.

"Jeanne." Lisette's hand was on her sleeve. The maid's face was furious and wet, the way it always was when the solar came up, because Lisette had carried the notes and Lisette had taken the beating for them and Lisette had never once believed the performance. "It's a cold room for old ghosts. Come away."

"In a moment." She crossed to the chest beneath the window and laid her palm on its lid, the place where they had sat under one cloak. The wood was cold and ordinary. "I am going to marry him, Lisette."

"I know. The whole palace knows. The scullions have odds on the date."

"Do you counsel against it?"

"I counsel against dying French, my lady, and against watching the guilds pull this house down brick by brick, and against every other thing that happens if you don't. I don't counsel about him. That one's between you and the girl you were." Lisette wiped her cheeks with the back of her hand, fierce and unbecoming. "Though if you want my plain opinion, he looked like a man being broken on the wheel that day, not a man getting off easy. I saw it. I was at the back. Nobody else was watching him. I was."

Jeanne said nothing. She had carried her version of that morning for seven years, polished and smooth and complete, and she had no intention of opening it now, ten days before the wedding that reason had already signed.

She locked the solar door herself and gave the key to no one.

* * *

The council met that evening over bread and eel pie, because the state would not adjourn for supper and supper refused to be postponed any longer. Foulques had arranged the marriage question on three sheets: the imperial alternative,

the Lorraine alternative, and a third sheet which was almost entirely blank, headed *Other Means*.

"The imperial alternative," said the chancellor, taking up his pointer like a schoolmaster, "is an archduke. The Emperor's cousin, aged nineteen, amiable, currently resident at a court two hundred leagues away, possessed of a name and no money. Marriage brings the imperial alliance in theory, an imperial commissioner in fact, and no troops for at least a year, because the Emperor's troops are always somewhere else. It also places your inheritance under the feudal umbrella of a house that has never once kept an umbrella in repair."

Brive snorted.

"The Lorraine alternative is Thiébaut himself. A reigning duke, twenty-seven, unmarried, hardened by six years of holding a marchland against France with no revenue and no friends. His full strength, by our best count, is eleven hundred men-at-arms, two thousand mounted archers, and an ordinance company of pike and gun that has never been beaten when paid. He is also, and the council does not conceal this, a man who knows this court, this duchy, and yourself. Some would count that last fact as a danger."

"Some would," said Jeanne. She cut her eel pie into exact quarters. "Some would count a man who cannot be surprised by me as useful. Continue."

"The treaty as drafted preserves your sovereignty entire. Separate councils, separate seals, no Lorrainer holds office or garrison in Vauréal without your written appointment. His troop quota serves under his banner but at your pay, which makes them yours. The dower lands run to you for life. The reversion clause protects the succession. Madame, the document is almost suspiciously favorable. His own chancellor must have fought it."

"The Abbé de Viray," Brive put in, "is a priest with the soul of a sergeant. He would have fought it. Which means the duke overruled him."

"Why would he?" Jeanne asked the room. "Why give a rich duchy a marriage contract that asks for none of its government? A man in his position could have held out for the regency. Hautperthuis would have."

Foulques's pen paused a fraction too long. "Reasons may be suggested. He needs the money more than he needs the title. His duchy is poor and exposed; Vauréal's revenue is what keeps Lorraine on the map. A regency clause would have split your vassals and handed Graçay his pretext for a war of liberation. A light hand binds the cities; the cities hold the roads; the roads are what he is actually buying." The chancellor's voice was level. "Men at the ends of their resources, madame,

make generous treaties. It does not require a romantic explanation."

Jeanne looked at him. There it was again, that small wrong note, the thing she had heard in his voice whenever the old subject came near. She filed it with the ledger entries and did not press. Pressing Foulques was like pressing a full cup in a dark room; one waited until one could see.

"The other risks," she said.

"Are real." Brive leaned forward. "He knows you. That cuts both directions. You will be sharing a bed with a man who can read your face at twenty paces, and a council table with a trained soldier who will want his say in the war that his army is fighting. The treaty says separate councils. Wars do not observe treaties about councils. You will have to fight him for every decision, every day, and do it smiling, because the vultures will be watching the marriage the way crows watch a sick sheep."

"And if I refuse him?"

The old marshal's face answered first. "Then he makes his terms with Paris, because Lorraine cannot stand alone another winter, and the French get his road instead of us. Or he takes the Emperor's money, and the Empire gets his road. Either way, madame, the map moves around you, and you become the thing maps are redrawn over:

a small rich country with a girl's name over the gate."

The fire settled in the hearth. Outside, the wind from the river moved the tapestries.

Jeanne ate a quarter of the pie, methodically, while the men waited. She thought of the muster field and its billhooks. She thought of de Key's arithmetic and Dolfin's fourteen percent and the Regent's silky letters. She thought of the boy who had caught her on the garden wall and the man who had cut her loose in the great hall, and she set the two of them side by side in her mind like two ledgers that could not be reconciled. Then she thought of the line she had written on the first night: what cannot be refused must be made to serve me.

"Send the answer tomorrow," she said. "I accept the treaty, with four additions. First, the troop quota is doubled in the event of a direct French invasion, at my cost and his command, the command to be exercised jointly through a war council of which I am the head. Second, the dower revenues are paid quarterly into an account controlled by my treasurer, not his. Third, all patents of office in Vauréal remain mine alone, including over any Lorrainer serving here. Fourth," she paused, choosing the words like blades, "the marriage is celebrated at the Haut-Tertre, in my capital, before my vassals, and no ceremony,

document, or custom anywhere shall describe me otherwise than as Duchess of Vauréal in her own right. He takes no title of mine. I will be called madame, and not Her Grace the duchess his wife, by any herald in either country. Write it down, Maître Foulques, in the plainest Latin your clerks can manage. If he signs, the gold for his first payroll leaves Malemort with the reply."

Brive stared at her. "You have thought about this."

"I have thought about nothing else for two weeks. I am merely the last person to be told my own decision."

* * *

The courier rode south at dawn with the sealed counter-treaty and the first gold convoy under a strong guard, and the Haut-Tertre turned itself to the business of a wedding with the grim efficiency of a fortress turning itself to a siege. Carpenters built stands in the lower courtyard. The cathedral chapter was consulted about flowers and processions. Oriabel produced, from somewhere in the bottomless arithmetic of her household, a length of cloth-of-silver and a dressmaker from Sainterre who was given a room and a deadline and, at Jeanne's insistence, no instructions about white.

"White is for virgins and queens," Jeanne said, standing still while the woman measured her shoulders. "I am a sovereign making a treaty. Make it the color of steel."

In the hours she stole from the state, she did what she had always done: she prepared. She read every dispatch out of Nancy for three years. She learned the names of his captains, the state of his fortresses, the debts his father had left and the ones he had added. She learned that the Abbé de Viray governed his conscience and the Bastard Jean governed his camp and that no woman had ever been named in connection with his court for longer than a season, which the gossips read as coldness and she read, unwillingly, as control. She learned that he had been wounded in the left shoulder at the relief of a town called Sarrebourg and that the shoulder still closed gates on him in winter.

She also, on the night before he was due, took the ribbon-tied letters from the casket one last time and read the topmost, the fifteen-year-old's letter, all the way through. It was worse than she remembered, fervent and certain and full of plans, and at the bottom it said that she would rather be Thiébaut's wife in a cottage than duchess of the world. She read it without expression, folded it, and put it back, and tied the ribbon with the same knot.

Then she wrote one more letter, short, sealed it with the ducal ring, and gave it to Lisette with instructions that it was to be delivered into the Duke of Lorraine's own hand when he arrived at the gate, before any ceremony, before any greeting, before he had so much as dismounted.

"What does it say?" Lisette asked, turning it over.

"It says the terms on which he enters this house." Jeanne fastened the chain at her throat, key and crucifix together. "It says that the Duchess of Vauréal receives the Duke of Lorraine as her ally and her contracted husband, in public, at the gate, at noon. And it says that if he has anything to say to the girl he once knew, he may save his breath, because the girl is not at home and has no intention of receiving."

Lisette's mouth twitched. "Not a word of greeting in it at all?"

"One. At the end." She reached for her cloak. "I signed it *Jeanne*. I thought I could afford him that much, since he is getting everything else."

Outside the window, far down the southern road, a trumpet called from the watchtower, and then another, the signal posts passing the word along the river toward the Haut-Tertre: a column was on the road, in Lorraine's colors, moving fast, with the standard of the alérions at its head.

He had come a day early.

Jeanne stood for a moment with her hand on the window frame and made herself breathe once, twice, while her heart performed the ancient, treasonous, ungovernable ritual it had clearly been saving for this occasion. Then she let the curtain fall and went to find the marshal, because there were not enough guards on the gate and she had an army to inspect before she had a husband to survive.

CHAPTER FOUR

Nancy's Bargain

The grain stores of Nancy were supposed to hold nine hundred quarters of wheat. The chief storeman, a man named Petitjean who had survived three dukes and two sacks, swore on his mother's grave that the figure was accurate, and Thiébaut, who had learned to count grain by counting it, drove his own arm into the bin to the elbow and came up with a handful of chaff and blackened kernels at the level where the wheat ought to have been.

"Your mother," he said, "was fortunate in her son's opinion of her. The bin is false-bottomed. Fetch the steward, the sergeant of the granary guard, and the man who built this, and be quick about it."

Petitjean went the color of old tallow. The duke of Lorraine stood in the dust of his own storehouse, in a plain leather jerkin with his steward's tally board in one hand, and did not raise his voice. He had learned very young that a man who never raises his voice is always overheard. By the time the three culprits arrived, he had probed four more bins and found two honest ones, and he had the numbers written in his head: six weeks'

bread for the garrison, not four months. Six weeks, with the French raiding parties already over the southern march and the spring campaign unborn.

He hanged the builder, because the false bottom was construction and therefore the man's own craft; he broke the steward before the garrison and stripped him of everything but his life; he put Petitjean, who had sworn the false oath, into the builder's old place on the theory that a caught thief makes the best watchman, which his father had taught him and which had never yet failed. Then he paid the garrison's arrears out of his own plate, which the goldsmiths weighed in the courtyard under the eyes of three hundred men, and rode back up to the palace of the dukes of Lorraine as the evening bell went, with two silver dishes the poorer and a garrison that would, for another month, hold the walls.

In the courtyard his half-brother Jean was waiting with a hawk on his fist and the particular grin that meant bad news being enjoyed.

"You've been hanging men again," said the Bastard of Lorraine. "The town says you're a just prince. It says so very loudly, in the taverns, where justice is admired in proportion to its distance."

"The town will admire me more when it isn't eating its boots. The bins were false, Jean. Six weeks."

The grin went. "Six weeks? Then we had better hope your bride's gold travels faster than her letters. The Vauréal courier came in an hour ago. The council is assembled, Viray has sent twice for you, and there is a letter for your own hand, delivered under a seal I did not recognize, which the courier says was to be given to no one else."

Thiébaut took the letter. He knew the seal before he turned it. The Vauréal arms, the red and silver, and below them, in place of the chancellor's office, a single hand-drawn letter: J. He had not seen that hand since he was twenty years old, and his body recognized it before his mind did, the old cold march of the heart, the old silence under the ribs.

"Feed the hawk," he said, "and tell the council I'll be along when I've washed the granary off."

* * *

He read the letter alone, in the high chamber that served him for study, armory, and bedchamber combined, because Lorraine could not afford a duke with separate rooms for his misfortunes. The window looked west over the roofs of Nancy toward the road that led, three days' hard riding and a world away, to Aubecourt.

It was a short letter. It was also, he thought, the most carefully unkind document he had ever held, and he had held peace treaties. It named him the

Duke of Lorraine throughout, never his name. It set out her terms for the gate, the noon, the public reception. It told him the girl he had known was not at home. It was signed, at the bottom, in that same hand, with the single word *Jeanne*.

He sat for a long time with the page on his knee. A log shifted in the hearth. The bad shoulder ached, as it did whenever the wind came west off the Vosges, a deep old weather in the bone, and he pressed it with his right hand the way one presses a tooth.

Seven years. He had made himself into a different instrument in seven years, the way a smith makes a plowshare out of whatever iron the scrap pile offers: campaigns in the snow, debts paid with plate, garrisons held by willpower, the long grinding defense of a duchy that every map in Paris had already divided among French lords. He had taught himself to sleep on the ground, to read a battlefield by the birds, to judge men by their excuses, and to want nothing that could be taken from him. There were nights when he believed the lesson had taken. Then some small thing, a storm, a certain grey light, a woman's handwriting on a dispatch, would show him the forge was not yet cold.

He had not been back to Aubecourt. He had not permitted himself even the road. Once, two years before, a truce conference had been called at

Pont-d'Ortelle, a half-day's ride from the Haut-Tertre, and he had sat through three days of clerks' quarrels and ridden home without once turning north, and Jean, who noticed everything, had said nothing, which was the Bastard's particular form of mercy.

Now the road was the only road. He folded the letter into his jerkin, over the heart, where he kept the things he did not intend to lose, and went down to the council.

* * *

They were twelve around the table, the great lords of Lorraine and the clerks who governed them, under a painted ceiling that flaked in the damp because there was no money to repair it. The Abbé de Viray sat at the duke's right hand, fifty years old and priestly in everything but shrewdness, with the face of a fasting saint and the mind of a Lombard. Jean lounged at his left, the hawk mercifully absent. The captains stood along the wall, smelling of horses.

The news from Vauréal had arrived in pieces: Roches-Noires, the dead duke, the destroyed army, the French at the fords, the girl in the high chair. Viray had assembled every dispatch and now summarized them in a voice made for sermons, so that even the dullest lord in the room could follow the road they were on.

"France intends the dismemberment," the abbé concluded. "The southern fiefs first, by this forfeit nonsense. Then the cities, which are already in revolt against their own duchess. Then, when Vauréal is a collection of obedient French towns, the turn of Lorraine, which has no money, no allies, and a frontier drawn by a madman. There is one wall between us and that future. It is not our army, excellent though the army is. It is a marriage."

A murmur. Old Comte de Salm, who had been against every innovation since the invention of gunpowder, cleared his throat. "The Vauréal girl. We know the history. She will not have him. The courtship of their childhood ended in the most public refusal this side of Rome. Why should she sign now?"

"Because she has no more choice than we have." Thiébaut spoke from the head of the table, and the room turned. "Her council has done its arithmetic. We have what she lacks: a field force that has not been broken. She has what we lack: everything else. This is not a courtship, Salm. It is a siege alliance, and the bride is a fortress."

"Then the terms," Viray said, and spread the draft treaty.

He had fought the terms, Thiébaut knew; the abbé fought every concession on principle, because concessions not fought for were

concessions unvalued. But the core of the document was the duke's own instruction, and it stood: separate sovereignty, separate seals, no Lorrainer office in Vauréal without her patent, the reversion clause that gave his house no grip on her inheritance if the marriage was fruitless. The lords who wanted him to demand the regency, the constableship, the right to garrison her towns, had all been overruled one by one.

"You give away every lever," Salm complained. "A husband's rights, a man's rights—"

"A man's rights do not hold Sainterre." Thiébaut's voice was quiet, and the old man subsided. "I have seen her father's court from the inside. Any lever I take, she will spend her whole reign working to pry loose, and her vassals will help her, and the French will walk through the crack. A light hand is not weakness. It is the only hand that can be kept there."

Jean grinned at him across the table. "Also, my brother is a romantic. He intends to be invited back."

"Your brother intends to be paid," Thiébaut said. "Speak to the gold convoy. It leaves Malemort the moment she receives our seal. Six months' arrears, Jean, in actual coin. The men will weep. Some of them may even salute."

The council laughed, even Salm. The vote, when it came, was unanimous, because unanimity is easy for men standing on a foundering ship. Viray sealed the treaty that night with the Lorraine arms, and the duplicate rode north at dawn with a fast escort, while Thiébaut sat late over maps of the Vauréal roads and calculated what he could spare to ride with him and what he dared not strip from his own walls.

* * *

Jean found him there after midnight, with two cups and a flask of the rough red wine the country produced in quantity and distinction avoided.

"Fifty lances," the Bastard said, sitting down uninvited. "That's the rumor. You're taking fifty lances into a country that's half in revolt with French columns on its roads. Have you considered a hundred?"

"A hundred strips Sarrebourg. Fifty says I come as a bridegroom. A hundred says I come as an occupying power, and every wall between here and Aubecourt shuts. I'll take fifty, and I'll take you, and I'll take the best scouts in Lorraine, and we'll ride fast and light and trust the countryside to be more afraid of the French than of us." He drank. "Also I want a word with you before I go. If I don't come back—"

"Spare me."

"If I don't come back, Lorraine passes to my uncle's line, and you know it. Viray has the succession papers. What I want is your word you'll hold the Vosges passes through the summer regardless. Don't chase my body with the army. Don't give battle in grief. Hold the roads, pay the garrisons with the Vauréal gold, and let the mountains do the work."

Jean was staring at him. "You actually expect trouble on the road."

"I expect the French have scouts too, and that a dead duke of Lorraine on his way to his wedding saves Paris a great deal of money. I expect bandits in the Harchies, because disorder always breeds them. I expect to be attacked. What I don't expect is to fail to arrive, because that would be rude, and she has already accused me in writing of being unable to receive the girl she used to be." He produced the letter, briefly, and tapped it. "I mean to answer that in person."

The Bastard looked at him for a long moment. The easy grin was gone. "You've never told me what happened there. At Aubecourt. The whole truth. I've stopped asking, mostly, because a man's silences are his own. But you're riding back into that house, and I'll say this once: whatever it was, you were twenty, and twenty-year-old men are not permitted to be wise, and most of them are not required to be brave in front of an entire court.

You did what you did. Don't let it eat the only useful alliance we've had in ten years."

Thiébaut turned the wine cup in his hands. The firelight moved on the painted walls. He thought of the letter in his jerkin, and of another letter, seven years old, that he had never answered because answering had been made the price of things he could not pay with words. He thought of a dawn in a dusty solar and the sound of a key turning, and of the only sentence he had been allowed to carry away from it: *This is my doing. She is innocent of everything but kindness.*

"Jean," he said. "If I told you the whole truth, you would do the one thing I cannot afford. You would forgive me. And then I should have to explain why forgiveness is not among the things on offer." He set down the cup. "Hold the passes. That's all I'll take from you tonight."

Jean said nothing more. They finished the wine in the old silence of men who had shared tents since boyhood, and at first light the duke of Lorraine heard Mass, kissed the abbey's relic, and rode out of Nancy under the alérion standard with fifty lances behind him and his brother at his side, west and north, toward the country that held his army's pay, his duchy's survival, and the one person in Christendom to whom he could not explain himself.

The road climbed into the March hills. Behind him the palace grew small, and the spires of Nancy, and the lead roofs of the cathedral; ahead, the long green country rolled away toward the river he had not crossed in seven years. He did not look back. Looking back was a luxury for men whose decisions were behind them.

* * *

They made the first night at a monastic grange in the hills, where the prior, a man with the eye of a mule trader, tried to charge the duke of Lorraine for the use of his own hayloft. Thiébaut paid without argument, in silver, and made a note of the grange's name, because wars were won and lost on such lists and he had a long memory for priors.

The fifty lances made camp with the practiced quiet of men who had done it in worse places. No fires beyond what cooking required, pickets on the high ground, the horses watered and unsaddled in strict rotation, the standard furled. Thiébaut walked the lines himself, as he always did, tasting the ration bread, testing a saddle girth, speaking to each man by name. It was not kindness, though it passed for it; it was the simplest discipline there was, the knowledge that an army which knows its leader's face is an army that will stand one volley longer than an army that does not.

Jean found him at the picket line, checking a hoof for a thrown shoe.

"Scouts in. The Harchies is busy. Two villages burned between here and the border, no one's colors, which means free companions wearing whichever colors suit the hour. The French pay them to chew the roads; our own merchants pay them to be left alone. They'll have heard a rich party is moving. Fifty lances is a tempting number."

"Not tempting enough for real soldiers. Tempting enough for bandits with a grievance." Thiébaut straightened. "We'll alter the march. Send four good men ahead in merchants' clothes, slow, with two pack mules and a visible purse. Let them be seen. The bandits will take the bait and show their position. We'll be a quarter-league behind in the woods, and we'll come at them from both sides of the road."

"That's a cold way to treat four good men."

"That's why I chose the four meanest men in Lorraine. Ask for volunteers; you'll have ten before you finish the sentence. Tell them the purse is theirs if it comes to a fight."

Jean laughed and went off to arrange it, and Thiébaut stood a while longer in the horse-smell and the dark, looking north. The grange stood on high ground, and beyond the black mass of the

nearer woods he could see the faint glow on the sky that was the watch-fires of the border marches, his country ending and hers beginning.

The shoulder woke him whenever he slept on hard ground. He had learned to lie on his right side and not move, and to think of other things, and tonight the other things were a solar with dust in the air and a girl's face lit by lightning. He allowed himself, once, in the dark of the hayloft with fifty men breathing around him, the memory he permitted only on the march: not the great hall, not the words, but the night before it, the two of them under one cloak, the solemn fifteen-year-old voice promising to give up the world for a cottage. He had believed her. That was the wound that never quite closed: not the loss, but the knowledge that she had meant it, every word, and that he had been made to answer meaning with theater, and that she would go to her grave believing the theater was the man.

He had thought, in the first years, that he would find some way to tell her. A letter through a trusted hand. A meeting at a pilgrimage shrine. Some crack in the wall of silence that the old duke had built around the girl, the maid, and the clerk. But the watch had been thorough, and the threats had been precise, and Thiébaut of Lorraine had come home to a duchy on the edge of dissolution with no money and no friends, and the years had done what years do: the possible routes had closed

one by one, and the silence had become a habit, and the habit had become a kind of stone.

Then Hugues was dead, and the stone was suddenly a road, and the road led here, to a hayloft, to a wedding, to a woman who had written him a letter as precise and merciless as a tax assessment and signed it with his own heart's first word.

He slept at last, badly, and was woken before dawn by the scouts' return, and by first light the column was moving again, down out of the hills, toward the forest and the border and whatever the road had in its throat.

* * *

The border was a river called the Nied, no wider than a banquet table, with a stone bridge that had been repaired so often it looked like an old man's teeth. Lorraine ended at the nearer bank. Vauréal began at the farther, and the difference was visible at once: the Lorraine side kept its watchtower manned, its hedge trimmed, its customs officer present and alert. The Vauréal side had a tower with a mossy roof and no flag, a customs house with its door hanging open, and an officer who arrived at a trot ten minutes after the column, buttoning his tunic.

He was an elderly sergeant with a Vauréal badge gone green at the edges, and he took one

look at the alérion standard and another at fifty quiet men in steel and chose his words with the care of a man negotiating with weather.

"My lord duke. We were told to expect a great train, baggage wagons, the whole court. The duchess's people are preparing at Aubecourt—"

"The duchess's people will be surprised, which is good for them and bad for anyone waiting on the road. Sergeant, your tower has no watch. Your customs house has no books. Who holds this bridge at night?"

The man swallowed. "We do, my lord. Four men. Though since the Roches-Noires, the levy's been drawn down for the southern forts, and four is—"

"Two, and one of them old. I can count the chickens from here." Thiébaut sat his horse and looked at the empty tower, and the sergeant watched him look, and the years of the man's life passed visibly across his face. "I am not your officer, and I will not be until your duchess makes me so, if she does. But write this down tonight in whatever book you have left: a bridge with no watch is a road with an invitation. Light the tower beacon at dusk from now on, every dusk, and send a rider to Aubecourt with the word that the Duke of Lorraine crossed the Nied with fifty lances on the third of April and found the gate of the

marches asleep. You'll be thanked or hanged, and either way the watch improves."

He left the sergeant stammering and crossed the bridge into Vauréal, and felt the country change under his horse's hooves the way a man feels a floor change in a strange house. It was richer country, that was the first thing: wider fields, bigger barns, stone villages with church spires, the commerce of a duchy that had not spent two generations being fought over. And it was frightened country, the second thing: farmsteads with the shutters nailed, a mill standing idle with its gate padlocked, families on the road with carts heaped high, going north, away from the French and the fords and the smoke on the southern horizon.

At midday they passed a burned hamlet. It was still warm; the raiders had been there within the day. Three cottages, a smithy, a byre, the usual wreckage of a quick visit, and in the churchyard two fresh mounds with a wooden cross apiece, dug by whoever had survived. Thiébaut dismounted and walked the ground the way his trade taught him: the hoofprints, the cart ruts, the ash pattern, the place where the raiders had watered their horses. Jean joined him, grim.

"Twelve, fifteen horses. No pikes, no order. Free companions, like the scouts said. They came from the southeast and went northwest, back

toward the Harchies. They have oxen with them, look, the wide wheels. They're carrying everything that wasn't nailed down."

"And two graves. Who?"

A woman's voice answered from the church door: "My man and the priest's boy. They stood at the bridge with axes. The rest of us ran for the woods. We came back when they'd gone."

She was thirty perhaps, hard and thin, with a child clamped to her hip and ash on her face and the particular calm of people who have used up their fear. Behind her, other villagers were drifting out of the trees, the way villagers do after the soldiers leave, to see what remains.

Thiébaut took off his glove. "Woman, the men who did this. How far ahead?"

"Half a day, lord, if you're asking me to guess. They had our cattle. Cattle are slow." She looked at the standard, and then at him, with a peasant's unblinking assessment. "You're the duchess's Frenchman, then. The one she's marrying."

"I am the duke of Lorraine. Whether I am the duchess's anything remains under discussion. Can your village feed fifty men for an hour? Bread, cheese, water; I pay, in silver, on the nail."

It was the silver that decided her, as silver decides most things in burned villages. An hour

later the column ate in the churchyard, under the wooden crosses, and the villagers watched the strange soldiers who paid for bread and cut their own firewood, and the woman with the child sat on the church step and told Thiébaut the news of the marches: the raiding bands, the French patrols, the lords who had begun looking the other way, the name everyone whispered, though she would not say whose tenants they had once been. Hautperthuis. The name hung in the air unsaid, the way smoke hangs in a thatch.

He gave her a purse for the two graves and a note under his hand to the nearest Vauréal garrison, and rode on with the ash of the hamlet in his nostrils.

* * *

That evening, in a beech wood above the road that entered the Harchies, the scouts came back with the confirmation. The bandits were camped in a ruined charcoal burner's clearing two leagues ahead, perhaps forty strong, drunk on the hamlet's cider, with the stolen oxen and a dozen other miserable prizes. The four decoy merchants had been seen on the road; the bandits meant to take them at dawn where the forest narrowed.

"Forty," Jean said, weighing it. "Fifty. I've seen worse odds at dice."

"We won't use the odds. We'll use the ground." Thiébaut had the map on his knees, a sketch the scouts had made on bark. "They expect four merchants. They'll come down off this slope onto the road at the narrows. We put the lances in the trees on both sides, dismounted, horses held back. The merchants ride through at dawn, slow, fat, careless. When the bandits commit, we close the road behind them and take them from the flanks. No pursuit into the deep wood; the Harchies is their house and ours only up to its door. Any man who throws down a weapon is bound, not killed; I want tongues more than corpses."

"Tongues for what?"

"For whoever's paying them. A free company doesn't burn Vauréal villages within a week of a French invasion for its health. Somebody with a seal has hired the road to be unsafe. I want the name on the seal."

The captains nodded and moved off to their posts. In the last light, Thiébaut walked the picket line himself, checking the lances, the girths, the quiet of the horses. He stopped at the edge of the wood where the road ran north, and between the black trunks, far off across the rolling dark of the country, he saw it: a point of light, then another, then a scattered constellation, the lamps and watch-fires of a great town in a river valley.

Aubecourt. The Haut-Tertre would be up there on its bluff above the lamps, and someone in it would be sitting up late over ledgers, because she always had, even as a child, even when the candles were rationed; the girl who had learned Latin from siege manuals and skated badly and promised away the world in a storm. Two more days, if the dawn went well. One fight, fifty bandits, and then the gate at noon and the letter's conditions and a marriage made of paper and necessity and a seven-year-old silence he still did not know how to break.

Jean came up beside him and followed his eyes. "Lights," the Bastard said. "Civilization. Wine. Beds. A man could get himself killed tomorrow and never know what the duchess keeps in her cellars."

"Then don't get killed." Thiébaut turned back into the wood, where his men were bedding down among the beeches. "And Jean. At dawn, when it starts, keep close. I have a wedding to arrive at, and I mean to arrive on time."

CHAPTER FIVE

The Road Between Armies

Din the Harchies came down grey through the beeches, the kind of light that makes every man look already dead. The four decoy merchants came along the road at a mule's pace, leading two pack animals and arguing loudly about tolls, their purses clinking with the silver Thiébaut had given them, which each man had sworn on his mother to return. They were the four meanest men in Lorraine, as requested, and they were enjoying themselves.

In the trees on both sides of the narrows, the lances waited dismounted, steel dark, horses held a hundred paces back. Thiébaut stood behind a trunk at the bend with Jean and the scout captain, and watched the road through the mist that the night's frost had drawn out of the ground. The bad shoulder was stiff under the leather; he worked it in small rotations, silently, the way he did before any fight, as though the old wound were a dog that needed to know who was master.

They came at the merchants from uphill, as predicted: a rush of ragged men in stolen jacks and ill-fitting sallets, perhaps thirty-five of them, with a few genuine men-at-arms among the trash and a

captain on horseback in a dented breastplate, shouting to kill the mules first. The merchants, who had been chosen partly for their sprinting, scattered off the road with remarkable conviction. The bandits reached the packs.

Thiébaut's horn blew once.

The lances came out of the trees on both sides in the same instant, not charging, because cavalry in a beech wood was a way to break horses' legs, but walking in fast in their steel, in ordered files, and the narrows became a pen. The bandits' captain understood the arithmetic in the first ten seconds and spurred his horse at the uphill bank to break out, and the scout captain, who had been placed exactly for that possibility, took him through the throat with a spear. After that it was the usual miserable work of a trap closing: men screaming in two languages, the wet sound of blades on jack-leather, a few shots from bandit hand-cannons going wild into the canopy, and then, quickly, the clatter of thrown-down weapons and the sound of Lorraine men shouting that lives were to be kept.

It lasted as long as it takes a kettle to boil. Of the bandits, eleven were dead, six more would die before noon, and the rest were bound with their own bowstrings against the beech trunks. Of the lances, one man had a broken arm and another a pike wound in the thigh, and the four merchants

were winded and rich in their own silver and already telling the story at twice its length.

Thiébaut cleaned his sword on a dead man's cloak and went to look at the prisoners.

* * *

They picked the undercaptain for the questions, a man with a split lip and a sensible face, who watched the hanged bodies of the two men who had refused to talk with the resignation of a professional revising his rates. Jean did the asking, Thiébaut the listening; he had learned early that a man who stays silent in an interrogation gets told more than a man who shouts.

The undercaptain's name was Beraud, and he had been a soldier once, in a real company, before the peace put him out of work and the roads put him back into it. The band had formed in January, he said, paid through the winter by a factor who came out of Pont-d'Ortelle, a man with no badge and good French gold. The work was simple: keep the roads frightened, burn the villages that paid their taxes too promptly, make the duchess's new reign look like a season in hell. Lately there had been a special commission.

"Word came ten days back," Beraud said, watching the bodies swing. "A party was coming from Lorraine. Small, rich, maybe the duke himself. We were to hit it in the forest and make

sure none reached Aubecourt. There was to be a bonus for the duke's body, and the factor said the proof wanted rings or a seal, not a story."

"Who is the factor's master?"

Beraud's split lip tried to sneer and failed. "My lord, factors don't tell road captains their masters. I can tell you he had the manners of a lord's steward and the money of the French crown, and both can be hired by the same man in this country. There's a lord on the southern marches whose tenants never get burned, have you noticed? Every village for leagues around is ash, and his stay fat and his mills turning."

"Hautperthuis," Jean said.

"I didn't say it. You did." Beraud looked at Thiébaut with the odd, level honesty of a man who had nothing left to sell but information and meant to get the going rate. "My lord duke, kill me or keep me, but I'll tell you one thing free. You're riding to a wedding in a house that's already got a thief in it. The French aren't at the gate of that duchy. They're at the council table. I've served lords half my life. I know the smell."

Thiébaut had him kept alive and bound for the Aubecourt cells, along with three others who confirmed the gist, and he wrote a short report in his own hand before the column moved on, because the duchess's letter had insisted on the

terms of his entry and he meant to enter the gate with something worth more than courtesy. The name Hautperthuis he did not write down. Names written on the road were names read by the wrong courier; he would give her that one in a room with the door shut.

* * *

At the Haut-Tertre, Jeanne reviewed the wedding arrangements as though they were a campaign, which in her opinion they were.

She went through the hall kitchens with the head cook and cut the banquet courses from twelve to nine, because a court that feasted while its garrisons went unpaid would be judged for it by every spy in Christendom, and because she wanted the guild deputies who would be present to remember restraint rather than revelry. She approved the stands in the courtyard and then moved them twice, for sightlines. She made Brive show her the gatehouse guard rotations three times and added twenty picked men in the livery of her own household, none of them Lorrainers. She set the seating in the cathedral with Foulques and then unseated it and set it again, because the order of benches was a declaration of the order of the world, and her vassals were reading it like scripture.

"Twice you've moved the Bishop of Heurtois," Foulques observed.

"The Bishop of Heurtois can sit behind the Sainterre aldermen and consider the humility of the Church. The aldermen are the ones I need to watch the wedding and believe the marriage is strong. Where is the Lorraine train now?"

"Last night's rider puts them in the Harchies. Fifty lances, my lady, when we were promised a great train."

"Good. A great train is an occupation. Fifty is an insult to bandits." She paused over the lists. "Any trouble on the road?"

"Not yet reported."

"He's early by a day. A man who arrives early to his own wedding is either eager or anxious, and Thiébaut of Lorraine has never in his life been eager. Make sure the gate is ready at noon. If he comes sooner, he waits until noon. I will not have this court think its duchess was caught putting on her shoes."

By the morning of the fifth of April the whole Haut-Tertre had been scrubbed, dressed, and drilled into a theater of sovereignty. The lower town turned out along the processional way, because a royal wedding was free bread and a holiday and the sight of the man the rumors had been chewing for a month. Banners hung from

every window, red and silver and the Lorraine alérions together, and the heralds had new tabards, and the choir had practiced until the precentor despaired.

Jeanne dressed in the steel-grey gown with the silver thread, and a veil so fine it seemed to float, and no maiden's white anywhere. Lisette laced her with the grim efficiency of a squire arming a knight.

"Your hands are cold," the maid said.

"My hands are always cold. It's a family trait."

"Your hands are shaking, which is not." Lisette tied the last knot and stepped back, and her face did the thing it did when she was choosing between truth and kindness, and truth won, as it usually did with Lisette. "He can't reach you, whatever he is now. Not in there, in front of everyone. The whole court is your armor. Walk through the day one trumpeter at a time."

Jeanne looked at herself in the silver-backed glass her mother had brought from her own wedding. A face she knew and did not quite recognize: the ducal daughter become the duchess, thin from three weeks of no sleep, eyes too large, mouth set. She thought of the girl in the solar, who had promised cottages and meant them, and she put that girl away the way she put away

the casket, with a key and a lock and a chain at her throat.

"One trumpeter at a time," she said. "Send word when he reaches the lower gate."

* * *

He came up from the river road at the head of his fifty lances, and the watchers on the walls saw first the standard and then the man, and the noise of the crowd changed pitch, the way it does when a rumor becomes a person.

Thiébaut rode a grey warhorse with its tail braided for ceremony, and he wore black armor without ornament and a surcoat of Lorraine's arms, and he had his brother beside him and his banner behind, and that was all. No wagons, no crowd of courtiers, no display beyond the thing itself. Jeanne watched from the gatehouse window behind a curtain, as a duchess may watch before she is seen, and her heart performed its treason again and she refused it audience.

He was broader than the boy. Seven years had cut the youth out of him and left something weathered and spare; he sat the horse like a man born at that altitude. Even at this distance she could see the economy of him, no gesture wasted, the eyes moving across the walls, the gatehouse, the guard positions, reading the fortress as she read ledgers. Then he dismounted in the courtyard

with the ease of long practice, and turned, and looked up at the gatehouse window with perfect timing, as though he had known she was there, and she let the curtain fall a heartbeat too late.

Noon. The trumpets went, and the great doors opened, and she walked down through the hall between the rows of her household, with Brive at her right and Foulques at her left and her train carried by two pages, and she emerged into the April sunlight of the upper courtyard where the Duke of Lorraine waited with his lords.

He knelt. It was the first gesture, and it was correctly done, the vassal-king of a foreign duchy kneeling to the sovereign of this one on her own ground, and the court noted it with the hunger courts have for small victories. Then he rose at her gesture, and they faced each other across two paces of flagstone, and seven years of silence stood between them like a third person.

Up close, his face was worse: hazel eyes greenish in the open air, the same eyes, lines at their corners that had not been there, a scar at the jaw she did not know, the mouth set in the formal curve of a man performing a public self. He smelled of horses and steel and road dust and, faintly, of the cold-water soap of camps.

"Madame la duchesse." His voice had changed, deepened, acquired the low register of camps. "I have the honor to place myself and my company at

your service, in accordance with the treaty between our houses. I come as your ally and your contracted husband, and I thank you for the welcome of your gate."

She had prepared her answer in writing and rehearsed it twice, and it came out level. "My lord duke, the Duchess of Vauréal receives you gladly, and the more gladly for the speed of your coming. Your company shall be honored in this house as our own. The council and the hall await you. You have had a long road."

"Not so long as some roads, madame." A beat, half a beat, the faintest stress on the word, invisible to anyone but her. "I have something for your private ear, when you choose. The Harchies gave us a small morning's work, and the names in it concern you more than me."

"You may present it to the council, my lord."

"I would rather present it to you. Names written in council chambers have a way of migrating. I was taught that at this court."

She held his eyes. Behind them the whole courtyard held its breath, though it could not have said why. "Then you shall have a private audience after the welcoming feast, my lord, with the chancellor and the marshal present. We do not keep rooms in this house without witnesses."

"No," he said, and for one instant something moved behind the formal face, old and tired and entirely without surprise. "I remember."

Brive stepped forward with the courtesies, and the moment passed into ceremony, and the two of them walked into the hall side by side, not touching, at the exact distance prescribed by the master of protocol, while the heralds shouted their styles and the crowd strained to see.

* * *

They had put him in the best guest suite, which adjoined her own apartments through a small connecting room that had been used, in her grandfather's day, for the ladies-in-waiting of visiting queens. The door between was heavy oak, and it had a lock, and Jeanne had the lock changed before his arrival and both keys brought to her.

The feast went by in the disciplined blur of state occasions. She ate little and noticed everything: the way his men drank the wine and judged it; the Bastard Jean making the lady next to him laugh within five minutes; Thiébaut's careful attention to every man presented, his hand on the arm of the old Brive, his correct indifference to the watching Hautperthuis. He did not look at her more than courtesy required, and she did not look at him at all, and the court saw two sovereigns behaving like sovereigns and was slightly disappointed.

After the feast, the private audience in the round chamber, with Foulques and Brive and the door guarded. He told them about the Harchies band, the French gold, the commission against his person, the steward's manners, and the unwritten name. Brive's face went the color of old beef. Foulques made notes with a hand that did not tremble, though Jeanne saw his jaw work once. When the duke had finished, she asked him why he had not written the name.

"Because I intend to be certain before I say it in a room with paper." He looked at her directly, the first unguarded look of the day. "Madame, a man can be hanged on a road captain's rumor. I would give you proof, or nothing. In the meantime, watch the lords whose mills keep turning."

She inclined her head, and the audience ended, and the day ended, and the palace of the Haut-Tertre banked its fires and its gossip and went to bed.

In her chamber, Jeanne dismissed the women and sat alone in the dark, on the edge of the great bed, listening. Through the connecting wall she heard, faintly, the small sounds of another person settling for the night: a boot set down, a pitcher pouring, the creak of a chair. Then silence. She wondered whether he was also sitting in the dark, and she hated the wondering, because it was the

girl's wonder and not the duchess's, and the girl was supposed to be locked away.

On the other side of the wall, Thiébaut sat with his head in his hands and the bad shoulder burning, and did not light a candle either. He had crossed half a country of burning villages to reach this room, and the hardest league of the journey was the thickness of one oak door, and he had no orders for taking it.

* * *

He did not sleep either.

He sat in the dark of the guest chamber with his boots off and his sword across his knees, the way he had learned to sit in the worst winters of Lorraine, and he listened to the small sounds that told him the room beyond the wall was occupied: a footstep, the faint creak of the bed frame, once the low murmur of a woman dictating to a maid at an hour when the court believed duchesses slept. The Harchies road and the bandits and the long ride seemed, in this room, to have happened to another man. Here he was twenty years old again, walking these same corridors with a ward's careful eyes, learning which boards creaked and which guards could be talked to and the exact hour the east wing went dark.

He rose after a while and went to the window, and the moonlit Haut-Tertre arranged itself below

him exactly as he remembered: the lower courtyard, the well, the wall of the lower garden with its crumbled coping, the road bending south by the willows. Seven years of his life had been spent in the keeping of this view. He had learned his letters in the schoolroom wing, his swordcraft in the yard, his first and only lessons in the cost of love in the old solar at the end of the gallery. The palace had not changed. The girl in the next room had changed into a duchess who wrote letters as cold as charter law and signed them with his own heart's first word.

A man could be afraid of many things in this trade. French lances, unpaid mutineers, the winter road. He had schooled himself out of all of them. He had not, he discovered, schooled himself out of the sound of her voice saying *my lord* as though he were an envoy from a distant country, and he stood at the window a long time, making his peace with the fact that the hardest siege of his life was going to be conducted in the same house as its prize.

When the moon went behind a cloud he said the soldier's prayer his mother's people had used, the short one, the one that asked for steadiness rather than victory, and lay down in his clothes with the sword unsheathed beside the bed, and at last, near dawn, he slept.

* * *

Dawn brought the bell for prime and the realization that a military man in the palace would not be kept in a guest suite like a piece of wedding plate. Thiébaut sent a request, correctly through the marshal's office, to see the muster and the walls. Jeanne granted it and came down to the inner courtyard herself, in a riding gown and a short cloak, to find him already there in a plain leather coat, talking horseflesh with the master of the stable.

Brive arrived a moment later, armed and armored for a parade, and the two soldiers went over the guard of the gatehouse together with the instant freemasonry of men who had both stood watches no one paid them for. The old marshal had intended, Jeanne could tell, to be unimpressed. Ten minutes in, he was arguing pike drill with the Lorrainer as though they shared a tent.

"Your wall pieces are good," Thiébaut said, running a hand along the breech of a wrought-iron serpentine. "Better than I expected. But they're mounted on the old carriages, high and fixed. The French guns at the Roches-Noires were low, on wheels, and they moved between shots. A gun that cannot be re-aimed is a bell."

"The master of ordnance, Van Brock, says the same." Brive looked sour. "He has said it for a year. The treasury says carriages."

"The treasury will find the carriages cheaper than a breach." Thiébaut turned to Jeanne, including her without turning the talk into a lesson. "Madame, if you permit, I'll have my own master gunner draw the carriage plans for Van Brock. The Lorraine foundries cast for that pattern now."

"You may. I'll have the chancellor note it as a gift under the treaty's military clause." She kept her voice even. "We keep accounts of gifts, like everything else."

"I remember." The ghost of something, not quite a smile. "You kept accounts of the orchard apples. I believe I owed you seven."

It was the first personal thing he had said, and it landed in the courtyard so quietly that only she caught the full weight of it, a stone dropped into still water. Brive had moved on to the next gun. The stable grooms were occupied. For two breaths they were alone in a crowd.

"Six," she said. "You ate seven, but one was sour, and I credited it."

"A generous reign."

"A precise one." She turned away before her face could do anything. "The council sits at ten, my lord. My chancellor will bring the final marriage contract, and I expect you will wish to consult the Abbé de Viray. I am told he is in your train."

"He is. He is also, at this hour, discovering that your palace keeps a better cellar than Nancy's. At ten, madame."

* * *

She took the long gallery back to the state rooms, the one with the dead dukes in the wall niches, and he was there before her, having taken the shorter stair, and they met beneath the carved lion of her grandfather with only a pair of pages at the far end to keep the proprieties.

"Madame. A word, before ten o'clock, where there are no ledgers."

She stopped. The pages were too far to hear, near enough to see. "My lord."

"Your letter." He had it, she saw, in the inner pocket of his coat, worn soft at the folds; he carried it. "I have read it until I know it by heart, which is more than it deserves, since it was written by a woman determined to be cruel in the most correct language available. I will not pretend it did not wound me. I will pretend, for the sake of the house and the treaty and every ear in this palace, that it did not. But I will not have us begin on a falsehood. The girl you say is not at home is the reason I am here. The duchy is the reason I signed. Both can be true. Men are permitted more than one reason, even in a letter."

Jeanne's hands were cold again. She folded them to keep them still. "You are permitted reasons, my lord. I am permitted walls. You of all people should know I had good teachers in the building of them."

That got through. She saw it get through, the small recoil behind his eyes, the disciplined face holding. "Yes," he said. "I did teach you that. Among other things. I hope the other lessons served you better than that one."

"They all served me." She looked past him, at the carved lion, at the painted glass, at anything but the greenish hazel eyes. "At ten o'clock, my lord. The treaty. Nothing but the treaty. Whatever else either of us is carrying, it does not sit at the council table. I find governments are easier than history."

"Governments can be amended. History cannot. But I accept your terms. They are, after all, your house." He stepped aside, against the wall, the gesture of a man yielding a passage, and she walked between him and the carved stone with her veil just brushing his sleeve, and did not hurry, and did not look back, and reached the turn of the stair before she allowed herself to breathe.

In her chamber she found Lisette laying out the council gown, and the maid took one look at her face and asked no questions, which was the highest service Lisette owned. Jeanne sat at the

table and uncapped the ink and wrote at the top of a fresh page, in the hand she used for the state, the agenda of the ten o'clock council: dower, revenues, troops, patents, style. She wrote them twice, because the first hand shook, and the second did not.

Then she rang for the chancellor and went down to make a marriage with the only man in Christendom she had ever loved and the only one she had ever feared, and she meant to get the better of the bargain, whatever it cost her.

CHAPTER SIX

The Treaty of Everyone But Them

She was at the table by seven, with the fire newly lit and Colard yawning into his sleeve, and the contract between them under a

weight of the late duke's dagger. Foulques arrived as the cathedral bell struck, immaculate as ever, carrying a second folder tied with green ribbon.

"The history of the reversion clause," he said, sitting. "You asked for it in writing. Three precedents. The marriage of 'fifty-one, where the widow's duchy was swallowed entire; the Hainaut settlement of 'sixty-four, which our side should have copied; and the Brabant case of 'seventy, where the children's inheritance nearly cost a county a war. I have marked the passages."

Jeanne turned the pages by the window's grey light. "He drafted a reversion that protects me. His own chancellor must have bled."

"Viray bleeds professionally. The question, madame, is why the duke permits it. Councils do not give away claims their masters want."

"Perhaps he does not want claims. Perhaps he wants a working ally and knows a stolen duchy is the least working thing in Christendom." She closed the folder. "Or perhaps he is more patient than the rest of them and intends the marriage itself to do what the clauses do not. Maître Foulques, I have asked you before and I will ask you once more, because today is the last day I can ask cheaply. Is there anything about the Duke of Lorraine I do not know? Anything at all? You were my father's hand in the business of that year. If there is a debt, a woman, a promise, a written thing—"

The chancellor's face did not change. It never did. But she had learned to watch his hands, and his hands straightened the green ribbon twice. "There is nothing that touches the treaty, madame. The man is poor, hard-pressed, and honest in his public dealings, which in a ruler is nearly a vice. As for the rest," he selected the words like a man selecting stones, "some doors are locked by people other than the persons standing outside them. I would not have you marry under a mistake, but neither can I give you a key I was never permitted to hold. Today, negotiate the treaty. Leave the man for after."

It was the closest he had ever come to the wall he kept around that year, and she filed it, as she filed everything, and let the bell finish striking. "Very well. Colard, the dower figures again. If the

abbé starts at fifteen percent, I will weep into my wine and accept ten."

Colard, who had never seen her weep over anything but her father's vault, bowed over his ledgers.

The ten o'clock council filled the round chamber with the particular silence of two sets of lawyers preparing to be difficult about money. On the Vauréal side sat Foulques with his clerks, Colard with his ledgers, Brive in steel as a matter of principle, and Jeanne in the high chair. On the Lorraine side the Abbé de Viray arranged his papers like a chess player, the Bastard Jean lounged against the wall with the air of a man attending for amusement, and Thiébaut sat upright on a plain stool with nothing in front of him at all, which Jeanne noticed because every other man in the room had armed himself with documents.

"Shall we begin with the spiritual clauses," Foulques said, "or the temporal?"

"Begin with the temporal," said Thiébaut. "The spiritual ones are only money wearing a surplice."

Jean laughed. Viray permitted himself a small pained smile. Foulques, who had prepared a speech, discarded it and opened the marriage contract at the military schedule.

For an hour they ground through the troop clauses. Lorraine's obligation: twelve hundred

lances and three thousand foot for the duration of the French war, at Vauréal's expense, mustered at Pont-d'Ortelle by the feast of Saint John. The abbé, who had clearly been saving himself, objected to the mustering point, the expense schedule, the phrase *duration of the war* ("a war, madame, may be ended by a peace that the duchy of Lorraine is not a party to"), and above all to Jeanne's added clause doubling the quota in the event of direct invasion.

"Direct invasion is the entire point of the instrument," Viray said, with the patience of a man explaining water to a fish. "My master's whole force is perhaps four thousand effectives. Your clause would strip Lorraine of every garrison it possesses and place the whole army of an independent duchy under a war council headed by a lady who, with every respect, has never campaigned."

"The duchess heads the war council because the war is in the duchess's country." Foulques's tone was silky. "As for her inexperience, the abbot will observe that the clause does not require her to swing a sword, only to hold the council. The duke of Lorraine retains field command."

"Jointly," Thiébaut said.

Every head turned. He had not spoken in twenty minutes.

"The clause says jointly, and jointly is what I will accept," he continued, looking at Viray. "Abbé, the alternative is her treasury paying an army it does not trust, and a duchess who spends the war watching her own back instead of the French. I will give the orders in the field, but no major engagement, no siege, no withdrawal without the war council's seal. Write it that way. It costs us nothing and gives them a lock."

Viray's mouth opened, closed, and made a small note, the gesture of a man filing a grievance for another day. Brive stroked his white beard and looked at the Lorrainer with the first thing resembling approval Jeanne had seen on the marshal's face.

* * *

The dower clause took longer. Viray wanted the dower revenues collected by Lorraine officers and remitted quarterly to her household. Jeanne's addition required payment into an account controlled by Colard, in Vauréal coin, at the Malemort counting house, with penalty interest for late payment and a lien on the Lorraine saltworks as security.

"It is an insult," the abbé said.

"It is a dower," said Jeanne. "Insults are free. Dowers are enforced. My lord abbot, you are a priest and a chancellor, and you know as well as I

do that every widowed duchess of the last century who lost her revenue lost it through the courtesy of husband's officers. I will not be maintained by kindness. I will be maintained by contract."

"She has you there," Jean said from the wall. "Our own aunt was maintained by kindness for nine years. She died of it in a convent."

Viray shot his duke's half-brother a look that would have felled a smaller man and turned back to the table. "The saltworks lien is impossible. It touches the regalian rights—"

"The saltworks stay in." Thiébaut did not look up from the map he was studying. "Strike the penalty interest above ten percent. She'll accept that; it's the figure her own bank charges. Madame?"

Jeanne kept her face still. It was the second time he had read her clause as though he had written it, and in a sense he had, because he had already thought through where she would stop. "Ten percent. Agreed."

The patents clause followed, and here the room expected a fight, because it was the clause that made her sovereign in fact rather than in song: all offices, garrison commands, and patents in Vauréal to issue solely from her hand, including over any Lorrainer serving within her borders.

Viray argued that a duke whose troops garrisoned her fortresses must name their captains.

"Then his troops may camp outside the fortresses," Jeanne said. "I do not garrison my own walls with men who hold their commands from another sovereign. The captains are mine, on my lord duke's recommendation, and I will not often refuse him, but the patent is mine. There is no compromise available in this clause, because it is not a clause about captains. It is a clause about whose country this is."

She had expected the Lorrainers to press. She had expected, privately, a long afternoon. Thiébaut merely said, "Granted," before Viray could draw breath, and then, to his chancellor, "Abbé, the next time a French army crosses our border, ask the walls whose country they are. The answer will be the same as hers."

The inheritance clause brought the only heat of the morning, because it was the clause about the future's dead. If the marriage had issue, the children would inherit both houses, with the actual government of each passing only at majority, under separate regencies; if it had none, Vauréal followed its own ancient succession and Lorraine its own, and neither house might claim the other's soil by marriage right. Viray wanted a joint regency named in advance, with the surviving spouse at its head.

"That is the Brabant error," Foulques said, and produced the green-ribbon folder with the air of a man unveiling a weapon. "A joint regency is an auction in which the child's crown is sold to whichever parent's council moves first. The Hainaut model: separate regencies, native councils, the child's person in the keeping of the duchy it currently resides in. It held for eleven years of minority."

"It held," Viray countered, "because the Hainaut dowager was a saint. Ordinarily, madame, a widowed mother in a foreign court is the weakest political creature in Europe. My master asks only that if the worst befall, he keep his child and his child's interests together."

"If the worst befall," Jeanne said, "I will be dead, and my lord duke's interests will be the security of Lorraine, which is as it should be. My child's interests in Vauréal will be the Vauréal succession, which cannot be governed from Nancy without becoming Nancy's. Separate regencies. Native councils. The child's person follows the Vauréal court until the age of seven, and the Lorraine court after, since the schooling of princes belongs with the father's house. I will give you that much, and the marriage contract will name the visiting rights in full. Is it enough?"

Thiébaut looked at Viray; Viray looked at the ceiling, seeking patience from a God who had dealt

him many difficult mornings. "It is more than Hainaut. Write it."

The last addition was style, and here for the first time Foulques himself looked uneasy. She would be styled Duchess of Vauréal in her own right in both countries, in every document, on every seal and herald's tongue, never the duke's wife. No title of hers would pass to him. The marriage would create no regency, no guardianship, no curtailment.

"The precedent," Foulques murmured, "is unusual."

"The precedent is necessary." Jeanne looked around the table. "My vassals are deciding this month whether they are sworn to a person or to a marriageable property. Let them see the property cannot be married out of its own name. My lord duke? You have said nothing."

Thiébaut set down the map at last. "I have nothing to say against a thing I have already agreed to twice. My lords and my clerks, understand it plainly, so that no one misreports it in his own interest: I am marrying a sovereign, not acquiring a sovereignty. The duchess reigns here. I reign in Nancy. The treaty binds the two reigns. It does not fuse them. If that is not the document on the table, I will not sign the one that is."

In the silence that followed, Jeanne looked at him with the same feeling she had had in the courtyard: the disconcerting sense that the man across the table had already had this argument, alone, and won it against himself.

* * *

At midday they broke for bread and wine, and the clerks went to fair-copy the agreed clauses, and the principals were left with a short, carefully witnessed interval in the window embrasure, with Foulques and Viray ten paces away in deep and ostentatious conversation about cathedral music.

"You concede more than your council likes," Jeanne said, low. "Why?"

"Because my council is thinking of the wedding and I am thinking of the war." He kept his eyes on the courtyard below, where the Lorraine lances were being shown the well. "A marriage contract that gives me a grip on your government is a contract your vassals spend five years sawing through, while the French wait for the crack. I want a tool that holds, not a title that rusts. And, madame," he paused, choosing it, "there are cheaper ways to buy an obedient duchess. The market is full of fifteen-year-olds with empty claims. I came for the one who keeps her own ledgers."

"You came for the road."

"I came for several things, and I have told you that men may have more than one reason. The road is among them. So is the fact that your wall guns need new carriages and your marshal is sixty-three and your treasury borrows at fourteen percent and your nearest lord is writing letters to Paris. You need me. I need you. The only open question between us is whether we do this well or badly, and I do not intend to do anything badly for the rest of my life, which I expect to be short if this fails."

It was the plainest speech any man had made to her since her father died, and she did not trust it, which she also marked in the ledger. "And the past? You ask me to bind myself for life to a man who once stood in my father's hall and—"

"And told a room full of witnesses that you were a foolish child." His voice had gone lower still, almost to itself. "Madame, I cannot undo that morning. I cannot even explain it to your satisfaction, not here, not now, perhaps not ever. I will say only this, and then I will not say it again while the treaty stands between us: that morning was not what it looked like, and there are documents in this world that lie by telling the truth. If the treaty is all you can ever bring yourself to have of me, I will take it and serve it and keep your borders, and you will never hear the word *once* from my lips. But I did not ride through a forest of hired killers to collect a document. You

may decide what I came for, in the end. You get to decide everything. I made sure of it in the clauses."

She had no answer ready. She had prepared for every argument except the argument that left her the judge. The silence lengthened, saved by the return of the clerks with their fair copies and their fresh ink, and the moment went under the surface like a stone in dark water.

* * *

They signed in the afternoon, in the great hall, before the assembled vassals and envoys, because every signature in this country was a performance. The documents lay on a table under the arms of Vauréal and the alérions of Lorraine, and the seals went down in red wax, and the heralds proclaimed the league and the coming marriage, and the company applauded in the careful measure of people calculating how the news would land elsewhere.

Jeanne watched her court through her lashes while the trumpets sounded. Hautperthuis, in the front rank, wore the face of a man at a feast who has found a hair in his soup and intends to eat smiling; his gloved hands clapped twice and stopped. The Erquelines nephew clapped with the earnestness of a man composing a letter to his uncle. The Sainterre deputies, three guildsmen admitted for the occasion, clapped like merchants

pricing a cargo. Von Zollern, the imperial, did not clap at all, and wrote something in a little book. Dolfin, at the back, smiled at her the way a banker smiles at a loan he has already decided to grant, and she understood that the Venetian had been certain of the signature before she had.

The formal betrothal followed at the cathedral door, per verba de praesenti under the bishop's eye, the words that made them contractually one before God while leaving the sacrament for the wedding. Thiébaut placed the ring on the book and then on her finger, and his knuckle grazed hers, and the contact went through her like a bell through a house. Neither of them looked at the other during the vows, which the court read as dignity and she read as self-defense.

* * *

Dolfin requested an audience before the sun was down, and received it in the treasury office, the room with no tapestries and one chair for the borrower, which was her father's little joke and now hers. The Venetian came with a single clerk and an iron-bound chest, and he did not waste the hour on congratulations.

"The first installment, ten thousand écus, weighed and sealed." He set the chest's inventory on the table. "The gold reaches Malemort by barge on the tenth, under my house's guard and my

house's banner, which even the French do not care to rob, since they owe my partners in Paris. My congratulations, by the way, are genuine. A marriage treaty this sensible is rare enough to be a collector's item."

"Your house's terms improved the moment his signature went on it." Jeanne turned the inventory. "The interest fell from fourteen to twelve and a half before the ink dried. I had not yet written to accept."

"You had not yet needed to. The treaty changed the collateral. A Lorraine army in being is worth one and a half percent in Venice; I could show you the tables." Dolfin folded his hands. "Madame, permit me a second piece of arithmetic, since the first has served us both. The loan will pay the troops and the guns through one campaign season. It will not pay for a lost city and a long war. Whatever happens at Sainterre, end it quickly. Revolts are like pregnancies; they become much more expensive after the first signs show."

"You have a low opinion of cities, Messer Dolfin."

"I have a precise opinion of cities, which is rarer. Sainterre does not want freedom. Sainterre wants its tolls fixed and its own men in its courts, and it will call those things freedom and die for them cheerfully. Give it the things. Keep the war taxes. A contented city that pays is the best

collateral in Europe; ask my partners in Florence, who own one." He rose. "I will also, if you permit, advance the wedding feast's costs against the next installment. A duchess who pays her fishmongers on the day of her marriage is a duchess the lower town believes in. Credit, madame, is only belief with a ledger."

When he had gone, Colard stared at the chest as though it might bite. "He gives advice like a member of the council."

"He gives advice like a man who owns a mortgage on the council's house. Write his every suggestion into the minutes. If his arithmetic works, we follow it and he takes the pride; if it fails, we have his handwriting." She locked the inventory away. "The gold to Malemort, and a strong escort of our own household alongside his banner. I want no story that Vauréal's war is paid by Venetian guard alone."

That evening the dispatches came, two of them, hard on each other's heels like dogs at a gate.

The first was from Coppens at Sainterre, and it was barely a letter at all: de Key's faction had taken the cloth hall, armed the weavers' guild with crossbows, and declared that no charter sealed to a foreign husband would be recognized by the city. Two of the moderates had been dragged through the streets. Coppens himself was under siege in his own house, and the city gates were held by the

weavers. He wanted soldiers or he wanted instructions, and he made it plain he expected neither in time.

The second was from the commandant of the southern marches, shorter and colder: a French column under Graçay's vanguard had crossed the fords in strength, seized the bridge-fort of Saint-Vaast by the treachery of its own sergeant, and put the garrison to the sword. The road to Mont d'Or lay open. The commandant had forty-seven men and intended, he wrote, to die at his post if the duchess had no better use for him.

Foulques read both aloud to the council, and the room was very quiet.

"So much for the season of weddings," Brive said.

The argument began at once, the argument that every divided map produces. Brive wanted the feudal host, raw as it was, sent south to the fords before the French could push beyond Saint-Vaast. Viray wanted the Lorraine companies held intact and marched on Sainterre, because a city with crossbows and a printing press was a more dangerous enemy than a single captured bridge-fort. Colard wanted neither, because neither could be paid for past midsummer, and said so in the voice of a man reading his own death sentence.

Thiébaut let them run for five minutes, studying the wall map with his hands behind his back, and then he said, "The marshal loses the south, the abbot loses the north, and the treasurer loses the war. May I?"

He did not wait for permission. He crossed to the map and took the pointer from Foulques.

"Graçay is a professional. He will not march on Aubecourt from Saint-Vaast; he lacks the guns and the supply, and the Regent has not yet paid for a war of conquest. He means to digest the southern fiefs through the summer and make the war legal before he makes it large. The real danger in the south is therefore not the French army. It is the example. Every wavering lord with a road to Paris is watching to see whether the new duchess can make a French capture costly. Mont d'Or must be reinforced and visibly provisioned, which says to the waverers that the duchess still answers her mail."

He moved the pointer north.

"Sainterre is the war. A city of forty thousand that seizes its own gates in your first month is a story told in every guildhall from Bruges to Venice. If de Key holds it a season, Malemort follows, Grisay follows, and your revenue dies in its bed while Graçay is still writing polite letters. You cannot storm Sainterre; you have no siege train and the burghers would burn the cloth stores first.

You cannot ignore it; the silence kills you. You go to its gates with enough force to be respected and enough charter to be accepted, and you let the city's own moderates win the argument for you. Which means, madame, that the wedding comes first, and comes fast, because only a married alliance marches into Sainterre without looking like a desperate woman's gamble."

He set the pointer down.

"The forty-seven men at the southern post get a letter, a purse, and a replacement sergeant with twenty good troops, and we make a ballad out of their commandant's fidelity, because fidelity is cheaper than castles and worth more this month. The host assembles as planned. The Lorraine companies, when the gold arrives, go north with us, not south. The south holds by reputation until the north is settled. Those are my recommendations. The war council is yours."

The room was quiet again, but it was a different silence. Jeanne looked at Brive, and saw the old marshal swallow his first plan whole and nod, slowly, like a man conceding a point of swordwork.

Jeanne looked at the map on the round chamber's wall, at the two new fires burning at opposite ends of her inheritance, and then at the man she had promised to marry, who was already on his feet, already thinking in roads and days.

"Can you be married by Sunday?" she asked him.

"The banns—" Foulques began.

"Special license. The bishop owes me three favors and I am calling in the largest. Sunday, in the cathedral, full court, every vassal who can be made to attend. A wedding is a muster with better clothes, and I will not go to war as a betrothed woman with half my lords pretending the alliance is provisional. My lord duke? Sunday?"

Thiébaut's mouth did the thing that was not quite a smile. "Madame, I have been ready since I was twenty. Sunday."

* * *

That night she sat late with the ledger, while beyond the connecting wall the new occupant of the guest suite read dispatches from his own war. She could hear his chair, his step, the low murmur of his voice dictating to a clerk. Once, through the oak, she caught a laugh, brief and dry, at something the Bastard Jean had said.

She wrote the day's entry: the contract signed, the terms won, the betrothal sworn, the revolt and the fort and the Sunday wedding. Then she sat with the pen over the page and added, in the small hand no clerk copied, the thing she would not have said aloud in any room: *He gave me every clause I asked for, and three I did not dare ask for. I do not*

know whether to be grateful or afraid. I think in this house the two are the same.

Beyond the wall, the murmuring stopped. A board creaked, close, as though someone had sat down on the other side of the door. She held her breath. Then the sound moved away, and his footsteps crossed the room, and she heard him begin to dictate again, steadily, the orders for the road north.

She closed the ledger and went to bed, and for the first time in seven years she did not lock the connecting door, though she left the key in it, turned against him.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Wedding at Haut-Tertre

She was woken before dawn by the sound of the lower town hammering itself festive, and for a moment, in the dark, she could not remember why a city would be hammering at four in the morning, and then she could, and lay still with her hands flat on the sheet while the knowledge came over her like cold water: today.

Lisette came with the washing water and the women came behind her, four of them, Oriabel at their head with the dress over her arms like a priest carrying a vestment. The steel-grey gown had been remade in three nights of sleepless labor, the silver thread worked into a pattern of walls and rivers along the hem, and over it went the ducal mantle of red velvet lined with miniver, heavy as a responsibility, which her mother had worn and her grandmother before her. They dressed her as they would have armed a knight: layers, lacings, the ceremonial girdle low on the hips, the great ruby brooch at the throat, the veil held by a band of gold instead of a maiden's circlet. No white. No flowers in the hair. A sovereign's wedding.

"You are white enough without the cloth," Oriabel said, studying her. "Eat something. There will be nothing until the feast, and a fainting bride is a story the vultures will carry to Paris."

Jeanne forced down bread and hot milk in the little antechamber while the palace woke around her. Through the window she could see the processional way being strewn with fresh rushes, the guild banners going up between the houses, the crowd already thick in the square, a holiday crowd with the particular edge of a crowd that has been told it is witnessing history and intends to judge it. Children perched on the fountain. Sellers of pies and commemorative badges did a trade. She watched a man sell a hundred tin badges stamped with the two arms joined, and made a note to find out who had licensed him.

"Letters during the night," Lisette said, producing them from her apron like a conjuror. "Foulques said you would ask."

There were three. From Coppens, smuggled out of Sainterre in a bale of undyed cloth: the de Key faction now held three gates, and the moderates were being made to swear a weavers' oath on pain of losing their workshops. From the commandant at Mont d'Or: the southern fort Saint-Vaast was being strengthened by French engineers, and Graçay's guns had been seen on the kingdom road. And a short line from the forty-seven-man post

whose commandant she had promised a ballad: *Reinforcements received. We hold. The duchess's name is said at every watch.*

She read them all and put them all away, and when she looked up the women were watching her with the particular gentleness people reserve for brides, and she understood that they had no idea she had just spent her wedding morning on three separate emergencies, and that this was the condition of her life from now on: to be always, in every room, the only person who knew the whole bill.

"One more thing," Lisette said, and brought out a small package. It was a handkerchief of the finest linen, edged with old lace, and Jeanne recognized it at once: her mother's, kept these thirteen years in the same casket as the unsent letters. "Oriabel thought. For the church. Something of hers."

Jeanne held it. Her mother had married at seventeen, a girl with a duchy in her dowry, and had died at thirty on a blood-soaked bed trying to give the duchy a spare heir. The handkerchief smelled faintly of dried lavender, kept with herbs all its long widowhood in the dark. Jeanne folded it into her sleeve and said, "Thank you. Both of you. Now find me the marshal. I want the guard rotation one more time before I put on the veil."

* * *

The procession left the Haut-Tertre at nine, between double ranks of household troops in the red and silver, and the crowd's noise hit her like weather as she came through the gate: bells, cheers, the deeper roar of thousands of people all exhaling at once. She walked under a canopy borne by four aldermen of Aubecourt, a canopy she had insisted on sharing with no one; the bridegroom walked fifty paces behind with his Lorraine lords, which was the order she had set and the heralds had argued about for two days. A duchess in her own right entered her own cathedral first, or did not enter at all.

The cathedral of Saint-Cyr was dressed as though for Easter, every chapel alight, every relic out, the nave hung with the joined arms in red and blue and gold. The bishop waited at the choir step in full pontificals, a fat, clever man who had sung her father's requiem three weeks ago and now stood ready to marry his daughter, and gave no sign that he found the rapidity of the transition remarkable. Bishops are trained early in the useful art of not being struck by history.

Thiébaut met her at the step. In black velvet with the Lorraine chain of office, he looked less like a bridegroom than like a man attending a council of war, which she suspected was the highest compliment available to him. He gave her the bow owed to a sovereign, and his eyes, passing over her in one quick clerk's inventory, missed

nothing: the veil, the brooch, the girdle, the hand she did not offer until the rubric required it. His own hand, when the moment came, was warm and hard and steady, a swordsman's hand with calluses along the fingers, and it closed on hers without urgency, the way one closes a hand on a helm before a charge.

The Mass was long, and she had been trained since childhood to endure long services with a face of attentive piety, and she endured this one as a performance inside a performance, her lips moving in the Latin while her mind went where it always went, to the accounts. The vows: to have and to hold, for richer for poorer, in sickness and in health. She made them in a clear voice, the voice of the council chamber, and heard his voice beside her, lower, answering the same ancient words in the same ancient language, two people promising things no contract could enforce. The ring went on, gold and plain, the bishop's hand over theirs, the smoke of the incense rising between their faces.

Then the kiss, the brief liturgical kiss of peace at the chancel rail, his mouth at the corner of hers in front of four hundred witnesses, the first time he had ever touched her with his lips, and the crowd in the nave broke into applause and cries of *Noël* and *Vauréal*, and she discovered that her heart was beating so hard she was afraid the ruby brooch would move with it.

"Madame la duchesse," he said, so low only she heard it, as they turned together toward the nave.

"My lord husband," she said, equally low, equally correct, and walked down the aisle on his arm at the sovereign's pace, while the bells of Saint-Cyr opened above them and the bells of the lower town answered and the noise rolled across the river to the camps of the army that was, after today, paid for by her gold and bound to her by this man's honor.

* * *

The feast ran to nine courses in the great hall, because twelve would have been vanity and seven an insult, and it lasted four hours, which was enough time for every faction in the duchy to present itself in the shape of a gift and a smile. Hautperthuis gave a gold cup engraved with a scene of the hunt, and a speech so perfectly pitched between grief and joy that she applauded with the rest while marking the cup's weight, which was less than its size. Erquelines's nephew gave the imperial letter he had been carrying for a week, choosing the wedding day to deliver a marriage offer from an Austrian cousin, a piece of insolence Jeanne received with thanks and set beside her plate where everyone could watch it be ignored. Dolfin's gift was a small painted map of the river trade, exquisitely done, which she valued

above all the rest and which the court took for a mere pretty thing.

The Lorraine men were the novelty, and the court inspected them as the court inspects everything, for weakness. The Bastard Jean sat below the salt and charmed the wife of the Aubecourt alderman within an hour, told a story about the Harchies bandits that lost nothing in the telling, and somehow ended the evening with the alderman himself proposing a family trade concession. The Abbé de Viray discussed plainsong with the bishop and grain prices with Colard, in the same gentle voice, and Jeanne saw Foulques watching the priest with the wary respect of one professional recognizing another.

Her husband sat at her right hand under the canopy of estate and ate whatever was put before him and spoke when spoken to and watched the room. Once, when the trumpets came in with the subtleties, the sugar castles and heraldic beasts that the cooks had spent two days on, she felt his glance and turned, and he said, under the noise, "In Nancy we cannot afford sugar. My cooks believe this is a fairy tale."

"It is paid for with the Venetian's money. You are eating credit."

"The best thing on the table, then." He lifted his cup to her, a small private gesture, and drank, and

she did not know whether to be irritated or amused, and chose irritation, which was safer.

By the time the light turned amber in the high windows and the hall had reached the wine's third stage, the musicians were playing the old dances and the younger lords were leaping and stamping in the French fashion, and the master of protocol appeared at her elbow with the face of a man about to undergo surgery. It was time for the bedding.

* * *

They had kept the ceremony as short as custom allowed, but custom was a jealous god and could not be denied its essentials. The procession formed: the married women of the court for her, the married lords for him, the bishop with his sprinkler, the musicians with a song so full of cheerful filth that Lisette, behind her, made a sound like a strangled cat. They went up the great stair in a wave of candlelight and laughter and old ritual, and Jeanne, walking in the middle of it with her veil on her arm, thought of the girl in the solar and what she would have made of this public delivery of the body she had once promised away in secret.

The bridal chamber was enormous and hot and full of people. The great bed stood under a red canopy, the sheets turned back, the pillows beaten,

the fire lit despite the mild night because the bedding ritual demanded a fire. The women undressed her behind the screen with practiced speed: the mantle, the gown, the girdle, the linen, until she stood in her shift with her hair down and her mother's handkerchief clutched in one hand, and Oriabel poured a cup of spiced wine and made her drink half of it.

On the other side of the screen, by the sounds of masculine hilarity, the lords were doing the same for Thiébaut, with less ceremony and more advice, most of it audibly supplied by Jean. The bishop sprinkled the bed, said the prayers over the linen, blessed the union and its hoped-for fruits, and then the whole roomful of witnesses watched, in the names of law and custom and the absence of any annulment, as the two of them were put into the bed together, she in her shift and he in his shirt, and the coverlet drawn to their wavers, and the curfew cup passed, and then, at last, with bows and grins and one final volley of the filthy song, the company withdrew, and the doors closed, and the key turned, and they were alone.

The silence was enormous. Beyond the doors the court's noise receded down the stair, laughing and music-bent, and in the chamber the fire made its small domestic sounds and the candles guttered in a draught from the window hangings. They lay side by side on their backs like two effigies on a tomb, staring at the red canopy.

"Well," Thiébaut said eventually. "That was remarkably thorough."

She had expected fear, or anger, or some return of the old tight hate. What she felt instead, to her deep annoyance, was the ridiculous, bubbling pressure of laughter, and she suppressed it with effort, because laughing in bed with a man on one's wedding night was the kind of thing that led to other things. "The bishop's Latin has improved since my father's funeral. I noticed."

"I noticed the Erquelines letter beside your plate. A marriage proposal, at your own wedding feast."

"The imperial party has no sense of occasion. It is one of their more reliable qualities." She kept her eyes on the canopy. "My lord. We may as well have the conversation. The law and the court and the Church have all had their parts. There remains the question between us. I will not be claimed like a fortress, and I will not have a duty performed at me in the dark as though I were a toll to be paid. If the marriage is to be a formality for a season, I will say so plainly, and no one outside this room will ever know, and the treaty will hold either way."

He was quiet long enough that she turned her head. He was looking at her, and in the candlelight his face was not the council face at all.

"Jeanne. The treaty holds whether I touch you or not. I signed it for roads and revenues, and those do not depend on this bed. Nothing in this room is a toll. Nothing in this room is owed. But I will tell you what I would choose, if the choosing were mine alone." He paused, and she watched him choose the words, this man who chose words the way he chose ground. "I would choose that we not spend our wedding night lying to each other in the dark. I want you. I have wanted you, in one way or another, since you were eleven and ordering me about the garden wall. I am not going to take anything, because there is nothing here that is mine by right. But if you can bear the thought, I would like to make the marriage real. Slowly. With your leave at every step. And if you cannot bear it, I will sleep at the edge of this bed like a well-paid guard, and we will both be perfectly comfortable and perfectly miserable, and I will never mention it again."

She had prepared for every man except this one. She lay holding her mother's handkerchief and listened to the fire and thought, with a kind of despair, that the most dangerous thing about him had always been this: he said the true thing, simply, and left her no wall to throw herself against.

"Slowly," she said. "And if I tell you to stop, you stop."

"If you tell me to stop, I stop."

"Then don't ask again. Just— know it."

He turned onto his side. His hand came to rest on the sheet beside hers, not touching, an offered geography. "Jeanne. Look at me."

She turned her head. In the candlelight his eyes were more green than hazel, and serious, and older than the boy's she remembered, and she saw him take stock of her the way he took stock of a room: not to possess, but to know. His hand moved the last inch and closed over hers, and when she did not pull away, he lifted it to his mouth and kissed the palm, once, gravely, as though swearing on a relic.

"I have no practice at this," she said, and hated herself for the tremor in it.

"Neither do I, at this. At the rest, a man learns what he needs and forgets most of it. You will tell me what to do. All of it. That is the rule of this bed."

He kissed her then, properly, not the liturgical brush at the chancel rail but a real kiss, careful and questioning, his mouth warm and unhurried, one hand at her jaw while the other stayed where it was, laced with her fingers on the sheet. It was nothing like the kisses she remembered from the solar, which had been all lightning and astonishment; this was a man's kiss, made of

knowledge and restraint, and it did something worse than astonish her. It made her answer. Her eyes closed. Somewhere beneath the covers her body, that traitor, began to unclench muscle by muscle, as though it had been keeping its own long siege and had decided, without consulting her, to discuss terms.

When his hand went to the lacing of her shift, he stopped. She nodded, once, not opening her eyes, and he undid it with a soldier's efficiency and a great deal less speed, and the linen came away from her shoulders in the warm dark. She felt the air of the chamber on her skin, and then his hand, flat and warm, at her waist, staying there while he kissed the place beneath her ear and said, low, things she would not afterward remember word for word, only the tone: that he was here, that she was not alone, that nothing was being taken.

She had imagined this moment over the years despite herself, in the way of courts where every marriage was a transaction and every bride had theories. She had imagined duty, embarrassment, perhaps pain, the endurance her mother's generation spoke of in proverbs. She had not imagined being asked. The asking undid her more thoroughly than any force could have. When at last he moved over her, his weight braced on one arm, his face above hers, she put her hands on his shoulders and felt the old bad one, the left, rigid with the effort of holding him up, and said, "Your

shoulder—" and he said, "The shoulder has been waiting longer than you," and despite everything she laughed, and he kissed the laughter, and after that there was no more room for proverbs.

It hurt, the first time, a sharp, tearing, unromantic hurt, and she made a small sound against his mouth, and he stopped entirely, breathing hard, his forehead against hers, until she moved her hand to the back of his neck and said, "Don't stop, I didn't say stop," and he said, "The rule is yours, use it," and she said, "Then go on," and he did, slowly, while the candles burned and the fire cracked and the red canopy of the ducal bed became the whole world, a small hot country with its own laws.

It was not beautiful in the way the songs promised. It was specific and physical and strange, the smell of his skin and the salt of him, the ache, the awkward collision of knees, the way his hand found hers again and held it as though it were the only point of navigation in a dark sea. And then, without her expecting it, against all the proverbs, there was a turning in it, a tightening and a strange gathering, and her breath caught at something building behind the pain, and he must have felt it because he changed his rhythm, watching her face with an intensity that made her want to hide, and she could not hide, and the thing gathered and broke in a long wave that went through her whole body and left her gripping his

hand with both of hers, and after it he let himself go at last, with one sound wrenched out of him that he tried and failed to swallow, his face buried in her hair.

Afterwards they lay in the wreck of the sheets, both breathing as though they had run a race. The hurt settled into a dull throb. She stared at the canopy, and her mind, which never stopped, came back online with its usual industry, and began at once to catalog, to assess, to file the experience under the proper heading, and discovered with some alarm that no heading existed.

He moved away from her with care, onto his back, and found the cup of watered wine on the stand and gave it to her without being asked, and drank after her from the same side, which the nurses would have scolded them for. The fire had burned low. Somewhere in the palace a clock struck, one bell, two.

"Well," she said, because someone had to say something and he appeared to be waiting for her. "That is done."

"That is begun." He did not look at her when he said it, which she appreciated. "Are you hurt?"

"Some. Not beyond bearing. I will have the linen changed in the morning. The court will want its proofs; let them have them." She sat up, pulling the sheet with her, and was absurdly glad of the

dark. "My lord. I have a question, and you will answer it plainly, because there has been enough plainness tonight to last the reign. Did they teach you that, in the camps? The asking. The stopping."

He was quiet a moment. "No one teaches it. Most men never learn it. I learned—" He stopped, and she felt him choose. "I learned young what it costs a person to have no door that can be shut. I decided, if I was ever given a door of my own, I would not behave like the men who taught me."

It was the second time in as many days that he had come close to the walled country of seven years ago without entering it. She let the silence stand, and then she did the thing she had not intended to do: she lay down again beside him, on her side, facing him, close enough that their breath mixed.

"The treaty says separate chambers are permitted after a season if either party wishes it."

"I know. I read it."

"I don't wish it. Not yet." She said it to the dark, to his collarbone rather than his eyes, which made it possible. "For one thing, the connecting door is absurd. For another, the court will read separate beds as a quarrel, and I will not give them the satisfaction. And for a third," she stopped, and made herself finish, "I find I do not dislike the arrangement as much as I intended to."

His laugh was low and close, almost soundless, and she felt rather than saw him smile. "A commendation of the highest order. Madame, I will endeavor never to rise above dislike."

"See that you don't." She closed her eyes. "Wake me at dawn. There is a letter from Sainterre I have to answer, and the war council, and I believe the guildsmen want another audience, and—"

"And tomorrow is tomorrow. Sleep."

He did not touch her again, except that his hand found hers under the coverlet and held it, loosely, the way one holds something one has been permitted to hold. Jeanne lay in the dark of the great bed, in the arms of the state she had married, and listened to his breathing slow toward sleep, and discovered that the ledger in her mind had gone quiet, an event so rare that she stayed awake a while simply to notice it. Then the warmth and the wine and the long day took her, and she slept, and did not dream, for the first time since the gate bell.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Two Heads, One Pillow

The first problem of the marriage, Jeanne discovered, was not the bed. It was the breakfast.

For three weeks she had taken her first meal alone at the writing table, standing, with a clerk reading the night's dispatches between sips of hot milk. On the first morning of her married life she came from the bedchamber to find the antechamber occupied: Thiébaut already at the table with a map spread among the bread, the Abbé de Viray saying grace in a low voice, the Bastard Jean eating an entire cold capon with the concentration of a man laying siege, and two Lorraine pages she did not know taking up useful space near the window. A Vauréal page of hers stood against the opposite wall, holding her letters, wearing the face of a boy who has discovered foreigners in his kitchen.

"Good morning, madame." Thiébaut rose, and the room rose with him. "Viray thinks better before noon if fed, and Jean thinks better never, but eats regardless. There is bread with honey, and the milk is hot. Your clerk may read aloud; nothing in this room travels past that door."

She sat, because there was no useful alternative, and the clerk, after one look at her face, began the dispatches. It came to her halfway through the Sainterre letter that she was presiding over a council in her shift and mantle before she had broken her fast, and that the marriage had achieved in one night what the treaty's clauses had only described: two governments in one room, with one bread basket.

The household adapted faster than she did. Servants are the true political scientists of any court; within two days the antechamber table had acquired a permanent second inkstand, the kitchens had learned Lorraine preferences in cheese, and Lisette had established, by means Jeanne did not inquire into, an exact understanding of which Lorraine pages could be trusted with messages and which carried everything to the Bastard. The two retinues circled each other like strange dogs, sniffing for precedence, and found it where such things are always found: in the duchess's own arrangements. She kept her hours, her table, her seal. He kept his. They shared a roof, a bed, and the war, and the court, denied the spectacle of a quarrel, began the slow, suspicious work of accepting the new geography.

The map room gave it the quarrel it wanted on the fourth day.

* * *

She came down after the morning's petitions to find the muster lists unrolled on the long table and Thiébaut with Brive and Van Brock, reorganizing the feudal host. Not discussing. Reorganizing. New columns in a hand she did not recognize, the old Vauréal banners grouped into combined lances with Lorraine captains named beside them, the gun crews consolidated under a single master gunner, his own man, a one-eyed Lorrainer called Hautemer.

She read the top sheet twice. "What is this?"

"The host cannot take the field in its present shape." He did not look up. "Your vassals arrive with their little retinues and their little jealousies, and the French roll over them as they did at the Roches-Noires. I'm breaking the retinues into squadrons of mixed companies, Vauréal and Lorraine together, under captains I can answer for. The guns go under one hand. The pikes, when the Swiss arrive, form the center, not the wings."

"The pikes are a loan contract, not a certainty. And you have named the captains."

"Provisionally."

"Provisionally, in writing, on my table, without my seal." She heard the level in her own voice, the dangerous level. "My lord. In this country, captains

are patents, and patents are mine. You signed that clause yourself."

That got his attention. Brive, to his credit, began an immediate and absorbing examination of the window. Van Brock found something wrong with his boot.

"The clause concerns offices and garrison commands." Thiébaut turned to face her. "Field appointments in an active campaign are the work of the commander, and the treaty gives me field command. I am not seizing your castles. I am making your army capable of not dying."

"Your treaty gives you joint field command under my war council. There has been no war council. There has been a man in my map room with my lists."

"Because if I wait for a council every time a company needs a new sergeant, the French will be baptizing their children in the cathedral." His voice had not risen; it never did, which made the anger in it more audible. "Jeanne, be angry about the manner if you like, and I will apologize for the manner. Do not be angry about the thing itself. The Roches-Noires army died of household politics. Yours is the same army with a new grief and fewer men."

It was true, and she hated that it was true, and the room knew it was true, which made it worse.

She looked at Brive, and the old marshal gave her the smallest possible nod, a soldier's confirmation, and then looked back at the window with the dedication of a man at prayer.

"Very well." She folded the top sheet with precise hands. "The reorganizations stand provisionally, until the war council confirms them. Every captain's name goes onto a patent in my chancellery by Friday, and any man I strike, you replace without argument. In future, my lord, you will bring your reorganizations to me before they reach the table, and I will bring my objections to you before they reach the room. We may argue in private until the candles die. In front of the captains, we have one voice. Is that understood?"

The Lorrainers in the room went still, because they were waiting to see whether a duke of Lorraine could be spoken to this way and remain a duke. Thiébaut held her eyes for a long moment, and then something in his face gave way, not to anger but to the recognition of an equal.

"Understood, madame. And the patents by Friday."

"One more thing. Hautemer is a good man, and Brive tells me his gunnery is the best in either country. But the master gunner of Vauréal answers to me through the master of ordnance. He keeps the guns. Van Brock keeps the seal on the powder store. Two men, one battery. No single hand on all

of it. That is not distrust. That is how my father kept his gunners from becoming kings."

"Your father," Thiébaut said, and the ghost of a smile crossed his face, "would have made a terrifying Venetian."

"He made a Vauréal. It amounts to the same thing."

The room exhaled and went back to work, and Brive, passing her at the door, murmured so that only she heard, "Well done, my lady. He'll respect it. The question was always whether you'd make him."

* * *

The charter framework was Foulques's draft and her architecture, and it took four nights to build.

The problem was arithmetic made political: she needed war taxes from the three northern cities, and the cities wanted self-government, and neither side could afford to look as though it was buying or being bought. The framework, as it emerged from her table, offered each city a sealed charter of limited liberties — elected aldermen from a franchise of guild masters, a city court for trade and labor cases, fixed tolls for a term of six years, and a licensed militia under city officers who held their commissions from the duchess. In exchange, the cities voted a war contribution in coin and

kind, kept the peace within their walls, and admitted the duchess's judges for crown cases. It was less than de Key's faction demanded and more than any duke of Vauréal had ever granted, and it was designed, with cold care, to split the cities' moderates from their radicals.

"Coppens can sell this in Sainterre," Foulques said, turning the draft. "De Key will call it a cage with gilded bars."

"De Key will call anything short of his own republic a cage. The question is whether four thousand weavers prefer a cage to a siege." Jeanne dipped her pen. "Make the toll term six years rather than ten. A privilege that expires is a privilege that keeps the aldermen courteous. And add the clause on the press: no printed ordinance without the city court's mark. The printing shop is where de Key breeds his sermons."

Thiébaut, who sat at the other end of the same table going through supply contracts, looked up. "You license a printing press in '84 and your grandchildren will still be explaining it."

"My grandchildren can explain it from a throne if I keep the country. Unlicensed printing in a city in revolt is not a liberty. It is a weapon. The Sainterre press prints what the aldermen approve, and the aldermen are my charter. I am not censuring truth. I am licensing order, and the

difference will matter to the people who pay for both."

"It will be called fear."

"It will be called government. Fear is the raw material; government is what you build with it." She sanded the page. "Your own Viray would say the same in Latin."

"Viray says everything in Latin. It saves him from being contradicted by people without education." Thiébaut set down his pen. "Jeanne. One substantive thing. The licensed militia. If the cities keep their own armed men, you are creating the very force that can shut your gates against you."

"Which is why the officers hold my commission and the powder is stored in the ducal arsenal under Van Brock's seal. A militia with officers and no powder is a parade. A parade that votes me taxes is a useful parade." She pushed the draft toward Foulques. "Seal the framework as a general proclamation, and send copies under safe conduct to all three cities before we march. Let de Key explain to his weavers why they should refuse the charter and keep the war."

The chancellor took it, and she saw again that small, considering look he gave her whenever the talk edged near the uses of power, as though he were comparing her to some older copy of the

same document. He said only, "It will be in the mail by morning, madame."

* * *

The nights were the strange part, and the part the court could not see, which made them the most important.

They kept her chamber, the larger one, and the connecting door stood open now and was never locked, though the key remained in her keeping. The bedding ceremony's formalities gave way to an ordinary negotiated by exhaustion: who took which side of the bed, whose boots went where, the rule that dispatches did not enter the bed but might be read at its foot. He slept on the left because of the shoulder, and she kept the right because the window was hers, and within a week these were laws.

It was not love, whatever the court assumed. It was something more useful and more complicated: the nightly practice of a shared silence. They would lie in the dark after the candles were out, each still carrying the day, and talk in low voices about the things that could not be said in rooms full of clerks. He told her how Lorraine actually worked, which was nothing like the romances: a patchwork of bishoprics and lordships held together by roads and debts, where the duke's writ ran as far as he could ride and no farther. She told

him the true accounts of Vauréal, the hidden borrowings, the vassals whose rents were fiction, the towns whose loyalty had a price she had not yet been quoted. In the dark, without faces, it was almost easy.

The physical life between them settled into its own cautious grammar. Some nights he simply held her hand the way he had on the first night, and they slept. Some nights, when the day had gone well or badly enough to require it, there was more, and she learned the geography of him the way she learned the roads of her own country, by use; the bad shoulder, the scar at the ribs from a French lance, the way he went still and watchful if a hand moved too fast, a thing she did not understand and did not press. He kept his rule, always: she had only to say the word. She never said it, though she tested once, early, turning her head away at a certain touch, and felt him stop at once without question, and the ease with which he stopped made the trust possible in a way no insistence could have.

On the ninth night she asked him the question she had been holding since the wedding. "Why did you really sign the light clauses? Don't give me the road again. Every man in Europe wants the regency of a rich duchy. You refuse it in writing, in advance, with your own hand."

The dark considered. "Because I saw what the wanting did to a man. I watched your father want everything in every room, and it made him great and it made him alone, and it got him killed at the Roches-Noires because there was no one he trusted enough to tell him the charge was folly." A pause. "And because a man who takes a woman's country from her has to live in it with her. I have lived in houses where I was not wanted. I will not make one of my own house."

She lay with that for a while. "You keep answering me."

"I keep being asked. Most people don't ask. They decide what I am and then listen for it."

"Most people have never been renounced in their own great hall." It came out harder than she meant.

The bed went still. "No," he said. "They have not." And then, carefully, as though crossing ice: "Jeanne. If you ever decide you can hear the answer, I will give you the whole of that morning. Not a version. The whole. But I won't force a door you've barred, and I won't tell it to make myself lighter at your expense. The truth of that day has other people's lives in it, and I don't own all of them."

"Other people." Her voice was steady. "Foulques, for instance."

He did not answer at once. "Foulques for one," he said, and left it there.

She filed it, and did not pursue it, and after a while his breathing slowed, and she lay awake listening to it, holding in her two hands the newest and most unwelcome fact of her reign: she was beginning, against every intention, to trust the man she had married.

* * *

The dispatch from Mont d'Or reached them on the eleventh day, and it was the commandant's own hand, written tight and small to fit the page. French engineers had pushed forward from Saint-Vaast; a second column was on the kingdom road; the fortress could be invested by the end of the month unless the field army showed itself. The commandant added, in a postscript, that he now had sixty-one men, the reinforcements having arrived, and that the duchess's name was still said at every watch.

The war council met that night and voted the march within the hour. The host would go north first, per the plan already proven: the Lorraine companies and the Vauréal squadrons to Sainterre, to settle the revolt while the French were still digesting the south, then turn south along the river roads before Graçay could complete his investment. Mont d'Or got another

convoy, more gunners, and a promise in the duchess's own hand.

On the morning of departure Jeanne rode out of the Haut-Tertre in steel and velvet, with her husband fifty paces away at the head of his lances and the joined arms above them on a dozen banners, and the lower town cheered itself hoarse because armies marching away are always more popular than armies returning. She did not look back at the gatehouse window from which she had watched him arrive. She looked north, where the road ran between the spring fields toward the richest, angriest city in her inheritance.

They were still strangers in everything that mattered. They were already, in everything that counted for the next months, a government. The distinction would have to hold.

* * *

The proclamation went out under the great seal in three fair copies, one for each of the northern cities, and Foulques brought it to her for the final impression with his own hand, which was unusual; the chancellor of Vauréal did not play clerk.

"Foulques. Sit."

He sat, with the careful patience of a man who has heard that tone before.

"You have been strange since the Lorraine treaty came to the table. Not opposed. Strange. I have asked you once and you gave me a locked door. I am asking again, as the person who carries every consequence of whatever is behind it. Is there any agreement, debt, or written thing between my late father and the Duke of Lorraine that is not in the chancellery files? Any document?"

The silence lasted long enough for the taper to settle in its holder. He did not look away from her; whatever his faults, he had never flinched from a direct question. "There is a document, madame. One. It is in my own keeping, not the chancellery, because your father ordered it so, and because it concerns the honor of persons still living, including your own. I have carried it for seven years and I have not shown it to a soul. I will not show it now, against the word I gave to a dying man's office, unless and until the duke himself releases me, or you can tell me a necessity greater than the harm of its coming out."

"Is it a thing that damages the state?"

"It is a thing that damages persons. The state, I think, would survive it. I am less certain of the marriage."

"Then consider this your notice." Her voice held. "I will have the truth of it before the year is out, one way or another. I do not pay a chancellor

to keep locked rooms in my own house. You may go."

He rose, bowed, and went with the document case under his arm, and she watched the door close behind him with the cold, strange feeling of a hunter who has found a track at last. Lisette, emerging from the antechamber where she had been officially mending linen, said without being asked, "I've had his clerk talking. The green case never leaves his room. He says his prayers twice as long as any canon, and he drinks a cup of wine alone every night before he sleeps. Men with easy documents don't drink alone."

"Noted. Keep watching, but nothing stolen. I want it given, not taken."

* * *

Oriabel took command of the baggage train as though it were a duchy of her own, which in the arithmetic of campaigns it nearly was: forty carts of munitions, tents, the portable chancellery with its seal chests, the hospital tents and the surgeon's instruments, grain and salt and the iron-bound chests of the soldiers' pay, each cart numbered and listed in triplicate. Jeanne found her on the quay arguing with a carter about axle grease, her widow's black replaced by a practical grey gown and boots.

"The carter believes grease is a luxury," Oriabel said. "The carter will believe otherwise at the first flooded ford. Cousin, tell your household that a duchess on campaign owns three changes of linen and no jewelry beyond what she wears, because anything else becomes a story told by whoever steals it."

"I own two changes. Lisette packed the third anyway."

"Then Lisette is wiser than her mistress, as maids have always been." Oriabel lowered her voice. "And the duke's people? How are they to be managed on the road? Two households in one camp is a quarrel with wheels."

"His household keeps its own fires and its own accounts, and shares the chancellery tent and the watchword. Any fight between the servants comes to me and to him together the same evening, and the first servant who makes a faction is sent home without references. Tell the women. He'll tell the men."

"You've discussed it."

"We discuss everything now. It is the principal advantage of the arrangement, and the principal danger." Jeanne watched the carts roll down to the quay one by one, the seals of the duchy on their canvas covers. "Oriabel. Did my mother ever say anything to you? About the early years with my

father. About what a marriage is, when it begins as paper."

Her cousin was quiet a moment, watching the river. "She said that paper burns slow. She said you don't light it with speeches; you feed it with the ordinary days, until one morning you notice it's the only fire in the room that's never gone out. She also said your father was the most difficult man she ever loved, and that she would not have traded him for an easier one. Make of that what you will."

Before the march, the review. She had ordered the whole host assembled on the muster field, and Brive had grumbled that reviews wasted a day and frightened no one, and she had answered that reviews were not for the French, and ridden out anyway.

It was a different field from the muddy emptiness she had looked over six weeks before. Three thousand men now, in the rough shape of an army: the household men-at-arms gleaming in the old plate her father had collected, the Lorraine lances in their darker, better-kept harness, the foot in leather jacks with bills and the new pikes, the guns on their new low carriages behind the patient oxen. Small, beside the armies the French king could put in the field. Real, beside the eleven riders who had come home from the Roches-Noires.

She rode the lines slowly on the grey mare, with Thiébaut a horse's length behind her, and let the army see her. This, too, was government. A lord's face at the muster was a soldier's pay in a month when the pay was late; she had learned it from her father, who had understood spectacle even when he failed at everything else. She stopped at the Vauréal companies and spoke to the survivors of the Roches-Noires by name, because she had made Brive give her the lists and learned them the night before, and she saw what it did to a man to have his duchess remember his village and his wound. At the Lorraine companies she let Thiébaut do the speaking, and watched the men's faces soften as his horse passed, and understood the other lesson: an army that loves its captain is an army that must be loved through him.

The last stop was the guns. Van Brock and Hautemer stood together by the biggest bombard, the one called *Marguerite* after a long-dead duchess, a bronze throat big enough for a man's fist, and the two gunners, Fleming and Lorrainer, were clearly deep in an argument that had survived three languages.

"My lady." Van Brock touched his brow. "She'll throw a stone two hundred paces and crack a wall that took ten years to build. The question is whether she can be moved fast enough to be useful."

"She can," Hautemer said. "On the new carriages. We proved it on the road from Nancy; my master will tell you."

Thiébaut nodded. "A gun that arrives is worth ten that sit in fortresses. Madame, when we reach Sainterre, let me put the battery where the guilds can see it. Not to fire. To be read. Cities negotiate better when they've seen the handwriting."

Jeanne looked at the great bronze tube, at the oxen, at the gunners with their powder-stained hands and their professional pride. "Do it. And keep *Marguerite* closest to the road. A bombard with a woman's name at the head of a duchess's army is a thing the ballad-sellers will work for us for nothing."

The men laughed, even Brive, and the laugh ran down the nearby ranks, and she turned the grey mare and cantered back to the standard with the sound of it following her, and knew that for today at least, the review had bought what she came for.

That night, the last in the Haut-Tertre before the campaign, she could not sleep, and went down to the empty council chamber with a taper, and found the round table still covered with the maps and lists of the day's work. Her father's chair stood empty at its head. She stood behind it for a while, hands on its worn arms, looking at the painted arms on the wall and the dark windows beyond.

Footsteps. She turned, knife hand already at her belt, and it was Thiébaut in a shirt and hose, his own taper in his hand, the bad shoulder held stiffly.

"I saw the light," he said. "Couldn't sleep either?"

"The chair. I keep thinking he should be sitting in it."

"You're sitting in it. That's the answer he would have given, if he'd been capable of giving comfort." He came to stand beside her, not touching. "Jeanne. Whatever happens at Sainterre, one thing. The city is yours, not mine. I'll hold the line and the guns and the soldiers. The talking is yours, all of it. If the guilds see a Lorrainer dictating terms, the charter is worth nothing and we'll be back here in a year with a siege."

"I know. I had already written that into my own instructions."

"Good." A pause. "Then we are thinking the same thing, which is either excellent generalship or the beginning of a disaster."

She almost smiled. "With us, my lord, I expect it will prove to be both."

CHAPTER NINE

The Charter and the Cannon

Sannounced itself from a league away by the smell: wet wool, fuller's earth, coal smoke, and the particular sour reek of the dye vats,

a stink so famous in the north that travelers claimed you could navigate to the city blindfolded. Jeanne's army came over the last ridge in the afternoon light and saw the whole cloth metropolis spread in the valley of the upper Ortelle, its walls long and black with the smoke of forty thousand hearths, its three great gatehouses wearing the red and white of the guilds instead of the red and silver of the duchess.

"Every gate," Brive said, beside her. "They've taken the ducal arms off every gate. That's not revolt in a hurry. That's revolt with a carpenter's bill."

Thiébaut reined up on her other side, studying the walls through the same professional calm with which he studied everything. "New palisades outside the eastern gate. See there, where the suburb starts? They're extending the covered way. And the ditch has been cleared. Someone in that city has read the same books I have."

"De Key has a journeyman carpenter's training," Foulques said, from his mule. "His father built guildhall benches. The dangerous revolutionaries are always the ones who can read a measurement."

The host made camp on the rising ground west of the city, between the river and the Ghent road, the position her father's maps called the White Field, where the ducal armies had traditionally assembled to reason with Sainterre. Tents went up in the ordered rows Thiébaut's sergeants insisted on, the horse lines upwind, the latrines down, the guns parked with their muzzles toward the walls. There was no assault to prepare and everyone knew it; three thousand men could not surround a city of forty thousand, and the war in the south needed every company whole. The army's work here was to be seen: a fact in armor, an argument in steel.

Jeanne sat her horse a while at the camp's edge, watching the walls. The walls watched back. She could see tiny figures moving along the parapet, the glint of a crossbow's steel, the red-and-white banners lifting in the wind. Somewhere down there Coppens was a virtual prisoner in his own house, and de Key held the cloth hall and the gates, and the printing press she had tried to license was turning out the broadsheets that the camp's pickets had already found nailed to roadside trees:

No Foreign Husband. No Old Taxes. The City Is Its Own.

"Will they fight?" Jean asked, ambling over with an apple. "I've money on two days of shouting and a nice fat tax bill."

"They'll fight if we make them," Thiébaut said. "The question is whether the city wants what de Key is selling. Cities rarely do, all of it. They want the tolls. They don't want the French."

"Then we give them the tolls and make the French frightening," Jeanne said. "See to the battery, my lord. Put *Marguerite* where the Ghent road can see her, and let the gunners take all day about it. I want the walls to count every ox."

* * *

Coppens came out at dusk through the river postern, in a fisherman's boat, wrapped in a sailcloth that smelled of herring, and he arrived at the duchess's pavilion with the sailcloth still around his shoulders and the face of a man who had not slept since his last audience at the Haut-Tertre. He knelt with difficulty, his knees not being what they had been, and rose only when she told him twice.

"Madame. He has three gates and the cloth hall and the weavers' guild, which is four thousand men with crossbows and the arms to use them. The fullers follow him because he promises them the

dye houses. The dyers follow me because they know who pays their accounts. The merchants want this over before the London convoy is due, which is in six weeks. The common people want bread, and de Key has been telling them your tax is why it costs double."

"And the broadsheets?"

"Printed at night in the cellar of the cloth hall, passed out free. A man called Verhoeven, a printer from Bruges. He sets type in the vernacular so the apprentices can read it, and the apprentices read it aloud in the taverns. Madame, the broadsheets are doing the work of an army. There are men in my own guild who voted for me last year who now call me the duchess's dog." Coppens's heavy face worked. "I am not a brave man. I came out because the alternative is watching the city I built burn for an idea that won't pay a single weaver."

"Sit. Drink." She poured the wine herself, which made the old guildsman blink. "The charter framework my chancellor sent. Can the moderates carry it against de Key?"

"Not as it stands. He'll say the six-year toll term is a trick to take the tolls back. He'll say the licensed militia is your garrison in our clothes. He'll say the war contribution is a dowry for the Lorraine mercenary." Coppens drank, wiped his mouth, and grew steadier, the way a trader steadies once the real bargaining starts. "But if the

charter named the city's own officers for the tolls, and the militia's powder stayed in the city's arsenal under two keys, one alderman's and one ducal, and the war contribution were fixed at the figure we offer rather than the figure you demand, then I could put it to the guilds and carry it. The fullers would still shout. The fullers always shout. The rest would vote."

Thiébaut, who had said nothing, leaned forward in his camp chair. "Maître Coppens. If the charter is granted and de Key refuses to accept the guilds' vote, what does he do?"

The old man looked at him with reluctant respect. "He calls the vote a fraud. He arms the weavers. He shuts the gates and dares you to storm them, because he believes the French will reach Sainterre before you can. The Sire de Graçay has sent him letters, my lord duke. I have seen one. Paris promises the city its ancient freedoms, meaning whatever keeps it out of the duchess's hands."

"Has he answered them?"

"I don't know. I think he's keeping the French as his second bidder." Coppens set the cup down. "Madame, if you grant the charter in full, publicly, tomorrow, in the city, with the guilds assembled, you make de Key choose between a vote he might lose and a riot he can't disguise. I ask you to come inside the walls. Under safe conduct sealed by

every guild, including his, because he won't dare refuse the seal and look afraid. Come with a small guard. Let the city see you're not the woman in his broadsheets."

The pavilion went quiet. Foulques's face said everything about chancellors and armed cities. Brive, who had come to stand at the flap, said, "No," before the word was fully out of Coppens's mouth.

Jeanne looked at Thiébaut. He was turning a small knife over and over in his hands, the way he did when he was thinking, his eyes elsewhere. "It's a risk," he said at last. "But it's the right one. A ruler who won't enter her own city hands the story to the man who will. I'll come inside with fifty lances and the household guard. If the gates close, the battery answers, and the first answer goes into the cloth hall."

"You'll come inside with twenty lances," Jeanne said. "Fifty says I'm afraid of my own city. Twenty says I'm not. And we bring the charter, fair-copied and sealed, so there is nothing to negotiate away in the room. Maître Coppens, send your boat back tonight. Tell the guilds the duchess will speak at the cloth hall at noon tomorrow. Tell de Key his safe conduct is in the same document as everyone else's. He can be there or explain to his weavers why he wasn't."

* * *

They entered Sainterre at ten in the morning, through the Ghent gate, between ranks of the city militia in red-and-white jacks with their partisans held rigid as fence posts. Twenty Lorraine lances in unpolished steel, no banners but the single joined arms standard; the household guard around the duchess's horse; Foulques with the charter in its leather tube; and at the very front, alone on her grey mare with no guard between herself and the street, Jeanne in the steel-grew gown and the ducal mantle, riding through her own angry city at a walking pace.

The streets were packed. The silence of a watching crowd is a physical thing, a pressure on the skin, broken by small sounds: a child's voice shushed, the clop of hooves on the cobbles, the slop of dye water in a gutter. Faces in every window. Apprentices perched on signboards. Women with folded arms on the doorsteps, the same flat assessment she had got from the fishwife in Aubecourt, multiplied by ten thousand. Once an egg splattered against a wall ten feet away, thrown from an alley, and the guard's hands went to swords, and she said, without turning her head, "No one moves. An egg is a vote. Let it vote."

Thiébaut rode half a length behind her left shoulder, where he could see both the street and the rooftops, and she could feel the controlled readiness of him like a drawn bow, and took from

it a steadiness she would not have admitted to needing.

The cloth hall stood at the city's heart, a vast Gothic barn of brick and glass, its square full of people, its steps crowded with the armed weavers of de Key's faction in leather jacks and red armbands, crossbows on their shoulders. The broadsheets had been pasted across the hall's doors. A man was reading one aloud in a carrying voice as the procession arrived: *"...and the foreign duke will garrison your houses and take your daughters, while the duchess counts his gold..."* He stopped when he saw her. The square took a breath.

She dismounted at the steps, and the crowd saw the guard stay at the bottom, and she climbed the steps alone except for Foulques with the charter and Thiébaut at her back, and stood where all of Sainterre could see her, in the shadow of the hall's great carved doorway.

"People of Sainterre." She did not shout; she had learned in the Aubecourt square that a lowered voice travels. The front ranks hushed to hear, and the hush spread. "I have not come with the army at my back, though it is on my field and paid by my hand. I have come with a charter. Before I speak of it, I will say one thing plainly, because I will not have my city governed by lies printed in cellars. My husband holds no office,

garrison, or patent in Vauréal. His soldiers camp beyond your walls at my pay and my order, and they will not enter this city except at the city's own request. Read the treaty. It is a public document, and I have had copies printed, by a licensed printer, for anyone who can read and anyone who can listen. The broadsheet that says otherwise is the work of a man who fears your literacy more than he loves your freedom."

A sound went through the square, half murmur, half laugh, the sound of a crowd recognizing an argument it could use at the tavern.

Then de Key came out of the hall.

He was younger than she expected, Willem de Key, thirty-five and broad, with the long arms of a weaver and the face of an apostle in a poor church: lean, burning, sincere. He wore the weavers' red armband and no weapon that showed, and he came down the steps toward her with the ease of a man on his own ground, followed by a dozen hard young men in the same red.

"Madame la duchesse." His voice was made for halls, deep and clear, and it carried to the back of the square without effort. "The city is honored. We note that you come with a charter in a tube and an army on the hill, and we are curious which one you expect us to read first."

A roar, half approval, half unease. Letting him speak was a calculated risk; she had discussed it with Thiébaut at midnight and concluded that a demagogue silenced in public was a martyr, while a demagogue answered in public was a man with a problem.

"Read the charter first, de Key, since the army costs you nothing and the charter costs me a great deal." She turned so that the square, not the man, was her audience. "It confirms your aldermen, elected by the guild masters. It gives your city court its trade and labor jurisdiction. It fixes the tolls for six years. It licenses your militia under officers who hold the duchess's commission, with the powder under two keys, one of them your aldermen's. And in exchange, the city votes the war contribution it has itself proposed, keeps the peace, and admits the ducal judges for crown cases. That is the whole of it. No garrison. No new tax. No husband's officers. You may inspect every word, and so may every man here, because I have had it printed."

Foulques unslung the tube, and her clerk raised the fair copy high, and from the crowd a schoolmaster was pushed forward, willing or otherwise, and began to read it aloud in the vernacular, his voice cracking at first and then finding its stride. The square listened. It was the thing de Key could not allow, Jeanne knew: a listening crowd. A crowd listening was a crowd

thinking, and his power lived in the gap where thought might have been.

He struck at the end of the first paragraph.

"Six years!" he shouted over the schoolmaster's voice. "The tolls come back in six years! A charter with an ending is a lease, and a lease is what a landlord gives a tenant. Are we tenants in our own city?" And then, turning it, finding the deeper wound: "And the militia powder under her key! When the French come, will we ask the duchess's keeper for leave to defend our wives? This is not a charter. This is a bridle, and she has brought a soldier to hold the reins."

The red-armband men took it up, a chant of *bridle, bridle*, and the square began to move, the front ranks pressing, the armed weavers on the steps spreading out with the practiced motion of men who had planned the geometry. Thiébaut's hand went to Jeanne's elbow, not pulling, just there, and over her shoulder he said one word, low: "Steel."

"Not yet," she said.

De Key was still speaking, arms wide, the apostle's face lifted, and the crowd was his again in the way crowds are, swinging like a weather vane, and she saw the young men around him produce what they had been carrying under their jackets: not crossbows yet, but clubs, iron bolts,

the cobblestones of the square pried loose in advance. This was not a riot. It was a performance with a script, and she had a brief, cold certainty that the script's final scene was her retreating from Sainterre in disorder, or not retreating.

The first stone came from the alley beside the hall, a good throw, and it took the clerk on the side of the head. The fair copy went red. He went down, and the crowd's sound changed, became the noise a mob makes when it crosses its own threshold.

"Now," said Thiébaut.

The twenty lances came up the steps not as cavalry but as a wedge of armored men, shoulder to shoulder, and the household guard closed around her with the precision of long drill, and somewhere below, the city militia, Coppens's moderates, the dyers and merchants with their two-key argument to win, hesitated and then, at a barked order from an old guildsman with a gold chain, formed across the square's far side, separating the press of apprentices from the hall. Two militias, one mob, and the armed weavers in between.

What followed lasted perhaps ten minutes and felt like an hour. The red-armband men charged the steps and were met by the Lorraine wedge, which did not draw steel but used the flat of arms and the weight of plate, and the crossbows that appeared were answered by the guard's crossbows

coming up in a single trained motion, and de Key's men, whatever their courage, discovered the difference between enthusiasm and discipline. A weaver got within three feet of Jeanne with a cobblestone raised, and Thiébaut took him down without looking at him, his left arm moving in a short, awful, efficient arc, and the man folded onto the steps with his teeth broken.

The killing was an accident, and everyone there would claim it was a massacre. A boy, sixteen or so, one of the fullers, panicked in the crush and loosed a crossbow into the air, and the bolt came down into the throat of a Lorraine man-at-arms, who made a surprised sound and sat down and died on the cloth hall steps with his hand at his neck. After that the guard's bolts went out in a volley, and four weavers fell, two dead in the square and two more who would die in the night, and the mob broke because mobs always break once the dying starts, pouring into the side streets and the alleys and the dye houses, leaving the square to the militia and the blood and the broadsheets fluttering in the wind.

"Hold the steps," Thiébaut said to his sergeant, and then to Jeanne, quietly, "Are you hurt?"

"No." Her heart was hammering so hard she could hear it. "The clerk?"

"Alive. Head wound. The surgeon's with him." He looked at the dead man-at-arms, then at the

two weavers in the square, and his face was the face she had seen in the map room, the one that did not waste anything. "This was coming whatever we did. Now it has a price, and de Key has to explain why he started a fight he lost."

* * *

De Key had fled the square before the volley; she learned that within the hour, through the aldermen's watch, out the river postern with three companions and a sealed letter in his coat, and the letter's destination was the French camp. Coppens, emerging from his house with the careful timing of a man who had spent the riot being unreachable, called the guild council that evening under the guard of both militias, and the vote, when it came, was not close. The weavers' guild abstained in a body and lost the argument by it; the other eight guilds accepted the charter, and the war contribution with it, and the old cloth merchant signed his name as the city's first elected lead alderman with a hand that shook only slightly.

She visited the press before the sealing, because a duchess who intended to license printing ought at least to know what the thing looked like. Verhoeven's cellar workshop was low and black and smelled of ink and lamp oil, and the printer himself, a thin Bruxellois with ink in his cuticles, received her as a man receives the weather: with resignation and an eye for shelter.

The press stood in the center of the room like a small cathedral of oak and iron, and on the composing table lay the loose type of de Key's last broadside, its broken sentences still legible in reverse. Jeanne picked up a line and turned it, feeling the metal's weight. "How many of these can you print in a night?"

"Four hundred sheets, madame, with two men and candles. The guildsmen distributed them free at the gates." Verhoeven's eyes were watchful. "I am a craftsman. I print what I am paid to print, as a smith shoes whatever horse is brought."

"A smith who shoes a thief's horse is hanged with the thief. But I am not here to hang you. I am here to hire you." She set the type down. "The charter's full text, five hundred copies, in the vernacular, posted at every guildhall and read at every market cross in the three cities. Then the marriage treaty, the same. Then, each week, a printed sheet of the news of the war and the council, under the city court's mark, sold for a denier. Let de Key's next broadsheet arrive in a town that has already read the truth in a licensed sheet. Rumor is cheap, Verhoeven. I intend to make it compete with a professional."

The printer's face did the slow arithmetic of his kind. "A weekly sheet, madame, has never been done north of the Rhine."

"Then we shall be the first, which costs nothing in ink and a great deal in courage, of which you appear to have a reasonable supply, having printed rebellion in a cellar for a month." She turned to Foulques. "Pay him in advance, from the city's contribution. A press that owes the duchess money is a press that thinks twice."

Up the cellar stairs, in the grey light, the chancellor said quietly, "You are arming him."

"I am arming everyone, Maître Foulques. The only question is whether I hold a share of the weapons. My grandfather kept the sword monopoly. This century is issuing new kinds."

Jeanne sealed the charter in the cloth hall the next morning, under the windows where the broadsheets had been scraped off, with the square full again but quieter, and the four dead weavers' bodies laid decently in the church of Saint-Géry at her expense, and the Lorraine man-at-arms buried with his arms and a mass paid from the privy purse. She attended all the funerals, including the weavers', and walked through the streets on foot afterward with no guard but Coppens and Thiébaut, and let the city look at her.

"He'll come back," Coppens said, low, as they passed the shuttered weavers' quarter. "De Key. With the French behind him."

"Then keep your powder dry and your aldermen honest." She stopped at the corner where the first stone had come from; the alley was empty now. "Maître Coppens, I granted this charter under duress and we both know it. Write that down in your city's book, because I want it remembered. I want your successors to know the duchess paid for this city's peace with a piece of her own sovereignty, and that the city paid for it in taxes and in blood on these steps. A charter that costs nothing binds no one. This one cost us both. That's why it will hold."

The old guildsman looked at her for a long moment, and then did a thing he had not done at the Haut-Tertre, for all his bows there. He bowed as the city bows to itself, fist to chest, slow and full. "It will hold, madame. On my guild's name."

* * *

In the camp that night, the tents struck and the army preparing to turn south, Thiébaut found her alone by the horse lines, watching the gunners grease *Marguerite*'s bronze throat.

"One man-at-arms, four townsmen, a clerk with a bandaged head, and a charter that will be quoted against every duchess of Vauréal for the next century." He stood beside her, not touching. "Do you count it a victory?"

"I count it a marriage." She kept her eyes on the gun. "Something expensive, partly against my will, that I now have to make work. The city voted the taxes, the gates are open, the river trade starts again at dawn, and de Key is a guest of the French, which tells every waverer in my dominion what his fine words were worth. Yes. I count it a victory. I also count that boy's face, and I expect I'll keep counting it."

"He was sixteen. The fullers confirmed it."

"I know. Lisette got the name. His mother's a widow in the weavers' quarter. I'm settling a pension on her, from the privy purse, not the treasury. A treasury payment makes him a riot casualty. A privy payment makes him my debt." She turned to face him at last. "You moved very fast on those steps."

"I had a great deal to protect." He said it flatly, without romance, a statement of fact. "Also twenty years of practice. Jeanne. The next time a man raises a stone within ten feet of you, I will not wait for permission. I thought I should state the rule, since you're so fond of rules."

"Stated and accepted." She looked back at the dark bulk of the city, its thousands of lamps reflected in the river. "Now take me back to the pavilion. We have a fortress to save, and I have a letter to write to a commandant with sixty-one

men, and I intend to tell him help is coming before the French tell him anything at all."

They walked together through the ordered camp, past the sentries who presented arms and the campfires where the soldiers were already turning the day's blood into the day's stories, and behind them Sainterre burned its broadsheets in a bonfire on the guildhall square, the smoke going up straight and black into the spring night.

CHAPTER TEN

South to the Frontier

The army turned south on the first of May with the river at its left hand and the new charter riding in the chancellery cart under three seals, and Jeanne learned in the first hour that an army on the march is less a weapon than a traveling town with stricter opinions about dung.

Three thousand men, twelve hundred horses, forty guns on their new carriages, the ox trains and the baggage and the long tail of camp followers and sutlers and engineers, all of it stretched over a league of road in an order Thiébaut's sergeants enforced with curses in three languages. Scouts went first, light cavalry fanning through the woods. The vanguard followed, Lorraine lances under Jean's banner. Then the guns and the pikemen, then the standards and the chancellery, then the infantry and the baggage, then a strong rearguard, because every soldier who had ever been surprised lived or died by his opinion of rearguards. Start and stop were marked by the same trumpets every day, and the camp went up and came down in the same order every evening, and Jeanne, riding at the center with the household guard, understood after three days that

this monotonous discipline was the actual Lorraine military secret, not courage or plate.

"Your father's armies moved like weddings," Thiébaut told her when she said so. "Everyone in his best clothes, no two men agreed where the wine was. Mine move like a brewhouse. Boring, early, and impossible to hurry."

They made nine leagues a day when the roads were good and five when they were not. She had expected discomfort and found instead a strange, exhausting freedom. At the Haut-Tertre every hour was an audience; on the road the state shrank to a pavilion, a folding table, and the people who could keep up. She rode the grey mare in a divided skirt and a leather jerkin over her gown, with the ducal ring on its chain and a dagger at her belt, and the soldiers, who had expected a court lady in a curtained litter, revised their opinions audibly in the ranks. She heard one Lorraine man-at-arms tell another that the duchess sat a horse like a sergeant's widow, which Brive considered an insult and she considered the highest praise available.

The country changed as they went. The rich northern plain gave way to the marches: thinner fields, more stone, watchtowers on every rise, villages with the walls and the watchful eyes of places that had been raided within living memory. The burned hamlet Thiébaut had found on his road was rebuilding, two new roofs among the

blackened beams, and the woman with the child was at her door when the column passed, and she looked at the standard and then at the duke, and gave him a nod that was not a bow. He returned it, equally level, and the column moved on.

"She got the purse," he said, when Jeanne drew level. "And the garrison letter. I asked after her. She used half of it to buy a watchdog and half to buy a crossbow. I consider that a successful policy."

"You make policy by purse?"

"I make most things by purse. Battles are the failure of accounting."

* * *

Mont d'Or rose out of the frontier hills like an argument: a great rock with a fortress crowning it, its walls following the stone, the river road passing directly under its guns, the one hard point between Graçay and the soft belly of Vauréal. The commandant met them at the outer gate with his sixty-one men drawn up as though for inspection, and Jeanne saw at once why Thiébaut had wanted the man kept.

Captain Valvert was fifty, thin as a fence post, with a face weathered to the color of old leather and the kind of calm that comes from having decided exactly how one intends to die and finding the decision restful. His garrison had been paid,

reinforced, and re-gunned, and the fortress stores were stacked with the obsessiveness of a man who had spent four months expecting the worst. He knelt on his own parade ground and rose at her gesture and said, without preamble, "The guns cover all three approaches, the well is full, the cisterns are full, and I've mined the outer ditch in two places, madame. If the French want this rock, they may have it at the same price I'd charge the devil."

"Show me," she said, and he showed her.

For two hours she walked the walls with Valvert and Thiébaut and Van Brock, and the education she had been getting in camps became an education in stone. She saw the difference between a wall that was merely high and a wall whose flanking towers could sweep every inch of its ditch; she learned why the old round keep was death in the age of guns and why the new low angle bastions were the future; she put her hand on a siege crack in the northwest tower and felt, through the stone, the slow patient patience of artillery.

"The French have eight bombards with the vanguard," Valvert said. "My scouts counted them on the kingdom road. At that rate they'd need six weeks to breach, and they know it. They won't besiege me properly while your field army exists. They'll try to make you fight a battle to save me, on

ground they choose. That's the whole of their plan."

"Then we will be so obliging as to refuse it." Thiébaut leaned on the parapet, looking south toward the smoke of the French pickets. "We reinforce, we provision, we make the rock unassailable, and we keep the field army mobile. Graçay can't march past a full fortress to his front; his supply line runs under these guns. So he sits. And while he sits, his master pays for an army in the field, and the Regent's treasury is not bottomless. This war is a clock. We are the slower clock."

Jeanne looked from the fortress to the green hills and the distant smoke, and felt the campaign settle into shape in her mind the way a ledger did when the columns began to agree. "Then our work is to make the clock expensive for him. Raid his convoys. Keep his scouts blind. Make every day in the field cost a week's pay."

"Exactly." He turned to her with something like surprise, as though he had forgotten she had not been doing this all her life. "You should have been a soldier."

"I am a soldier. I hold the treasury that keeps you one."

* * *

The gunnery lesson happened the next morning, on the practice range behind the camp, because she had asked for it plainly and Thiébaut had learned that when she asked for a thing plainly she meant to have it.

Hautemer himself laid out the instruments: the gunner's quadrant, the powder measures, the sheaf of range tables worked out in Lorraine and copied in the chancellery hand. *Marguerite* sat on her low carriage with her muzzle elevated toward a butt of packed earth two hundred paces off, and the gunners moved around her with the unhurried swagger of men who owned a rare and dangerous craft.

"A gun is a contract," Thiébaut said. "So much powder, so much elevation, so much weight of stone, equals a predictable result. The poets write about swords. Wars are decided by clerks who can do sums in the rain." He showed her the powder scoop. "The first mistake of amateurs is courage. They overload to make a bigger noise, crack the breech, and kill their own crew. The measure is the measure. Now. The quadrant."

She knelt in the mud in her jerkin and learned to read the plumb line against the graduated arc, and then the range table, the columns of figures that translated distance into elevation, and then the strange, satisfying logic of it: a problem in geometry with a city wall at the end. When the

crew had loaded and primed, he stepped back and offered her the linstock himself, the slow match smoking at its end.

"Your gun, madame. Touch hole. Don't flinch; flinching pulls the match wide."

She took it. The crew had their hands over their ears, and she made herself breathe out the way he had taught her on the archery range of her childhood, and touched the match to the priming.

The world became noise and smoke and a deep, chest-filling concussion. The stone shot went away in a long flat arc and struck the butt low and to the right, throwing earth in a fountain, and the crew cheered, partly for the duchess and partly because the gun had not exploded, and Thiébaut said, "Right by two paces, long by none. A gunner is born. Do it again, and correct."

She did it again, and again, and the third shot struck within a pace of the marker, and by then she had powder on her face and smoke in her hair and a grin she could not have suppressed with both hands, and when she turned he was watching her with an expression she had not seen before, not council and not strategy, and the look lasted only a moment before he nodded to Hautemer and said, "Mark her ladyship down as qualified. We'll make her load next time; the nobility of war consists mostly of carrying things."

That night at the campfire, with the stars out over the frontier hills and the sentries calling the watch in the dark, the lessons turned into stories. Jean, full of the army's rough wine, told the tale of the Sarrebourg relief, the fight that had given Thiébaut his shoulder, and acted out the parts with a stick for a lance while the headquarters circle laughed.

"It was winter, the snow to the horse's belly, and my brother here decides—"

"I decided nothing. The garrison had four days' bread."

"—decides to charge an entire Burgundian company with forty lances because they were warm and he was cold." Jean struck a pose. "The lance broke on the first man, the horse went down over the second, and he lay in the snow for an hour pretending to be dead while the battle walked around him. A man-at-arms finally recognized his shield and pulled him out, and the first thing he said was, 'Did we win?' because his shoulder was pointing the wrong way and his priorities were flawless."

"We won," Thiébaut said. "The shoulder was put back by a farrier. I recommend against the experience."

Jeanne looked at the left shoulder, invisible under the leather, and thought of the nights in the

great bed when the cold woke it and he never complained, only changed his position in silence. "Why forty lances? Why not wait for the rest?"

"Because the arithmetic said the garrison fell on the fifth day, and the rest arrived on the sixth." He poked the fire with a stick. "There's a notion that command is about choosing the good option. It's usually about choosing which disaster you can afford. I could afford forty dead men. I couldn't afford the fortress."

She was quiet a while, turning her cup. The firelight moved on the faces around them, the easy scarred faces of men who had made these choices and slept after them. "You never told me. In all the nights at the Haut-Tertre, you never told me how you got it."

"You never asked."

"I'm asking now."

He considered the fire. "My father died when I was eleven. Lorraine was run by regents who stole the revenue and called it administration. I came home from your father's court at twenty with a title, three fortresses that were still loyal, and no money. The first winter I ate in the garrison hall because the palace had no cook. I learned the shoulder and everything else because there was no one else. That's the whole story. No sagas. A series

of small, cold, expensive decisions, most of which I made badly the first time."

It was the closest he had ever come to giving her the seven missing years, and she took it as it was offered, without pressing toward the locked country beneath it. Somewhere beyond the camp a trumpet sounded the last watch, and the fire settled, and Jean took himself off to his tent with a parting yawn, and they sat alone together in the embers' light, two people in a hostile country at the edge of a war, and for a little while neither of them needed to say anything at all.

* * *

She held her first field court on the third evening, under an oak at the camp's edge, because the petitioners had followed the army for two days and the sergeant of the guard had run out of reasons to refuse them. A field court was not the chancellery; there was no bench, no usher, no Latin, only a folding chair, a clerk with a board, and the long light of a frontier sunset. Thiébaut sat his horse twenty paces off and did not approach, which she noted and approved.

The cases were the raw material of rule, small and ancient. A miller from a burned village sued a sutler for the price of a stolen donkey. Two widows disputed a field boundary and produced dead husbands' contradictory charters, which Foulques

would have loved and she had to untangle by asking who had paid the tithe. A boy of fourteen, caught with a stolen dagger from a Lorraine tent, knelt in the grass white as milk while his mother offered everything she owned, which was a goose and two silver gros.

"The theft of a soldier's weapon in wartime is a hanging matter," the provost said, with the satisfaction of men who know the rule.

"So it is." She looked at the boy, who was shaking. "And if I hang him, his mother becomes a charge on the parish, and the army loses a strong pair of hands. Provost, the next levy needs drummer boys and latrine diggers and boys who can carry powder. Take him into the pioneer company, under the master of works, at a soldier's half pay. If he runs, you hang him then, and I'll sign the warrant. If he serves the campaign out, the theft is struck from the record." She turned to the mother. "The goose goes to the company mess. The two gros are the court fee. Go and make him a bundle; he marches at dawn."

The woman's thanks followed her back to the pavilion, loud and incoherent, and Thiébaut rode up alongside as though by accident. "The provost thinks you're soft."

"The provost may think whatever he likes. A hanging would cost the army a worker and the parish a pauper's keep, and buy me three hours of

fear. The boy's service buys me the same fear, a pair of hands, and a story that travels faster than any proclamation." She glanced at him. "Don't tell me you've never done the same."

"I once made a sheep thief into a scout. He's now a sergeant, and steals only from the French." His mouth twitched. "I was beginning to think you kept all your mercy in the privy purse, the way you keep your pensions."

"Mercy is a coin like any other. It has to be budgeted."

That night, for the first time on campaign, the two retinues ate at one fire rather than two. It happened without an order, the way the important things usually did: Jean carrying his cup to the Vauréal side, Brive's captains answering in the rough French of the camps, the soldiers' wives sharing out a stew between the two horse lines. She watched it happen over her own portion, and said nothing, and marked it down among the campaign's victories, which were never the ones the songs chose.

* * *

The French came at the misty hour before dawn, the hour they had chosen because every sensible man in every war is at his stupidest then. Jeanne was woken not by a trumpet but by the camp itself changing sound: the sentries' calls

shortening, the horses picking it up, the whole animal machinery of an army coming alert before the human mind had caught up. She was dressed and armed with her dagger before Lisette got the taper lit, and outside the pavilion the tents were already coming down in the grey fog, the companies forming by beat of drum rather than voice.

Thiébaut was already mounted at the center, fully armed, his breath pluming, his captains around him receiving their orders in short sentences. She saw the method of him now, the same method as the march: no shouting, no heroics, a place for everyone and everyone put into it before the fog showed the enemy's numbers. The vanguard to the river bend. The pikes across the road. The guns unlimbering on the left rise, where the mist would thin last. The baggage and the pennons pulled back behind the hill.

"Madame." He turned the horse to her, and in the half-light his face was all business, and she was grateful for it. "It's a probe, not an attack. Two or three hundred gascons and light horse, testing our pickets at the south ford. I don't intend a battle; I intend them to go home with correct information. You'll take the standard to the windmill on the rise with the household guard, where you can see the field. If the mist closes, stay there; the guard has its orders. Don't come down."

"And if it goes against us?"

"It won't. But if it does, you ride north with the chancellery and the seal, and you don't look back, because a duchy without a duchess can still fight and a duchy with a captured one cannot." He said it without heat, a piece of logistics, and then, lower, "Also I would prefer you whole. Both reasons."

"Both received." She wheeled the mare toward the rise. "Bring me prisoners. I want their paybooks."

The windmill was a black skeleton against the lightening sky, and from its rise she could see the whole theater: the river shining in loops through the fog, the south ford where the French were crossing in disordered files, the camp's campfires now abandoned, and the dark ordered blocks of her army waiting in the mist like reefs under water. Brive joined her with the standard guard, armed cap-à-pie on a great bay, and gave her a look of approval for being on the rise rather than in the pavilion, and said nothing.

The French came through the fog at a trot, gascon infantry with their white crosses and a screen of light horse ahead, and they met the Lorraine pickets at the ford and pushed them back exactly as Thiébaut had predicted they would, and then they came up the road in the confidence of

men chasing a rear guard, and the fog thinned over the left rise, and the guns were there.

She had fired *Marguerite* herself on the practice range. She had not heard a battery open in war. The difference was the difference between a door slamming and a house falling: a rolling, continuous thunder, the guns firing by platoons down the road, and the road dissolving into smoke and screaming horses and bodies thrown sideways by the stone shot. The French light horse broke first, as cavalry will against guns it cannot reach. The gascons, better men, tried to spread off the road into the meadows, and found the pikemen there, the long Swiss weapons lowered in a hedge, and the Lorraine lances coming around the flank in a controlled canter, not a wild charge, her husband's hand visible in every careful piece of it.

It was over in the time it takes a fog to burn off a field. By full sun the French were running for the ford in groups, the lances herding rather than slaughtering, because prisoners and information were worth more than corpses and Thiébaut had said so in his orders. The guns fired one more round at the last formed company and then fell silent, and the smoke drifted over the trampled meadow and the dead and the small miserable sounds of the wounded.

Brive let out a long breath. "Textbook. Your husband, madame, does not make exciting war."

"Good. I am not paying for exciting."

* * *

They brought the prisoners to the command tent by midday, forty-one of them, bound and gray-faced, and the paybooks and letters found on the sergeants were laid on the folding table still wet with river water. Thiébaut interrogated the officers himself, briefly, with food in front of them and no threats, because hunger and courtesy had extracted more information in his experience than cords. Jeanne sat to one side with Foulques, taking her own notes, and watched the method again: the quiet voice, the unhurried questions, the way he let a man talk himself into telling the truth because silence began to feel worse than speech.

The news matched Valvert's estimate. Graçay had eight bombards and perhaps four thousand effectives, with the forfeit fiefs being digested by garrisons rather than field troops. The probe's work had been to count the Vauréal army and, if possible, take a prisoner who knew whether the duchess was with it.

"Which they now know," Foulques murmured.

"Which I wanted them to know." Thiébaut stripped off his gauntlet. "A duchess in the field with her army and her guns is a duchess whose vassals get the correct story. Let Graçay hear she

watched his probe break. He'll move slower. He's a man who respects evidence."

The last prisoner was a young French gentleman, an ensign, wounded in the arm and doing his best to be brave. He had a letter on him, not military, from his mother in Orléans, and when Thiébaut saw it he pushed it back across the table. "Keep that. The sergeant will dress your arm. You're paroled to the surgeons' tent; give me your word not to leave it, and I'll take no bond."

The boy stared. "My word, my lord?"

"You're an ensign. Your word is all you own that's worth anything." A pause. "And tell the Sire de Graçay, when you're exchanged, that the duchess's gunnery improved his road. He'll understand."

When the tent had cleared, Jeanne said, "You were gentle with the boy."

"I was an ensign once, in another country's war. Someone was gentle with me, and I've never forgotten it, and I've never been able to find out who." He sat down across from her and rubbed the bad shoulder, which the morning's armor had woken. "Also gentleness to the captured is a payment into a fund I may need myself. The day I'm taken, I want it on record how I behaved."

"You don't believe you'll win, then. Not truly."

"I believe we'll win this one. I don't believe any soldier is ever truly safe, and I'd be a fool to act like it." He looked at her across the maps. "Jeanne. You stayed on the rise. You didn't come down. You watched the road take the guns without making a sound. Brive says you didn't even blanch."

"Brive flatters. I shut my eyes during the first volley, behind the standard, where no one could see."

"That's the second-best thing a commander can do. The first is not letting anyone know." He almost smiled. "The army will have its own version by evening. In the army's version, you directed the battery."

"Let it stand. Rumor is cheap, and I have a press now." She rose, and the long morning moved in her bones, the fog and the thunder and the prisoners and the wounded, and she found she was not tired, or rather that the tiredness was the good kind, the kind of a day that had earned its night. "My lord. The dispatches. Sainterre needs the story by the weekly sheet, the Haut-Tertre needs the casualty lists, and the commandant at Mont d'Or needs to know the French just lost their best chance to count us cheaply. Then we eat. Then we sleep. Tomorrow we make Graçay's clock more expensive."

He stood with her, and for a moment, in the tent's dim light, the council faces fell away and

there were only the two of them, muddy and smoke-smelling and bound by paper and by something newer that neither had named. "Tomorrow," he said, "and every day after, until they price this war beyond Paris's purse."

Outside, the army was burying its dead in the captured meadow, and the detail fired a volley over the graves, and the sound rolled across the river toward the French hills like a message, which was exactly what it was.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Weight of Bodies

It came for Saint-Vaast in the third week of May, because the river was low enough to ford and high enough to keep the French supply wagons chained to the one bridge, which was the arithmetic of the whole affair.

The fort stood at the end of its stone bridge like a fist on an arm, a square castle with a walled town huddled under its guns, and the French had spent six weeks making it uglier: new earthworks at the bridgehead, a ditch cut across the only meadow, two bombards on the keep whose barrels the scouts could see glinting in the sun. Its commandant, a Gascon knight named de Noailles, had four hundred men and the confidence of a garrison that had never yet been attacked by an army it could see.

Thiébaut laid the siege in the careful, unromantic way he laid everything. "No assault until the walls are worth assaulting," he told the war council in the command tent, his finger on the sketched plan. "We batter the bridgehead earthworks first, because they're new and raw, and we do it from across the river where their guns can't answer at full weight. When the earthworks are gone, the town's river wall is open.

Marguerite and her sisters make a breach. The infantry goes through at dawn, when a garrison's watch is at its thinnest. The cavalry crosses the bridge behind them to stop any relief from the south. Nobody enters the keep before the gunners have its gate covered. Questions?"

Brive had one, about the honor of the first assault, and got the answer he expected: the forlorn hope went to a mixed company of Vauréal and Lorraine men under Jean's command, because the duke's brother leading in the first wave was worth a hundred speeches, and because Jean would personally have murdered anyone given the task instead.

Jeanne sat through the military details with the map open on her own table, and asked the questions the soldiers forgot. "The townsfolk. Four hundred hearths inside those walls. What are their provisions?"

"Three weeks', at French rates of seizure." Thiébaut did not look up. "Which means their own stores are already empty. The commandant is feeding his men on the town's winter grain."

"Then the town wants him gone. I want proclamations, before the first gun fires, in the vernacular, nailed to the bridge posts and shot over the walls on arrows. The duchess's army makes war on the French garrison, not the town. Any townsman who keeps to his house is safe in

person and goods. Any soldier who surrenders before the breach keeps his arms and his ransom rights. Any man who harms a civilian answers to my provosts. Make the words plain. Foulques, I want no Latin in it anywhere."

The chancellor bowed. "A siege won in the proclamations before it's won at the breach."

"A siege won at all," she said. "Write it."

* * *

The proclamations went out at dawn, nailed to the bridge timbers and wrapped around arrows shot into the town in high arcs, and by noon the answer came back, not from de Noailles but from the town: the parish priest, out under a white cloth on a mule, with a frightened alderman behind him. They were shown through the lines to the command tent, and the priest, a stout man who had clearly decided that courage was his only remaining profession, spoke for both of them.

"The town has three days' bread, madame. The French took the rest for their stores. They have also taken the bells from our church to make gunpowder measure, and twelve men for forced labor on the earthworks. The commandant says your proclamations are lies and that any man who speaks of surrender will hang. The town would like to know whether the proclamations are lies."

"You have my word, which is sealed." Jeanne pushed the fair copy across the table. "Read it yourself, Father, in the square, with my herald beside you. Houses and goods untouched. The French garrison alone is our quarrel. Open the river gate to my men when the breach is made, and the town keeps its charter and its grain and earns a remission of this year's war contribution. The alternative is the assault, and in an assault no proclamation in Christendom can guarantee a single house."

The priest read it twice, moving his lips. "And if the commandant prevents us?"

"Then keep your people indoors and your doors barred, and wait for the duke's provosts. They'll be the second men through the breach, and their first work is to hang looters." She paused. "Father. What is the garrison's true temper?"

"They're Gascons, madame. Good soldiers, bad guests. They believe the relief column comes from the south before the month ends. They do not know what I learned in your lines, that your horse holds the bridge road. If they knew, half of them would be on the walls arguing with the other half."

"Then see that they learn it. The truth is in the proclamations; print it on their dinner tables. A town that talks itself into surrender saves us a breach and saves itself a sack. Go with the herald. And Father," as he rose, "the twelve laboring men.

When this is over, send me their names. I keep a book of them."

When he had gone, Thiébaut, who had said nothing through the interview, leaned back in his chair. "You're besieging them with paperwork."

"Paper is cheaper than powder. Every man in that town now knows the terms and knows his neighbor knows them. De Noailles has lost the one thing a garrison needs: the certainty of the men behind him." She folded her copy. "If it works, the breach opens an empty wall. If it doesn't, the guns do what guns do. Either way, the town has been told the truth, which means whatever happens, the next town believes my proclamations."

"The next town," he said, "is already studying this one. Yes. I know. That's the part they don't teach in the romances."

* * *

The guns spoke for two days. She watched the first day from the battery line, at Thiébaut's side, and learned what her practice-range shots became when they reached stone: the slow, patient mathematics of destruction, stone balls striking the bridgehead earthworks at measured intervals, the earth faces crumbling, the French working parties rebuilding at night and the Lorraine gunners undoing it again by morning. On the second day the bombards turned on the river wall,

and then it was possible to watch a wall die, block by block, the medieval stone no match for the new bronze throats, until by dusk a ragged breach gaped like a wound and the French drums could be heard inside, mustering the defense.

That night the camp was quiet with the particular quiet before an assault, men writing letters and sharpening steel and pretending to sleep. She walked the lines after the last watch, with Lisette behind her and two guards at a distance, and saw the things no proclamation could reach: a young soldier teaching his friend his home village's name in case a letter had to be sent; a veteran methodically greasing every rivet of his harness; Jean, by a fire, shaving his head with a knife so no one could grab his hair in the breach, and grinning at her when he saw her.

"Can't sleep either, madame?"

"I'm reviewing the hospital tents. The surgeons have asked for more linen and more vinegar, and I've given them the household's table linen rather than wait on the baggage. I want you to do something for me, Jean."

"Name it."

"Send the wounded to the rear the moment they fall. No heroics about staying in the line. A man down in the breach is a man who bleeds out before the surgeons ever see him. I've put twelve

stretcher-bearers with the first wave, and they answer to me, not the captains."

The Bastard's grin faded. "You've done this before."

"I've read the surgeon's accounts of the Roches-Noires. Three hundred men died of wounds who needn't have, because there was no one whose work it was to carry them. My father's army did not number the wounded. Mine will." She held his eyes. "Bring my husband back, Jean. That's the other thing."

"Madame, I've been keeping him alive since he was twelve. I'm not stopping for a French wall."

* * *

The assault went in at first light, through the mist off the river, and she heard it rather than saw it from her post at the rear: the trumpets, the roar of three hundred men running, the sudden, deeper sound of the breach defense opening fire, the guns of the keep answering. The hospital tents stood two hundred paces behind the battery, already prepared, the trestle tables laid out, the surgeons in their leather aprons sharpening with small, terrible sounds, the coals glowing for the irons.

The first wounded came within the quarter hour, carried by her stretcher-bearers, and then there was no time for anything but the work.

She had imagined she knew what battle was. She had read the chronicles, seen the lists, watched the probe at the ford from a windmill. None of it was this. The smell was the first thing, the iron-and-bowel reek of opened men, and under it the vinegar and the coals and the strange, sweet stink of a body the surgeons could not save. The sound was the second: not the trumpets and glory of the camp stories but the noise human animals made when their bodies were failing, screaming and praying and cursing in four languages and sometimes, worst of all, calling for their mothers in voices that had not finished changing.

She had intended to oversee. Instead she worked, because there was more work than hands, and her hands were steady, and a duchess in a bloodied apron was worth two surgeons' boys who froze. She held legs for the saw and turned away her face only the first time; she poured vinegar into the long slashing wounds the French bills made; she threaded needles and fetched linen and learned which screams meant a man was dying and which meant he was merely feeling it. A man with his face half gone by a gunstone gripped her wrist with his one good hand and would not let go, and she knelt in his blood and said the prayers with him until the grip loosened, and she closed his eye herself because no one else was free.

The boy came at midday, carried by two bearers who were themselves splashed with someone

else's red. He was fourteen, a page in the household guard, an Aubecourt boy she knew by sight, the one who had poured her wine at the Easter feast and blushed when she thanked him. A crossbow bolt had gone in under his ribs, and the surgeon looked at the wound and looked at her and gave the smallest shake of the head, the economy of a man who had learned to spend his time where it could win.

She went to him anyway. They made a place for him at the edge of the tent, away from the worst of the noise, and she knelt and took his hand, and he knew her, which was the thing that would come back to her in the nights.

"Madame." His lips were white. "I ran. In the breach. I want you to know I didn't stop running."

"I know you didn't. I have the reports. You were the third man through." She had no idea if it was true; she made it true by saying it, and watched it steady him. "What's your name? Tell me again, so I have it exactly for the letter."

"Philippe. Philippe Aubert, of the lower town, my lady. My mother keeps the chandler's by the Mercer's Row."

"Then listen to me, Philippe Aubert. I will write to your mother myself, in my own hand, and she will have the pension and the shop's freedom from tolls for her life, and the whole lower town will

know what you did at Saint-Vaast. Do you hear me? These are the duchess's words, and the duchess keeps her accounts."

He heard her. Something like a smile crossed the grey face, and he said, "I ran so fast," and then, a while later, with her hand still holding his, he stopped breathing, and one of the bearers came and closed his eyes with a coin in them for the ferry, and she stayed on her knees because her legs would not immediately do anything else, and Lisette put a cup in her hand and said, "Drink. It's wine. Drink, my lady," and she drank.

* * *

The town fell before the afternoon. Jean's company was through the breach at the third attempt, the French commandant's banner came down over the keep by vespers, and de Noailles himself was taken alive in the gatehouse, wounded in two places and furious. The danger then was the old danger, the danger every army carried into every taken town like a plague: the sack. Soldiers who have fought their way through a breach believe, with the deep conviction of their trade, that whatever they can carry is theirs.

Thiébaut had written the orders before the assault. The provosts went through the gates with the second wave, and the gallows went up in the market square before the flags did, and three men

caught looting a goldsmith's shop were hanged from the town's own signboard within the hour, in front of the townsfolk they had been about to rob. A fourth, who had struck a woman, was flogged through the streets by his own company. It was brutal and it worked; by evening the town's bakers, after a guarded conversation with the army's commissary, were baking bread for both garrisons, and the proclamations on the bridge posts were being read aloud in the taverns by men who had expected to be murdered.

De Noailles was brought to her in the town's own guildhall, which the French had used as a guardroom and which still smelled of their tobacco and wet wool. He was a man of fifty with a bandaged thigh and the manners of an older, chivalric war, and he bowed from his chair because he could not stand.

"Madame la duchesse. I offer my parole and my ransom, according to the customs."

"Granted, on the usual terms, and your surgeons may attend you with mine." She sat across from him with the articles on the table. "Before we discuss your ransom, commandant. Your garrison seized the town's grain, its bells, and its labor. The grain and the bells are the town's and go back. Your ransom is yours, and I will not inflate it to punish a defense that was, until the end, correctly conducted. One question. Why hold

a town whose wall could not survive a week of guns?"

"Because my orders said hold, and a soldier who rewrites his orders is a merchant." He met her eyes. "And because I did not believe the army of a duchess new-made and a duke half-bankrupt could bring a siege train at all. I was mistaken about the guns. I was more mistaken about the proclamations. My men spent the last two nights arguing in French and Gascon about whether to kill me and open the gate."

"Then remember the argument when you're exchanged. Tell the Sire de Graçay what it cost him." She rose. "You'll be held at Aubecourt, in the officer's tower, not a common cell. My chancellor will write the ransom terms. Conduct yourself as you have today, and they'll be generous."

After he had been carried out, she sat alone in the guildhall with the clerk and wrote the letter she had promised, in her own hand, slowly, because it had to be exactly right: to the chandler's widow of the Mercer's Row, Aubecourt, the news of Philippe Aubert's death, the manner of it, the third man through the breach, the pension, the toll freedom, the gratitude of the duchess in words a chandler could read aloud in a tavern and be proud of. She wrote three drafts and kept none of the first two, and the clerk, who had watched her draft state papers in a single pass, said nothing at all.

"One more letter," she said when it was sealed. "To all parish churches of the duchy. The names of the dead of Saint-Vaast, to be read at Sunday mass from the pulpit, every name, in every church. No rank, no order of precedence. They died in the same levy; God can sort them."

She found Thiébaut in the breach itself, at dusk, standing with Brive and the engineers, his armor blood-spattered and his face the color of ash. The left shoulder was being favored, though he would not say so. When he saw her come through the rubble he excused himself and met her in the shelter of a broken wall, and the two of them looked at each other for a moment without words, because there was nothing in the language for the day they had separately spent.

"Casualty lists are being drawn," he said. "Forty-one dead of ours, perhaps ninety wounded. French dead over a hundred, the rest prisoners. No civilian deaths that the provosts can find. The proclamations held."

"The boy Philippe. The page." Her voice did not quite work. "He died in the hospital tent. I was with him."

"I heard. Jean sent word." He reached out, slowly, as though touching something fragile, and put his hand on the bloodstained apron she had forgotten she was wearing. "Jeanne. You're covered in it."

"So are you."

"I'm a soldier. It's expected of me."

"It's expected of me too. It's my duchy and my war and my taxes pay for every bolt in that breach." She pressed the heels of her hands against her eyes, and the hands were stained, and she made a sound that was not quite a laugh. "He was fourteen. He poured my wine at Easter. He kept telling me he ran."

Thiébaut did not say any of the soft useless things. He said, "The camp's ready. The tents are up by the river. Come away from the wall. There's hot water, and food you won't want, and no one who needs anything from you until dawn."

* * *

Dawn came grey over the captured town, and she kept her word about the living and the dead. The book was a plain ledger taken from the chancellery cart, and she opened it in the market square under a guard's pavilion, with the provost and the surgeons and the company clerks, and the names went in one by one: the forty-one dead of the assault first, with parish and next of kin against each name, then the wounded and their wounds, then the French dead where they could be identified and the prisoners in their companies. It took four hours. The square filled and emptied and filled again around her, soldiers and townsfolk

drifting up to see the duchess of Vauréal sitting in the rain-light doing a clerk's work, and by the time she closed the book the army had its new custom, though no one had decreed it: a man who enlisted under her banners knew his name would be kept.

The stretcher-bearers she decorated herself, twelve common soldiers kneeling in the mud of the square while she put a small silver badge on each man's sleeve, a hand bearing a lamp, and raised their pay by two gros a month from the privy purse. The veterans of the old duke's wars watched with the faces of men revising everything they believed about rulers.

"Your father would have spent that silver on a banner," Brive said, low, at her shoulder.

"My father's men died unnamed in a river crossing and the account says only 'losses moderate.' I read it last winter. Banners don't write home to widows."

"No, madame." The old marshal was quiet a moment. "They don't."

Thiébaut watched the ceremony from the guildhall steps with the Bastard, and Jean said, "She's buying something you can't buy with pay."

"She's keeping accounts," Thiébaut said. "That's what she calls it."

"You know what I call it? I call it why the next levy will be oversubscribed." Jean shook his head. "We're going to have to become better men to keep up with her. I resent it already."

The command tent had a copper bath, a campaign luxury Oriabel had insisted on, and she washed the day off in water that went pink and then grey, and put on a clean shift, and sat by the brazier with her hair loose and her hands shaking now that they were allowed to. The tent flap opened and closed, and Thiébaut came in washed and out of his armor, in a shirt and hose, with the shoulder wrapped, carrying a flask and two cups.

He set them down and looked at her, and the restraint he carried like a second skin was visibly at war with something else. "If you want to be alone, say so. I'll take the other tent."

"I don't want to be alone." She said it into her cup. "I want not to be in my own head for an hour. Is that a thing you know how to do?"

"It's the one thing soldiers are good for." He set his own cup down and came to her chair, and knelt in front of her the way she had knelt by the boy, and took both her hands. "Jeanne. Look at me."

She looked. His eyes were tired and steady and entirely without the careful distance of the council.

"Tell me to stop and I stop."

"Don't stop."

He kissed her then, and it was nothing like the wedding night, nothing careful or asked in stages. It was urgent and rough and close to grief, two people who had spent the day in the presence of death clutching at the proof of life, and she answered it with the same desperation, her hands in his hair, his mouth on her throat, the brazier's heat and the wine and the distant camp sounds all running together.

They made it to the camp bed with most of their clothes still on, and there was nothing graceful in it, no instruction and no sequence, only need. He was rough when she wanted rough and gentle the instant she made a sound of pain, his hand finding hers in the dark of the tent and holding it the way he had the first night, the one fixed point. Her body, which had learned him in the slow nights at the Haut-Tertre, knew what to do even while her mind was full of the hospital tent, and somewhere in it the strangest thing happened: the boy's face and the gunsmoke and the blood began to recede behind the living warmth of the man over her, the beat of his heart against her breast, and she clung to that as though it were a rope thrown into dark water.

Afterwards they lay tangled in the sheets, both slick with sweat, the tent glowing faintly with the brazier's embers. He did not withdraw into his own

side as he usually did, but stayed close, his head against her shoulder, careful of nothing except her.

"Philippe Aubert," she said into the dark. "Write that name down tomorrow. I won't trust it to anyone else's ledger."

"I'll write it with you." A pause. "And the others. All of them. We'll keep the book together. Every name."

"Every name." She stared at the tent roof. "My father never kept a book of the dead. He kept a book of the victories. I used to think that was strength."

"It's a kind of strength. It's just not yours." His arm tightened around her. "Sleep if you can. Tomorrow we count the living, which is harder."

She slept, eventually, with the weight of him beside her and the names of the dead already arranging themselves in her mind in the clerk's neat columns, and outside the tent the army of Vauréal and Lorraine kept watch over the town it had taken and not sacked, and the river went on under the broken bridge as though no one had died for it at all.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Banker's Ledger

The campaign season ended as campaigns do, not with a decision but with mud. Through June and July the army took the war to the French in the old fashion of marches: raiding parties across the fords, the convoys harried, the two captured bridge-forts repaired and regarrisoned, Graçay's expensive army made to pay for every league of road it held. By August the Regent's treasury was feeling the war in the only place Paris felt anything, and the French pulled back to the forfeit fiefs to digest them, and by the first snows the field armies were in winter quarters and the war moved indoors, where Jeanne had always been strongest and where it was about to become more expensive.

The Haut-Tertre in December was a different palace from the one she had inherited in March. The corridors smelled of woodsmoke and drying wool; the chancellery had doubled its clerks and tripled its hours; the great hall did double duty as a storehouse, with bales of Sainterre cloth stacked against the walls as collateral Dolfin's factors had already inspected twice. A duchy at war, she discovered, was a household that never slept: dispatch riders at all hours, the treasury cart trundling between Aubecourt and Malemort under

guard, the wounded from the frontier billeted in the lower town with their pensions and their missing limbs and their claims.

She and Thiébaut had settled into the strange, workable architecture of a marriage made in council. Days were separate sovereignties: she in the round chamber with Foulques and Colard, he in the map room with Brive and the Lorraine captains. Evenings were shared, the supper table a second council, the nights the negotiated country of the great bed. The court, denied quarrels, had begun to manufacture stories about the arrangement instead, and Lisette brought her the harvest of them with relish: they were said to be rapturously happy, coldly estranged, secretly pious, and in one imaginative version the parents already of a hidden son being nursed in a village.

"People will believe anything that saves them from thinking," Jeanne said, and went back to the tax rolls.

The tax rolls were the winter's true battlefield. The campaigning had cost, by Colard's final reckoning, seventy-eight thousand écus, of which Dolfin's loan had covered forty and the rest had been scraped from the customs, the war contributions, the sale of two ducal manors, and the melting of the late duke's ceremonial plate, which the goldsmiths had received with the faces of men at a funeral. Now the vassals had to be

made to pay for the next season, and the vassals had other ideas.

* * *

The assembly of estates in the great hall was three days of practiced grievance. The lords wanted the war financed by the towns, the towns wanted it financed by the lords, the clergy wanted it financed by nobody and offered prayers instead, and Hautperthuis, smooth and mourning-clad and freshly arrived with his train, wanted a committee.

"A committee," Jeanne repeated, in the silence after his speech. "For the collection of the subsidy."

"To ensure, madame, that the burdens fall justly, and that the ancient customs of the lordships are respected." He smiled his warm, unreadable smile. "No man here refuses the duchess's needs. We seek only the means to meet them without crushing the tenantry, whose love is the true wealth of the state."

There was a murmur, the sound of men buying time. She let it run, then set down her own copy of the subsidy schedule.

"The tenantry's love is a fine thing, cousin. The tenantry is also currently being defended by soldiers whose pay is in arrears. Let me assist the committee before it is born. The crown's own tax practice, which I have had copied from the Paris

records, sets the noble subsidy at a tenth of assessed rents in wartime. I ask a fifteenth. The towns, under their new charters, vote their own contributions at a twelfth, which is their affair. The clergy, who hold a fifth of the best land in the duchy, will pay a twentieth and like it, since I have the bishop's own admission that the alternative is a forced loan at interest, which he considers a sin. There will be no committee, because a committee is a machine for turning an emergency into an argument. The schedule stands. Payments in two installments, by Candlemas and by Easter. Colard has the books open at the door."

It was not quite the end of it; nothing ever was. Erquelines's nephew wanted exemptions for his uncle's marches and got instead a lecture about the imperial correspondence Lisette's people had intercepted, delivered in a voice sweet enough to curdle milk. Two old lords tried the gambit of weeping for the late duke and were given copies of his last campaign budget to weep over. Hautperthuis himself, when the hall had emptied, lingered to pay his compliments, and she watched the charm go to work one more time at close range.

"You have grown into your father's chair, madame. It is remarkable to see."

"I have grown into my own chair, cousin. My father's is in the chapel vault." She folded the

schedule. "Your own installment is a large one. I trust the road repairs did not overburden the estate."

"Not at all. A labor of love." The smile did not waver. "Though I confess I look to the spring with some anxiety. The French are very strong. There are those who wonder whether even the Lorraine alliance can—"

"Those persons may bring their anxieties to the war council, where the Sire de Graçay's strength is discussed with maps rather than murmurs. Good day, cousin."

When he had gone, Foulques emerged from the window embrasure where he had been ostentatiously reading. "He'll delay the first installment."

"He'll delay it, and then pay it in clipped coin, and then ask for a receipt in full. Lisette?"

The maid materialized from behind a tapestry, which never failed to unsettle the clerks. "His steward met a French factor at the Heurtois fair, my lady. Two days' ride, in a priest's clothes. We have the inn and the witness. Also his leases: three border manors changed hands last month through a lawyer in Pont-d'Ortelle, and the new tenants are all men who used to be French garrison sergeants. My lady, he's planting soldiers on the marches as rent-payers."

"Keep watching. Nothing that would warn him. I want the whole pattern before I move." She turned to Foulques. "And Dolfin. He's asked for an audience; give him tomorrow, and give him the treasury's true books, not the pretty ones. A banker who catches you lying once prices every truth you tell him afterward."

* * *

Dolfin came in out of the December sleet with snow on his velvet and the smell of the counting house about him, and they did business over spiced wine in the treasury office with one chair and no witnesses but Colard.

"The war will cost you ninety thousand next season," he said, opening his own books. "I have the figures. Your subsidy will bring perhaps thirty-five, the customs twenty-eight if the river stays open, the Sainterre contribution twelve. That leaves fifteen, plus the interest on the existing forty, plus whatever the spring's emergency invents, and the spring always invents something. My house is prepared to lend a further thirty thousand."

"At what rate?"

"Twelve percent, given the collateral's performance. But my partners want new security. The Malemort customs are now lent against twice.

They want the iron tithe of Grisay, and a seat on the Grisay board."

Jeanne set down her cup. "The iron tithe is the duchy's oldest revenue. If I give your house a hand in the forges, the forges answer to Venice within a decade."

"Then refuse, and finance the spring from your vassals' patriotism, which I have watched for three days and would not lend a florin against." Dolfin was not unkind; he was merely accurate. "Madame, hear the professional. You are winning the war. I mean that literally; my factors travel, and Graçay's suppliers are going unpaid while yours are paid in full. But wars of attrition are decided by the side whose borrowing holds out one season longer. The Regent borrows at eighteen in Paris and hates every minute of it. You borrow at twelve. Time is your asset, and time is paid for in my coin. Give me the iron tithe as a six-year security, reverting fully on repayment, with no board seat but an inspector's right of audit. I will talk my partners down from the board."

She looked at Colard, who gave the small nod of a man who had already arrived at the same arithmetic.

"Six years, the audit right, and a clause allowing early redemption at par." She wrote it herself on the spot. "And one thing more, Messer Dolfin. Your house knows every money movement

in this country. I want the names of every lord in Vauréal who holds a balance outside the duchy, at Paris or with the imperial banks. Not the amounts. The names."

The banker's eyes flickered, the only sign of surprise he permitted himself. "That is not information my house sells."

"It is information your house gives to a borrower who is asking, in confidence, as a condition of the next thirty thousand. I will not use it in court. I will use it to know which of my vassals can afford a long war and which cannot. You may keep the amounts."

He considered her for a long moment, and then did a thing she had not seen before: he laughed, once, without bitterness. "The late duke kept ledgers of soldiers. You keep ledgers of souls. Very well. The names, in a sealed list, with the loan papers. Madame, I will say to you what I say to no client: do not lose. A default would oblige me to admire your successor, and I have grown used to admiring you."

* * *

Claire de Sombernon arrived three days before Christmas, with a cart of salvaged furniture, two women, and a story that had half the palace in tears before vespers.

Her late husband's manor in the Lorraine marches had been among the first places overrun in the spring's fighting; the French had put the steward to death and turned the house into a supply post, and she had spent six months in a kinswoman's damp castle before Thiébaut's letters won her safe conduct through the lines to the Vauréal court, where he had promised her the protection of the household until her lands could be recovered. She was twenty-seven, auburn-haired, quietly beautiful in the manner of women who have been told so often that they no longer need to think about it, and she knelt to Jeanne with a grace that made every other woman in the room look as though she were kneeling for the first time.

Jeanne raised her with the correct words and the correct smile and the cold, unwelcome sensation, somewhere under her ribs, of a cat entering a room full of birds.

The court noticed everything. It noticed that the new lady was given apartments near the duchess's own, that Thiébaut received her in the antechamber with a brief handclasp and a low conversation about her late husband's tenants, that Jean the Bastard greeted her like an old friend and the Abbé de Viray kissed her forehead like a niece. It noticed above all that she was perfectly, irritatingly admirable: she organized the palace's sewing circle into a bandage workshop, she played

the lute without ostentation, she was polite to Foulques and kind to Lisette and ate without complaint the salt cod of fast days.

"She's good," Lisette admitted, darkly, on the second evening. "That's the problem. If she were a schemer I'd know what to do with her. She's just a widow with good manners and a manor the French are sleeping in."

"Then we shall have to be excellent to her, and die of it quietly." Jeanne examined her own face in the silver-backed glass with more care than usual. "Find out one thing. Not gossip. Fact. What there was, between her and the duke, before the marriage."

Lisette found it by the unromantic method of asking the Abbé de Viray's housekeeper over bread and ale, and brought it back entire and unadorned: after his return to Lorraine, in the bleak years, there had been a connection, discreet, brief, ending by mutual consent before the Vauréal treaty was ever signed. Claire de Sombernon had wanted a convent or a second marriage; the duke had wanted neither to be misunderstood; they had parted friends, and she had married within the year, a marriage he had attended as a witness.

"Over," Lisette said. "Decidedly, boringly over. He hasn't written her a personal letter since the wedding, only the safe-conducts, and I've seen them all because her woman talks."

"Thank you. That will be all."

The knowledge did not help as much as it should have, because the trouble was not the facts. The trouble was the sight of the woman across the hall, at home in a way Jeanne could not yet be, in the easy possession of years of Thiébaut's life that Jeanne had not shared: the poor duchy, the cold winters, the farrier and the shoulder and the long road between. She had the treaty and the bed and the name. Claire de Sombernon had the missing seven years, and there was no clause for that.

* * *

The Christmas feast was smaller than the wedding's, nine courses again but plainer, with the officers of the army and the household rather than the vassals, and the hall dressed in green boughs and the red and silver rather than cloth of gold. Jeanne had planned it as a statement of disciplined wartime economy, and the statement was proceeding well until the musicians struck up a dance and Thiébaut, with the unreadable politeness of a man walking onto a frozen moat, led Claire de Sombernon out for the first measure.

It was correct. It was, in fact, unavoidable: the highest-ranking widow of the court took the first dance with the host, and the hostess danced with the highest-ranking gentleman, which was the Bastard Jean, who promptly stepped on her hem

and apologized with such comic sincerity that she laughed despite herself. The court watched all of it with the attention courts give to anything that might become a story. Jeanne danced the measure correctly, talked to Jean correctly, smiled across the hall at the correct intervals, and kept her face on so tight by the end of it that her jaw ached.

Thiébaut handed Claire back to her chair with a word that made her smile, and came down the hall toward the high table, and the smile he gave Jeanne was entirely without guilt, which was somehow the most provoking thing about it.

"You're angry," he said, low, taking his seat beside her.

"I am observing the feast."

"You observe the feast the way a cat observes a mouse hole. Jeanne. Whatever is being built in your head, stop building it. I danced with her because not dancing with her would have been the larger story, and I have known her since she was a girl in my wife's—" He stopped. "Since she was a girl at my court. There is nothing in that room that belongs to us except us."

"Don't." She kept her smile on for the hall. "Don't say the thing that makes me the unreasonable wife. I know the protocol. I wrote the protocol. I am perfectly capable of being

reasonable in public. It is the private practice that is currently costing me."

"Then we'll practice in private. After the feast."

* * *

The fire in the bedchamber had been built high against the December cold, and the tapestries were drawn against the draughts, and for once she dismissed the women early and did not take out the dispatches. He came in smelling of snow and horses, shut the door, and stood against it with his arms folded, and they regarded each other across the firelit room like two negotiators who had finally run out of clerks.

"Ask me," he said.

"I don't need to ask. I know the facts. The connection after your return from Vauréal, brief, ended before the treaty, and her marriage which you witnessed. My information is good."

"Your information is excellent, and also beside the point, because the facts are not the thing." He crossed to the hearth and stood looking down into the flames. "Jeanne. I will tell you the whole of it, not because you asked but because I have decided there will be no locked rooms between us that I hold the key to. You may keep yours as long as you like. Mine are open."

He was quiet a moment, choosing it.

"I came home from your father's court at twenty with a duchy falling apart and a hole in my life where my future had been. I did not intend to touch anyone for years. Claire's husband was alive then, and there was nothing, only friendship. He died in the French raid of 'eighty-one, and she was left with a burned manor and a dower the lawyers were eating, and we were both people who had been refused something, and for six months, carefully, with all the proprieties, we were together. It was kind. It was never going to be anything but kind, and we both knew it. She wanted a life. I had no life to give anyone; I had a siege. We ended it cleanly, she married Sombernon the next year, and I stood as witness because I was glad for her. Since my wedding day I have not written her a word that the Abbé de Viray could not read aloud in church. That is the whole account. Do with it what you like."

Jeanne sat in the chair by the fire with her hands in her lap and made herself examine the jealousy honestly, the way she examined a ledger column. It was not distrust of him; the facts were the facts, and she believed them. It was the old wound, the thing that had happened in the great hall, the certainty lived at fifteen and never quite killed: that she could be given up, that another arrangement could always be made, that she was at bottom a clause in someone else's treaty.

"The problem is not Claire," she said at last. "The problem is that she had seven years of you that I don't get to inspect. No one does. I have the man at the end of them, and I have to take the finished article on trust, and I am not built for trust. I was built for accounts, and accounts are only good when you've seen every entry."

"I know." He came and knelt by her chair, the armorless, undefended gesture, and took her hand. "But consider what you're asking. You want evidence that I won't leave. The only evidence is the staying, and the staying takes years. There's no document. If there were, you'd be the first person I'd show it to. You'll have to watch me keep the door, day after day, until the watching becomes a habit. That's the whole security on offer. I'm sorry it isn't better."

It was so exactly the answer she would have given someone else that she had nowhere to put her anger. She looked at the top of his head, at the grey beginning at one temple that the campaigns had put there, and thought of the boy in the solar and the man kneeling by her fire and the long, uninspectable road between.

"One condition," she said. "No mercies I have to discover from the servants. Whatever there is, whatever comes, you tell me yourself, first, even when it's awkward. Especially when it's awkward. I

can bear anything except being the last person in my own palace to know."

"Agreed. And your side of it?"

"My side of what?"

"Reciprocity. The locked rooms. You don't owe me the past; I've told you I won't ask. But the present, Jeanne. The things you decide alone in the dark because you've never had anyone to say them to. I want those. Not because I have a right. Because a government of two that only one of them talks to is just solitude with a witness."

She looked at him for a long time. The fire shifted. Somewhere in the palace a watchman called the hour.

"I'll try," she said. "That's the only promise I know how to make honestly."

"It's the only one worth having." He rose, and lifted her hand, and kissed the palm the way he had on the wedding night, gravely. "Now. The feast was excellent and the dance is over and I believe there's a bed that has heard more state secrets than the council chamber. Will the duchess consent to be escorted to it?"

"The duchess will. And Thiébaut," she stopped him at the bedcurtain, "thank you. For the open door. I know what it costs you."

"It costs less than the other thing." He drew the curtain. "I've tried both."

* * *

Claire asked for the audience herself, in a short, correctly worded note delivered by her own woman rather than through the palace channels, and Jeanne, who had been expecting either the note or its absence as a test of character, granted it at once.

They met in the solar of the queen's tower, a small room of women's things, tapestry frames and a virginal and a view over the frozen river, and Jeanne took Lisette but no other guard, and the other woman brought only her sewing.

"Madame." Claire did not kneel; she curtsied, the courtesy of one great lady to another, and sat only when invited. "I will be brief, because I have spent my life among courtiers and distrust the long speech. My presence here is an injury to you whether it should be or not, and I have been asking myself whether to go. I have decided not to, unless you send me, because a woman who flees in the middle of a war confirms every story it would be kinder to kill. But I owe you the direct statement, and I make it once: the duke and I were something, years ago, in another country, and it is over as completely as anything between two living people can be. He has never given me one word since his

marriage that the whole court might not hear. I am here for my manor and my tenants, in the only court strong enough to get them back. That is the whole of my politics."

Jeanne had prepared several versions of this conversation and used none of them. "You're plain, madame."

"I'm twenty-seven and a widow. Plainness is one of the few luxuries left to me." Claire's hazel eyes, lighter than Thiébaut's, were direct. "I will also say, since I am being plain, that you need not like me. But you may use me. I know every lord within fifty miles of Nancy, their wives, their debts, and their mistresses, because that is the work a woman of my station does whether anyone asks her to or not. If I am to live in your household, let me earn my bread."

It was impossible to dislike her. Jeanne noted the fact with some irritation. "Then earn it now. What does the Lorraine camp truly think of the marriage? Not the official version."

A small, genuine smile. "That you are the most alarming piece of good fortune to befall Lorraine in a century. That the duke sleeps, which he did not before. That the army's pay arrives on time, which it never did. And that you and I would one day have exactly this conversation, on which there were wagers in my escort, which I have now won."

Despite herself, Jeanne laughed. "Tell your escort the duchess admires its imagination. Madame de Sombernon, you will remain, and you will have a place in the household, and we will be courteous in public and honest in private, because I have no use for anything else. One rule: no closed doors with my husband that I have to hear about from anyone but him."

"Agreed with all my heart. Closed doors are a young woman's mistake." Claire rose, curtsied again, and went out with her sewing, and Jeanne stayed by the window watching the ice on the river, and found that the cat in the room of birds had turned out to be another bird, and that she was not entirely sure what to do with the absence of an enemy.

"She's good," Lisette repeated, gloomily.

"She's useful. There's a difference, though I'm damned if I know which is more dangerous."

* * *

The Grisay dispatch came with the first hard frost, carried by a courier whose horse died at the lower gate. Brother Anselm's preaching had moved from the churches to the market squares and now to the guildhalls: the rich were damned, the clergy were wolves, the duke's wars were God's judgment on a wicked city, and the forges ought to be making plowshares rather than guns. Two of the

ducal tax collectors had been driven out of the iron hills with their account books burned, and the city's aldermen, chosen under the new charter, were writing in some panic that they could not answer for the peace past Candlemas.

Jeanne read it aloud at the supper table, in the flat voice she used for bad news, and watched the table's faces. Brive wanted soldiers. Foulques wanted an ecclesiastical process. Dolfin, dining with them that evening, wanted the forges protected above all considerations, because the iron tithe was now his security.

Thiébaut said nothing until the others had spent themselves, then: "It isn't a revolt yet. It's a conversion. You don't put down a conversion with the provost. You go and argue."

"Argue with a man who preaches damnation?" Brive said.

"Damnation is an argument. It has premises and conclusions, and its premises can be shown to be expensive." He looked at Jeanne. "Take the charter, take the law, take a small guard, and take Lisette, because a city in a religious mood will trust a woman's household sooner than soldiers. I hold the army a day's march away. If he turns it into a fight, I'll come. But I think he'll talk. Preachers who want to fight don't write sermons; they write letters."

Jeanne folded the dispatch. "After Candlemas, then. Let him burn hot through the winter. The colder the weather, the thinner the crowds in the squares. And send word to the aldermen: the duchess is coming, with the charter in one hand and the law in the other, and she expects to be heard in her own city."

She wrote it into the ledger that night, beneath the loan and the subsidy and the names of the vassals Dolfin's sealed list had given her, and closed the book on the year fourteen hundred and eighty-four, which had begun with a corpse in a cart and ended with a marriage, an army, and the first fragile outline of a reign.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Preacher's Fire

Ghent announced itself before it was seen. The iron hills were red with it, a rust-colored country of mines and charcoal stacks and muddy roads churned by ore carts, and the sky above the valley wore a permanent brown haze through which the winter sun hung like a worn coin. The smell came next, cinders and sulfur and the hot-metal reek of a hundred forges, and then the sound, the deep rhythmic hammering that gave the city its pulse and never entirely stopped, day or night, weekday or feast.

Jeanne came down the valley road with two hundred lances, a deliberately small force, and Thiébaut's army a full day's march behind at the river crossing, according to the plan. The city's charter aldermen met her at the gate in their new red gowns, and their relief was so poorly concealed that it bordered on insult.

"Madame." The senior alderman, a forge master named Bertout, kissed her ring with a sweating face. "The city is yours. It is merely, at present, of several minds about it."

"Then show me the minds." She dismounted in the courtyard of the ducal house that served

Grisay as a hall of justice. "First the dead man, then the preacher, then the forges. In that order."

The dead man was a clerk of the chancellery, young, twenty-three, sent out in the autumn to audit the iron tithe. His name was Rémy, and his body lay in the chapel of Saint-Eloi, the smiths' church, preserved through the cold in a lead-lined coffin and watched by his fellow clerks in shifts, as though the watching could keep the manner of his death politically alive. The aldermen's account, stammered out on the road, was this: Rémy had been cornered in the tithe yard by a crowd stirred from Anselm's sermon on the damnation of tax-gatherers, chased into the church porch, and beaten to death with hammers and a piece of paving stone. No one had seen anything. Everyone had been there.

"Thirty witnesses and no culprit," Jeanne said, looking at the coffin. "That is not an investigation, Bertout. That is a city hiding."

"Madame, the mood—"

"The mood is my business. Yours is the law. Open the coffin."

They opened it. She had seen worse by now, the siege surgeons had seen to that, but she made herself look properly, the way she had taught herself to look at the ledgers she did not want to read. The boy's skull was crushed in three places.

His hands were broken, raised in defense. On his thumb was an ink stain that would not wash off, the mark of his trade.

"Thirty people watched this," she said, more to herself than to the aldermen. "Thirty people who go to confession and take the sacrament. What is he preaching, exactly?"

* * *

Anselm preached in the great square of the iron market, because the churches had begun refusing him their pulpits and the square suited him better in any case. He was forty, lean to the point of emaciation, barefoot in the January frost in the Franciscan manner, with a face made for high balconies: deep-set burning eyes, a prophet's brow, and the voice of a man who could fill a square without effort. Jeanne went to hear him on her second morning, plainly dressed in a dark gown with a plain wool veil, Lisette at her side and twelve guards in ordinary cloaks spread through the crowd.

He was magnificent, which was the trouble. He preached on the rich man and the eye of the needle, and he preached it with a craftsman's knowledge of his audience's injuries: the tithe that took a tenth of the smith's profit, the toll that ate the carter's margin, the war taxes that came while the duke's soldiers ate the countryside. He named

none of it wrong, Jeanne thought, standing among the smells of cinders and unwashed wool. That was his genius. Every grievance was real. What he did with the real grievances was the fraud: he stacked them into a staircase that led only upward, to the conclusion that all authority was demonic, all priests corrupt, all taxes the mark of the Beast, and the only Christian life the one that burned the account books and hammered the plowshares out of the guns.

"*Two masters*!" he cried, and the crowd answered him in groans. "*No man can serve two masters, and yet they make you serve the duchess's tax and God's tithe together, and call it peace! The Christ had no ledger! The apostles kept no toll! What fellowship has the hammer of the faithful with the cannon of the princes?*"

He saw her then. She had known he would; a preacher of his quality watches every rich cloak in his crowd, and her guards, plain as they tried to be, had the set of soldiers. His eyes locked onto hers across the square, and without a heartbeat's pause he bent the sermon toward her like a river finding a new channel.

"*And here is the age in little! A woman who rules what God gave to men, a Jezebel in a veil, come up from her painted palace to count the iron of the poor! Let her answer if she can: by what scripture does a woman hold the rod of the*

princes? By what right does she tax the bread of the children of the forge?"

The crowd turned, a slow collective movement, four hundred faces swinging onto her, the hostility and the curiosity and the ancient, dangerous joy of a crowd that has been handed a victim. Lisette's hand found her sleeve. Under their cloaks the guards' hands moved.

Jeanne let the silence lengthen until it became uncomfortable, and then she did the thing she had planned in the cold logic of the night before: she walked forward, through the crowd, to the foot of the preaching cross, where everyone could see that she was not afraid and that she was alone, and she raised her voice without shouting, the trick of the Aubecourt square.

"Brother Anselm. I will answer, since you ask in public and the question deserves a public answer. Scripture first, since you chose it. Deborah judged Israel, and the book of Judges calls her a mother in Israel, and no scribe thought to strike the verse. Huldah prophesied to the king, and the king obeyed her. The queen of Sheba tested Solomon's wisdom and was praised for the journey. If you know a text that forbids a woman the rod, bring it to the scholars of Heurtois and dispute it; I will pay for the debate. But do not answer a text with a shout. That is what the heathens do."

The crowd's sound changed, the shifting noise of people who had been offered an argument instead of a spectacle and were not sure what to do with it. Anselm recovered first. "Deborah did not tax the forges! A woman's rule may be suffered as a scourge, but it is not a grace—"

"Now the tax. You say the apostles kept no toll. They also kept no forges, no walls, and no army, and the day the French come over your hills you will discover why. What does the tax buy, Brother? Ask the smiths of Saint-Vaast, whose town was taken and whose houses were not sacked, because the army you despise crossed a river and died in a breach to take it back. Ask the widows of this city whose husbands' names are read in every church because I keep a book of them. You call the tax a mark of the Beast. I call it the price of the walls, and the walls are the reason you are allowed to stand in this square and call me Jezebel instead of preaching in a cellar to a French garrison."

A voice in the crowd, a woman's, called out that the tolls were still too high, and Jeanne turned toward it at once. "Then petition your aldermen under your charter, because the tolls are their court now, not mine. That is what the charter says, and I sealed it with my own hand. The preacher offers you heaven. I offer you a court that can lower a toll by Friday. Which of us has the better answer for a Tuesday?"

The laugh that went through the square was the thing that broke him, she thought later; crowds that laugh are no longer crowds, they become audiences again, and Anselm's power was the power over a crowd. His face twisted with the pure, sincere fury of the man who has lost a room, and he raised his arms for the closing denunciation, and Jeanne, who had not finished, spoke over him.

"One thing more. Rémy the clerk died in the porch of Saint-Eloi, beaten with hammers, while thirty of this city watched. Whatever you think of taxes, Brother, a boy who kept accounts was murdered at the door of a church. If your gospel has no room for his widow and his mother, then your gospel is not the one the apostles kept. I am here to see his death answered. I will be at the justice house tomorrow. Any man who saw what happened in that porch may come to me there, under my hand and seal, and no hand in this city will touch him for the telling."

She turned and walked back through the crowd with Lisette rigid at her side and the guards closing like a drawbridge, and behind her Anselm's voice rose again, but the square was arguing now in little groups, and argument, as Thiébaut had said, was the one thing a demagogue could not survive.

* * *

The trouble came from the side, the way trouble always does. They were halfway down the street of the armorers, the crowd thinning, when Lisette said, very quietly, "Three behind. The one with the hammer. They've been with us since the square."

Jeanne did not turn. "The guards?"

"Too far. They're closing the honest people between us on purpose." The maid's voice was steady; she had been carrying messages through courts since she was twelve. "Walk faster. The chandler's shop, ten paces—"

The rush came with a roar of drink and dogma, three men with their hoods up, one indeed carrying a smith's hammer, and the crowd shrieked and scattered. Jeanne had her dagger out by training rather than thought, but it was Lisette who did the useful thing: she seized the heavy iron shop sign beside the chandler's door and swung it, chain and all, into the foremost man's knees, and he went down in a clatter, and the second tripped over him, and the third was met by the guards, who arrived in a storm of cloaks and steel and took him into the gutter with a professional efficiency that ended the affair before the street had fully understood it.

"Are you hurt?" Jeanne gripped her maid's arm.

"My heart, my lady. Nothing else." Lisette was white but her eyes were blazing. "They meant you,

not me. They meant it in the square and followed the chance."

The captured men were bound and marched to the justice house under a doubled guard, and by evening the interrogations had their answer: three fullers' journeymen, drunk on cider and Anselm, who had decided among themselves that killing the Jezebel would be a work of merit. They named no order from the preacher, because there had been none, and Jeanne believed them; the dangerous thing about Anselm was precisely that he did not need to give orders. He manufactured the weather, and other men committed the storms.

* * *

The witness came at dawn, as witnesses do when the night has been spent in argument with conscience. She was a washerwoman, middle-aged, with the red hands of her trade and a face set for trouble, and she asked for the duchess by name and would speak to no one else. Jeanne received her in the justice house with Foulques and the aldermen and the city's own magistrate, because the arrest she intended had to wear the city's law, not the duchess's will.

"I was in the porch," the woman said, staring at her own hands. "I come for the priests' laundry, and I was early. I saw it. The clerk ran from the tithe yard and into the porch, and the crowd after

him, and Brother Anselm at the back of it, and he called out—" She stopped.

"Called what?" Foulques asked, gently for him.

"He called, 'Let the account books be answered in blood.' Or near it. My lady, I can't give every word. But he said it, and the crowd went up the steps like the words had loosed them. He didn't strike him. He never struck him. But he stood at the bottom and watched them do it, and when the boy was down he turned away and went across the square, and he didn't send for the surgeon or the watch."

The room was quiet. The magistrate, a careful man, wrote it all down and read it back, and the woman made her mark, and Jeanne had the mark witnessed by three aldermen.

"Your name is protected under my seal," she said. "If any man troubles you, the city answers to me. You have done a hard thing. Go with the guard; they'll see you home."

When she had gone, the argument began exactly where Jeanne had expected. The aldermen wanted the three journeymen tried and the preacher left alone, because arresting Anselm meant facing the fullers, and the fullers meant the streets. Foulques wanted an ecclesiastical process, slow and distant, which would turn him into a martyr without burning the city. Brive, by express

courier from the army, wanted him hanged from the highest chimney in Grisay as an example.

"None of those," Jeanne said. "Listen to the law, because I have spent two nights with the city's charter and the statutes, and this is why we keep them. The city statute against incitement to murder: any person whose public words directly move a crowd to a killing, when the speaker remains present and neither prevents it nor raises the watch, is held as principal to the murder. It's an old statute. Your own aldermen passed it after the grain riots of 'seventy-six, and the crown confirmed it. We try Anselm in the city court, under the city's law, for the killing of Rémy the clerk. Not for his sermons. Not for heresy, which is the bishop's business and would make a saint of him. For a murder in a church porch, under a statute the city wrote for itself."

The magistrate's mouth opened and closed. "It has never been used against a man of the Church."

"It has never been needed. The statute says *person*. If the bishop claims jurisdiction, show him the porch: a secular clerk killed on secular ground in a secular riot. Rome can have an appeal after the city has had its verdict." She stood. "Arrest him this morning, in the square, by the city watch, in the city's name, with the aldermen present. My soldiers stay in their billets. If the fullers riot, the charter militia answers it, not the duke's army.

This city is going to govern itself in public, and find out what that costs."

* * *

They took Anselm at the third hour, in the middle of his morning sermon, and the scene was stranger than anyone had feared and much less bloody. The watch, thirty tradesmen in the city's red and white, climbed the preaching cross while the crowd roared, and their captain, a master smith with arms like oak beams, read the statute aloud in a voice trained over furnaces, and the aldermen stood at the front in their gowns, and the whole thing was done under so much law that the fullers, who had expected soldiers and martyrdom, found themselves with nothing to charge. Anselm went white with the genuine fury of a man who had expected to be struck down and discovered instead that he was being processed, and he shouted prophecy all the way to the city gate, and the crowd watched him go, and did not move.

De Key vanished that night. Jeanne had half expected it; the weaver had been in Grisay since the autumn, moving between the discontented trades, and Lisette's people had his lodging watched. He was gone before dawn with two companions, down the southern road toward the French lines, and when the watch searched his rooms they found copies of Paris letters and a sum of gold écus that no weaver could have earned,

and the letters were read aloud in the market square by the magistrate, and the city learned in one morning that its most radical voice had been on the Sire de Graçay's payroll. The fullers' agitation did not survive the news. Nothing dries up a street movement like the discovery that its leader was a foreign agent.

The trial ran three days. Jeanne attended but did not preside, sitting with the aldermen as the city's court did its work, and the washerwoman gave her evidence again, and the journeymen were tried first, so that the chain from words to killing was laid link by link before Anselm ever came to the bar. He defended himself with passion and some learning, and he was entirely sincere, and he was also, under the plain text of the statute, guilty. The court condemned him to death by hanging, the city's punishment for murder, and the bishop's furious claim of jurisdiction arrived a day too late and was answered with a copy of the statute and the record.

Jeanne commuted the sentence. It was the most discussed act of the winter. She did it in open court, in front of the same crowd that had heard him preach, and she gave her reasons aloud.

"Anselm is guilty under your law, and the sentence stands as the law's sentence. But a hanged preacher is a relic, and I will not give the discontented a grave to march to. The sentence is

commuted to perpetual confinement in the ducal house of correction at Malemort, at hard labor, in silence, with books of devotion and no visitors. Let the man who told the poor that work was a curse spend his life doing work for the poor's bread. If his faith is as real as his fury, God can still find him there. The city keeps its verdict. The city's peace keeps its preacher alive. Take him away."

* * *

She went to see him before she left, because a ruler who will not look at the people she has broken is a ruler who will break the wrong ones eventually. The house of correction stood by the lower river, a former granary with small windows and whitewashed walls, and the keeper led her through the workroom where the prisoners picked oakum in the cold to the cell they had given the preacher alone, for safety's sake.

Anselm sat on a stool in his coarse prison shirt, thinner than the man in the square, his bare feet on the stone, and he rose when she came in with the instinctive dignity of the clergy even in disgrace.

"Jezebel comes to view the captive prophet," he said.

"Jeanne comes to ask a question, and then she'll leave you to your silence." She stayed by the door,

her hands in her muff. "Did you mean for them to kill him? Rémy. In the porch."

The burning eyes flickered. For a moment she saw the man under the prophecy, a clever, exhausted, frightened man who had discovered too late the size of the force he had summoned. "I meant the fear of God. I meant the books to burn and the clerks to run. I did not mean a boy to die. I have said so in my prayers every night."

"Then learn the arithmetic of crowds, since God apparently hasn't explained it. You don't get to choose what a crowd does after you've heated it. You may intend the books. The crowd intends whatever the cruelest man in it intends, and it does it in your name. That is why rulers keep law, Brother. Not because law is holy. Because it is cold, and cold things don't catch fire."

"The law is the rich man's shield."

"The law is the only shield the poor man has that the rich man also has to carry. Your crowd in that porch had no law in it at all. Ask the washerwoman who saw it." She turned to go, then stopped. "You'll be treated well here. Warmth, bread, the offices, books. If in a year you wish to write a recantation of the sermon, not of your faith, it will be read and you may earn a parish. I don't require you to be wrong. I require you to stop being dangerous. The rest is between you and your God, and unlike you, I won't speak for Him."

Outside, the winter air was a relief, and she stood a moment on the steps filling her lungs, and Lisette, who had waited with the guard, said, "You were kinder than he deserved."

"Perhaps. But I meant what I said about the cold." She pulled the muff tighter. "A hanged Anselm would be preaching still, in ten years' time, in a dozen market squares, by other mouths. A silent Anselm picking oakum is a story with no ending. Stories without endings don't spread."

* * *

The forges relit within the week, one by one, the great hammers taking up their old rhythm, and the iron tithe began to flow again, and the aldermen, who had lived a month in terror, were discovered to be suddenly taller. Jeanne spent her last days walking the workshops, because the guns and armor of the spring campaign were being made here and she intended to know how. She learned the difference between bloomery and finery, the smell of good steel and bad, the tempering colors of a gun barrel, and she promised the smiths' guild the same charter terms as Sainterre in exchange for a fixed price on ordinance for the duration, a bargain sealed over wine in the guildhall and written down by both sides.

On the morning she left, the washerwoman came to the ducal house with a parcel, a linen shirt of her own making, coarse and clean, and would say only, "For the road, madame." Jeanne took it with the same gravity she would have given a lord's gift, and wore it on the march, and put the moment in the ledger of the things that were not money.

Thiébaut met the column at the river crossing with the army's van, and fell in beside her horse, and said, "The whole camp knows the story. You argued scripture in a market square, arrested a prophet by his own city's law, and made him a weaver. Jean says you're the most dangerous woman in Europe and wants to know if you'll lecture his officers."

"Jean can be first in line." She looked back once at the red haze above the iron hills. "He was right about some things. That's the difficulty. The tolls are too high, the tithe bites, the clerks are sometimes insolent. A ruler who can't hear the true part of a demagogue's speech is a ruler who deserves him. I've asked the aldermen to review the toll schedule. Not abolish. Review."

"You keep giving ground and ending up taller. I've stopped understanding how you do it."

"It isn't ground." She turned the grey mare north. "It's rent. I pay a little of it on purpose, at

my own time, so no one comes to collect the whole house."

He was quiet a moment, and then laughed, the low, rare laugh she had begun to listen for without admitting it. "We're going to win this war, Jeanne. I don't know when, and I don't know what it'll cost. But we're going to win it."

"Write that down," she said. "I keep accounts of predictions, too."

Behind them the hammers of Grisay beat on, steady as a heart, making the iron that would decide the spring, and the road north ran white and hard through the winter fields toward the court and the next fire, which was already, in the dispatches riding ahead of them, beginning to burn.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Letters from Paris

The French courier was taken at the lower crossing of the Nied, in the grey first week of February, by a Lorraine patrol that had learned to watch for single riders on good horses with plain saddlebags. He swallowed nothing and fought not at all, being a clerk of the postal service rather than a soldier, and the dispatches reached the Haut-Tertre still in their sealed tubes, with the courier himself under a polite guard in the gatehouse, because the Vauréal chancellery had discovered that captured clerks were worth more intact than hanged.

Foulques broke the seals in the round chamber with the reverence of a priest at the altar, and the council spent the afternoon inside the enemy's mind.

There were four letters. The first, from the Regent's war secretary to Graçay, laid out the spring plan in the calm, bored prose of the Paris bureaucracy: a two-pronged advance once the roads dried, the main force against Mont d'Or to pin the field army, a second column through the eastern marches with the cooperation of "the party known to us," which the margin identified nowhere but which every person at the table read as

Hautperthuis. The second was a paymaster's list, and it told them the French army was three months in arrears and borrowing against the next year's taxes, which Jeanne underlined twice. The third was an agent's report on the Sainterre charter, shrewd and hostile, noting that the chartered cities were now the duchess's strongest anchor rather than her weakest wound, and recommending that Paris find its own city to champion.

The fourth was Anne de France's own hand, short and silky, addressed to "our well-beloved cousin the Duchess of Vauréal," and it was this letter that the council read last, in silence, because it was not intended for them at all.

It offered peace. The Regent wrote with apparent warmth of the ancient friendship between the crown and the house of Vauréal, regretted the misunderstandings of the forfeit, and proposed terms: the southern fiefs to remain under French protection as a dowry of reconciliation, a marriage portion in gold to the crown's war treasury, a French garrison, politely called an escort, at Saint-Vaast, and in exchange the immediate withdrawal of all French claims on the northern towns and the Regent's personal guarantee of the duchess's sovereignty under the ancient treaties. The letter ended with an invitation to a conference at Heurtois, under the bishop's roof, at the duchess's convenience, and a

postscript in the same elegant hand: *It is the part of wise princes to buy cheaply what wars sell dear. I write as one woman of business to another.*

"She's read my ledgers," Jeanne said.

"She's read everyone's ledgers." Foulques turned the page. "Note the structure. Every concession she offers concerns lands she does not hold. Every guarantee she asks concerns the door into your country. This is not a peace offer. It is an inventory."

"It is also," Thiébaut said, from the map, "the first sign her treasury is nervous. You don't write letters like this in a winning year. The paymaster's list is the truth of it. Paris wants the war paused so it can afford to restart it."

"Then the answer is not no. The answer is a courtship." Jeanne set the letter down. "We accept the conference in principle, at a date after the roads dry, and we send negotiators with instructions to be endlessly courteous and endlessly incapable of agreeing. Every week Paris spends talking is a week she isn't paying an army to march. Foulques, draft it yourself. Be so reasonable that she cannot find the insult."

"While we use the same weeks to finish our own preparations." Brive's beard moved in what might have been a smile. "Madame, you would have made a fine Frenchwoman."

"I am a fine Frenchwoman. That's why I know exactly what she's doing."

* * *

The Rostaing business came to them three days later, carried not by dispatch but by a priest, which was how the worst things traveled in winter.

He was the parish curate of a village called Argnon, on the southeastern marches, and he had ridden two days in snow to reach the court, and he asked for the duchess by name and would speak to no one else. She received him in the justice room, with Foulques and Thiébaut and Brive, and the old man knelt on the cold flags and wept before he could speak, and when he did speak the room went very still.

Captain Rostaing, the hard young cavalryman whose courage at the fords had made him the army's favorite, had been scouring the eastern marches for the French raiding parties that winter. At Argnon, the curate said, the village had given shelter for one night to a dozen armed strangers who claimed to be disbanded soldiers and who had paid for their bread in good silver. They had been French scouts. Rostaing's company had found their trail, reached the village at dawn, and asked the headman why he had fed the king's enemies. The headman had answered that he had not known,

which was probably true, and that the strangers had had swords, which was certainly true.

Rostaing had held a summary inquiry at the well, in the snow, with no witnesses called and no clerk. He had concluded that the village was a nest of traitors, and he had burned it. Not the houses alone. The curate's list, read out in his shaking voice, named twenty-seven dead: four men, nine women, fourteen children and the aged, trapped in the church where they had been put for safety when the thatch went up. The scouts themselves were long gone. Rostaing had reported a successful action against a hostile village and commended his men, and the report had gone into the war files and would have stayed there if the priest had not walked through the snow.

When he finished, the justice room held the particular silence of men who have just had their own side made unendurable.

Brive spoke first, heavily. "The captain's authority in hostile country does extend to example. There are customs—"

"There are customs for soldiers and laws for villagers." Jeanne's voice was level, which frightened the curate more than shouting would have. "Argnon is in my dominion. Its people are my people, sworn to my peace. There is no hostile country here. There is my country, in which a twenty-eight-year-old captain has made himself

judge, jury, and fire over women and children on the word of a trail. Father, leave us the list and your parish register. You have my protection for the journey home, and the village will be rebuilt from the privy purse. No one will ask your name again."

When the priest had gone, she looked at the four men in turn. "Bring him in. Not under arrest yet. I want him to walk into this room believing he's been summoned for a commendation."

* * *

Rostaing came in bright with it, booted and spurred and still carrying the frost of the road, a handsome, reckless man who wore his courage like a decoration. He kissed her ring with the easy confidence of the army's darling, and then read the room, and the confidence did not leave him but became watchful.

She let him tell his own version first, in full, the trail, the strangers, the well-side inquiry, the judgment, the fire. He told it well, without bluster, and she saw the shape of his truth: he believed every word. In his mind he had fought the war the only way it could be fought, and the dead of Argnon were the price of keeping a hundred other villages honest, and a woman at a cushioned court two hundred miles away could not be expected to understand the arithmetic of the snow.

"Captain." She pushed the curate's list across the table. "Twenty-seven. Fourteen of them under twelve years old. Read the names."

He read them. His jaw tightened, but his eyes held. "My lady, war is not a court of pleas. If every hamlet that feeds a French scout is treated as innocent, every hamlet will feed one. I made an example. The eastern marches have had no more sheltered scouts since Argnon. Ask the patrols."

"I am asking you. By what law did you hold court?"

"By the law of necessity, and by my commission as the duchess's officer in the field."

"Your commission binds you to my law, and my law requires a clerk, witnesses, and an appeal to the marshal's court for any judgment of death against a civilian. You held no clerk, called no witnesses, allowed no appeal, and your victims could not flee a burning church. Necessity is the word men use when they have forgotten the law they are paid to defend." She leaned forward. "If your arithmetic is right, captain, why did the French scouts go free while the villagers burned? Why did the armed enemy walk out of your story and the unarmed die in it?"

That got through. For the first time something cracked in the confident face, not guilt exactly but

the recognition of a question he had not asked himself. "They were gone. The trail—"

"The trail led to peasants because peasants don't ride away. You killed the people you could catch and called it the people who were guilty. That is not war. That is hunting."

The word hung in the room. Brive, who loved the boy's courage, stared at his boots. Thiébaut had not spoken once; he sat with his arms folded and his face still, watching her, and she felt rather than saw the support held in reserve, the knowledge that this had to be her judgment and not a husband's.

* * *

Brive came to her chamber that evening, which he had never done, and stood by the fire with the look of a man who had rather be in a siege.

"Madame. I'll not waste your time. The captains are talking. The whole camp is talking. They don't defend the women and children; even Rostaing's friends won't defend the church. They say two other things, and you need to hear them from me and not from a barrack wall. First, that the French scouts would have slit those villagers' throats themselves if the village had refused them, so the village was damned either way and Rostaing merely made the damned useful. Second, that a duchess behind a table can afford a conscience the

men in the snow cannot, and that if every hard judgment in the field is to be hanged at leisure, no officer will make a hard judgment again, and the next French raid will walk through a duchy of careful men."

He stopped, and added, lower: "His father carried my banner for nineteen years. I held him at his christening. I'm not here for him. I'm here because the army believes what it believes, and you cannot command a belief you don't know."

Jeanne let the fire crackle between them for a moment. "Thank you for telling me instead of resigning. Now answer me two things, marshal, as a soldier. If Rostaing's example works, if the marches grow safer because of Argnon, who is it exactly that is safer? The villagers, or the army? Because the villagers are dead. The example does not protect them. It protects future patrols at the cost of present peasants, and a state that prices its peasants below its patrols is a state whose peasants will open their doors to the first Frenchman who knocks. Second: you say careful officers won't make hard judgments. What hard judgment did Rostaing make? He did not fight. He did not scout. He did not catch an enemy. He burned the one thing in the country that cannot run away. That is not the hard judgment. That is the easy one, and I will not have my army learn that the easy thing wears the name of the hard one."

The old man's face worked. "And the army's belief?"

"The army will believe what it sees. It will see a brave man stripped and sent to the ranks, not hanged, and the law said hanging. It will see the village rebuilt at my expense and the dead named in every church. It will see that courage is honored even when its bearer is condemned, and that peasants have a standing in this duchy that captains cannot burn. Give that five years, Brive, and you'll command an army that fights for the country instead of over it."

"You ask a great deal of five years."

"I ask the same five years from everyone, including myself." She rose and put her hand briefly on his armored forearm. "I am not going to hang your godson. But I am going to make him answer. If he is half the man you think, he will answer at Mont d'Or with a pike in his hand, and the story will end better than this chapter."

Brive stood a while longer, looking into the fire. Then he bowed, one of his old formal bows, and said, "Your father could never have done this. He'd have made the brave man a lord and paid the village in silence. I don't know yet whether you're wiser than him. But you're different, and different is the only thing the French won't have planned for."

* * *

The trial, such as it could be, took two days in the great hall, open to the army's officers and the town, because she would not have a whispered sentence. Foulques presented the law, the curate gave his evidence with the parish register in his hands, and Rostaing, advised now and silent, heard the court find him guilty on three counts: unlawful judgment, unlawful killing, and the destruction of the village without lawful order. The statutory sentence was death, and the hall knew it, and the army's officers sat in their rows with closed faces, because the state was about to execute the bravest captain in the host, and every man there was measuring the thing in his own heart.

She pronounced it herself, from the high chair, in the voice of the council chamber. Then she set the document down and did the harder thing.

"The sentence stands as the law's sentence. I will now exercise the duchess's mercy, and I will give my reasons in public, because mercy without reasons is favor, and favor is how armies become bands." She looked at the kneeling man. "Rostaing, you did not kill for gain or cruelty, and you did not kill in fear. You killed out of the belief that your judgment stood above the law. That belief is the true enemy, and it cannot be pardoned, because it would return with your next command. Therefore: the death sentence is commuted. Your commission,

your rank, your company, and your arms are forfeit. You are stripped of the name of captain in this hall, before these witnesses. You will leave the duchy's service and take service with the frontier garrison at Mont d'Or, as a common man-at-arms, under Valvert, at common pay, for the duration of the war. If you earn a name again, it will be a name built from the ranks, and no one will ever say the duchess's law made exceptions for bravery. If you refuse this, the sentence stands. Choose now."

He chose, hoarsely, on his knees, and the hall let out its breath. The officers filed out past him where he knelt, and not one looked away, and she saw in their faces the complicated thing she had wanted: the knowledge that the law reached everyone, and that even the army's darling had been made to answer to a clerk's words and a priest's register.

Afterwards, in the emptying hall, Foulques lingered, and she saw that the chancellor's face had gone grey under its usual composure. "You said something in the justice room," he said, low. "About the law being the only shield the poor have. It moved me, madame. More than I can well say."

"Why? It's true."

"It is true. I once knew a man who forgot it. Who used the law as a weapon against a girl who had done nothing, because a greater man's convenience required it, and who told himself for

seven years that necessity was the word." He put a hand to his chest, briefly, as though it pained him. "You will think me strange. I am only an old clerk with a cold conscience. Forgive me."

He went out quickly, leaving her with the echo of it: *a girl who had done nothing. Seven years.* Lisette, materializing as ever from a curtain, said, "He's been keeping too many late nights. All the same—"

"All the same, write down what he said, word for word, in the private book. And Lisette. Find out where he keeps the green case, and whether it ever leaves his room. I've stopped being patient."

Thiébaut found her there among the empty benches, and did not ask her what Foulques had said, and she did not tell him; but when she stood, his hand closed briefly on her shoulder, and the pressure said that whatever the locked room held, she would not open it alone.

* * *

Rostaing left for Mont d'Or two days later, in a common trooper's cloak on a common trooper's horse, with the stripped rank and the frontier orders in his saddlebags, and she watched him go from the gatehouse because a ruler who pronounced such sentences ought to be seen watching their execution.

He stopped at the gate, though his escort moved on, and looked up at her window, and she came down to the courtyard because there was no useful purpose in making a man shout at stone.

"You could have hanged me," he said. The easy confidence was gone; the face that remained was younger and more honest.

"The law could have hanged you. I chose otherwise, and my reasons don't include kindness. Argnon needs to know its dead were answered, and the army needs to know its bravest man is not above the clerks. A hanging would have bought the first and lost the second. Mont d'Or buys both."

"Then I'm an invoice."

"You're a soldier. It's much the same thing." She held his eyes. "Rostaing, the courage was real. The judgment was not. Learn the difference, and the ranks will give the captain back to you, and I'll confirm it. Don't learn it, and the frontier is a long cold place to spend a war. Serve Valvert. He knows the difference better than any man in the dominion."

He saluted, the common soldier's salute rather than the officer's, and rode out under the portcullis. Brive, who had watched from the stair, came down and stood beside her.

"He'll either be the best captain in the army by next winter or drink himself into a ditch."

"Then we make sure the frontier has no wine worth drinking and every reason to make a man of him. Write to Valvert tonight. Hard, fair, and never once my name in the matter. If there's a redemption, it belongs to the ranks."

* * *

The war council that followed the trial was smaller and colder, held in the map room with only Foulques, Brive, Thiébaut, and the Bastard Jean, and the map on the table was marked in two colors, the known French movements in black and the guessed ones in red.

"The party known to us." Thiébaut put his finger on the secretary's phrase. "It has to be Hautperthuis. The second column's route runs through his marches, and no column of that size moves in winter without prepared supply. Someone has contracted the grain and the guides."

"Proof, not rumor." Jeanne studied the red marks. "Lisette has the steward's meeting at the Heurtois fair and the planted tenants, the ex-French sergeants. None of it hangs him. If I move on a vassal of his rank on suspicion, every other wavering lord runs to Paris before the ink dries."

"Then we leave him in place and make his position useless." Thiébaut's finger moved west. "The second column can't start until the Harchies

roads are passable. But Graçay is already tightening on the Lorraine forts. Our reports say the fort at Sarrebourg, the one that gave me this shoulder, is being invested by a brigade of gascons and light guns. If it falls before the spring, the French winter inside Lorraine and the war comes to Nancy."

"Can it be relieved in February?" Brive asked, the skepticism plain.

"No sane army marches through the Harchies in February." Thiébaut's mouth did the not-smile. "Which is why the gascons won't post a proper screen. I take six hundred lances and the best of the mounted archers, light, no guns, eight days' biscuit, through the forest tracks. We come out behind their investment, break their supply, and the garrison sallies. Jean knows the forest; he smuggled brandy through it at sixteen."

"I smuggled excellent brandy," Jean said. "The forest remembers me fondly."

Jeanne looked at the map, at the long green smear of the forest between the two rivers, and thought about the arithmetic of risk that was becoming her daily trade. "Six hundred is half our best cavalry. If you're caught in the snow, we lose the mobile army and you, in one week."

"If Sarrebourg falls, we lose Lorraine's southeastern wall and spend the spring rebuilding it. One is a risk. The other is an invoice."

"Then we take the risk, and we make it smaller." She traced a track on the map, one of the charcoal-burners' roads her own foresters used. "The Grisay gunners have been making winter powder and testing short-barreled guns on light sledges. I'll send a convoy with fifty mounted gunners and four of the sledge guns, by the western track, the one no soldier would choose. If you're in the forest eight days, the convoy needs ten, and it comes in behind you. My seal on the orders, my treasury for the cost. If this works, Thiébaut, the army sees a Vauréal column save a Lorraine fort. The alliance stops being a wedding and becomes a fact."

The two brothers exchanged a look. "She's better at this than the war college," Jean said.

"She's better at this than most generals," Thiébaut said. "Do it. And Jeanne — one thing. I'll be ten days out of reach of any courier. Whatever else happens, whatever the council brings, don't move on Hautperthuis while I'm in the forest. I want to be in the room when that door opens."

"You will be. I keep my best quarrels for witnesses I trust."

That night she wrote three documents in her own hand. The first was the rebuilding order for Argnon, with the grants of timber and the remission of five years' dues, and the pensions for every bereaved household, and the curate's name nowhere upon it. The second was the order stripping Rostaing's name from the army lists and entering him as a man-at-arms at Mont d'Or, with a private letter to Valvert: *He is to be treated as any man, neither broken nor favored. I have made him answer to the law. See that the law answers him with fairness.*

The third was a short note to the Regent's conference, accepting Heurtois in the politest terms and naming the duchess's envoys, with instructions to discuss everything and settle nothing until the spring had revealed what Paris intended to do.

She sanded the third letter and sat back, and through the connecting door she heard Thiébaut dictating to his clerk the orders for the winter march he was already planning, the desperate mid-February march through the Harchies to relieve the Lorraine fort the French were moving to encircle. She would learn the details in the morning, and argue about them, and probably lose the argument, and finance it anyway.

She closed the ledgers. Outside, the snow fell steadily over the sleeping duchy, white and even,

covering the rebuilt village and the stripped captain and the sealed letters from Paris as though the world intended, for one night, to keep no accounts at all.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Frost March

The cold came down from the Vosges like an invading army, and by the second day in the Harchies the men were calling it the third enemy.

Thiébaut rode at the head of the column with his hood up and his breath pluming, watching six hundred lances and mounted archers diminish into the long white corridor of the forest road. There was no sound but the muted iron of hooves on frozen ruts, the creak of leather, and the endless, patient sifting of snow through bare branches. No trumpets, no banners unfurled, no fires except the small careful ones at the midday halt; a winter march was a thing done in whispers, because noise carried across snow the way it carried across water, and the gascons were somewhere in these woods with the same arithmetic and different orders.

"Smugglers' country," Jean said, cantering up from the rear where he had been checking the stragglers. His eyebrows were white with it. "The charcoal burners have three governments: the duke's, the forest's, and their own, and only the last one collects. I've sent two of them ahead with

silver. We'll know every French picket before it knows us."

"How are the horses?"

"Twelve thrown shoes, two foundered. Better than I feared. The biscuit's holding. The men's boots are not; I've got the cobblers working at every halt. A march in February is mostly a question of feet." Jean looked sideways at his brother. "You're thinking about her convoy."

"I'm thinking about whether ten days was enough, and whether the western track exists, and whether I've put my wife's gunners in a forest no soldier would choose."

"Your wife, as you keep discovering, is not a soldier. That's her advantage." The Bastard grinned, white-mustached with frost. "The track exists. I've used it. And she didn't put the gunners anywhere; she asked for volunteers and got twice the number, because every man in the army wants to be in the story where the duchess's guns come through the snow. You married a legend, brother. Try to look pleased."

They made eight miles on the third day and nine on the fourth, threading the charcoal roads, sleeping in their cloaks around buried fires, the cold so deep that the sentries were rotated every hour and the wine froze in its skins. On the fifth morning the forest scouts came back with the first

hard intelligence: the French brigade investing Sarrebourg had posted a screen of light horse in the eastern wood, four strong pickets, and, the thing Thiébaut had feared, a company of francs-archers working their way down the same road he was on, meaning Graçay's officers had not entirely forgotten the Harchies.

"Then we don't give them time to finish remembering." He spread the scouts' bark map on a shield. "We go around their screen on the north track, hit the archers in their camp at dusk, and keep moving. No pursuit past the road. Jean, the van is yours. I want prisoners with tongues and no noise after dark."

* * *

The francs-archers had made their camp in a clearing where two tracks met, the confident camp of men who believed the war was elsewhere: poor sentries, big fires, their pikes stacked and their tents up. The snow gave the attackers in their white surcoats the only gift winter ever gave, which was invisibility, and Jean's van was among the tents before the French trumpeter got his instrument to his lips.

It was a short, ugly business in the failing light. Thiébaut came in with the second wave and found the fight already breaking into its components: a knot of French infantry making a brave, useless

stand around their captain's banner, men running into the trees, the Lorraine archers shooting the runners down with the cold efficiency of huntsmen. The captain himself, a young Norman with a sword in each hand, sold his banner dearly and took a Lorraine man-at-arms through the throat before Jean's hammer blow to the helmet put him in the snow, and then it was over, and the dark wood was full of the sounds of wounded men freezing.

Thiébaut was taking the count, four dead of his, eleven French, twenty prisoners, the rest scattered, when the scout he had posted on the eastern track came in at a dead run through the snow with the news that turned the evening: the picket screen had not been routine. A full squadron of French men-at-arms, two hundred lances, was moving up the forest road behind them, warned by the camp's first trumpet, and they were perhaps forty minutes out.

"Battle in the open, in this snow, with their weight against our tired men?" Brive's kinsman, the captain of the van's second company, was shaking his head. "We should draw off into the west."

"West is the convoy's track, and we don't lead two hundred fresh lances onto fifty gunners and four sledge guns." Thiébaut was already looking at the ground, the soldier's automatic inventory: the clearing, the stacked French pikes, the narrow

road with its high snowbanks, the bend where the trees met overhead. "We don't run. We take their charge. Jean, the pikes — all of them, French and ours, across the road at the bend, butts braced in the frozen ruts. Archers in the trees on both flanks, dismounted. The horses to the rear. They'll come up the road at a trot because the snow won't allow a gallop, and they'll come two files wide because the banks won't allow more. A charge that wide is a procession. We receive it, we break it, and then the archers take it in the flanks."

It was the right ground and the right answer, and the men knew it, and they moved with the will of soldiers who have been spared a decision. The pikes went up across the bend in a bristling hedge, the archers melted into the snow-laden trees, and Thiébaut dismounted with the rest and took his place at the center with a poleaxe in his hands and the bad shoulder already warning him.

The French came out of the grey dusk at the trot, two hundred armored men on armored horses, lances lowered, the breath of them white in the road. At fifty paces the first rank saw the pike hedge and the narrowing banks and understood the trap, and could do nothing about it because the ranks behind were still pressing. The charge met the pikes at the walk it had been reduced to, and the road became a screaming wall of men and horses and steel.

Thiébaut's war narrowed to the length of his poleaxe. A lance shattered against his shield; he killed the horse with the axe's hammer side and got the rider on the way down. The snow underfoot went red and slippery. He could hear Jean roaring on his left, the archers' arrows thudding into the flanks, the French trumpets blowing recall that no one could reach. The French front was folding, but the press behind kept shoving, and a dismounted man-at-arms got inside his axe's reach with a short sword, and the blade went through his left forearm's weak place in the harness, and the shoulder screamed, and he took the man's jaw with his gauntleted fist and went to one knee in the snow.

The pike meant for his throat came out of the tangle without warning, a Frenchman's weapon lifted high over the press, and there was no time and no angle, and then Jean was there.

The Bastard threw himself sideways into the line of the thrust with no weapon interposed, taking the pike through the meat of his own upper chest and shoulder, and his weight carried both him and the Frenchman down into the bloody snow. Thiébaut saw his brother's face go white, the eyes still open and furious, and something cold and enormous moved in him then, colder than the forest, and he got his axe up and killed the pikeman and the next man and the one after that,

and the French center, which had been bending, broke.

After that it was the road again, the long butcher's pursuit that winter makes slow and terrible. By full dark the squadron was gone in fragments into the trees, leaving sixty dead and as many prisoners, and the Lorraine lances held the bend and the road and the night, and Thiébaut, bleeding from the forearm, knelt in the trampled snow beside his brother.

* * *

Jean was alive. The surgeons said it three times, as though the fact required reassurance. The pike had gone in below the collarbone and come out by the shoulder blade, missing the great vessels by the width of a finger, which the chief surgeon, a man who had seen every wound the century produced, called the work of a guardian angel with steady hands. They got the shaft out with two men holding him down and a leather bit between his teeth, and Jean did not scream, though his did, and then they cauterized and bound and gave him wine, and the Bastard lay in the captured French tent with his face the color of the snow outside and said, through the wine, "Did we win?"

"You know we won. Lie still."

"Then I'm delighted. Tell me I didn't take a pike for a draw." He closed his eyes. "Thiébaut. It was

coming at your throat. I'd do it again, which is the worst thing about being an honest man."

"The surgeon says if the wound fever takes you, I'll kill you myself for making me write the letter to your mistress."

"Which one? Be precise; the letter must be precise." But the grin was weak, and the fever was already there by midnight, the hot dry skin and the wandering talk, and Thiébaut sat by the brazier with his own arm bandaged and the campaign's arithmetic turning coldly in his mind: the French screen broken, the road open, the garrison at Sarrebourg still holding, and somewhere to the west, on a track that might or might not exist, the convoy he had staked his wife's gunners on.

They marched at dawn with the wounded on sledges and Jean among them, and reached the heights above Sarrebourg on the seventh day, and looked down on the French siege lines in the valley: the gascon camp, the zigzag approach trenches, the two light guns already emplaced against the fort's southern wall, and the fort itself, battered but flying the Lorraine standard, which meant the garrison still had breath.

"The investment is loose," Thiébaut said to his captains, glass to his eye. "They never expected a relief in February, and they've built for comfort, not siege discipline. We hit at dawn tomorrow from the wooded slope. If the convoy's guns have

arrived, we'll hear them on the western road. If they haven't—"

"If they haven't," said the van captain, "we do it with what we have."

"With what we have, then."

* * *

They came through the snow at first light, six hundred dismounted lances and archers in their white surcoats, down the wooded slope onto the flank of the gascon camp, and for the first ten minutes it was the francs-archers all over again: surprise, trumpets, tents going down, the enemy running for his weapons. But the gascons were better men than the francs-archers, and their commander was a professional, and within the quarter hour the French had formed a proper square around their guns, and the attack stalled in the frozen mud of the camp approach, and Thiébaut, one-armed and raging, could see the numbers beginning to tell.

Then, from the western road, the unmistakable rolling thunder of artillery.

Four short-barreled guns on their sledges came through the trees at the trot of their draft horses, with fifty mounted gunners in Vauréal red and silver around them, and the crews unlimbered and loaded with the drilled speed Van Brock and Hautemer had spent the winter teaching, and the

first round went into the closed French square at close range, and the second, and the square became a thing with a hole in its side, and the Sarrebourg garrison, seeing the relief on the heights and the guns in the road, sallied out of the southern gate with the remnants of its strength.

The gascon brigade did what a professional brigade does when the ground disappears under it: it withdrew in good order, spiking its two guns and leaving its camp, its stores, and its wounded, and by noon the valley was Thiébaut's, and the Lorraine standard over the fort was answered by the joined arms on the relief column, and the snow was being trampled into a road between the two positions by men laughing and weeping in the same breath.

He found the convoy's commander, a young Grisay gunner named Leclerc, and said only, "The track. Was it as bad as they said?"

"Worse, my lord. But we had charcoal burners as guides, and the duchess's orders, which said the guns were to be at Sarrebourg on the eighth day, and it is the eighth day." The man allowed himself a small, frost-cracked smile. "She also said, if we were late, we needn't bother arriving."

* * *

She arrived in the afternoon, at the head of the convoy's rear guard, on a horse that looked as

exhausted as she did, in a fur-lined leather coat with snow crusted on the hood and the ducal ring glinting on its chain over the leather. Thiébaut, who had believed the worst of every courier for eight days, saw her come through the captured camp and stood very still for a moment, because the alternative was doing something unsoldierly in front of six hundred men.

"You came yourself." He met her at the edge of the tents, and the words came out more roughly than he intended.

"The track was passable, and I wanted to see the sledge guns work." She dismounted without waiting for a hand, stiff-limbed, and looked him over with the clerk's eye he had learned to fear. "Your arm. And Jean. Take me to him."

Jean was feverish but himself, and he saw her and said, "Madame, I have been shot with a pike in your service, and I intend to spend the fact for at least a year," and she sat beside him and gave him the willow-bark draught herself and said he might spend it for two if he lived, which made him laugh and then gasp, and the surgeon said the laugh was the best sign he had seen.

The storm came at dusk, the true February storm the forest had been promising, wind and driven snow that closed the valley within the hour and made the camp tents into a world of their own. The command tent went down in the first gust, and

in the confusion the charcoal burners who had guided the convoy offered their hut in the trees, a low smoky structure of stone and turf with a central fire and room for four, and Thiébaut and Jeanne took shelter there with one brazier and the guards posted outside in pairs, rotated every half hour.

It was warm in the hut, after the cold; the heat was extraordinary and close, smelling of smoke and resin and the drying wool of their clothes. They sat across the fire from each other with their boots off and their frozen feet toward the embers, and for a while there was only the storm's noise and the fire's, and the long, trembling relief of two people who had expected to lose each other and had not.

"I read your dispatches every night," she said. "The ones that reached us. The gaps were the worst part. There was a day with no word at all, the day of the road fight, and I spent it doing the accounts, and I remember thinking that if I stopped doing the accounts I would start something I couldn't stop."

"The road fight was close." He looked at the fire. "Jean took a pike that was meant for me. In the press, I didn't see it coming. He did. He's been doing that since I was twelve. I don't know how to be a man whose brother keeps his accounts in blood."

"Then keep yours in something else. The book of names. The pensions. The things you can pay, while you can't pay him back." She was quiet a moment. "Thiébaut. Why were you twenty years old in my father's court with no one in the world but a hostage's oath? I know the treaty story. I mean the true one."

It came out of the snow and the warmth and the day's nearness, and he understood that she was asking, at last, about the country behind the wall; not the whole of it, perhaps, but the road into it. The fire popped. Outside, the guards stamped their feet.

He nearly told her.

He had the words ready; he had carried them for seven years, polished and re-polished in the dark nights of Lorraine, the full account: the dawn in the solar, the chancellor's face, the old duke's terms, the threats against the maid and the convent, the written renunciation and the public performance, the price of speech set at other people's ruin. He could have said it all in this smoky hut, with the storm to keep the world away, and watched her seven years of belief about him fall into the fire and change.

And Foulques's face rose in his mind instead, the clerk who had been the instrument, who had grown old in the same court as the woman he served, carrying his own case of documents and

his own guilt; and the rule he had made himself in the years of silence, that he would not unload the truth at a time and place of his choosing, when the telling might break the chancellor before she had the whole of it, might turn the court against an old man who had, in the end, kept the evidence. And beyond even that, the deeper thing: he would not take the story as a gift from the storm. A confession made in the relief after battle, in a warm hut, when she was shaken and he was wounded, was a confession smuggled past her judgment. She deserved to receive it standing, in her own capital, with every paper in front of her, and decide what to do with both of them.

So he said, instead, "The true one is that my father died with the duchy mortgaged and my regents selling the furniture, and your father's court was the only school in Europe that would take me on credit. I learned everything there. Latin, gunnery, how a court eats a man who trusts it. And one lesson I never learned how to unlearn." He held her eyes across the fire. "Jeanne. I am going to tell you the whole of the old story, properly, with the papers and the names and the witnesses, and soon. Not in fragments, not in a storm, not because we might have died today. You will have it whole or not at all. Will you give me until the spring?"

She searched his face, the firelight moving on it, and he let her look. "You're asking me to keep carrying the question."

"I'm asking you to trust that I'm not dodging it. You've taught me the value of a document over a rumor. This is the one case where I agree with your own methods."

That surprised a small, unwilling laugh out of her. "Very well. Until the spring. But Thiébaut — when the spring comes, I want every key. I have a green case of my own to open, and I think they're the same lock."

The cold went through him then, a different cold from the forest's. "What do you know of a green case?"

"I know my chancellor keeps one he won't show me, and that it concerns a girl who did nothing, and that he drinks alone at night because of it. I've had him watched since Christmas." Her face was steady. "Whatever it is, we open it together. That's my condition."

"Together. Agreed." He reached across the space between them, and after a moment she put her hand in his, and they sat like that while the storm spent itself on the hut, the fire making its small domestic sounds, two people bound by paper and war and the promise of a truth that would either weld them or cut them free.

* * *

In the morning, while Thiébaut made the rounds of the camp's frozen sentries, Jeanne sat with Jean in the wounded tent, where the Bastard lay propped on furs with the willow bark at his elbow and a face the color of old parchment.

"He didn't sleep," Jean said, without opening his eyes. "He sat by the fire and watched you breathe, the way a man watches a fuse. You have no idea what you are to him, and that's probably for the best, because if you did you'd be impossible."

"You're feverish."

"I'm lucid, which is worse for you. Madame, I'll tell you a thing I've never told him I noticed. In the year after he came home from your father's court, he didn't play at cards, didn't hunt for pleasure, didn't look at a woman. He worked. He rebuilt the garrisons like a man building walls around something. We thought it was the duchy. It wasn't only the duchy." The Bastard opened his eyes, bright with fever and certainty. "Whatever happened in that house, he has never once in my hearing said a word against you. Not when it would have been easy, not when his own lords called the marriage a folly. Whatever he's carrying, it isn't blame of you."

Jeanne said nothing for a while. The tent's brazier ticked in the cold. "He's promised me the whole truth by spring."

"Then he'll give it. He's the only man I know who treats a promise the way other men treat a wall: load-bearing." Jean winced, settling against the furs. "Now. Since I've been shot and am permitted speeches. Take care of him out there. He thinks he's made of the same stuff as the fortresses, and he isn't. The shoulder's worse than he lets on, and he hasn't slept a full night since Sarrebourg the first time. A man who doesn't sleep eventually makes decisions for a tired brain and calls them courage."

"I'll take care of him on the condition that you take care of yourself. I have no intention of explaining a dead Bastard to your mistress, whichever one the letter would have gone to."

That earned a genuine, gasping laugh and a wince. "Cruel. Ducal and cruel. I begin to see why he watches the fuse."

She left him with the bark refreshed and the tent flap secured, and found Thiébaut at the horse lines, stamping circulation into his booted feet, and when he turned at the sound of her steps she looked at him with Jean's words still in her ears, the man building walls around something, and said nothing of them, only gave him the hot cup she had

brought, and their gloved fingers touched, and the camp went on with its morning around them.

* * *

By the third day the storm had passed and the valley was a white dazzle under a hard blue sky, and the work of the relief could be done properly. The French stores fed the garrison through the rest of the winter; the captured guns were sledged back to Sarrebourg's walls; the gascon prisoners, paid for out of the Vauréal treasury, went east under guard to the prisoner cages at Nancy. Thiébaut wrote the dispatches himself, naming the Vauréal gunners first and his own lances after, and saw to it that the story rode every road before the army did.

Jean's fever broke on the fifth night, sweating and swearing and demanding solid food, and the surgeon said he would live and probably argue, and the camp breathed again. They carried him south on a sledge lined with furs, and he complained about every mile of it, which the men took as the finest possible omen.

The march back was slower and lighter, the forest no longer an enemy but a road they had proved. At the edge of Vauréal, where the watchtower stood with its beacon lit at last as he had ordered on his wedding journey, Thiébaut

reined in and looked back once at the white wall of the Harchies.

"A month ago the French thought the winter belonged to them," he said.

Jeanne, beside him, looked ahead to the southern fields and the faint smoke of the first villages. "Nothing belongs to anyone in February. That's the lesson of the snow. It all comes back in the spring." She touched heels to the mare. "And in the spring, my lord, we open the green case."

He followed her down the road toward the light, with six hundred men and four famous guns and a wounded, grumbling brother behind them, and the long war ahead, and the promise of the truth waiting like a second spring under all the frozen ground.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Hunting Lodge

The spring of 1485 came in like a relief column. The ice went out of the Ortelle with a sound like distant guns, the roads dried from mud into ruts and then into dust, the rooks returned to the Haut-Tertre elms, and the war, which had spent the winter indoors among the ledgers, put its armor back on.

The news in the first warm weeks was mostly good, which made the court nervous. The Harchies relief had done the work Jeanne had designed it for: the story of the Vauréal guns coming through the snow to save a Lorraine fort was told in every market from Sainterre to Nancy, and recruits were coming into the musters faster than the treasury could equip them. Graçay's army had gone into quarters around the forfeit fiefs without a single new conquest to show for the season's expense, and the Regent's letters to her own war secretary, bought at considerable price through Dolfin's friends in Paris, had taken on the thin tone of a woman questioning her invoices. At the Heurtois conference the duchess's envoys were being endlessly reasonable, and the French negotiators were being endlessly polite, and every week of it cost Paris money and cost Vauréal only patience.

"We have one season of true advantage," Thiébaut told the war council, with the maps spread and the windows open onto the April rain. "Graçay needs a victory. His treasury needs a victory more. When the roads harden he'll move, and he'll move at the thing that will make the loudest story, which means Mont d'Or. We spend the spring making Mont d'Or expensive and keeping the field army whole."

"Valvert has nine hundred men now," Brive said. "The new battery's mounted. He says he can hold against six weeks' open trenches."

"Then six weeks is what we'll make sure Graçay doesn't get." Thiébaut's finger traced the river roads. "The army camps within four days' march, not four hours. Close enough to relieve, far enough not to be pinned. The war is a clock; we remain the slower clock."

Jeanne let the military talk run and attended to her own side of it, the side that would decide whether any of it could be paid for: the subsidy receipts coming in better than the winter's forecasts, the Sainterre customs rising with the reopened trade, the new weekly news sheet carrying the winter's victories into every guildhall, and the quiet, unglamorous work of keeping the vassals uncertain enough to be loyal.

It was in the middle of this spring accounting that Oriabel produced the hunting lodge.

"The lodge at Vertbois," she said, over the ledgers, as though it were a tax receipt. "It's been repaired, against the day the court wanted it. The roof is new, the glass is new, the keeper has been stocking the river with trout. My cousin, you have not spent one day outside the sound of bells since your father died. Neither, for that matter, has your husband. The court can survive a single day without either of you. The household will, in fact, be delighted, because nervous rulers make nervous servants."

"The dispatches—"

"Will be held at the gate until morning. I have spoken to Foulques. One day. Hawks, horses, a supper without a clerk at the table. If the French besiege Paris between dawn and dusk, I will personally bring you the letter."

Jeanne looked at Thiébaut, who had come in at the end of this. "Can the field army spare you for a day?"

"The field army has survived worse than a day without my conversation." His face was perfectly grave. "Also I have not seen you properly upright on a horse since the snow, and I am told the hawking is excellent."

So it was arranged, in the teeth of the protocol officers, that the duke and duchess would ride to

Vertbois with four companions, two grooms, and the hawks, and no clerks at all.

* * *

The morning they left was the first truly warm morning of the year, the kind that turns the woods green overnight and makes the horses dance with their own foolishness. They rode west through the forest roads under a canopy of new leaves, the party small and quick, Jean still favoring his healed shoulder but refusing to be left behind, Claire and Oriabel ahead with the falconer, and Jeanne found, with something like surprise, that the weight between her shoulders was actually lifting, the way a pack does when the road finally runs downhill.

Vertbois sat in a clearing above a bend of a small river, an old stone lodge her grandfather had built, with a steep roof and a terrace and the new glass glittering in its narrow windows. The keeper's family had it open and aired, with woodsmoke and the smell of bread, and the hawks were given their block and the horses their oats, and for the first time in a year Jeanne stood in a room that contained no maps.

They hawked the river meadow after the midday bread. The falconer flew the peregrine at duck, and the bird climbed into the blue like a thrown soul and stooped out of the sun, and the whole party shouted at the strike in the unguarded

way of people released from court, and Jeanne laughed aloud, a real laugh, and heard it with the mild shock of a person meeting a younger version of herself.

"You're good at this," Thiébaut said, cantering alongside as she reined in.

"I was raised for this. All the useless accomplishments. Latin, accounts, and the management of birds of prey. My father said a ruler who understands a hawk understands a vassal: keep it hooded, fly it often, reward it exactly."

"A cheerful doctrine."

"It was a cheerful childhood, in the manner of fortified places."

They left the others at the river and took the woodland path slowly, two horses side by side in the dappled light, and for a while neither of them spoke, and the silence was the new kind, the kind that had to be built and had been. It was he who broke it first.

"Vertbois. I remember it. Your grandfather's great hunt, the year I was fourteen. You got lost in this wood and were found asleep under a fallen oak, entirely unconcerned, and your father had the whole forest beaten for two hours and then beat the gamekeeper instead."

"He beat the gamekeeper because he couldn't beat me without scandal. I remember the oak. I remember you were the one who found me, actually. You followed the dog."

"The dog followed the bread trail you'd been leaving. You'd stolen a whole loaf from the breakfast table. Even lost, you were provisioning."

She laughed again, and he looked at her with an expression she was learning to recognize, the expression of a man watching something he had thought dead show signs of life.

They found the fallen oak, or one like it, and dismounted in a glade where the bluebells were coming up, and sat with their backs against the bark, and the horses cropped the new grass, and the wood went on with its own business around them.

"I want to ask you something," she said, "and you may tell me it's none of my affair."

"Ask."

"Did you ever want it? Lorraine, I mean. As a boy. Before the treaties and the wardship. Did you want to be the duke, or did it happen to you the way it happened to me?"

He considered it, turning a piece of bark in his fingers. "It happened to me. I wanted to be the master of the horse, I think. Someone whose whole

office was horses. I was seven. Then my father died and the regents stole everything that wasn't nailed down, and by the time I came home from your father's court the wanting had been replaced. There's a point where a duchy stops being an inheritance and becomes a patient. You don't ask whether you want it. You ask whether it will live through the night."

"That's exactly it." She plucked a bluebell and turned it in her fingers. "I wanted to be a clerk. A woman clerk, which the Church wouldn't have, so really I wanted to be left alone with books. Now I keep a country instead. Sometimes I think the people who want power are the last who should have it, and the people who don't are the ones who can't escape it."

"Your father wanted it. Every room, every hour. And it ate him."

"It ate my mother first. She died buying him the spare heir, and he loved her, I think, in his fashion, and went to war six weeks later because grief was the one account he didn't know how to keep." The bluebell went round and round. "I've been afraid, since the wedding, that I would turn into him. That the ledgers would eat everything and there'd be nothing left but the high chair."

"You won't."

"How can you be certain?"

"Because you keep the book of the dead." He said it simply, without rhetoric. "He kept a book of victories. You keep a book of names. That's the whole difference, and it's a difference of soul, not policy. A ruler who counts the cost in people will never be the ruler who counts only the cost in ground."

The wood was very quiet. Somewhere a woodpecker worked at a trunk, methodical and calm. She did not look at him, because if she looked at him she would do something unduchesslike in a spring wood, and instead she said, to the bluebell, "When we open the green case, Thiébaut, whatever is in it — I need you to know I've already decided one thing. The marriage is not on trial. The alliance is not on trial. Whatever your seven years were, they don't get to undo the year we've had. I don't know what I'll feel. I know what I'll do."

He was quiet long enough that she turned at last, and his face was the face of a man who has been handed a reprieve he had stopped praying for. "I would have built my whole life," he said, slowly, "around deserving that sentence. You've just given it to me before I've earned it."

"Then earn it after. We have a war."

* * *

They stayed the night, because the day had been given to them and it seemed foolish to spend it on the road, and the keeper's family moved into the forester's cottage and left the lodge to the court. The others took the lower rooms; Jeanne and Thiébaut had the upper chamber under the steep new roof, with the river sound below the windows and no dispatch box anywhere in the room, an absence so strange that she stood looking at the empty table for a moment.

The supper was trout from the river and early asparagus and a cold fowl, eaten without ceremony at the kitchen table, and Jean told his worst forest stories and Claire sang an old Lorraine ballad in a clear small voice, and for a few hours the war existed only as a thing outside the lamplight. Afterwards, on the terrace, the others drifting in one by one, they were left alone with the stars coming out over the black mass of the woods, and the first nightingale.

"No one can see us," she said. "No one is watching for the story."

"I'm always watching for the story. It's a professional deformity." He was leaning on the stone beside her, close enough that their sleeves touched. "But I'll try to be merely a man, if you'll try to be merely a woman. For one evening."

"Merely." She said the word with distaste, and smiled. "It's the hardest thing we've attempted."

He turned to her then, and took her hand the way he had taken it in the smoky hut, and she let him, and after a while he said, "Jeanne. I would like to kiss you without an audience of four hundred people. May I?"

It was the asking, again; the asking that undid her more reliably than any force. She put her other hand to his face, the weathered cheek and the small scar at the jaw, and said, "You may. You may also stop asking permission for things I have never once refused you," and he laughed, low, and kissed her under the new leaves with the nightingale going and the river doing the talking below.

The chamber upstairs had none of the great bed's state, only a wide wooden bed with clean linen and a window open to the spring night, and what happened there had nothing of the wedding night's careful instruction and nothing of the battle night's desperation. It was slow, and easy in the way of people who had learned each other's weather, the shoulder protected without being mentioned, the cold hands warmed, the laughter once at a knot in the lacing and once at nothing at all. Afterwards she lay with her head on his good arm and listened to the river, and he said into the dark, "If the duchy fell tomorrow, I could live in this lodge."

"No, you couldn't. You'd be rebuilding the forester's cottage within a week and issuing him regulations."

"That's true. I'm afraid of being happy, it turns out. I keep expecting an invoice."

"Expect it in the morning. The invoices always come in the morning." She pressed closer. "Tonight we're bankrupt and content."

They slept, astonishingly, until full daylight, and woke to the keeper's wife knocking with hot water and the news that no dispatch had arrived, which was the best news of the year.

* * *

The morning of the return had the particular sweetness of all last mornings. Mist lay over the river and the woods were full of birdsong, and they ate their bread and cheese on the terrace with the hawks hooded on their blocks and the horses saddled below, and nobody mentioned the word *dispatch*.

Jean, pale and thin from the wound but armed with opinions, had spent the previous evening losing at cards to Claire and spent breakfast re-litigating every hand. "The queen of spades was the issue. A woman with that expression does not appear in a hand by accident."

"She appears," Claire said, buttering bread, "to men who waste their trumps. Your brother plays correctly and says nothing, which is why he wins and you don't."

"Because he has no conversation. I have conversation."

"You have monologues. Conversation requires a second person."

Oriabel caught Jeanne's eye across the table, and the two women smiled the private smile of people watching a court arrange itself into something resembling a family, and Jeanne thought: this is what the treaties never buy. This is what a year has bought, if anything has. The easy table, the wounded brother, the widow who was once the mistress and is now the friend, the cousin who runs the baggage like a duchy. She had inherited a state and a siege; she seemed, without quite noticing, to have also inherited a household.

Thiébaut walked the terrace with her after the meal, along the stone above the river, where no one could overhear. "A year ago this week, the gate bell woke you."

"You remember the date."

"I remember everything about that week. The rain, the number of your escort, the grey mare, the curtain that fell a heartbeat too late." He leaned on the parapet. "Jeanne. If the green case holds what

I think it holds, and if after it you find you cannot bear the sight of me, I want the treaty to hold anyway. The duchy comes first. I'll sign whatever distance you require. I needed to say it before the spring, so you know it's policy and not panic."

She looked at him for a long moment, at the grey at his temple and the lines around the eyes that had not been there at twenty. "What if I find I can bear it? What then?"

"Then I will have been wrong about being unworthy, and I will need new plans. I have none ready."

"Make some." She turned toward the horses, where the grooms were waiting. "On the road. You have a year of my accounts to catch up on, and I expect a thorough job."

* * *

The invoices, as promised, came home with them.

Dolfin requested an audience within twenty-four hours, and this time he came without a clerk, carrying the news in his head rather than a chest. The spring campaigns of every court in Europe were being financed in the same handful of counting houses, and the Venetian's information was therefore better than the spies'.

"Graçay's spring pay is short by a third," he said, settling into the treasury office. "His Swiss contingent has been sent home unpaid, which is a story the cantons will remember. The Regent's new loan in Paris is being subscribed slowly, because the merchants have noticed her war has no victories. My house, by contrast, is prepared to renew your full credit against the Sainterre customs, now that the customs have performed for two quarters. I mention this not as generosity but as evidence: Venice believes you are going to win. It is the only kind of belief I deal in."

"The rate?"

"Eleven. Down from twelve. The collateral is better and the borrower is punctual; punctuality is the most expensive virtue, which is to say the best rewarded." He permitted himself a thin smile. "I would also, madame, advise the timing of your next negotiation with Paris. A borrower whose credit is falling while yours rises should be met at the moment she has just paid an army to do nothing. The Heurtois talks will smell different by midsummer."

"You make policy sound like the Rialto."

"All policy is the Rialto with better clothes."

The same post brought a letter from Coppens, and she opened it after the banker had gone, because the old guildsman wrote as he spoke, at

length and without flattery. The charter was holding. The elected aldermen had survived their first winter and were now arguing among themselves with the ferocity of free men, which he considered the highest possible compliment. The militia drilled every Sunday after church under officers holding the duchess's commission, and the two-key powder store had become a kind of civic temple, shown to visiting merchants. The weekly printed sheet, Verhoeven's news, was being copied as far as Bruges and Cologne, and Sainterre cloth was carrying the duchess's badge to markets that had never heard of the Roches-Noires. He ended with the bill for the city's spring war contribution, paid in full and early, and a single line: *The weavers who used to shout de Key's name now shout at the aldermen about drains. I count this a victory.*

"Read that," she said to Thiébaut, passing it across the table.

He read, and the not-smile crossed his face. "You built a country in a year. One city at a time, one charter at a time. Paris still thinks countries are built with marriages."

"Marriages helped."

"Marriages were the down payment. The rest is drains."

She wrote Coppens a reply in her own hand that evening, no clerks, confirming the toll review the city had asked for and adding a postscript about the drains, which she said sounded to her like the proper music of a well-governed city. It was the kind of letter no sovereign wrote who had not begun, somewhere in the winter, to think of the towns as partners rather than property, and she sealed it without quite recognizing the change in herself.

The second invoice arrived from the east, in the form of Othon d'Erquelines himself, who had not previously deigned to visit the court in person. He came with a large train and a letter from the Emperor's chancellery, and he was received with the full ceremony due to a man whose family had held the marches for two hundred years, and in the round chamber he proceeded to demonstrate why two hundred years of ancestry did not buy two hundred minutes of sense.

The Emperor, he said, viewed with growing alarm the Vauréal alignment with a Lorraine house that had, in the imperial view, become too clever by half. An alternative remained: an imperial alliance in earnest, with an archducal marriage (the cousin again, now with a name and a small estate), imperial garrisons at the eastern forts, and the immediate withdrawal of the French forfeit claims under the Emperor's guarantee. In

exchange, Erquelines himself would be named the duchess's lieutenant in the eastern marches.

"Let me be certain I understand." Jeanne kept her voice pleasant. "The Emperor, who has sent no troops and no money and whose promises I could paper a privy with, now offers me garrisons I don't want and a suitor I've refused, and asks in exchange for the eastern marches under your lieutenancy. Have I missed a clause?"

"The guarantee, madame—"

"The guarantee of a man who cannot keep his own Swiss paid. Count Othon. I will answer in writing, as is proper. But I will give you the shape of it now. The marches are held by officers who hold my commission, and the eastern forts are commanded by my garrisons, and neither will change. You may keep your Emperor's friendship, which I value, and your own homage, which I require. The door is open on the way out."

When he had gone, purple and stammering, Thiébaut, who had sat silent through the audience, said, "He'll go to Paris now."

"No. He'll go home and wait to see who wins. That's his genius; he never commits until the invoices are settled. But he'll make us pay for the marches when we need them. Note it." Foulques noted it. "What else is in the post? I've had a day in

the country and I intend to catch up on every disaster in Christendom."

The third dispatch came at dusk, and it was the disaster that mattered.

It was from Mont d'Or, but not from Valvert. The writing belonged to the garrison's second-in-command, a young officer named Sancerre, and it was short because it had been written in hiding and smuggled out inside a cooper's barrel: Hautperthuis had visited the fortress two days before, on a courtesy inspection with a train of sixty men, and at the changing of the watch his people had seized the south gate. Valvert was dead, killed in the first minute at the gatehouse, and the French vanguard was already marching through the pass under Gui's banner. The fortress had fallen without a siege, to a smile, a handshake, and sixty cutthroats. The rock that was to have cost Graçay six weeks had been given to him in a night.

Jeanne read it aloud to the council in the silence that followed, set the paper down, and looked at the map she knew by heart, at the black mark of Mont d'Or on the kingdom road.

"The clock just changed," Thiébaut said quietly.

"Yes." She folded her hands to keep them steady. "Then we change with it. Marshal Brive, the host. Full muster, three days. Foulques, the

attainder papers, every lease and treason in the chancellery, drawn by the week's end. Dolfin gets a message tonight; tell him the iron tithe may be needed sooner than we thought. And send to Sainterre. The war we planned in the spring is over. The war for Sainterre begins."

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Treason's Market

The army moved within the week, because the one thing the fall of Mont d'Or could not be allowed to become was a story with a long first chapter. Jeanne had the host on the southern roads by the fifth day, the Lorraine lances and the Vauréal squadrons and the new Sainterre militia companies riding together under the joined arms, and the news sheet came out in the same week with the facts stated plainly and no panic at all, which was the first battle of the new war and was won at the printing press.

But an army could not un-take a fortress in a week, and the council knew it. They camped at the river junction below the lost rock, within sight of the French banner on its walls, and the war council in the command pavilion did the arithmetic that no ballad would record: a full siege train could not come up before midsummer, Graçay's field army was somewhere beyond the hills, and an assault on Mont d'Or now would be the Roches-Noires again, brave men dying on prepared ground at the enemy's chosen hour.

"We don't besiege the rock yet." Thiébaut put his finger on the map. "We besiege the road to it. Mont d'Or is only useful to Graçay if he can feed it

and move through it. We put light horse across every supply route, we take the convoys, we make the garrison eat its stores, and we wait for the city war he's actually preparing. His objective was never a fortress. His objective is Sainterre. Mont d'Or is the door he opened; the room is the cloth cities."

"Then why did he pay Gui to open it?" Brive demanded.

"Because doors are cheap and sieges are expensive. Hautperthuis sold him a year's campaigning for the price of sixty cutthroats." Thiébaut's face was without heat. "The question is what we do about the seller."

That was the true business of the night, and it kept the council late.

Lisette's network, built patiently over a year of kitchen conversations and courier-watching and silver changing hands in tavern yards, had produced its map. The maid unrolled it on the table herself, a plain thing of ink and butcher's paper, and the lords of the council looked at it with the respect it had earned. There were the ex-French sergeants planted as tenants on the Hautperthuis manors, twenty-three households now, each marked with a name. There was the factor at Pont-d'Ortelle, the priest's clothes, the fair-day meetings. There were the lesser lords who had ridden to Gui's hunting lodge in the winter, seven

names, and the merchants who held French coin on his account, four. There, at the center, in the careful script of a woman who had learned her letters from the duchess's own clerk, was the word *Hautperthuis*, with lines reaching outward like a spider's web.

"This is the fifth column." Jeanne looked around the table. "It has always existed; it is simply visible now. We will do two things. First, every name on this map gets a watch, and none of them gets a warning. Second, the tenants. The soldiers planted on the marches are not the lords. They're paid men with families and leases. I want the leases examined by the chancellery, not the provosts, and the ones that can be broken by law broken by law, with the families given time and the tenants offered places in the new works at Grisay. We do not create twenty-three widows for the French to recruit."

"Madame." Brive's voice was heavy. "In my grandfather's time this would have been a week of fire. Ride the manors, burn the roofs, leave the lesson. The army expects it. The army wants it."

"The army is commanded, it does not dictate." She kept her voice level. "Marshal, I understand the pleasure of the thing. Fire is easy and it feels like justice. But every cottage we burn without a trial is a cottage whose sons join Marcenay's company. Every tenant we make homeless

becomes the enemy's best recruiter. The law is slower. The law also keeps. We attainder the lord, we prove the leases, and we protect the people, and in five years the marches are ours in fact rather than in smoke."

Thiébaut said nothing until she had finished, then: "She's right. I've fought both ways. The fire wins the month. The law wins the country."

Brive argued for another hour, and lost, and took the loss like the soldier he was, and the council moved to the attainder, which was the true instrument and the one the lord had never believed would be used against a man of his blood.

Foulques laid the precedents out himself, and Jeanne saw the chancellor's craft in all its cold beauty for the first time. A simple treason charge could drag for years through the privileges of a great lord: the right to be tried by his peers, the delays of Parlement, the appeals to the crown that would treat the whole question as a family quarrel among princes. An attainder was different. It was an act of the ruler in council declaring the bloodline corrupted, the lands forfeit, the name extinguished, and it moved at the speed of the state rather than the speed of the law.

"Use it wrongly," Foulques said, "and every lord in the dominion reads his own name into the document. Use it with a mountain of proof, and

every lord reads instead the price of his own bad faith."

"Then build the mountain." Jeanne turned the drafts. "I want every lease, every witness, the fair-day meetings with dates, the planted tenants with their old regiments named. We do not attaint him for taking the wrong side in a war. We attaint him for the steward's office he ran under a false name while he ate my bread. The charge is corruption of the marches, and the proof is paperwork, because paperwork is the one thing a great lord cannot answer with a smile."

The letter from Hautperthuis arrived two days later, as though he had smelled the drafting ink. It was a masterpiece of its kind: grief at the "misunderstanding" of Mont d'Or, assurances that he had been visiting the fortress on the duchess's own business when "certain hotheads" acted without his knowledge, a reminder of their shared grandmother's blood, and a proposal that he and the duchess meet privately at the Heurtois border to settle all differences as became a family. There was no mention of Valvert's body, the French vanguard, or the banner over the rock.

She read it aloud to the council, and then answered it herself, in the clerk's hand of her state letters, and the answer was short. She thanked him for his concern. She noted that the hotheads included sixty of his own household men in his own

livery, and that the French vanguard had crossed on a bridge his tenants guarded. She regretted that a private meeting was impossible while he held her fortress against her peace, and she summoned him, in the proper feudal form, to present himself at the war camp within thirty days to answer the council's questions, failing which the attainder would proceed in his absence.

"Give him the whole thirty days," she said, sealing it. "He'll spend them writing to Paris. By the time he understands the summons isn't a negotiation, the mountain is built."

"His blood claim will move the other lords," Thiébaut observed.

"Let it move them. I want the waverers to watch a man of the blood answer a clerk's questions with clerks' evidence. The lesson isn't for Gui. The lesson is for every Erquelines in the country."

* * *

The news from the western marches reached the camp on the third day, carried by a Dominican friar who had walked forty miles with the story and the survivors' names. He came to the duchess's pavilion in the rain, and he was shown in at once, and he told it standing, because he said he could not sit while the words were in him.

Marcenay's free company, four hundred men in the pay of Paris and the loose discipline of no one,

had crossed the border ahead of the main army and taken the town of Sainte-Florence, an undefended weaving town with a charter and a militia of eighty, which had opened its gates on the promise of the soldier's word. The word had lasted until the gates closed. What followed was not war by any definition the friar could find in his books. The town was systematically looted over two days. The guild chests were seized, the church plate melted, the merchants' houses stripped to their timbers. The militia who surrendered were hanged from their own gatehouse, thirty-one men, in their charter uniforms. A group of townswomen who had taken refuge in the church were held there through the night by the company's sergeants; the friar gave the number, which was forty-two, and the number who had not survived the night, which was three, one of them a girl of twelve. The town's four hundred looms, the reason it existed, were smashed with hammers so that it would not make cloth for the duchess's war.

He had the names in a small book, written in his own hand, and he put it on the table, and the rain ran off his habit onto the pavilion floor.

No one spoke for a while. Jeanne opened the book and read the first page and made herself read all of it, because someone had to, and the someone might as well be the person whose war this was in name. When she looked up, the men in the pavilion had the various faces of grief: Brive's white fury,

Foulques's open distress, the guards at the flap with their jaws set. Thiébaut's face was the worst, because it was not angry. It was cold, the cold of a man making a professional inventory of what he intended to do.

"Where is Marcenay now?"

"At Sainte-Florence still, madame. They remain because there is still food. The countryside for ten miles is empty; the people are in the woods."

"Then he's closer than his judgment, and his judgment was never good." Thiébaut turned to Brive. "Four hundred free company, drunk, in a town whose walls they've partly pulled down for their fires. A fast column of lances and mounted archers can be there in two days. I'll lead it myself."

"No." Jeanne closed the friar's book. "You won't. Not because you shouldn't, but because the next move is Graçay's and the field army's commander can't be two days away on a raid. Brive takes the column. Jean goes with him, since he's been asking for a reason since the pike. Orders: Marcenay's men are to be treated as soldiers under no lawful colors. No quarter for the sergeants who held the church; the rest may yield into bonds. The town's surviving people are to be fed and sheltered from the army's own stores, and the friar goes with the column to name the men he can name. And Brive."

The old marshal turned.

"No burning. No sack in answer to a sack. I know what the men will want. Tell them the duchess pays double bounty for every prisoner brought in and nothing for a roof put to the torch. Make the discipline pay better than the cruelty. That's the only sermon soldiers will believe."

* * *

The column's first dispatch came back in four days, Brive's hand, terse and soldierly. They had covered the ground in half the expected time, found Marcenay's scouts blind and drunk, and taken the town's outer barricades at dawn with one charge. The free company broke at the first real contact, the kind of force that excelled at churches and dissolved before lances. Marcenay himself had escaped with perhaps eighty men through the east gate, riding hard for the French lines, and Brive had not pursued past the river, per his orders. The sergeants named by the friar had not been so fortunate; six were taken in the cellars, and the survivors of Sainte-Florence had identified them in the square, and the provosts had hanged them from the same gatehouse as the militiamen, in the same number, which was the kind of arithmetic the towns understood.

Jeanne read the rest of the dispatch alone in her pavilion, because the rest was not for the council.

The survivors' accounts, taken by the friar and the women of the town: who had been held where, and by whom, and which of the dead had names. Bride's note at the bottom, in a hand less steady than the military parts, said that the army's discipline had held under provocation he would not commit to paper, and that the double bounty had been paid in full, and that he had served thirty years under three dukes and had never been prouder of an order he had argued against.

She sat a while with the papers. Then she called her clerk and dictated the relief: timber and masons from the Grisay works for the town, a year's exemption from all dues, the rebuilding of the looms at the ducal charge, and a hospital of twenty beds endowed in perpetuity, its charter to name the twelve-year-old among its patrons. The money would hurt; Dolfin would raise an eyebrow and produce another lien. She wrote the order anyway, because some payments were the kind that showed up in no repayment table and in every tavern for a hundred miles.

Thiébaut came in as the clerk left, read the order over her shoulder, and said nothing for a moment. Then: "The army will hear of this by Sunday."

"The army is meant to. I want every soldier in this host to know the difference between his pay and Marcenay's. One serves a law. The other

serves an appetite. The law builds hospitals. The appetite burns towns. Men will fight longer for an idea than for a purse, though they require the purse as well."

"Your father never spent a penny on ideas."

"My father is in a vault. Draw your own conclusions."

* * *

The Dominican brought her one more witness before the column rode, because he said his office required the whole truth be given to the person who could do something with it. She was a woman of thirty, a weaver's widow from Sainte-Florence, one of the forty-two, and she came into the pavilion with her eyes on the ground and her hands knotted in her cloak, and Jeanne dismissed everyone but Lisette and sat her at the table and poured the wine herself.

The woman told it without tears, in the flat voice of someone who has used them all. The church, the dark, the sergeants, the girl of twelve who did not survive the night. She told it in the plain vocabulary of a weaving town, and Jeanne wrote the names herself, because the clerks would soften them, and when it was done the woman looked up at last and said the thing she had come to say.

"Madame, they tell us you will answer with fire. My neighbor says the duke's men will burn every French village in the marches and it will serve them right. I'm here to ask you not to. The villages didn't take my husband or my girl. Marcenay's men did. Burn the villages and you make more Marcenays, and my girl died for nothing at all but a story that gets repeated."

Jeanne was quiet a moment. "What is your name?"

"Marthe, madame. Marthe Dubois."

"Marthe, I have already given the column the order you're asking for. No burning, no sack in answer to a sack, double bounty for prisoners, nothing that teaches the countryside to hate my peace. I gave it for reasons of state. You've just given me the better reason." She folded the paper with the names. "Will you let me keep these? The state keeps a book of its dead. Your girl belongs in it."

"She belonged to me first." The woman's voice cracked once, and steadied. "But the book can have her after. Put her down as Agnès Dubois, twelve years old, a weaver's daughter. She wanted to be a nun. She had the voice for it."

"I'll write that too."

When she had gone, Jeanne sat a long time with the list, and then she added to the column's

written orders a line the soldiers would not understand for years: that every town taken from the French was to receive a copy of the proclamation of Sainte-Florence, so that the country might learn the difference between the two armies not from the priests but from the invoices.

She walked the camp alone after the council, with Lisette at a distance, and went among the hospital tents where the wounded from the skirmishes lay, and the new recruits were drilling in the mud, and the guns sat under their tarpaulins. The rain had settled into a steady drizzle, and the camp fires smoked, and the army did its evening work around her, the endless ordinary labor that made the atrocities possible to keep going at all.

She had believed, at twenty-two, that rule was a matter of ledgers and law, the things her father's clerics had taught her. She had believed the hardest question would be finding the correct answer. The year had taught her differently. The correct answer sat in the book on her table, in the friar's careful hand, in the twelve-year-old's name, and there was nothing in all her education that could make the thing itself bearable. Rule was not finding the answer. It was reading the names and then going on with the work.

Foulques found her at the gun lines, standing under the awning of the biggest bombard with her hand on the cold bronze, and he came to stand beside her without speaking for a while. The chancellor had aged in the winter; she saw it now, the stoop that had not been there, the tremor in the hand that had never trembled over a document.

"Madame," he said at last. "I must ask to speak with you. Privately. Soon. There is a thing I have carried too long, and I find I cannot carry it into whatever the summer will be."

She turned to look at him fully. "The green case."

It struck him like a blow. His face went grey, and then, with an effort she could see, he gathered himself. "You have known."

"I have known there was a locked room. I did not know its contents. I know now that whatever is in it concerns the duke and me, and a girl who did nothing, and that it has cost you your sleep and your wine. Foulques. I am not asking for it here, in the rain, in the middle of a war. But when this campaign allows, I will have the whole of it, and the duke will be present, and you will bring every paper. Do you understand?"

"I have been waiting for you to say that since the day you were fifteen." His voice was steady

now that the thing was named. "I will bring everything. I have kept it all, madame. Perhaps that is my one merit in the matter. I did not destroy the evidence of what we did."

"We. You said *we*."

"Because it was. A chancellor does not act alone, and a chancellor does not refuse his prince. But I held the pen. I will not pretend otherwise." He bowed, an old man's bow, and walked away into the rain toward his own tents, and she watched him go with the friar's book still under her arm and the cold bronze under her hand, and understood that the last locked door of her girlhood was about to open, and that she had no idea what she would do on the other side of it.

* * *

The ripples reached her before the week was out, which was the point of the thing. Othon d'Erquelines wrote in his own hand, a long, anxious document that said nothing and said it at length: his distress at the troubles of the house, his unshaken devotion to the duchess's person, his hope that no false friend would ever poison her mind against her true lords, and, buried in the fourth paragraph, a request to see the chancellery's evidence concerning "certain leases on the southern marches," since he himself held

similar arrangements and wished to be certain of his own standing.

"He's checking whether his name is in the net," Thiébaut said, reading it over her shoulder.

"He's checking whether the net exists. Answer him warmly. Send him the lease regulations as a public document, nothing private, and add a line about how consoling it is that the loyal lords are diligent in their own paperwork. Let him spend the summer being diligent."

The lesser lords needed no such hints. Three of the seven winter visitors to Gui's hunting lodge sent in their muster quotas early and without the usual complaints, and one, a nervous young baron named Villers, rode to the camp in person to make a full and tearful declaration: he had attended a hunt, yes, and heard talk, yes, but had known nothing of treachery, and here were his receipts and his conscience and his company of forty lances if the duchess would have them. She received him with kindness, kept the declaration in writing, and confirmed him in his lands, and the story of the weeping baron did more for the discipline of the marches than a hundred hangings.

"Power that forgives the small fish and grinds the big one," Foulques observed, making the note. "It is a fearsome combination, madame. The textbooks don't teach it."

"The textbooks were written by big fish."

* * *

The column rode at dawn, eight hundred lances and mounted archers under Brive and Jean, with the Dominican in his wet black habit riding beside the standard, and Jeanne watched them go from the camp's rise and then returned to the pavilion and the work that did not stop for dread: the supply lists, the watch rosters, the letters to the cities, the careful building of the army that would meet Graçay when he came for Sainterre.

That night, when the camp had banked its fires and the guards called the watch through the dark, she went to the field chapel alone, a small canvas tent with a single candle before the altar, and knelt on the bare ground a long time. She did not pray for victory; she had long since stopped asking God to do the work of her treasuries. She prayed for the steadiness to read whatever was coming, and for the forty-two women and the twelve-year-old and the thirty-one hanged militiamen and the boy Philippe and all the names in all the books, and she prayed, with less certainty, for the courage to know the truth about herself and the man she had married without flinching from either.

Then she rose, and snuffed the candle, and went back through the dark camp to the pavilion, where Thiébaut sat awake over the maps with a

cup of cold wine, and she did not tell him what Foulques had said, because the telling would be soon and whole or not at all, and she sat down beside him and put her hand over his on the map, and together they went on with the war.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

What the Chancellor Carried

They were back at the Haut-Tertre for the summer war council, the court returned to its stone walls and its bells, and Foulques collapsed in the middle of a sentence about grain contracts.

One moment he was standing at the round table with a dispatch in his hand, speaking in the dry clerk's voice they had all heard for twenty years, and the next the dispatch fluttered to the floor and he had gone down beside it, his knee striking the table leg, his face the grey of river clay. Brive reached him first, being a soldier and therefore used to men falling, and lifted him with the help of a guard, and the room became a confusion of shouted orders and running feet. Jeanne was on her knees beside him before she had decided to move, her hand at his wrist, finding the pulse there, thin and rapid and frightened.

"The physicians. Now." Her own voice surprised her, steady as a charter. "Clear the room. Marshal, the council adjourns; the contracts wait. Lisette, my own physician, and send to the cathedral for the bishop's man as well. I want two opinions before anyone bleeds him."

They carried the chancellor to his own chamber, the narrow, ordered room above the chancellery where he slept among his archives, and put him to bed, and the physicians came and bled him and examined him and used the grave, evasive language of their trade. The heart, they said. A seizure of the heart. He might live the week; he might live the year; he might be taken in the night. In the meantime, complete rest, no business, no agitation, no papers.

"No papers will kill him faster than any seizure," Jeanne said, but she said it outside the door.

He was awake by evening, weak and chalk-white, propped on pillows in the room that smelled of parchment and the dried herbs he strewed against fleas, and when she came in alone with the door closed and the guard outside, he looked at her with the eyes of a man who has been shown the exit and decided what to do with the interval.

"Madame. I was going to wait for the summer. You gave me until the spring, and the spring became the campaign, and I told myself there would be time. The heart has corrected my scheduling." His voice was thin but clear. "I will not die with the green case unopened. It is in the coffer at the foot of the bed. The key is on the

chain at my neck. I would ask you to take it yourself."

She did not move at once. Seven years of her life were in that coffer, the shape of every wound she had built herself around, and there was a part of her that wanted to walk out of the room and leave the case shut forever. Then she thought of the girl in the solar, who had deserved better than silence, and she rose and took the key from the chain, her fingers steady in a way her heart was not, and unlocked the coffer.

The green case lay on top. Beneath it were folded documents in several hands, tied with the same ribbon, and a small portrait in an old style, and she lifted the whole weight of it and brought it to the table beside his bed, and sat, and said, "Start at the beginning. I want every word, Foulques. Whatever it costs either of us."

* * *

He told it like a man making a final deposition, in order, with dates, the way he had been trained.

Her father, he said, had known nothing of the feeling between his daughter and his ward until the sewing woman came to him with her report, but once he knew, every decision had been made in the space of a single night. The duke's position was precise: a fifteen-year-old heiress compromised, even by rumor, in a court full of

envoys, could not marry the landless young Duke of Lorraine, whose duchy was bankrupt and whose wardship was the seal of a peace that was already failing. A love match with Thiébaut would give every vassal a pretext and France a weapon. The girl, moreover, had to be protected from the consequences of her own tongue, which had been heard saying she would give up the inheritance.

"The duke's first thought," Foulques said, "was to put the young lord on trial for the ravishment of the heir. I argued him from it. A trial would have made the story public and permanent, and the law would have required the worst. His second thought was convent walls for you and a writ of treason for him. I could not move him from the convent. I could move him on the method."

The method was the agreement in the green case. The young duke would sign a written renunciation of every claim, suit, and understanding with the heiress, and perform it before the full court in terms that made the attachment look like a boy's indulgence of a child's infatuation. He would leave Vauréal at once and never communicate with her again, on pain of the original charges being revived. In exchange: no trial, no convent, and the maid Lisette, who had carried the notes and stood to be flogged and branded and turned out without a character, would be spared. The document in the case was the renunciation in Thiébaut's own hand, and below it,

in her father's marginal writing, the list of the threatened penalties and the names of those who held their safety by the signing.

"He had no choice that did not cost someone else," Foulques said. "I want that understood before you read the words, madame. He did not choose the great hall. He chose it over your convent and your maid's face. He was twenty years old. He signed at dawn, and he wept while he signed, and I have seen only two men weep in my life, and I remember both."

The words in the great hall, then, had been written for her father's ear, not hers. Every cruelty she had carried for seven years had been the price of her own safety and Lisette's, paid in a coin she had never been allowed to see. The boy who had not looked at her had not looked because looking would have broken him, and the man who had ridden away without turning had done it because turning was forbidden on pain of her ruin.

Jeanne sat with the document on her knees and the room very quiet, and she did not weep, because she had trained herself too well for weeping, but something behind her ribs shifted like a stone in a wall, and she put one hand flat against her chest as though to hold the structure in place.

"The night in the solar." Her voice came out level, which astonished her. "Nothing happened. You know that."

"I knew it then. The guard knew it. Your father did not care, because the question was never what happened. The question was what could be made to have happened. I wrote that sentence down in my notes, madame, the day after: *the question is not the truth but the story.* I have spent seven years trying to decide whether it is the definition of statecraft or the definition of hell."

"Why didn't he tell me? Afterwards. Years afterwards. When I was of age."

"Because the agreement forbade him communication on pain of reviving the charges, and because the duke, your father, watched the ports and the couriers for years; I know, because the watching came through my office. And because, I believe, he could not be certain the threats were dead. The convent order was actually drawn up. I have kept it; it is in the case. It was never canceled. It was merely filed. A man who knew that would not write the letter, even years later, that might send the woman he loved into a strict observance and her maid to the branding iron."

Jeanne closed her eyes. Behind them she saw not the great hall but the solar, the lightning, the cloak over both of them, the face of a boy who had

meant every word. She had carried the wrong story for seven years, polished and complete and false, and the true story was worse and better at once, and she did not yet know what she was going to become on the other side of knowing it.

"Leave me with the papers," she said. "I will read them all. And Foulques — do not die. I forbid it. I have not decided your sentence, and I will not have you escaping it."

The ghost of his old smile crossed the grey face. "No, madame."

* * *

She took the green case to her own chamber and dismissed everyone but Lisette, and the maid, who had lived inside the edges of this story since she was a girl, sat by the window with her sewing and said nothing at all, which was the highest service in her possession.

The documents were careful and complete, the work of a chancellor who had spent seven years preparing to be judged. The renunciation in Thiébaut's hand, young and fierce, the signature driven into the parchment. Her father's marginal threats, in his own clerk's hand, the convent order with its blank date and its strict observance, the order concerning the maid with the words *flogging and branding* spelled out in the administrative language of a kitchen inventory. Foulques's own

contemporary notes, dated and ordered, including the line about truth and story. And at the bottom, the small portrait, painted in the Aubecourt years, of a fifteen-year-old girl and a twenty-year-old boy in the gallery, standing too close and too unaware of it, the artist having caught what the court had refused to see.

She read it all twice. Then she sat with the portrait in her lap for a long time, while the afternoon light moved across the floor and the palace went on with its indifferent business of bells and footsteps and the distant shouting of the drill yard.

The anger, when it came, was not the thing she had expected. She had imagined, if the truth ever proved him innocent, a great unlocking, tears and reconciliation and the easy closing of a wound. What arrived instead was a cold and complicated rage, and it was directed at three men in turn. Her father, who had built the machine. Foulques, who had oiled it. And Thiébaut, who had let her carry the false story for seven years and become the man he had become in the silence, without once giving her the chance to choose what to do with the truth. That last was unfair, and she knew it, and the knowledge did not make it smaller.

"Lisette." Her own voice sounded strange to her. "The branding. Did you know?"

"I knew they meant me harm if anyone talked. I didn't know the paper existed." The maid's sewing had stopped. "I always said he looked like a man on the wheel that morning, didn't I? I said it. You wouldn't hear it."

"I wouldn't."

"Because hearing it would have meant the story wasn't simple, and simple was all you had." Lisette came and sat on the stool beside her, the way she had when they were children. "Jeanne. What now?"

"Now I speak to him. And I do it tonight, because if I sleep on it I will construct a version that lets me avoid it, and I have spent seven years inside a constructed version. Send word. The solar, the old one, after vespers. He will remember it."

* * *

She walked the east wing before vespers, through the schoolroom and the long gallery, with the case under her arm and Lisette following at a respectful distance. The place had not changed; storage still, the cradle still in its corner, the broken falcon's perch. She stopped at the window where she had watched him ride away, the bend in the road by the willows where a boy had not turned back, and she saw the memory now with new eyes: not the coldness she had carried, but a guard's report waiting to be written, a convent order with a blank date, the discipline of a man

who had been told that a single glance would be used against the people he was trying to save.

"The wall," she said, going to the window that overlooked the lower garden. "He caught me here. And my father caned him for it, in front of the guard. I thought then that he was being punished for me. I understand now that he was being trained. The lesson was never about the wall. The lesson was that his body and his honor were the coin, and he had better learn to spend them."

Lisette said, "He learned it well, didn't he. The great hall was the same lesson, bigger."

"The whole marriage is the same lesson. He keeps giving away what he wants so that other people can be safe. The light clauses, the patents, the shoulder, you, me." She pressed her palm to the cold glass. "And I have spent a year reading every concession as strategy. Some of it was strategy. He would say it was mostly strategy. But some of it was a man who was never once permitted to choose himself."

"Can you forgive that, my lady? Not him. The knowing. Can you bear finding out you were wrong?"

Jeanne was quiet a while. A groom crossed the garden below, whistling, with two dogs at his heels, and the ordinary world went on being ordinary. "I don't know yet. I know I've been angry

at the wrong man for seven years, and anger is easier than this. This is a country without maps. But my father used to say that a ruler who cannot revise her map when the ground changes is a ruler who loses. The ground has changed. I will revise."

She turned away from the window. "Also, I am furious at being made to revise. I expect I will be for some time. He will have to tolerate it, since tolerating things appears to be his particular gift."

Lisette's mouth twitched. "Shall I tell him that when I take the message?"

"Tell him the solar, after vespers, and to bring his memory. He'll need all of it."

* * *

The old solar had been opened and cleaned, at her order, the week before, though she had not known why she gave the order. The tapestries were gone, but the chest beneath the window remained, and the view of the orchard, and the wall they had climbed. A fire had been lit, and two chairs placed before it, and she sat in one of them with the green case on her knee and waited, and at the appointed hour the door opened and Thiébaut came in alone, in plain clothes, with the face of a man who has known this summons was coming and has prepared for it like a soldier.

He saw the case. He stopped. Then he crossed to the fire and knelt, not to her, exactly, but before

both of them, the old gesture of the tourney field, and said, "Ask me anything. There are no locks left."

"Then start with the night. Tell it to me as though I had never been there."

He told it. The storm, the candles, the conversation, the kiss, the sleeping under one cloak, the door at dawn, Foulques's face, the guards. Then the day that followed, the part she had never seen: her father's chamber, the charges, the convent order, the order against Lisette, the choice presented to a twenty-year-old with no army and no friends. The renunciation written and signed at dawn, the tears Foulques had mentioned. The words in the great hall, chosen, he said, to be so cruel that she would not follow him or try to write, because a girl who followed a disgraced ward walked into the same trap. The ride to the border with the guard who had orders to report every glance backward. The seven years of watching the couriers and never sending.

"Why the clause about never communicating? Why accept that? You could have told me once. One letter."

"Because the convent order was never canceled. I saw it, Jeanne. I held it. Your father's hand, his seal, the blank date they had only to fill. If I wrote and the letter was taken, you went into strict observance and Lisette lost her face. I was

not prepared to buy my own peace at that price. And then," he stopped, and for the first time his control cracked, and she saw the cost of the seven years in the open, "then the years went by, and you were the Duchess of Vauréal, and I was the duke of a bankrupt rock, and there was never a moment when telling you did not risk the only thing I could still do for you, which was to stay out of your story. I thought if you ever needed the army, you would send for it. You did."

"For the army."

"For whatever you needed. I would have come for the army and I would have come for a clerk's post and I would have come to sweep your stables. The treaty was the only door your father's ghost had left open."

The room was very quiet. The fire made its small explosions. She looked at the man kneeling by her chair, the weathered face and the grey at the temple and the left arm he still favored, and behind him she saw the boy of twenty signing the parchment, and behind the boy the girl of fifteen whose whole understanding of love had been rebuilt into a fortress by a morning's work.

"I am not going to forgive you tonight," she said. "I want you to understand that. I may not get to forgiveness at all. You made a choice for me, Thiébaut. You and my father and Foulques, all the men who knew better, decided what I could bear

and what I could know, and I have spent seven years being the person that decision made. I do not know how to unbecome her in an evening."

"I am not asking for forgiveness." He had not risen. "I am asking for the chance to be known. Whatever you decide, the treaty holds, the army holds, the war holds. I made you a promise that the marriage was not on trial, and I will keep my promises, all of them, even the ones you didn't ask for."

"Get up. Kneeling doesn't suit you, and I refuse to have this conversation at two different heights." He rose, and she stood with him, and the firelight was between them. "I have also decided this: we do not become the kind of marriage that buries the past and calls it wisdom. You will tell me the rest, over time, every year of it, and I will tell you mine, including the years I spent hating you. And if I ever catch you choosing what I can bear for my own good again, I will make the attainder of Hautperthuis look like a kindness. Is that understood?"

"Perfectly." The ghost of the not-smile, careful and hopeful. "May I ask what happens tonight?"

"Tonight you sleep in your own chamber, because I cannot think with you on the other side of a wall. And tomorrow we go to war, because Graçay is moving on Sainterre and I will not have my domestic arrangements losing me a city. The

rest we will build, badly and slowly, in the intervals of the fighting. Go on."

He went to the door, and there he stopped with his hand on the latch. "Jeanne. One thing, from the night in the solar, since all the doors are open. I meant every word. The cottage, all of it. I still do."

Then he was gone, and she was alone with the fire and the green case and the strange, enormous work of revising her own life.

* * *

She did not sleep, and she did not want to. She worked through the night, which was the only medicine she trusted: the Sainterre dispatches, the supply contracts, the letters to the cities, the old machinery of rule. At dawn Foulques's physician came with the bulletin that his master had passed a quiet night and was asking, against all orders, for the duchess.

She found him propped on his pillows, thinner than ever, the case gone from its coffer and a look on his face that she recognized after a moment as peace, the peace of a man who has been caught and sentenced and found both preferable to the waiting.

"Your resignation of the seal," she said, sitting beside him, "is refused. I have it here." She produced the document he had sent at midnight and tore it once, twice, and put the pieces in his

hand. "You will not die, and you will not escape. A man who can carry a secret for seven years can carry his penance for the rest of his life, which I intend to be long and extremely busy."

"Madame—"

"Be quiet. Here is the penance. First, you will keep the chancellery, because no one else knows where the bodies are buried, and I require that knowledge in my service. Second, you will write, in your own hand, the full account of the matter, with every name and every threat, and it will be sealed in the private archive until my death, after which it belongs to history. Third," she paused, choosing it, "you will personally see to the education, at the duchy's charge, of every orphan girl of the court and the lower town whose fathers die in this war. Latin, accounts, law. I want a generation of women whom no man can decide things for, because they will know more law than he does. Name the school for my mother."

The old man's eyes were wet, which she had never seen. "And the duke, madame? What is his sentence?"

"His sentence is the same as mine. We have to make a marriage work without the lie it began in. It is a harder one than yours." She rose. "Live, Foulques. That's an order."

At the door she looked back once, and he was already reaching for his pen, because work was the only confession he had ever been capable of, and she closed the door softly and went down into the courtyard where the army was mustering for the north and the new war and the long, slow, unfinishable business of learning to trust the one person who knew every weakness in her walls.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Siege of Sainterre

General moved in the first week of June, and he moved the way a professional moves, without drama and without warning: three columns out of the forfeit fiefs, converging on the river roads, the vanguard under strong cavalry screens that ate the scout patrols and left the duchess's army blind in the one week of the year when visibility mattered. By the time Thiébaut's dispatches reached the Haut-Tertre, the French were across the upper Ortelle, and the war everyone had planned for over maps had become the war of actual dust and hoofbeats.

Jeanne was already in Sainterre. She had come for the midsummer charter council, the first full meeting of the elected aldermen under the sealed charter, and Coppens had prepared a banquet and a speech and a set of figures on the river trade that he considered more moving than any poetry. The news of the French advance reached the city at the same hour as the first refugees from the eastern villages, their carts heaped with bedding and their faces set in the particular expression of people who have done this before and hoped never to do it again.

The council met in the cloth hall through the night, and there was a moment, only a moment, when leaving remained possible. The river gate still stood open, the road west was clear, and the duchess's guard had fresh horses. Coppens put the case himself, heavily, because the case was heavy.

"Madame, if you stay, you are inside a city Graçay intends to take. If you go, you remain in the field with the army, and the war keeps its head. A duchess in a siege is a hostage with a crown. The aldermen will say so, off the record, every one of them."

"And on the record?"

"On the record, the city will hold because you are in it. You know that, or you wouldn't be asking." The old guildsman met her eyes. "I won't pretend it's an easy thing I'm saying. It's the truth. The garrison is twelve hundred, the militia six thousand on paper, the walls sound, the cisterns full. What the city lacks is a certainty that the charter means anything. Your person in the streets gives it that."

She sent the guard's captain with the answer to Thiébaut before she gave the answer to the hall, because she had learned the order of things: first the person whose treaty gave him the right to be heard, then the room. The letter was short. *Graçay's vanguard is a day from the walls. I am staying. Not for romance; for the charter and the*

customs and the reason this city is worth an army. Do not attempt a relief against a prepared ring; we both know that road. Make his war expensive and wait for the moment the ground gives. I will keep the city. You keep the field.

His answer came back before dawn, written in the hand she knew from a hundred dispatches, and shorter than hers. *The treaty's worst clause is the one that makes me obey. I have posted riders to every garrison. Hold, and write by every arrow.*

Then the river gate was shut and barred and bricked up at the hinges, and Sainterre became a world with walls for its skyline.

* * *

Outside, Thiébaut watched the ring close and did the only thing an inferior field army can do against a siege: he made himself intolerable.

Graçay had perhaps eight thousand men, the guns, and the supply trains. The duke had four thousand, more mobility, and the population's goodwill across the countryside the French had to cross. He refused the battle the French offered on the flat ground below the city and instead took the army into the woods and river valleys, cutting convoys, burning supply dumps, hunting the foraging parties so aggressively that a French detachment could not leave its camp under company strength. The messengers between Paris

and the siege lines began to need escorts of cavalry. Every night the French saw his watch-fires on different hills, and every morning some party of their men failed to return.

"It's not relief," he told the war council in the field camp, over a map pinned to an oak. "It's a tax. Every week he sits in front of Sainterre, I make him pay for the privilege. The Regent's treasury is already bleeding. The question is which of us runs out of money first, and I have a Venetian and he has Paris."

The arrow post was the strangest instrument of the siege, invented out of necessity and refined into a small, grim art. Every night, when the wind was right, the city's archers sent letters wrapped around bolts over the French lines into the nearest pickets, and the army's archers sent them back, and the French never fully stopped it, because a picket line is a sieve in the dark and a letter weighs nothing. The correspondence between the pavilion and the cloth hall became the siege's secret heartbeat: numbers, morale, the state of the wells, the price of bread, and at the bottom of each, in a hand only the two of them could read, the private line, the sentence that no clerk copied.

His first letter reached her on the third night. *The ring is strong on the south and east, weaker west where the ground is wet. I have marked his*

two big bombards; they move on Thursdays. Are you well? Do not answer only in figures.

She wrote back: *The bombardment has not begun. I am well and unpopular with the aldermen, which is the correct condition. Stop asking about my health in letters a sergeant could read.* And then, after a long pause, in the private hand: *I sleep with the green case's copy under my pillow. The revision continues. We are not finished, you and I.*

* * *

Outside the ring, the duke's war ran on its own dark clock. Jean, healed but stiff, led the best of the mounted archers in the night raids, and the brothers planned them in the field pavilion over the same maps by candlelight, marking the convoys the scouts reported and the weak points in the French escort system.

The biggest raid came in the second week, against a grain convoy from the south, forty carts with a guard of two hundred. Jean took the van through a wood at midnight, the lances went in from both sides of the road, and the escort broke in the first ten minutes, the kind of fight that is decided by whichever side believes in the dark less. By dawn the convoy was theirs: the grain redirected along forest tracks to hidden stores, the carts burned, the French prisoners bound and the

oxen driven off, and not a single sack had reached Graçay's camp.

"His bread bill just doubled," Jean said, watching the smoke. "How long before Paris asks why an eight-thousand-man siege is being fed by foraging?"

"Paris has already asked. Dolfin's friends send the replies." Thiébaut turned his horse toward the hidden camp. "But none of this matters if the city breaks. Every convoy I burn buys a week. She has to sell me the weeks."

The scouts and the arrow letters were his only window into Sainterre, and he read each one with his face under control and his hand white on the paper. Jean watched him do it and said nothing, because there was nothing to say, and because he had watched his brother carry this particular dread since he was twenty years old. But once, after a letter that mentioned the crossbow bolt two feet from her head, the Bastard said, "She is the most capable woman in Europe. She is also your wife. You are permitted to be afraid."

"I'm not afraid. I'm calculating. Fear is a tax on attention."

"You're afraid. I know the difference; I've been afraid next to you for fifteen years." Jean clapped his good shoulder. "She'll hold. She has a city full

of people who've seen her carry stones. What does Graçay have? de Key and an invoice."

Thiébaut said nothing, but that night his letter went in with a longer postscript than usual, and the archer who carried it reported that the duke had stood watching the dark walls for an hour after the bolt was away.

* * *

The bombardment began on the fifth day, and it began the way all artillery war begins, with noise that rearranges the body's understanding of the world.

The two big bombards, the ones that moved on Thursdays, opened at dawn from the eastern rise, and the first stone shot struck the wall above the Ghent gate with a concussion she felt in her teeth at the cloth hall, half a mile away. The walls held; medieval stone was thick and the new guns were still learning their trade, and the aldermen had spent the winter shoring the foundations with earth and timber. But the houses behind the walls did not hold, and the first casualties were civilians in the eastern streets, where a shot overran the rampart and went through a weaver's cottage and the family eating their morning pottage.

Jeanne went to the eastern quarter at once, with Coppens and the surgeon and the guard, and she worked the rubble the way she had worked the

hospital tents at Saint-Vaast, carrying stones and binding wounds and saying the names when the bodies came out. It was the correct government and the correct example, and she knew it, and did it anyway, because there was no other way. By midday the quarter had a system: the houses nearest the wall emptied into the cellars and the church crypts, the fire-watch organized street by street, the children moved to the western cellars where the shot could not reach. The city, which had feared the guns as a beast fears thunder, began the long civilian labor of living inside their sound.

The rationing was Coppens's work and her signature. Grain was inventoried house by house in the first week, the merchants' stores entered on the public books at fixed prices, and the bread ration set by category: soldiers and laborers first, then the guild households, then the rest, with the children and the sick under a separate list that Jeanne supervised herself. Hoarding was punished by seizure and a public reading of the offender's name, which in Sainterre was a worse penalty than the seizure. The water was the deeper fear. The river ran outside the walls, and the French knew it; their archers covered the quays, and the city wells, though sufficient, were old and shallow. By the second week the first cases of the flux appeared in the lower town, and the cistern water was boiled whether people liked the taste or not, and the

hospital of Saint-Géry became the busiest place in the city.

De Key came back to them in the second week, carried in through the French lines under a flag of truce, and the city discovered what its former prophet had become.

He arrived at the cloth hall in French-cut clothes, with a French clerk and a French paymaster's confidence, and he asked to address the aldermen and the guilds, and Jeanne let him, because forbidding the speech would make it sacred. He spoke in the same deep hall-filling voice, but the message had changed. The war was lost; the duchess's army could not break the ring; the city's trade was dying by the day; Paris offered the ancient freedoms, the tolls, the militia, everything the charter had given and more, under the crown's guarantee. He did not say that he held a French captain's commission. The French-cut clothes said it for him.

She answered him from the same platform, in the same voice she had used in this square before the riot, and she did not raise it. "He asks you to trade a sealed charter for a promise. I have the charter in this hall, under my hand and the city's seal. Where is the promise written, and who seals it? The Sire de Graçay? Ask the people of Sainte-Florence what his promises are worth. Ask the thirty-one militiamen hanged in their charter

uniforms. This man wears French cloth and eats French bread and asks you to pay for both with your gates. The city will vote, as a free city may, and I will abide by its vote. But I will record it, and so will the history of this guild."

The guilds voted by roaring acclamation rather than ballot, and de Key left the hall under hoots, and Jeanne watched him go with the cold knowledge that the vote had settled the city's spirit but not its danger. A prophet who has lost his audience becomes a man with a grievance and a paymaster, and the French had uses for such men.

* * *

A siege, Jeanne learned, was not a battle but a household, the same work as the Haut-Tertre stripped of every ornament and enlarged to the scale of a city: water, bread, fire, sickness, the removing of waste, the keeping of watches, the morale of people who had expected to be ordinary. The aldermen ran the machinery; she ran the aldermen, and between them they built, in the first fortnight, the small republic of the besieged.

The women were its spine. The guild wives organized themselves by parish into crews under the duchess's own commission, sealed and dated so that no man could call it meddling: water crews for the walls and the fires, linen crews who tore the city's spare cloth into bandages, stone crews

who carried rubble to the breaches, and the crews of the hospital of Saint-Géry who did the work no one else could bear. Jeanne worked beside them in the first days until Coppens, with the bluntness she paid him for, told her the duchess had better uses than a strong back, and after that she went the rounds every day on foot, and the rounds themselves became an institution, the woman in the plain grey gown appearing in every quarter at every hour, knowing the names, checking the lists, eating the ration bread in public so the city could see its duchess ate no better than a fuller.

Verhoeven's press ran in the cellar through the bombardment, the type rattled by the concussions, and the weekly sheet came out even when its printer did not sleep. It carried the true casualty figures, the ration schedules, the dispatches from the field army, and, at Jeanne's insistence, the names: every defender killed, listed by parish and guild, the book of the dead translated into print and read aloud at every market cross. A city that saw its dead named in print, she had argued, would not surrender their names to silence. The sheet also carried, in every edition, a short section of the charter's text, so that the people being asked to die for a document knew exactly what the document said.

The merchant class was the hardest problem. The great traders had the most to lose and the strongest case for an early accommodation, and

two of them were caught in the third week sending price signals to the French by the arrangement of their rooftop cloths. Jeanne tried them before the city court, not her own, and let Coppens pronounce the sentence: seizure of the stock and expulsion through the river postern, under flag of truce, to go and live under the government they had been advertising. One of them, a cloth merchant named Vanisse, begged at the last for mercy, and she gave him the answer she had worked out in advance for the whole watching city.

"I do not punish opinion. You may believe the French will win; half of Europe believes it. I punish signals sent to an enemy's guns while your neighbors' sons hold the walls. Go. If you are right, you'll return in triumph and I'll be in a cell. If you are wrong, the city has your stock for the common bread."

The story was in the next sheet, and after it the rooftop cloths all hung in the ordinary way.

The flux took its own toll in the cellars, where the displaced families lived on boiled water and thin bread, and the hospital filled with the sweating, shitting sick alongside the wounded. There were no medicines beyond the old ones, willow bark and vinegar and the herbal lore of the convent women, and the dead of disease outnumbered the dead of the guns by the third week, as they did in every siege in Christendom.

Jeanne's hardest daily work was the hospital, where the smell never left her clothes and the children recognized her step and called her by the name they had made up, the Grey Woman, because of the gown.

* * *

The first assault came on the twenty-first day, at the point the bombardment had been weakening for a fortnight: the curtain wall east of the Ghent gate, where the stone had crumbled into a ragged slope of rubble that the French had begun to fill with fascines and earth.

They came before dawn, in the old formal sequence: the crossbowmen to the edge of the ditch to drive the walls clear, the miners and laborers with their bundles, the storming columns behind with ladders and the new scaling stairs. The night sky over the eastern rise went red with the alarm fires, and the city's bells began, and Jeanne climbed the Ghent gate tower with the garrison commander because there was nowhere else the duchess could be on such a morning, and she had learned at the windmill by the ford that the watching was also work.

The fight lasted four hours and cost the city ninety-seven men.

She saw it in pieces through the smoke: the French crosses filling the ditch, the ladders going

up and coming down, the militia holding the rubble with pikes the Lorraine captains had trained them to use, the gunners working the wall pieces at close range until two of the guns split their barrels. She saw a boy her own guard's age climb a ladder with a banner and be thrown off it by a stone, and the banner fall with him and be caught before it touched the ground. She carried water and bandages and the spare bolts along the wall-walk with the other women, and once a crossbow bolt struck the stone two feet from her head and whined away into the dark, and she did not scream, because she had decided in advance that she would not, and decisions made in advance are the only kind that hold at such hours.

By full morning the French had drawn back, leaving the ditch full of their dead and the ladders against the wall and the smell of smoke and blood over the whole eastern quarter, and the city's bells changed from alarm to the rough, exhausted sound of survival, and the militia on the wall began, of all things, to sing, a guild drinking song with the words changed for the occasion, and the song ran along the ramparts like fire along a fuse.

Coppens came up the tower stairs, bleeding from a cut on his scalp, and looked at her with the face of a man who has just discovered reserves he did not know he held.

"They'll come again, madame."

"Yes. They'll come again, and again, until the money or the food runs out. That's the whole of a siege." She looked out over the ditch and the French lines and the watch-fires of the distant army where her husband's banners moved among the hills. "So we make sure ours runs out second."

The cellar of the merchant's house became her school in what bombardment did to people who had no part in the war.

It was the cellar nearest the eastern wall, deep and vaulted, where thirty families had taken their blankets and their bread and their frightened children, and the aldermen had asked her to visit because the keeper of the ration lists had broken down in tears there the night before and no one could make the columns add. She came after the hospital rounds, with two guards who waited at the top of the stairs, and sat on a flour barrel in the lamplight and did the lists herself, and the cellar, which had gone quiet at the sight of the duchess, slowly found its voices.

A woman with a baby at her breast asked, without accusation, whether the charter would still mean anything if the French came through the wall, and Jeanne told her the charter was a document in three cities and a treaty in Venice as well as a paper in Sainterre, which was a better answer than the one she felt like giving. An old weaver, one of de Key's original guild, said he had

voted against the war contribution and now watched his own grandson carrying sand to the ramparts, and he asked whether she found that amusing, and she said no, she found it the cost of being wrong in public, which he had paid and she honored. A girl of perhaps seven, with the flat, serious face of the chronically underfed, asked her whether the guns ever stopped, and Jeanne said they stopped when the city made stopping cheaper than firing, and the child considered this and said she would tell the others, as though the duchess had handed her a commission.

When the next bombardment began, close enough that dust sifted from the vault, she stayed. The cellar flinched as one body at each concussion, the babies wailing, the women holding the smaller children, and she sat on her flour barrel and held the hand of the nearest woman and said nothing at all, because there was nothing to say, and when the guns moved off at last the keeper of the ration lists came to her in the new quiet and said he could do the columns now, and did them, with his hands still shaking.

Coppens met her at the top of the stairs. "You'll be expected at every bombardment now. The whole cellar will be talking by morning."

"Then let them say the duchess sat in the dust with them. It's the cheapest propaganda in the war, and it happens to be true." She brushed the

flour from her gown. "Keep the cellars provisioned and the lists in order. The walls are stone, but the siege is won in those rooms."

* * *

The treachery inside the walls showed its hand two nights later, the way treachery always does, through a small and greedy man. A watchman at the water gate, one of de Key's old weavers, was caught by the gate's militia sergeant in the act of oiling the barrier's bar and marking the postern with a chalk cross, and under the city's questioning he gave up the whole small web: five men, a plan to open the water gate on the next moonless night, and de Key's name on the pay, passed through a French deserter in the lower town.

Jeanne insisted the trial be the city's. The aldermen sat in the cloth hall with their charter on the table, the evidence was read aloud, and the five were condemned by their own neighbors under their own law, and hanged at dawn from the gate they had meant to open, in the red armbands they had kept since the year of the riot. The watchman, who had turned king's evidence, got the city's mercy and a place in the stone crews for the duration, and was the most thoroughly watched man in Sainterre.

"De Key's name wasn't on a paper he touched," Coppens said, walking back with her through the

waking streets. "He'll deny it from the French camp."

"He will. But the city has now hanged its own traitors under its own charter. That's worth more to me than his neck. The aldermen didn't execute my enemies this morning. They executed their own. There's a difference, and the difference is why the wall holds."

The French answered with a second bombardment, longer and heavier, and a herald under parley who read out Graçay's terms at the Ghent gate: the city's life and goods and the ancient freedoms if it opened within ten days, and the fate of Saintes if it did not. The crowd heard him in silence, and when he had done, the militia captain on the wall shouted down the one reply the city had agreed in advance, and the whole gate watch roared it after him: "The charter!"

That night the arrow post carried his letter: *I counted the assault columns from the ridge. Your wall held, and I know who held it. The French lost, by my scouts, four hundred for a ditch. I have never been prouder of a document in my life. Sleep if you can. I cannot.*

She wrote back: *The charter is holding the wall. I am merely keeping the books. Send powder. We have more courage than saltpeter.*

And underneath, in the private hand, she added: *I have revised several more pages. When this is over, you and I have a great deal to say, and I intend to say all of it. Stay alive to hear it.*

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Sallies

By the fortieth day Sainterre had eaten its horses.

The rationing held because the books held, but the books could not invent grain. The fixed price became a fixed hope; the bread shrank from a loaf to a wedge and from a wedge to a dark cut of bean-and-rye that tasted of the grit in the millstones. The cavalry mounts went first, by public decree, the duchess's own grey mare among them, and Coppens saw to it that the meat was divided by the parishes and not by rank, which single act of the knife kept the city's peace through a week when another city would have torn itself apart. Cats disappeared from the gutters, then the dogs, then the swans on the canal, and the news sheet recorded every measure in its flat clerk's voice, because a city that can read its hunger in print is a city that understands the hunger has a shape and an ending.

Jeanne's day had taken on the rhythm of the walls. Before dawn, the hospital of Saint-Géry, where the night's dead were counted and the morning's medicines issued. Then the wall-walk with the garrison commander, the inspection of the guns and the powder store, the numbers written in

her own hand. Then the rationing courts, the disputes, the aldermen, the long middle hours of keeping a city civilized by willpower. Afternoon, the crews: the women's water-and-sand crews now three hundred strong, the stone crews, the boys' messenger corps, the old men's fire watch. Evening, the letters, the dispatches, the arrow post, the private line at the bottom of the page. And night, the few hours of sleep on a pallet in the cloth hall cellar, with the guns in her dreams and the list of the dead waiting for the morning.

She had not told anyone about the nausea. It had begun in the third week, the small reliable sickness at dawn and the strange, altered smell of the hospital, and she had put it down to the ration bread and the strain until the accounting in her own body caught up with the accounting in her mind: the courses that had not come in March, or April, or now June; the fullness and tenderness she had been ignoring through the campaign. The convent physician, an old nun named Sister Margriet who had delivered half the guildsmen of Sainterre and feared neither blood nor duchesses, confirmed it in a cellar room with one candle, in the plain trade language of her profession.

"Two months gone, perhaps a little more. The body does not keep precise ledgers, madame, even when its owner does. Strong heart, good color in spite of everything, and the sickness is a healthy sign, though you won't think so at dawn. What you

must not do is starve it. I will see to a separate ration, and I will hear no argument about the example."

"Then we will make the example do double work." Jeanne sat with her hands folded in her lap and the knowledge settling through her like a stone through still water. "The city's children and its pregnant women eat from the same list, including the duchess. If my extra ration is known, it is known as the rule, not the privilege. And Sister — not a word beyond this room. Not to the aldermen, not to the guard. The city is carrying one fear already. It does not need mine."

The old woman studied her. "The father should know."

"The father is four miles away with an army and reads every letter I send. He'll know by the week's end. He has earned the right to worry at the same time as I do."

* * *

The second assault, when it came, was aimed at the river wall, and Marcenay led it.

He had arrived in Graçay's camp after the failure at Sainte-Florence with his eighty survivors and his undamaged self-regard, and the French commander, who had small use for the man but a use for the reputation, had given him the storming column and the point where the river wall had

been weakened by a mine the French engineers had run under the outer ward. The ground above the mine was propped with timber the besiegers could fire at the chosen hour, and the chosen hour was the dark before dawn on the forty-third day, in the fog off the river.

Jeanne was woken by the ground moving. The mine went up with a deep, dull roar rather than the crack of the guns, and a section of the outer wall slumped into the ditch in a landslide of stone and earth, and through the smoke and the fog the French storming party came at the gap with their ladders and their fascines, and behind them, shouting in a voice the sentries would later repeat with loathing, Marcenay drove his men on.

The outer ward fell within the hour. It was not a wall of houses, only the lower enclosure, the store yards and the tanners' sheds and the church of the old foundation, but its loss put the French inside the first skin of the city, and the inner gate became the line, and the alarm bells of Sainterre rang from every tower at once, and the night became a chaos of smoke and running feet and the red light of the tanners' sheds going up.

The women's refuge was the crypt of the old church, and it was directly in the path.

She learned it from a breathless messenger boy, one of her own corps, who found her at the inner gate organizing the sand crews: the outer

ward's fleeing civilians, the women and children and the wounded from the forward hospital, had been herded into the crypt, and Marcenay's free company, pouring through the ward, had found the church and put a guard on its doors. What happened in the next hour belonged to the logic of men who had done it before, at Sainte-Florence and a dozen unrecorded villages, and the messenger did not need to spell it out. The faces of the women within earshot did that.

Jeanne made the decision in the time it took to turn from the gate. The inner wall's defense belonged to the garrison commander and was in good hands; the breach could be held for an hour. The crypt could not.

"Coppens. The women's crews, every crew within call, and the militia reserve from the cloth hall. Bring pikes, knives, the fire buckets, and every crossbow from the armory that a woman can shoulder. We're going to the church."

"Madame, you can't—"

"I can, and I will, and the city will see me do it." She was already moving, the grey gown kilted into her belt, the dagger at her hip, and the word ran through the streets like a current: the Grey Woman was going to the church, and the women of Sainterre were going with her.

They came from the cellars and the wall-walks and the hospital, three hundred and then four, guild wives in their leather work-jerkins, servant girls with kitchen knives, the widows of the first assault carrying the pikes their husbands had used, and Jeanne put them into the street column the way the Lorraine captains had taught her to put men into a formation: the crossbows in front under the three militia women who could actually shoot, the pikewomen in the center, the fire-and-sand crews behind, and at the head, because there was nowhere else for her to be, the duchess herself with a steel cap she had taken from a dead man and a dagger rather than a sword, because she had never been taught the sword and refused to pretend otherwise.

"Listen to me." She spoke low, and the word passed back through the column. "We are not charging an army. We are taking back a building. We move at the walk, in order, and no one breaks for any reason. They are drunk and disorganized and do not expect a formed body coming the other way. At the church, the crossbows take the door guard. The pikes hold the street. The rest of you get the women and children out through the crypt's rear passage to the canal. I go in with the first file. Is that understood?"

It was understood.

* * *

The outer ward burned along its northern edge, and the fog and smoke made every street a room without walls. They moved through it in their dark clothes with the measured pace of a guild procession, and the first French foragers they met, three men with armfuls of stolen plate, simply stared at the column of women as though at a vision, and were taken from behind by the pikewomen before they could shout.

The church square was worse than the messenger had described. A dozen of Marcenay's sergeants held the doors, and through the broken windows came the sounds from inside, the sounds Jeanne had read in the Dominican's book and sworn she would not hear in a city of hers. The door guards had their backs to the street, watching the church, and the crossbow women's first volley took four of them down at thirty paces, and the rest turned in disbelief into the lowered pikes.

It was not a battle. It was the application of order to appetite, and order won as it usually does when it arrives in time. The sergeants were professional enough to understand a formed body and drunk enough to be slow against it; they gave ground, then broke, two cut down in the square and the rest fleeing up the ward toward the breach, while the pikewomen held the street in their drill and the fire crews went past them into the church.

Jeanne was through the doors with the first file. Inside, the old church was a ruin of overturned benches and smoking lamps, and the women of the refuge were on their feet in the crypt stair, the ones who had found weapons in the altar rail, and at the back a knot of Marcenay's men had hold of two girls and were trying to drag them toward the vestry, and the sight did something to the careful, clerkly ruler of Vauréal that no ledger would ever record.

She did not scream. She put her steel cap lower and ran, and the file ran with her, and in the close dark of the church her dagger found the thigh of the first man, and a pikewoman's weapon took him in the throat, and the rest let go of the girls and made for the windows with the city's women at their heels. One of them, the worst, she recognized from the friar's description, a sergeant named for the night at Sainte-Florence, and she had him marked before he went out through the broken glass, and she said his name once, aloud, to be sure of it.

The evacuation took an hour: the women and the children and the wounded through the crypt passage to the canal, under the sand crews' guard, while the pikewomen held the church and the square and the street beyond. By dawn the inner gate had done its work as well. The garrison, reinforced by the militia, had thrown the French column back through the burning ward and into

the breach, and Marcenay's assault had cost him two hundred men and gained nothing but rubble, and the bells of Sainterre changed their note from alarm to the ragged singing of people who have survived the night.

Jeanne did not sleep. She went the rounds of the hospital and the crypt and the breach, and the city watched the Grey Woman in her bloodstained jerk in moving through it, and the story went ahead of her as stories do, and grew, as stories will, and she let it grow because there was no stopping it and because a legend in a siege was a kind of gunpowder.

* * *

She stayed in the crypt until the last of the women had been seen to. The two girls the sergeant's party had taken were twelve and fourteen, and neither had been harmed, though the older one could not stop shaking and the younger had lost the power of speech. Their mothers came through the canal passage at first light and the scene in the crypt was beyond the reach of any chronicle, and Jeanne held the younger girl for a long time because no one else was free, and said nothing, because nothing was the correct thing.

The women of the refuge organized themselves around their own with the competence of the

unprotected. One, a dyer's wife with a face like a fist, had broken a Frenchman's arm with a brass candlestick and wanted it entered in the city's record, and Jeanne had the clerk take the name and the deed then and there, and saw in the woman's eyes the exact thing she had been building since the first charter: the knowledge that the city's defense was not the soldiers' property.

"They told us through the doors," the dyer's wife said, "that if we made a sound they would fire the church. I thought, the duchess is inside these walls. The duchess would not let a church burn with us in it. I thought it like a prayer, madame. And you came."

"The city came. I was at its head, which is my proper place." Jeanne gave her the steel cap to hold for a moment, because she had seen women handle holy objects and wanted the gesture of it. "Your name and your deed are in the book. When this is over, the city will owe its women a debt it can never pay in full, and I will make sure the ledgers keep trying."

The story needed no printing, though Verhoeven printed it anyway, in the next sheet, without names but with every detail the women chose to give, and the reading of it in the market crosses changed the mood of Sainterre. Up until that week, the women's crews had been auxiliary. After the church, they were part of the garrison,

and the militia captains stopped arguing about crossbows for women and started issuing them.

* * *

The count came at midday, in the cloth hall, over the ledgers. Forty-one dead in the night, a hundred and twenty wounded, the outer ward gone, the river wall breached but the inner gate sound. And the powder: Van Brock's store, the two-key arsenal that was the charter's pride, had taken a shell in the first bombardment, and the true remaining stock was enough for perhaps ten days' hard fighting, no more.

"Then we make ten days into the war." Jeanne looked around the aldermen's table, the smoke-stained faces, Coppens with his bandaged head, the militia captains, Sister Margriet. "First, every ounce of saltpeter in the city, in the merchants' stores and the apothecaries' shops and the convent gardens, goes to the arsenal, paid for at fixed price, receipts in the book. Verhoeven prints the requisition tonight with my seal. Second, we cut the guns' firing to fixed rates, no more than the captains sign for; the wall pieces hold their shot for the assaults, and the small arms use the rest. Third, a letter goes out tonight by every route we have — arrow, swimmer, the canal at low water. The field army has to know the exact number, because a relieving battle without powder is a massacre, and with it is a rescue."

"The swimmers," Coppens said. "Three have been lost already."

"Then the fourth goes with the letter in a wax tube and a purse of gold and my personal warrant of a pension for his family. We will not stop sending because the river is dangerous; the river is why the city exists."

The council nodded, the slow nods of people who had stopped being surprised by their own courage. After it broke, Sister Margriet detained her with a hand on her sleeve and a look at her face.

"The fighting in the church. You should not have been in it. In your condition."

"No one else was, in the first ten minutes." Jeanne kept her voice even. "Sister, if this child is a girl, she will be told one day that her mother was in a church at four months with a dagger in her hand. I would rather that than tell her her mother stood counting linen while other women's daughters were taken. Watch the sickness for me, and say nothing. That is all I ask."

The old nun looked at her a long moment, and then said, "I have delivered four hundred babies, madame, including two in the middle of a flood. This one will be fine. You, I am less certain of. Sit down now and eat, or I will tell the whole city its duchess is more stubborn than its aldermen."

She sat, and ate, and wrote the letter.

* * *

The sallies were the garrison's answer to the guns, and by the sixth week they had their own grim tradition. Every third night, a chosen company went out through the water gate at the ebb, blackened with soot, to work on the French siege lines: cutting the fascines, spiking the emplaced guns with iron nails driven into the touch holes, firing the timber of the approach trenches, and coming home before the enemy's drums could form a response. The guilds competed for the places, because the sally companies got double pay and the best of the ration bread, and because a city that can hit back stops being afraid.

Jeanne authorized each raid herself, from the lists the garrison commander brought, and she made two rules of her own: no harm to the French wounded, who were stripped of arms and left for their own surgeons, and no looting beyond the actual tools of the siege. The first raid under the rules came back with a prisoner instead, a young engineer's clerk with a satchel of the trench drawings, and the drawings, sent out by arrow, told Thiébaut exactly where the French mine was being run under the second wall.

"He says the south mine will be ready in a fortnight." She traced the ink lines in the cloth hall

cellar with Coppens and the gunner captains. "Then we have a fortnight to make the ground give somewhere else. Countermine here, under their sap, and keep it quiet. When their gallery reaches ours, we break through and flood the works with the canal water. The engineers can do it?"

"The miners say yes, madame. They want double pay."

"They get it, and a barrel each when the thing works." She set down the dividers. "A city that fights under the ground as well as on the walls is a city that believes it can win. Let's make sure it's right."

The countermine was dug in the cellar-dark over nine nights, the miners relaying in silence with their ears to the rock, and on the tenth night the two galleries met, and the Vauréal party broke the last wall of earth and let the canal in, and the French mine flooded with a roar the sentries heard on both walls, and the besiegers' best approach drowned in mud. Graçay's engineers started a second mine farther east, and everyone in Sainterre knew the calendar had just been rewritten.

* * *

The swimmer came back.

Three had been lost to the French archers and the river's cold, and the fourth was a Malemort

waterman named Goujon, thin and sinewy and entirely without fear, who had spent his youth smuggling salt past the tolls and considered an army in siege just another kind of customs house. He went out at the ebb with the wax tube braided into his hair, and the city gave him up for lost through two black days, and on the third night a patrol on the water gate heard the agreed signal, three knocks under the stone, and hauled him out of the river blue and shivering and alive, with an answering tube tied where the letters had been.

Thiébaut's reply was terse and soldierly: the ground was giving; the relief was set; hold eight more days; and for her alone, the line in the private hand that made her read it twice. Goujon, wrapped in blankets by the guardroom fire, drank the hot wine they gave him and delivered the report his body could not: the French camp's ration riots, the deserters crossing at the fords, the convoys that never arrived. He had floated among the reeds for six hours on the return, he said, because a patrol was watering horses at the landing, and he had counted every horse and every man and memorized them, because his instructions were to bring back more than paper.

"He should be paid," Jeanne said to Coppens, "double the purse, with a receipt, and the city's mark. And he should never be sent out again. A man this lucky owes the river a life, and the river collects."

The old guildsman nodded. "There'll be no shortage of volunteers after him. The watermen are fighting over the next message."

"They can fight in line. Write the man a guild charter of his own while you're about it, the guild of the river watch, with the toll freedom as its fee. In a year's time they'll be the proudest company in Malemort, and no one will remember it began in a sewer."

She saw Goujon before he was sent home to recover, and he said the thing she had been carrying without knowing it: "The duke reads your letters twice, madame. I watched him by the picket fire. A man reads a dispatch once. He read yours twice." She gave him no answer she would have printed, but she wrote the detail in the private book that no clerk ever saw.

* * *

The arrow went out at midnight, and the swimmer went with it, and the letter said the things the clerks required, the breach, the ward, the powder number, the dead, and at the bottom, in the private hand, it said the rest.

There is more. The physician confirms it, and Sister Margriet is certain. I am carrying a child, conceived, by the reckoning, in the winter, and I am well, and the child is well, and the city is well enough to go on. Do not do anything reckless with

this news. That is an order, and I have discovered I enjoy giving them. The child will be born in a city that has kept its charter, because you and I between us are going to make that sentence true. I was in a fight today, in a church, and I was not afraid, which I think is what you taught me without ever saying it. Come when the ground gives. We will be here.

She signed it with her name alone, the way she had signed the first letter of all of them, the cold one with the gate terms, and the archer wrapped it around the bolt and loosed it into the dark over the French lines, and somewhere in the hills the picket line would pass it from hand to hand until it reached the pavilion where a man sat awake over maps, and she imagined his face when he read the last of it, and allowed herself, for one minute in the cellar dark, to be not the duchess but the woman.

Then she put out the taper and lay down on her pallet in her clothes with the steel cap within reach, and slept, because the morning had walls to defend and a child to keep and a siege to finish, and none of it would wait for her grief or her joy.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Breaking of the Siege

The letter came through the lines in a wax tube at the third hour, carried by a shivering swimmer who had floated two miles down the Ortelle among the reeds, and Thiébaut read it in the pavilion with the whole war council pretending to study the maps. He read the military parts first, as she had known he would, and the last part second, and then he read the last part again, and his face went through a sequence of changes that Jean, who had been watching him for fifteen years, later described as the expression of a man who has simultaneously been given a duchy and told to defend it with his bare hands.

He set the page down and said, to the council, "The powder holds ten days. The breach is at the river wall. The city can open the water gate at a signal. And I am to be a father, which is not strictly a matter for the council, but you will all know by Sunday anyway."

The room's relief at the first three pieces of news came out as laughter at the fourth, and even Brive permitted himself a smile, and then they got down to the work, because ten days of powder was an hourglass, and the sand was already moving.

The plan took three nights to build and every favor the alliance had banked in a year. Dolfin's gold, advanced against the next quarter's customs, hired a regiment of German Landsknechts, twelve hundred pikes under a captain named von Eppeln, who marched in from the east with the careful neutrality of men paid well enough not to ask whose war it was. The feudal host, thinned and hardened by a season of raids, supplied the men-at-arms and the mounted archers. The Sainterre militia's brothers from Malemort brought a company of arquebus men, new and uncertain and proud. In all, perhaps five and a half thousand effectives against Graçay's eight, but eight thousand strung around a city in a long, thin ring, with their convoys burned and their pay in arrears and their commander's best officer, Marcenay, disgraced twice and hungry for a reputation.

"Graçay expects a relief attempt at the southern camp, where his guns are." Thiébaut put his finger on the map. "So the feint goes south. Brive, you take the lances and the banners, every standard we own, and you make a demonstration at dawn with trumpets and dust and the kind of noise an army makes when it intends to be noticed. He'll draw his reserves to you. The real column comes west, through the river woods the French think are impassable for guns, and we bring the sledge cannon from the Harchies, because the ground is

the same and the gunners know the tracks. At the signal, the city opens the water gate, and Coppens's militia takes the French works from the inside while we hit the ring from the outside. The key is the timing. We have to be at the gate at the same hour they are."

"Von Eppeln's terms say his pikes don't assault works," Jean said.

"His pikes hold the field against the French cavalry, which is what pikes are for. The assault is ours and the city's. Pay him his double rate and tell him the double rate buys silence as well as steel." Thiébaut's finger moved to the river. "The signal. One rocket from the west at the first hour after midnight. Two if it's delayed. The swimmer goes back tonight with the date and the hour. After that, no more letters. We run silent until the morning."

Bride looked at the map for a long moment. "It works or it ends the war in a morning, with the field army dead in a marsh and the city without hope."

"Everything works or ends the war in a morning. That's the definition of a battle." Thiébaut rolled the map. "I've spent a year making this the battle they don't want. The French are tired, unpaid, and spread thin. We are paid, angry, and coming through a wood. I'll take those odds."

* * *

The swimmer went back with the tube and the date, and the army moved in four columns over two nights, leaving the campfires burning and the tents standing and a skeleton of drummers and trumpeters to keep the French scouts honest. Brive's feint went south in a cloud of dust and every banner in the train, and the reports that came back through the scouts were exactly what the plan required: Graçay had drawn his cavalry reserve and two thousand foot to the southern lines, and the western ring was held by the gascon infantry and the free companies, with Marcenay's men around the river works.

The night march through the river woods was the kind of thing soldiers tell stories about and never want to repeat. No trumpets, no fires, the guns dragged in silence with rope and oxhide over the soft ground, the men hand-passing the powder casks along the chain where the wheels would have betrayed them. Thiébaut walked at the head of the column with the scouts, the bad shoulder wrapped and aching in the damp, and Jean beside him with the pike wound healed into a permanent stiffness, and behind them five thousand men moved through the black trees with the muffled, patient sound of a tide.

They reached the edge of the woods at the third hour, and the siege ring lay below them in the dark: the French watch-fires in their long curve, the black bulk of the city beyond, the river bending

like a question mark between them. The water gate was a darker patch on the wall where the reeds grew thick, and Thiébaut looked at it for a long moment and thought of a woman in a steel cap in a burning ward, and put the thought away, because a commander who takes his feelings into a battle is a man who gets his people killed.

"Rocket at the first hour," he said. "Pass the word. No one fires until the gate moves."

* * *

Inside the city, Jeanne had spent two days making the inside half of the plan work. The militia was sorted into the storming companies and the wall-holders; the women's crews were assigned to the water gate with the beams and rams; the remaining powder was husbanded for one hour's hard firing; the wounded from the garrison were given weapons they could hold from fixed positions, because every body would be needed. Coppens, who had not slept since the swimmer returned, moved through the cellars and the halls with his lists, and Verhoeven's press ran off the order of the morning in hundreds of copies, so that every captain held the same paper and there could be no confusion in the dark.

She saw to the one thing no one else would have thought of: the canal boats. Every boat in the city was gathered at the water gate, and the

wounded of the coming fight were to go back through them the moment the lines broke, and the flour stores were loaded on the first boats to feed the outer army, which she had correctly guessed would arrive short of bread.

At the first hour after midnight the rocket went up from the western woods, a single red thread in the dark, and the city answered with one bell from the cloth hall tower, the lowest and deepest of the bells, struck once. The beams of the water gate came up, the rams went to work on the inner barrier, and the first companies of the Sainterre militia, two hundred strong, went out through the reed beds at the French siege works with their pikes lowered and their boots muffled in rags.

Thiébaut's first line went forward at the same moment, and the French woke to the battle on both sides of their own wall.

* * *

The fight for the siege lines lasted until the sun was up, and it was never one battle but a dozen small ones, each with its own ground and its own name that would be told in the taverns afterwards. The gascons, professional to the last, formed in the trenches and held the Landsknechts for an hour of push of pike, the two blocks grinding together in the dawn mud with the long weapons bristling like two hedgehogs in combat, until the arquebuses of

the Malemort company began to tell on the gascon flank and the great block edged backward, step by step, the way a door gives under steady pressure.

At the river works, the free companies broke first. Marcenay's men, the survivors of Sainte-Florence and the church, had no stake in a siege line and no pay for one, and when the Sainterre militia came over their own parapet behind them and the Lorraine lances came through the reeds in front, they made the calculation of their kind and ran, many of them throwing their arms into the river. Marcenay himself did not run. Whatever else he was, he was no coward, and he rallied a knot of his sergeants around the French battery and kept the guns firing case shot into the press until the press reached him.

Rostaing reached him first.

The disgraced captain, who had spent six months as a common man-at-arms in the ranks at Mont d'Or and then in the field, carrying his own kit and answering to sergeants he had once outranked, came through the battery ditch at the head of the file with no armor above the waist but a dented breastplate and a face that had forgotten how to smile. The fight at the guns was close and wordless. Marcenay killed the first man and the second, and wounded Rostaing's sword arm, and Rostaing took the blade through his own forearm to close the distance, and killed the French captain

against the wheel of his own bombard with a dagger through the gorget, the way a butcher kills a pig. He held the body there a moment, in front of both armies' survivors, and then he sat down in the mud beside it and bled, and did not rise until the stretcher-bearers came, because the leg wound he had not noticed would not carry him.

They told Jeanne later, in the cloth hall, that he asked only whether the law would consider his account paid, and she sent back word by the same messenger: *Tell him the duchess keeps the books, and the entry is marked in full.*

* * *

De Key died by his own city, which was the only end the story allowed.

He had been in the French camp through the siege, the prophet in foreign clothes, and when the ring broke he ran for the eastern road with a small party of the men who had followed him from the first riot, and the road was held by the weavers' company of Sainterre, the guild whose hall he had once filled with his voice. They knew him in the dawn light as well as they knew their own hands, and they took him without a fight and hanged him from the framework of the French siege gallows before any officer could stop them, and the company's sergeant pinned a copy of his first broadsheet to his chest, so that he went into the

next world carrying his own words. When the report reached Coppens, the old guildsman said only, "The city did that. Not the duchess. Remember it in the record."

Graçay did the professional thing. With his western ring gone, his cavalry pinned by Brive's feint turned real, and his guns taken in their emplacements, he did not spend the army of the Regent in a prideful last stand. He drew the southern brigades off in good order, burned what stores he could not carry, spiked the guns he had to leave, and was marching south by midmorning with his wounded and his pay chests and his honor, leaving the field, the siege works, and a great deal of his reputation in the mud outside Sainterre. The Lorraine horse harried his rear for two miles and then, per the standing order, came back rather than be drawn into a running fight on French terms.

The southern feint became a real battle halfway through the morning, which was the risk Brive had carried. Graçay, discovering at last that the dust and trumpets were a screen, sent his heavy cavalry around the camp to catch the allied flank, and the gendarmes came across the open ground in the old magnificent fashion, two hundred armored horsemen at the full trot with their lances down, the charge that had won a hundred fields. Von Eppeln's Landsknechts received it in the new fashion: a square of pikes, the front ranks kneeling

with the butts braced in the mud, the steel hedge glittering in the sun, and the charge that had been the queen of battle spent itself on a formation that could not be made to run. Three times the gendarmes came, and three times the square held, and the mounted archers worked the flanks with their arrows, and by the third charge the French horses would no longer face the pikes, and the cavalry drifted off toward the marching column like water around a stone.

Bride, watching from the ridge with the reserve, said aloud to no one, "There goes the world my father knew," and then sent in the lances at the disorganized retreat, and did the new war the courtesy of taking its prisoners properly.

It was in that last phase that the old marshal found Rostaing's name coming up through the reports again, carried in on a stretcher with the French captain's dagger wound in his forearm and the gash in his leg, and Bride went himself to the dressing station and looked down at the man he had once expected to hang, and said, "You killed Marcenay."

"Yes, my lord."

"With a dagger, through the gorget, in a battery ditch."

"The sword was gone. It seemed the practical thing." Rostaing's face was grey with loss of blood,

but the voice was steady. "I held the law against him, my lord. The duchess's law. She said the entry was marked in full. I would like to know if that means what I think."

"It means you're a captain again, if the surgeons keep you alive, and the commission will be backdated, because that's the kind of sentimental woman she is." Brive gruffed out a sound that might have been a laugh. "Don't make her regret the entry. I'm too old to watch another trial."

"Never, my lord."

"See that you don't." And the old marshal went back to his battle, and left the stretcher-bearers to carry the redeemed man down to the canal boats.

By noon the joined arms standard flew over the French camp, and the river gate stood open, and the first canal boats were carrying flour out and the wounded in, and the siege of Sainterre was over.

* * *

They met in the cloth hall, because it was the center of the city's story and because neither of them could have borne a private reunion with the day's work still undone. He came through the doors in his battered plate with the mud of the river woods on him and the stubble of the night march, and she came down the aisle of the great

barn of a hall in the grey gown and the steel cap, with the lists in her hand, and the companies filing in behind them stopped to watch, because armies are incurably sentimental and know the value of what they see.

There was no speech. He crossed the floor and took both her hands, and looked at her face, the thinness and the smoke stains and the new lines, and then lower, at the barely visible change in her body that his hands recognized before his mind had finished the arithmetic, and he said the only thing he had planned on the march and rejected twice and decided anyway.

"You were in a church with a dagger. At four months."

"At three months, and only just. The city's women were with me, and the church was ours by the time I left it." She held his hands because the whole hall was watching and because she needed to. "Your letter said you would come when the ground gave. The ground gave."

"The ground was mined and flooded and paid for and voted on. I merely arrived." His thumb moved once across her knuckles, the only private thing he permitted himself. "Jeanne. The child. Is it well, truly?"

"Sister Margriet says so, and she has delivered four hundred babies and is not impressed by

duchesses. It is well, and I am well, and you will be a father in the winter, and we will discuss your feelings at length after the count." She turned to the lists, because the lists were safe. "The city's dead first, then the army's, then the prisoners and the guns. Coppens has the city's book. Your clerks will have the rest."

The count took the rest of the day. The siege had cost Sainterre four hundred and eleven of its people, counting the flux; the relief had cost the field army two hundred and thirty; the French left near a thousand dead and wounded in the works and the roads, and the city took back its gates and its honor and four bombards with the royal arms on their bronze. The stories sorted themselves in the telling: Rostaing's debt paid in the battery ditch, the weavers and their gallows, the Grey Woman at the church, the drowned mine, the rockets and the reeds. Verhoeven's press, which had not stopped through the siege, set the first relief sheet that night, and by morning it was being read in the camp and the city and bundled for every road in the dominion.

* * *

* * *

Graçay's herald came at dusk under the parley flag, with the professional courtesies of a beaten man who intends to remain in his profession. The

Sire de Graçay requested leave to bury his dead in the siege lines and to send his surgeons to the wounded he had been obliged to abandon, and he asked, in the careful language of chivalry, for the return of the body of Captain de Marcenay, whose family in Gascony would pay the customary sum.

"Say yes to the dead and the surgeons." Jeanne read the letter in the cloth hall with the aldermen and Thiébaut around her. "Say no to Marcenay's body. He hanged thirty-one militiamen in their charter uniforms and held a church full of women. Let the city decide his grave. Coppens?"

"The guilds would like him buried at the crossroads outside the Ghent gate, madame. Without a service. The families asked."

"Then write it as the city's answer, not mine, and tell the herald the French army's wounded will be treated by my surgeons at my cost, and the names sent under flag for exchange. One more paragraph. The Sire de Graçay's men fought, and that is an honorable trade. His free companies butchered, and that is not. I will treat with soldiers. I will ransom brigands only at the gallows. Make sure the letter is printed."

Thiébaut watched the herald ride out and said, when the doors were shut, "He'll show that letter in Paris. Every professional officer in France will read it."

"That's why it's printed. The Regent's army is held together by professionals who haven't been paid. I want them comparing their treatment with ours when the spring campaign comes up for debate. War is also a court of reputation, and I intend to win that one too."

The French dead were buried next day in the common ground beyond the siege works, with the priests of both sides and the city's bells, and the French surgeons worked in the hospital of Saint-Géry beside the convent women for a week, and more than one of them went home carrying a reputation of Vauréal that had nothing to do with its guns.

* * *

The private reunion came at last, late, in the chamber the aldermen had made ready in the cloth hall's upper floor, a room of stored bales with a bed made up in clean linen and a fire and a tub of hot water, and a guard at the stair foot with orders to kill any messenger short of a second invasion.

He shut the door, and the discipline of the day broke all at once, and he crossed the room and put his arms around her with a care that was almost comical, as though she were made of the new gunpowder, and she let him, and then she pulled his head down and kissed him with none of the morning's public restraint, and for a while there

were no words at all, only the two of them holding on in the firelight like people come up from deep water.

"I read the letter eleven times." His voice was rough. "The march was the easiest part. I had something to do with the fear."

"I wrote it eleven times. The version I sent was the least alarming." She drew back enough to see him. "Thiébaut. The green case. I want to say this while I can say it plainly, before the rest of the war and the child and everything. I have been revising, as I promised. I am not finished, and I don't know that I ever will be. But I know what to do with the anger now. I keep it for the people who built the machine. I don't spend it on the boy who paid its price."

He closed his eyes. "That may be the nearest thing to absolution I will ever deserve."

"It isn't absolution. It's an audit. I've looked at the books and decided where the debts actually lie." The ghost of her own smile. "Also you are strictly forbidden from being noble about this. We have a government to run and a child to produce and a war to finish, and I require you in working order."

"Yes, madame."

"And one more thing. When this child is born, we are going to raise it differently. No wardships

of convenience. No secrets kept for its own good. If there is a hard truth, it gets the truth, at an age when it can bear it, from us. I will not have another generation of this family built on locked rooms."

"On my oath." He kissed her forehead, the only place he seemed to trust himself to kiss. "Now, by your leave, I am going to sit in that tub and then fall asleep in that bed, and you are going to do the same, because the duchess who runs the world is currently swaying on her feet."

They slept twelve hours, fully at first across the coverlet and then, when the fire woke him in the small hours, properly under the linen, with his arm carefully arranged around the shape of the child, and outside the door the sentries paced their watch and the ruined city breathed and the first peacetime quiet in seven weeks settled over Sainterre like snow.

* * *

In the morning the work found them again, as work always does. Coppens came with the aldermen and the relief accounts. Brive came with the French prisoners and the question of exchanges. Dolfin's factor came with the terms of the emergency loan and a face of careful optimism, because Venetians can smell a victory before it is paid for. And the news sheet went out with the casualty lists and the charter text and the names,

all the names, and the story rode every road: the city had held, the duchess had stayed, the alliance had broken the greatest siege the French crown could buy.

Jeanne sat at the cloth hall table with her hand on the growing ledger of the state and watched the morning sun come through the high glass windows onto the smoke-stained walls, and she thought: this is what survival costs, and it is worth every line of the invoice. Then she opened the next dispatch, because there was no other way to be a duchess, and went back to work.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Price of Crowns

A siege that fails is a ruin; a siege that succeeds is also a ruin, with better morale. Jeanne learned this in the first week after the relief, walking the streets of the city she had saved and finding that saving was the beginning rather than the end of the work.

The eastern quarter was a wasteland of shot-blasted houses where families lived in cellars under open sky. The tanners' ward had burned and still smelled of it. The canal was choked with the refuse of seven weeks and the bodies of the French horses, and the fishing boats would not put out until it was cleared. The mills had been hit twice, the guildhall's stained glass was gone, and the famous looms, the reason the city existed, had survived only because the guildsmen had taken them apart and hidden the frames in the crypts, an act of civic foresight Coppens considered the equal of any valor on the walls.

The people were thin, and the children were thinner, and the flux still ran in the lower town though the worst of it was over. What the city did not have, to its own astonishment, was the thing every besieged city in Europe expected: the famine price. The rationing books had survived the

bombardment, and the fixed prices with them, and the grain that came in on the first boats was sold at the same rate as the last grain before the investment, with the difference charged to the ducal war account. Dolfin's factor, watching the boats unload, said it was the most expensive piece of benevolence he had seen north of Venice, and Jeanne said benevolence was a word for people who had never had to govern a bread riot, and the price was an investment in the next tax vote.

She was right, and the tax vote proved it within the month.

* * *

Dolfin came himself in July, when the roads were hard, and they did the new business in the cloth hall's upper chamber with the windows open onto the sound of rebuilding, because the treasury office at Aubecourt felt too far from the invoices. The Venetian had aged in the year, or rather the war had caught up with him the way it caught everyone, and he came to the point with even less ceremony than usual.

"The victory has a number, madame. Your total debt to my house and its partners now stands at ninety-four thousand écus, against customs and iron revenues pledged for six years. The relief campaign added the Landsknechts, the sledge guns, the emergency grain, and the city relief.

Paris, by contrast, has spent perhaps a hundred and forty thousand on a war that produced one captured bridge-fort and a dead captain, and the Regent's new loan is being refused in three cities. You are winning the borrowing war. You are also, in absolute terms, running out of room."

"Then give me the rest of the arithmetic."

"The next campaign, the one that takes Mont d'Or and ends the war, will cost forty thousand. My house will lend it, because the collateral has performed and because a duchy that breaks Paris's credit is the safest loan in Europe. But the partners want two things. First, the Sainterre customs become a direct six-year annuity, administered by the joint board, not merely pledged. Second, the war taxes the cities vote under their charters are written into the loan covenants, so that the repayment does not depend on a future council's humor." He folded his hands. "I dislike saying the second part aloud. It is the price of the first."

Jeanne looked at the river traffic below the window, the long barges of the reopened trade. "An annuity on the customs makes your house a part of my government. The tax covenants make the cities' votes into paper your partners hold. You understand what you're asking me to mortgage."

"I understand better than you think. I am also the man who has watched you turn two restive

cities into the strongest government in the marches by giving them charters and asking them to pay for their own freedom. Build the covenants that way. Let the cities vote the taxes themselves, openly, in their guildhalls, and then pledge the voted taxes. My partners get their security. Your aldermen get the dignity. Venice is famously indifferent to dignity, which makes it cheap for us and valuable for them."

It was the old Dolfin, the banker who understood that politics and ledgers were the same book. She thought it through the way she thought through a charter, clause by clause, and found the shape of it sound.

"One alteration. The annuity has a redemption clause at par after three years, and the board's Vauréal seat always holds the casting vote. And you will write to your partners in Paris that the duchess's credit is open for the Regent's inspection. I want Madame Anne to know exactly what victory is costing me, and that I can afford it."

The thin smile. "It will give her indigestion. Done."

* * *

The enlarged charter was her own answer to the debt, and it was presented to the Sainterre

guilds in the same cloth hall where de Key had once preached surrender.

The terms were deliberately large. The aldermen's council became a permanent body with its own election law; the city court's jurisdiction widened to include all civil cases below a set sum; the tolls, fixed for six years under the first charter, were now fixed for ten, with any alteration requiring the council's formal consent; the city kept its militia, its two-key powder store, and its press under the licensing law. In exchange, the guilds voted, in full public session with the votes recorded by name, a permanent war tax for the duration plus three years, collected by the city's own officers under the city's own seal, and pledged under the loan covenants Dolfin had described.

The vote was not unanimous. It never is, in free assemblies, and Jeanne would have distrusted it if it had been. The weavers' guild, de Key's old ground, held out longest and voted last, and their new dean, a man who had carried a pike on the wall during the second assault, said the quiet thing aloud: that the old radicalism had ended on the French gallows, and a city that taxed itself was harder to conquer than a city that was merely ordered to pay. The vote carried, and the bells of Sainterre rang for it, and the news sheet printed every name on both sides, which was the most revolutionary thing Verhoeven's press had yet done.

The nobility's rage arrived at the Haut-Tertre in September, in the persons of seven lords and a great deal of inherited self-regard. They came as a deputation, and they were received in the round chamber with full ceremony, and their spokesman, an old baron with a face like a winter apple, said the thing as plainly as it could be said.

"The duchess is making the towns rich in rights while the blood that defends them pays the ancient subsidies. A charter is a grant of crown property, madame. Every toll fixed for ten years is a toll taken from the ducal domain, and every city court is a court taken from the lord's. If this continues, the lords of Vauréal will be tenants of their own aldermen."

She let him finish, and let the silence age, and then she answered him from the high chair with the state's whole voice, because this was a speech the whole dominion would read in the news sheet by the end of the week.

"My lord baron, the lords of Vauréal hold their lands by a charter too, the one my grandfather's sword wrote and my father's clerks engrossed. You call the city grants a loss of domain. I call them an exchange: fixed rights for fixed taxes, self-rule for self-defense. While this court debated in April, the weavers of Sainterre died on my wall holding pikes your levies never arrived to carry. The city voted its own money through a siege while three of your

number were writing careful letters to Paris. I do not give rights away. I buy loyalty, and I buy it cheaper than fire. If the ancient subsidies buy you better government than the new charters buy me, bring me the receipts. Until then, the charters stand, and the lords who do not like them may audit their own contributions to the war."

The deputation withdrew in the order it had come, but noisier. Two of the seven would be careful ever after; the rest would grumble into their manors and pay their installments, because the alternative was the example of Hautperthuis, which now sat in a fortress under attainder with his name being read aloud in every parish. Fear and interest, her father had taught her, are the two levers; she had spent a year discovering that a third existed, which was pride in a government that kept its word.

* * *

The recognition of the women's companies was Jeanne's own ceremony, held in the rebuilt square of the cloth hall on the first dry day of September, and the aldermen argued against it for a week, which told her it was necessary. The crews paraded in their leather jerkins with their pikes and crossbows, four hundred of them, and the dyer's wife who had broken the Frenchman's arm with the candlestick walked at their head carrying the steel cap Jeanne had lent her in the church,

and the duchess, six months rounded and standing on the hall steps with the joined arms standard behind her, gave each company a charter of its own: the Guild of Saint Margaret, with the right to keep arms in its hall, to train on Sundays after church, and to send two of its number to the city council in matters of defense.

"Armed women with a guild charter," Coppens murmured, beside her. "The historians will not know what to do with us."

"The historians are mostly clerics, so they will ignore us. The city will not, which is what matters." She watched the dyer's wife receive her sealed copy with hands that shook only slightly. "A city whose women know how to defend it is a city no one ever takes twice. Write that into the record."

The record got it, and the news sheet got it, and by the next assembly the other two chartered cities were asking, in careful, formal language, whether the privileges of Sainterre might extend to Malemort and Grisay, and she answered by sending them drill masters and a standard form of words, and said nothing at all about the speed with which an emergency custom could become a right.

Rostaing came to her in the same month, on crutches, thin and pale and re-commissioned, with the new captain's patent in his hand and the old arrogance burned out of him and replaced by

something harder and more useful. He knelt in the cloth hall chamber with difficulty and said, "Madame. I am told the entry is marked in full. I want to say, in my own words, that I spent six months as a common man-at-arms and learned what the law costs the people under it. The village of Argnon has a new well with my back pay, if you want to know where the captain's pay went."

"I know. My treasurer told me; you didn't ask for the receipt." She looked at him the way she looked at a repaired gun, testing the seams. "Captain. I'm giving you the light cavalry company in the Mont d'Or siege, under the duke's direct eye. One more judgment without a clerk, and the next commutation will not exist. You may rise."

He rose, and his salute was the most precise thing in the room, and when he had gone Thiébaut said from the window, "You build weapons out of men the same way Van Brock builds them out of iron. I'm not sure whether to be impressed or afraid."

"Both. It's the correct response to a gun foundry."

* * *

The household closed around the pregnancy with the clucking efficiency of women who had survived a great deal and intended to survive this as well. Oriabel took over the lying-in

arrangements from the moment the pregnancy was announced, producing from somewhere a complete inventory of linen and a midwife of ferocious reputation. Lisette ran the intelligence network from a stool beside Jeanne's writing table. Claire de Sombernon, who had lost her own first child in the year before her husband's death, became the pregnancy's particular guardian, grave and funny and entirely without rivalry, and the two women had long conversations about swaddling and sovereignty that the men of the council could not follow and did not attempt.

"Your court is run by women," Brive grumbled one evening, watching a dispatch leave in Lisette's hand while Claire audited the hospital accounts at the other end of the table.

"Your war is won by women, marshal. Keep up." Jeanne shifted against the cushions, the child heavy and active. "The siege taught me what the books only suggested: half of every population has been doing the work of government for centuries without the patents. I'm issuing the patents."

"She'll want the vote next," the old man said to Thiébaut.

"She has the vote. She has all of them. She's the duchess."

It was said as a jest, and the table laughed, and Jeanne laughed with them, and wrote in her own

private book that night that the truest jokes in a court were always the ones delivered as flattery.

* * *

Othon d'Erquelines came in October, in the end, because the arithmetic of the spring had reached even him.

He did not come to submit. He came to bargain, with the imperial letter in one hand and the duchy's need for the eastern roads in the other, and the bargaining was exquisite and interminable and finally settled, as such things always are, over money. The count wanted his homage made cheap and his standing made high. Jeanne, who needed his roads for the Mont d'Or siege and could not afford a second enemy, gave him neither land nor office but a thing more dangerous and more useful: a twenty-one-year monopoly on the toll bridge at Erquelines, the crossing the imperial convoys used, with a fixed annual payment to the ducal treasury and a clause that the monopoly lapsed the instant his homage lapsed.

"You're making him rich," Foulques observed, when the document was sealed.

"I'm renting his loyalty with his own greed. A lord who profits from my roads keeps my roads. When the war ends, we audit the bridge and find reasons to shorten the term. Twenty-one years is a long time in a charter and a short time in the

history of a toll." She set the seal down. "Also note the clause: his toll collectors are my commissioned officers. The monopoly is his. The law remains mine."

The chancellor, thin and careful since the heart seizure but back at his table, made the note, and said, "The orphans' school enrolled its first forty girls this month, madame. The bishop objects to the Latin."

"The bishop may teach the boys. Tell him I will personally examine the girls at Easter and publish the results. Competition in education, Foulques. It works for tolls."

The memorial was held in the cloth hall square on the first anniversary of the relief's eve, because Coppens insisted the city's grief had a calendar and meant to keep it. The four hundred and eleven names were carved into a stone wall the aldermen raised at the square's edge, the soldiers and the civilians together without rank or order, and the families processed past it through the morning, each leaving what the household could spare: a ribbon, a loaf, a candle, a child's drawing.

Jeanne came on foot, six months rounded and in the plain grey gown, and laid her own gift with the rest: a copy of the charter, sealed in bronze, set into the wall's center. Her speech was short, because the widows had already done the speaking in their processions.

"This wall is not a monument to a siege. It is a receipt. The city paid a price for its own government, and the state acknowledges the debt in the only durable currency it has: the names. Every charter this duchy grants from now on will be read within sight of this square's account. Go home, and tell your children the debt is remembered by the duchess as well as the dead."

The news sheet printed the speech beside the list of names, and copies went to Malemort and Grisay and the villages, and the phrase *the duchess's accounts* began to appear in tavern talk with a meaning it had never had in her father's time: not what the ruler took, but what the ruler admitted she owed.

Thiébaut, walking back with her through the crowded, respectful streets, said, "Your father built tombs for dukes. You're building them for weavers."

"The dukes have the cathedral vault. The weavers needed a wall." She shifted her weight, the child heavy. "Also it's policy, if you want the unpoetic truth. A city that sees its butcher's name in stone beside an alderman's is a city that answers the next French herald with pikes. Grief is a fortification. I learned that from a book of names."

"I know. I watched you keep it."

* * *

The Regent's letter arrived with the first frost, carried by a herald of the old, careful school, and its silkiness had a new undertone, which Foulques identified at once as the sound of a treasury in pain. Anne de France wrote as one woman of business to another, deploring the "misunderstandings" of the campaigning season, noting the heavy costs borne by both crowns, and proposing a formal conference at Heurtois under the bishop's neutral roof, with full safe conducts and a view to a general settlement before the new year. There was no mention now of forfeit, garrisons, or the dowry of reconciliation.

"She wants out of the war," Thiébaut said, when the council had heard it. "Not permanently. Cheaply. A peace she can break when her books recover."

"All peaces are that. The question is the terms we write while she needs the ink." Jeanne turned the letter in her hands. "Answer yes, in the warmest language Foulques can compose, with the conference fixed for after the Mont d'Or siege. I will not negotiate with a fortress of mine still in enemy hands; the sight of our guns on the rock will improve every clause. And I want the city charters named in the treaty as recognized customs of the dominion. If Paris signs the charters, no future

French king can champion their enemies inside my walls."

Foulques permitted himself one of his thin smiles. "She will dislike the charters clause."

"She will dislike all of it. She will sign the parts that cost her money and leave the parts that cost her pride. That is the whole art of negotiation with Anne de France: never ask for her pride when her purse is open."

The herald went back with the answer and a gift of Sainterre broadcloth for the Regent's own wearing, and Jeanne turned the council's attention back to the rock in the south, because conferences were for the end of wars and the war still had a fortress to take.

That night, alone with Thiébaut in the chamber where the connecting door now stood permanently open, she let the day's composure go and sat heavily on the bed's edge, five months rounded and feeling every day of it. He knelt without a word and took off her shoes, which was among the things he had learned to do without being asked, and put a stool under her feet.

"The court calls us joint sovereigns now," she said. "I heard an envoy use the phrase this morning, as though it were an old title."

"The court is catching up with the documents. Also with the facts." He sat beside her. "The

vassals hate the charters, the cities love the taxes they vote themselves, Venice owns more of my wife's customs than is strictly comfortable, and the most expensive war in our history is being won on credit. Did I miss anything?"

"Only the part where we have an army in being, a capital no one dares besiege twice, and a traitor in a fortress with his price on his head. The usual season's work." She leaned against him, carefully, because of the child. "Thiébaut. When Mont d'Or falls, Paris will have to talk. I want the peace conference at Heurtois, and I want it before the Regent's treasury recovers. Can the army be ready by the new year?"

"The army can. The question is the snow. A winter siege of a rock like Mont d'Or is a thing old officers tell horror stories about."

"Then find me officers who tell stories about winning them. We have the sledge guns and the gunners and the men who drowned a mine. Winter is the season the French don't expect us, because they have never once expected us." She put her hand over his where it lay on the curve of the child. "Also I would like this baby born in a duchy at peace. That is a maternal sentiment, and I intend to use it shamelessly in council."

He laughed, low, and kissed the top of her head. "Then peace by the lying-in. I'll put it in the

dispatches. The duchess's commands have grown more specific."

Outside, the October rain moved over the river and the darkened town, and somewhere in the chancellery the clerks were still at work on the attainder papers and the loan covenants and the charters and the endless, patient ledgers of a reign that had begun with a corpse in a cart and was becoming, invoice by invoice, a government.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Fortress at Mont d'Or

They came south in the hard December of 1485, and the army that moved down the kingdom road was not the army that had marched the same road in the spring of the year before. The feudal levies had become contracted squadrons; the billmen had pikes and drill; the guns rode on their low carriages in a proper artillery train, and the gunners had a year of practice and the confidence of a city saved. The discipline held in the snow because it had been learned in the snow, in the Harchies, and the men believed in the command because the command had, so far, kept them alive and paid.

Jeanne rode with the column for the first four days, in a fur-lined saddle against the cold, seven months rounded and tired by noon every day, until the doctors and Thiébaut together staged a small, respectful mutiny and put her into a covered wagon on the frozen ruts, where she did the accounts and hated every mile of it. Her orders reached the van by courier, and the army knew she was in the train, and that was the part that mattered.

Mont d'Or rose out of the white hills exactly as she remembered it, the great rock with its walls following the stone, the river road under its guns, the fortress that Valvert had held with sixty-one men and that Gui de Hautperthuis had given away with a handshake. A French garrison of six hundred held it now, under a commander named Chastel, a professional sent by Graçay with enough provisions for the winter and the confidence of a man on top of a mountain. The traitor himself was inside, the reports said, with his household and his gold, having chosen the rock over the open country when the attainder rolled through his manors like a slow, legal tide.

"He thinks we'll sit here until the spring and go home." Thiébaut spread the siege plans in the command tent, the brazier glowing red at its center. "He's read the old books. Armies don't take rocks in January. Therefore we take it in January, because that is precisely what he has not paid for."

The investment went in over three brutal days. The camps went up on the four approaches, the circumvallation trench was cut through the frozen ground with picks and hot water, the river road was closed by a fortified bridge of barrels and earth, and the guns, the four big bombards and the sledge pieces and the new long culverins, were emplaced in battery positions looking up at the walls. The cold was the true enemy of the first week. The sentries rotated by the half hour, the

horses were blanketed and walked through the nights, the powder casks sat in warmed tents with a guard who did nothing but watch for sparks, and the hospital tents had their own braziers and the convent women's knowledge of frozen limbs.

Jeanne established herself in the commandeered manor house at the camp's center, within earshot of the guns, and ran the civilian side of the siege from there: the supply convoys up the frozen road, the mail, the money, the relations with the countryside that made the convoys possible. The village mayors of the region, who had spent the year watching which army kept its word, brought grain and timber at fixed prices and went home alive with receipts, and the French on the rock watched the convoys arrive and understood that the besiegers were not going to starve first.

* * *

The countryside decided the siege almost as much as the guns. In the old wars the local people had fled from both armies and sold to neither; in this one, after a year of proclamations kept and receipts honored, they came to the camp instead. The mayors of the river villages met the commissary officers at the crossroads with grain and hay and the great ox teams needed for the guns, and the market that grew behind the siege lines had its own charter of prices, nailed to an oak and enforced by the provosts. A farmer who

brought a load in December got the same silver as in June, and the story traveled, and the convoys went through where the French foragers found empty barns and closed doors.

Jeanne had the market visited every week by her own clerk, and she sat once, in her furs on an upturned cask, while a village elder explained the logic of it. "The French take, madame. They have the king's name and the king's manners, and both mean empty cellars. Your duke's men pay, and your provosts hang the ones who don't. A peasant can do arithmetic too. We're tired of being the arithmetic that loses."

"Then make sure your sons remember who kept his receipts. The peace will need remembering."

She had the exchange printed, of course, in Verhoeven's sheet, with the elder's name and village, and Dolfin's factor wrote to Venice that the duchy's army was being supplied by public opinion, a thing he had not previously classified as a military resource.

The camp itself became a winter town, the same disciplined rows as the Harchies march but larger: the artillery park with its guards, the hospital tents where the convent women treated the frozen and the wounded, the chapel tent with its two services a day, the sutlers' street where the soldiers spent their pay and the news sheet was read aloud by the literate to anyone who would buy the reader a cup.

At night, from the rock, the French garrison looked down on five thousand fires and a city in the snow that was better supplied than their own fortress, and the deserters began to come over the walls on ropes, one or two a night, with their accounts of the dwindling stores and the quarrels between Chastel and Hautperthuis.

* * *

The gunnery duel opened on the eighth day, and it gave the new army its first lesson in what a rock could do.

Mont d'Or's walls had been built by her grandfather's engineers and improved since, and the French had added earth and timber behind the stone in the modern fashion, so that the shot that broke the outer face buried itself in packed earth instead of opening a breach. The fortress's own guns, mounted high, looked down into the siege works and made the battery crews pay for every round: a culverin on the keep tower enfiladed the main trench, and three gunners died there in the first morning, and a dozen men were wounded.

Hautemer, the Lorraine master gunner, commanded the batteries, and he came to the manor at dusk with a face of stone and the casualty list and a problem that the old war could not solve. "The keep gun has the angle of us, madame. I can silence the wall pieces, but not that

one, not from the lower battery. We need a battery on the west spur, the high ground. It's a fortnight's trenching in the rock, or we don't take the place cheaply."

"Then we trench the spur, and we move the two sledge guns up there first, because they can be hauled where the bombards cannot." She had the map; she had studied every spur and watercourse of this rock in the months of planning. "And answer the keep gun with a counter-battery of the culverins at the angle where the tower's embrasure narrics its arc. Van Brock worked it out on paper in November. The gunners can see it; I'll send the drawing tonight."

The west spur became the siege's slow, grinding heart: a sap pushed forward through rock and frost, a yard a day, then two, the working parties protected by gabions and the covering fire of the archers, the guns dragged up behind them on platforms that had to be rebuilt every night against the cold. Jeanne went up to the spur as often as the doctors allowed, muffled in furs with her own guards around her, because the gunners worked differently when the duchess had stood in their trench, and she had learned the value of being seen.

It was on the spur, in the third week, that the shell came in.

The French gunner on the keep had found the range of the working platform at last, and a stone shot struck the gabion at the trench's head and went through it and through the platform beyond, and Hautemer, standing where Jeanne had stood an hour before, took the splinter of the platform timber through the chest and died before the stretcher-bearers could get him off the rock. The battery, with its captain dead and its sergeant's arm broken in the same strike, wavered in the full view of the fortress, and the French watch raised a cheer from the wall.

She came up the spur herself, through the working parties, eight months heavy and slow on the frozen ground, with the gunners staring and her guard begging her to keep below the parapet, and she took command of the battery the way she had taken command of everything: with the book.

"Van Brock's tables. Who has them?" A shaken young gunner produced the sheaf. "Then we follow them. You, the elevation, quadrant level with the embrasure lip. You, the charge, the measure and no more, because Hautemer trained you and I have seen your drill. The keep gun fires every nine minutes; time it. We fire between its shots, and we fire at the embrasure, not the tower. A gun that cannot show its muzzle is a gun that does not exist. Sergeant, the working party continues the sap, because the only answer to a death in the trench is the trench moving forward. Is that understood?"

It was. The battery went back to work under her direction, the gunners finding their nerve in the numbers, and by the end of the afternoon the keep gun's embrasure had taken three direct hits and its firing slowed to a trickle, and the sap had gained another yard and a half. When she came down the spur at dusk, frozen to the bone, the whole working line knew the story by the time she reached the bottom, and the story did the army's morale more good than a week of pay.

Thiébaut met her at the manor door with a face she had not seen since the church at Sainterre, and said, through his teeth, "If you ever climb a battery under fire again while you are carrying my child, I will have you carried off it by the guard, in front of the army, and take whatever the story costs me."

"You would not dare."

"I would dare precisely that, and you know it, which is why you came back down." He helped her out of the furs with hands that were not quite steady. "Jeanne. The gunners can do the work. You cannot replace yourself. Neither can I."

"Hautemer is dead. Someone had to hold the battery."

"The gunners would have held it. They're trained."

"Then I made sure of it." She put her cold hand to his face. "I am not being brave. I am being the duchess. There is a difference, and you taught it to me. Now tell me the trenching reports, because the child has decided to use my bladder as a pillow and I have perhaps an hour of useful work left tonight."

* * *

The fifth column made its last throw on a dark night in the first week of January, in the command tent itself.

The man was a groom, taken into the headquarters horse lines at the musters, a quiet worker with good references from a lord's stable that no one had troubled to trace because grooms were beneath the level of treason. His name was Colas, and the French had bought him at the autumn fair, with thirty écus and a promise of more, and his work was the duke's two best horses and therefore his routine: the saddling hour, the picket line, the evening water. The poison, a white powder the French called *poudre de succession*, went into Thiébaut's evening wine cup on the night before the planned assault, and it would have gone unseen if Perrin had not been fourteen and in love with the whole idea of being a squire.

The boy had made it his business to know every man who came near the headquarters tents, the

way other boys knew horses or saints, and he had noticed that Colas the groom had no friends among the other grooms, that he went out alone after dark, and that his hands were too clean for stable work. On the night in question he followed him, watched the cup go down on the trestle and the groom linger by it with his back turned, and then did the thing that makes fourteen-year-old squires into legends or corpses: he picked up the cup, smelled the bitter almond no wine should have, and knocked it out of his master's hand in front of the duty guard, spilling the wine across the maps.

They had Colas within the hour, and under the provost's questioning he gave up the whole small thread: the fair, the écus, the contact in Hautperthuis's old service, the instructions to wait for a night when the duke's tent was busy and the cup unguarded. The contact, when they took him in the camp followers' quarter, had papers that named the chain back to the fortress itself, to Hautperthuis's steward, who had fled inside Mont d'Or with his master. The fifth column, the long network Lisette had mapped and the attainder had broken, had spent its last coin on a groom.

Thiébaut had the man tried by the army court and hanged at dawn in the horse lines, where every groom in the camp could see, and he made a point of standing beside Perrin at the execution with his hand on the boy's shoulder. Afterwards he said, "You're a squire no longer. As of this morning

you're a man-at-arms, with the pay, and you'll take the spurs when this is over. And in the meantime, you sleep outside my door, where I can keep an eye on the only competent groom in the army."

Perrin, white and trying not to be sick from the hanging, managed the salute. Jeanne, who had watched from the manor doorway, said later that the boy's face was the face of every person in the war: frightened, promoted beyond expectation, and determined to be equal to it.

* * *

The mine was ready on the fourteenth of January.

The engineers had run two galleries under the southwest angle of the fortress, the miners working in relays through the frozen ground with the same patient silence as the men of Sainterre, and the chambers were charged with every pound of powder the train could spare, because a rock that had cost this much could not be allowed to survive a weak blow. The assault force, twelve hundred picked men under Jean's command with Rostaing's light cavalry dismounted in the van, waited in the forward trench through the dark morning, and the guns held their fire to keep the noise of the mine unexpected.

Thiébaut led from the second wave, because no order could keep him behind, and Jeanne watched

from the west spur battery with the gunners and her own guard, heavy and breathless in the cold, her hand on the parapet.

At the first light the mine went up.

It did not sound like the guns. It sounded like the mountain itself being torn open, a deep, prolonged roar that came up through the soles of the boots, and the southwest angle of Mont d'Or lifted and folded and came down in a cataract of stone and earth and the men who had been standing on it. The dust hung over the rock like a grey curtain, and through the curtain the assault went in at the run, and the drums and the trumpets opened all at once, and the siege of six weeks became the battle of an hour.

The breach was worse ground than it looked, a chaos of shattered masonry with the French behind the inner retrenchment they had built against this exact possibility, and the first wave took it with pikes and grenades and the brute courage of men who had watched their friends die in the trenches. Jean went down in the first ten minutes with a stone blow to the helmet that cracked it and knocked him senseless, and Rostaing took over the van and carried the retrenchment at the second rush, and then the fighting was inside the walls, in the narrow lanes of the fortress, the old work of door and stair and courtyard.

Thiébaut's wave came through the breach as the sun cleared the hills, and he was in the lane below the keep when the French counterattack came down it, and that was where the shoulder went. A man-at-arms with a two-handed sword caught him at the edge of the press, and the blade came down on the left shoulder where the old Sarrebourg wound lived in the bone, and the harness held but the bone did not, and he went to one knee in the snow with the world going white, and killed the man anyway with his right hand and a dagger, and refused the stretcher until the keep gate was taken, because he had seen what happened to assaults when the commander left the ground.

From the spur, Jeanne saw the banner check in the lane and then go forward again, and she did not know whose blood was on it, and the next quarter hour was the longest of her life, and she spent it doing the only useful thing available to her: running the guns. The battery fired over the breach at the keep's upper works to keep the walls clear, round after round on the tables, the gunners loading and firing in the rhythm she had learned on the practice field, and when the joined arms standard finally went up over the keep gate, she sat down on a powder cask in the snow and discovered that her legs had stopped working, and Lisette and Sister Margriet, who had come up with the army against every rule, put her into the

wagon with hot bricks at her feet and a great deal of unsentimental scolding.

* * *

They found Gui de Hautperthuis in the donjon's high chamber, under his ancestors' portraits, with his gold and his remaining letters and a cup he had not drunk from. He was alone; his French garrison had surrendered in the courtyard below, and Chastel the commandant had given up his sword in proper form, and the man who had been the richest lord in the dominion stood against the wall of his last room in a furred gown with the court smile still on his face, though it had slipped at the edges.

Thiébaut had him brought down to the manor at dusk, under guard, and Jeanne received him in the commandeered hall with the fire lit and the attainder papers on the table between them, and she did not rise.

"Cousin." The smile made one more attempt. "I see you are with child. The family continues, at least. Will you not sit with your own blood at the end of it?"

"My own blood is why I am standing, Gui. The man who dandled me on his knee sold the fortress that was supposed to protect my people, and his price was sixty cutthroats and a French pension. Valvert died at his gate. The villages of his

marches burned. The letters in this room connect your steward to a poisoner in my husband's tent. We are past the part where blood is a courtesy."

"The law—"

"The law is in these papers, and it is going to take its course in open court, before your peers, with every witness and every lease. You wanted to be the regent. Instead you will be the example, which I think is the office you were always fitted for." She looked at him fully, the charm and the grey beard and the eyes that had calculated every room they entered. "You are held for trial at the Haut-Tertre. Your life belongs to the court. Your name belongs to the record. Take him away."

Chastel the commandant was brought in separately, under his parole, and the difference between the two prisoners was the difference between war and treason, and she meant the whole rock to see it. Chastel kept his sword, his purse, and his officers' table; his ransom would be set at the customary rate and his wounded treated by her surgeons. She received him standing, and said so to his face, and added that the defense of Mont d'Or had been correctly conducted and would be reported as such in the exchange papers. He bowed with the genuine surprise of a professional who had expected the treatment given to free companies, and the French officers with him took note, because officers always took note.

They found Valvert's grave behind the gatehouse chapel, a hasty mound with a wooden cross the French had permitted out of some residual chivalry, and Jeanne had the body disinterred in the thaw and sent home to Aubecourt with an escort of honor, and she ordered the gate of Mont d'Or rebuilt with a stone over the arch naming the captain who had held it with sixty-one men and died at its gate under a flag he had not opened. The garrison that took over the fortress paraded past the new stone on the day it was unveiled, and the old marshal said the dead man's name aloud in front of them, and the name became another of the duchy's small, durable currencies.

* * *

Thiébaut's shoulder kept him in the manor for a fortnight, in a sling and in the ferocious bad temper of an active man forbidden his horse, and the court of the siege camp rearranged itself around his convalescence. Jean, his own head wrapped against the concussion, came each evening to play cards and lose loudly, and Perrin, the boy who had saved the wine, was attached to the sickroom as a kind of honor guard, and took the duty with the solemnity of a bishop.

"The bone's set crookedly," Sister Margriet told Jeanne, in the flat way she delivered all medical news. "He'll keep the arm. He'll lose some of the

lift and all of the sword in that hand for a year, perhaps forever. A man who fights left-handed will need a new teacher."

"He's been fighting left-handed since Sarrebourg. He just pretended otherwise." She watched him through the doorway, arguing with Jean over a hand of cards with his good hand and his face set against the pain. "Sister, between us. The shoulder or the child. Which of us did you dread more in the snow?"

"You, madame. The duke obeys orders. You rewrite them." The nun permitted herself a small, dry smile and went off to bully the surgeons.

That night he admitted, to the ceiling rather than to her, the thing the soldiers' code would not let him say by day. "I'm forty years old, and I have been wounded in the same place twice for the same patch of ground, and the second time my wife was on a battery under fire with my child inside her. Somewhere in the accounting there's a lesson, and I don't like its shape."

"The lesson is that the ground is ours now. That's the shape. Stop reading ledgers over my shoulder; it's my trade." She put her hand on the good arm. "When this heals, Van Brock wants you for the new cavalry drill. The gunners have ideas about men who can't raise a lance."

"I'm to be an experiment."

"You're to be alive. The experiments come after."

When the doors had closed, Thiébaut, his arm in a sling and his face grey with the pain the surgeons were managing badly, came and stood beside her at the fire. "Jean's alive. Concussion, nothing more. The shoulder's broken again, worse than before; they say I'll keep the arm and lose some of its motion, which is a bargain. The fortress is ours, the road is open, and Paris has just lost its last door into your country. Madame la duchesse, the war is over except for the paperwork."

"Paperwork is the part I'm best at." She leaned against him carefully, on the good side. "We have the peace conference, and the trial, and the baby, in roughly that order."

"Roughly in that order. Jeanne," he stopped, and said the rest to the fire, "when the banner checked in the lane, and you couldn't see, I want you to know I had every confidence in the gunners."

"The gunners had every confidence in the tables. I merely held them." She closed her eyes. "Take me to bed, my lord. The rock has fallen and I am extremely tired, and the paperwork can begin at dawn."

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The King's Peace

The Prince-Bishop of Heurtois received them in a palace built for the precise purpose of looking neutral, and it was in that high, draughty, magnificently impartial building that the war was finally reduced to paper.

The conference opened on the second Monday of February, in the great hall of the bishop's residence, with the French delegation at one long table and the Vauréal-Lorraine delegation at the other, and the bishop's own clerics between them like referees at a duel. Graçay himself led for Paris, which told Jeanne everything about the Regent's mood: a royal lieutenant did not sit at peace tables while his master's cause was thought to be winning. Across the polished oak he looked older than the man of the Roches-Noires, a professional soldier who had spent two years discovering that professional soldiers cannot win against ledgers, and the two of them exchanged the bows of opponents who had come to respect each other's arithmetic.

Von Zollern was there as the Emperor's observer, perfumed and watchful, and the Burgundian Netherland envoys had come uninvited on the theory that other people's peace

treaties were their business, and Dolfin sat at the far end with his clerk, because every war in Europe ended somewhere within walking distance of a Venetian banker.

Thiébaut sat beside her with his left arm in a silk sling, the shoulder healing stiff and slow, and the sight of the sling across the table did the alliance's work before a word was spoken. Foulques, thin and careful since the seizure, carried the documents, and the Abbé de Viray carried the theology, and Brive, who hated conferences, had been brought for the single purpose of looking like a man who would happily resume the war.

Graçay opened with the crown's formal position, delivered in a voice made for parlements: the forfeit fiefs were ancient crown holdings, the war had been a regrettable policing action, and the Regent's natural tenderness toward her sex wished to settle all differences on terms that preserved the honor of France. The terms, as read, were the old terms: the fiefs under French protection, a garrison, a marriage portion, the usual language of conquest dressed in the vocabulary of reconciliation.

Jeanne let him finish, and then she put her own first document on the table, the casualty and expenditure returns of both sides, carefully

compiled, including the figures Dolfin's friends had supplied from Paris.

"Sire de Graçay. We will begin with the truth, since the bishop's hall is consecrated and the figures are sacred to me. The crown's army has taken one fortress by purchase and lost it by assault. It has fought one successful battle in two years, and failed to hold a single one of the cities it was sent to reduce. Its pay is nine months in arrears. Its last loan was undersubscribed in three cities. My customs revenues exceed their pre-war level, my cities are armed under sealed charters, and my credit is offered at eleven percent while the Regent's is refused at eighteen. You have come here because Paris cannot afford another campaign. I have come here because I prefer not to pay for one. Let us write the peace that follows from those facts, and leave honor to the heralds."

The room was quiet. Graçay looked at her for a long moment, and then, with the faintest inclination of his head, he set the crown's first paper aside and nodded to his clerks, and the real conference began.

* * *

It ran nine days, and the work was the old work of every peace: turning positions into numbers and numbers into clauses.

The southern fiefs were the hardest. Paris could not withdraw entirely without confessing the forfeit void; Jeanne could not accept a French garrison on her roads without making the whole war pointless. The compromise, when it emerged from three nights of Foulques's drafting, was the homage. The three fiefs were acknowledged as ancient holdings of the Vauréal house, but their duke or duchess would do homage for them to the French crown in the old form, once, at the king's court, at a time of peace. No garrison, no governor, no French officer within their borders; the homage was personal, feudal, and largely ceremonial, but it gave Paris the sentence it could take home: the crown's suzerainty recognized. In exchange, the forfeit declaration was annulled and struck from the rolls, and every French claim on the northern towns and the chartered cities was withdrawn in perpetuity.

"The homage will cost you with the imperial party," Viray warned her, in the private room they used for the alliance's own quarrels. "Von Zollern will write to Vienna that you've bent the knee."

"Von Zollern can write whatever he likes; the Emperor has never sent a single gun. An homage performed in peacetime at the king's court costs me a journey and a speech. A garrison costs me a road. I know the price of both." She turned the draft. "Also note the next clause. The crown recognizes the city charters as the settled and

ancient customs of the dominion. Paris signs that, and no future French agent can walk into Sainterre as the champion of the city's liberties against its duchess. I'm buying the cities with a bow."

The marriage portion became a cash payment, euphemized as a dowry of reconciliation: twenty-five thousand écus, paid in three installments, against the return of all prisoners of rank without further ransom and the crown's formal release of its claims on the captured ordnance. It was the part she hated, the gold that would go to the treasury that had burned Sainte-Florence, and she said so, and Dolfin, who had drifted into the room like a well-dressed shadow, said, "Madame, every peace includes an indemnity paid by the winner. It is the price of making the loser able to sign. Think of it as the final installment of the loan. It is certainly cheaper than another siege."

The prisoner exchange took a day, the trade clauses two, and the eternal question of the river tolls an entire evening, and on the ninth day the Treaty of Heurtois was engrossed in fair copies, sealed with the arms of France, Vauréal, Lorraine, and the bishopric, and signed at a table that had been worn smooth by centuries of other people's wars. Graçay signed with a steady hand, and when the clerks had sanded the ink he said, low enough that only she and Thiébaut heard, "Madame, I

served the late duke your father in the field once, and I thought him the most difficult man in Christendom. He would be proud of you, and Paris would not have believed that was meant as a compliment."

"I will take it as one, and put it in the book of the unusual."

Von Zollern, in his final audience, made one last attempt at the imperial marriage, vaguely, in the language of future understandings, and she answered him in the same language, with the same smiles, and sent him back to Vienna with a gift of Sainterre broadcloth and no commitments at all. The Empire, she had learned, was best managed by being treated as a letter that never required a decisive answer.

* * *

The other trial waited for her at home, and it was the harder of the two.

Hautperthuis was brought to the Haut-Tertre in the third week of February, under a strong guard, in a closed wagon with his name on the warrant, and the great hall was made ready for the court of peers that the law of the dominion required for a lord of his blood. Every vassal of standing was summoned; the bishops and the aldermen and the officers of the cities sat behind the lords, because Jeanne had ordained that the trial would be open

and its record printed, and the whole dominion would be able to read the evidence against one of its own great names.

He played his part well, in his furred gown and his grey beard, the warm smile held in place like armor. He denied nothing that the documents proved and admitted nothing that they did not. The court heard the lease records of the planted tenants, the fair-day meetings with the French factor, the steward's accounts with the Paris paymaster, the correspondence from the captured fortress, and the chain of the poison plot, from the groom Colas to the steward in his service. Lisette's map, enlarged and fair-copied, hung on the wall of the hall, the spider's web with his name at its center. His counsel argued necessity, the duchess's marriage to a foreigner, the ancient right of lords to choose their side in a disputed succession; and the court heard it, because she had insisted every argument be heard at length, so that no man could later say the great lord had been rushed.

She spoke last, from the high chair, in the voice of the council chamber, and the hall was so full that the silence had a weight.

"Gui de Hautperthuis. You were of my blood and my council, and your lands were the shield of my southern road. The court has found the facts, and the facts are not in dispute: you took a foreign

pension, you planted foreign soldiers on my marches, you delivered my fortress by the murder of its captain, and your steward's hand reached into my husband's cup. The law calls this high treason, and the law's sentence is the extinguishing of the bloodline and the forfeiture of the name. In mercy, and because I will not have the children of your house judged for the father, I am striking the attainder's clause against the blood. Your children keep their lives and such property as was your wife's. The name of Hautperthuis as a lordship ends with you. The lands return to the crown, and the tenants keep their holdings and their rights, because they were never the traitors."

She paused, and made herself say the rest, the part she had rehearsed alone in the chamber until the words stopped shaking.

"For your person, the sentence is death, by the axe, as befits your rank, in the courtyard of this palace, at dawn on the day after tomorrow. I will not pretend that this is not a grief. You dandled me as a child. You ate my father's bread. That is why the law must be seen to reach even the people who have memories. Take him away."

The court rose in silence, and he went out between the guards with the smile finally gone and his real face visible at last, frightened and old, and Jeanne sat a moment longer in the high chair with

her hands folded over the child heavy inside her, and then she rose and walked out through the watching hall with the duchess's pace, and did not let herself stop until she was in the privacy of the solar, where she was sick into a basin for the first and only time of her pregnancy.

* * *

She went down to the garderobe tower the night before the execution, because she had learned in the Rostaing business that a ruler who cannot look at the people she condemns will eventually condemn people she cannot look at. Foulques tried to dissuade her; Thiébaut did not, and came with her as far as the cell door, where he posted himself with his back to the wall.

The cell was dry and clean, which was itself a statement, and Hautperthuis sat at its table with a lamp and a cup and the calm of a man who has finished negotiating. He rose when she came in, and bowed, and waited for her to sit before he sat again, the old habits of the court surviving everything else.

"You shouldn't have come, cousin. It will cost you sleep."

"I have a budget for sleeplessness. I came because the trial was for the record and this is for us. Tell me one true thing, without the smile. Why? You had the richest lordship in the dominion. The

road repairs, the leases, the office I refused you — none of it explains the gates of Mont d'Or."

He was quiet a while, turning the cup in his hands. "Because I could not be ruled by a girl and a foreign duke, and I was too old to learn. My whole life, the world had a shape: the great houses, the blood, the council of men who owned the land. In one year you took it apart with charters and bankers and printed sheets and women's guilds, and every time I looked, there was less room in it for men like me. Paris offered me the old world back. I believed the French would win because I wanted the French to win, and wanting is the poor man's intelligence." He looked up. "There. The true thing. Does it help?"

"It helps me understand the sentence isn't only about you."

"It never is. That's why they make a show of it." A pause. "The children, Jeanne. My boys."

"Are mine now, by the court's order and my own. They'll be educated with the orphans' school, under my eye, and they'll enter adult life with their mother's property and no father's name to carry. I will not make the son pay the father's invoice. It's the one part of my father's practice I've deliberately unlearned."

Something cracked in the polished face, and he looked away at the wall. "Then you're a greater ruler than he was."

"I'm a different one. Whether greater is for the ledgers to decide." She rose. "I won't come again. Make your confession properly; I've asked the bishop to send a man worth talking to. Goodbye, Gui."

"Goodbye, little duchess." He said it without mockery, almost gently. "You were always the one in that family who could count."

Outside the cell, Thiébaut fell into step beside her in the torchlit corridor, and said nothing, and after a while she said, to the wall ahead, "He wanted the old world back. That's the treason. Not the gold. The nostalgia."

"Most treasons are. Gold is just the costume." He offered his good arm, and she took it, and they climbed the tower stairs together into the cold upper air.

* * *

She had decided to be present in the same way she decided every hard thing: by writing the decision down the night before, so that the morning could not argue with it. The warrant lay on the table with the rest of the state papers, and underneath it, in the private hand, the single line:

A ruler who cannot watch the sentence cannot sign it. I will watch.

The courtyard was black with people before dawn, the lower town and the court and the soldiers of the guard in their ordered ranks, and the scaffold stood against the wall of the chapel where her father lay, black-draped and plain, with the block and the sawdust and the great two-handed sword of the headsman, because she had refused the axe's clumsiness and paid for the executioner of Nancy, a man famous for one stroke. Thiébaut wanted her to watch from the hall window; she refused, and came down into the courtyard in a dark gown and a thick veil, and stood at the front of the dais with Brive on one side and Foulques on the other, and the child moving inside her like a second heartbeat.

Gui came out at the first bell, in a dark velvet gown, his hands bound before him with a silken cord, the privilege of his blood. He had made his confession and heard Mass, and he walked the scaffold with the careful dignity of a man performing the last scene of a long career. At the top he turned to the court and the crowd, and his eyes found the veiled figure on the dais, and he said, in a voice that carried, "Madame, I was wrong, and I have written it. The children are not to blame."

It was the best thing he had ever done, and she inclined her head once, under the veil, so that he could see he had been heard. Then he knelt, and put his head on the block, and the Nancy executioner did his work in the single stroke for which he was paid, and the sound went through the courtyard like a door closing, and the crowd, which had expected a longer noise, let out its breath all at once.

She did not look away. She had promised herself she would not, and she kept the promise the way she kept all promises, as a matter of bookkeeping. The body was taken for burial in the church of a distant convent, without the lord's tomb, and the head was placed over the southern gate for the statutory month and then, at her private order, taken down and buried with it, because she had no use for a skull and the children did not deserve one.

In the chamber afterwards, with the doors shut and the guard outside, the composure held for exactly as long as it took her to reach the chair, and then she wept, hard and without dignity, for the man who had dandled her, for the boy Philippe and the girl at Sainte-Florence and all the names in the books, for the child who would be born into a country that required its mother to sign such warrants, and for the girl she had been, who had once believed that being a duchess was mostly a matter of Latin and ledgers.

Thiébaut came in without knocking, because the rule about knocking had died somewhere in the siege, and he said nothing at all, which was correct, and sat in the chair beside her and put his good arm around her and let the crying run its course. When it was over and she had blown her nose on the state handkerchief, he said, "The people will say you were merciful."

"The people will be wrong. I was precise. Mercy would have been a man who didn't make the choice." She dried her cheeks. "His children, Thiébaut. I want them brought up at court, under my eye and my charge, the boys educated with the orphans' school and the girls with the others. The blood survives. Only the treason is buried."

"An expensive mercy."

"Everything I do is expensive. Ask Dolfin." She looked at the sealed window, beyond which the courtyard was being scrubbed. "He said he had written it. Find the letter. I want to read what a traitor writes when the block is in the room."

The letter came that evening, in the bishop's keeping, and it was short and not what she expected. It did not beg. It gave the names of the last French contacts in the dominion, three of them unknown even to Lisette's map, and it ended with a paragraph in a hand less steady than the rest: that he had been wrong about her from the first, that he had believed a woman and a foreign

marriage meant a duchy for the taking, and that the country she was making was one he could no longer read, which was perhaps why he had chosen the one he knew. She read it twice, and put it in the private archive with Foulques's sealed confession and the green case's documents, the growing library of the locked rooms she had chosen to open.

* * *

The ratifications came in through the spring. Paris sealed first, because Paris needed the peace more than it needed the grievance; the Emperor's court sent a chilly note that recognized nothing and ignored everything; the cities held bonfires when the charter clause of the treaty was read aloud at the market crosses, and Sainterre rang its bells for a day. The disbandment began, the careful paying off of the contracted regiments, the Landsknechts marching east with their pockets full and their reputations enhanced, the feudal lords going home to their manors with new stories and old grievances.

Foulques, in the chancellery, began the long work of codifying the emergency customs into ordinary law: the charter forms, the city courts, the women's guild, the book of the dead, the printed news sheet that was now simply a part of how the dominion governed itself. The law, he said to her once, was the memory of the state, and the

state had learned a great many things in two years that it must not now forget.

Bride took the army's reductions with the grumbling of an old soldier and the private relief of a man who had survived his third war, and Rostaing, reinstated and quieted, was given the southern command at Mont d'Or, the fortress that had made and unmade him, and went to it with a garrison and a clerk and no expression at all when the warrant was read.

The peace was proclaimed at Aubecourt on a bright March morning, from the steps of the cathedral, and Jeanne made sure the ceremony answered the trials and the executions with something better than silence. The treaty was read aloud in the vernacular, all of it, the homage clause and the charter clauses and the names of the restored towns, while the town and the court and the companies stood in the square, and when the heralds cried the final words the bells began and did not stop for an hour.

She had the proclamation printed as well, in Verhoeven's shop and its two competitors, and a copy went to every parish and guildhall in the dominion, with the charter guarantees marked in red ink at the edge. The same sheet carried the news of Mont d'Or's new garrison and the reopening of the southern road, so that the peace

arrived in every village already attached to the practical blessings of bread, tolls, and safety.

"Paris will call it propaganda," Foulques said, watching the bundles go out with the couriers.

"Paris has been calling things propaganda since the first stone was carved. We'll call it literacy, and let the difference show in the tax receipts." She watched the square below, where the townspeople were drifting toward the taverns in the holiday mood she had declared at the treasury's expense. "Also note the homage. I'll perform it myself, in Paris, when the child is born and the roads are safe. A duchess who bows once in public and keeps every gate in private has the better end of the bargain."

Thiébaut, beside her with the sling gone and the arm still stiff, said, "I'll come with you. Someone has to keep the king's courtiers from quoting the wrong precedents at you."

"Then it's a progress. Put it in the calendar for the autumn. First the lying-in, then the homage, then the next emergency, in the usual order."

And the child, oblivious to treaties and attainders, grew and waited in its own time, while the snows retreated up the hills and the river opened and the first barges of the peacetime trade came up the Ortelle with their holds full of everything that was not war.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Peace

Peace, Jeanne discovered, was a war with different ledgers and the same hours.

The armies went home, and the work that remained was the work no ballad celebrated: roofs and roads and the long repair of everything the war had eaten. The treasury's peacetime accounts came to her table in the same hand as the wartime ones, and the columns were even more unforgiving, because there was no longer an emergency to excuse them. Ninety-four thousand écus to the Venetian house and its partners, the annuities running out six years ahead, the war taxes voted for three more, and against them the reopened river trade, the Sainterre customs rising month by month, the Grisay iron flowing again to the forges and the foundries. Dolfin, reviewing the first peacetime quarter with her over spiced wine, pronounced the patient in excellent health for a patient who had technically been at death's door two winters running, and raised no objection when she redeemed the first of the pledged revenues at par, as the contract allowed.

"You're the only client I have who reads the redemption clauses," he said.

"I'm the only client you have who was raised by clerks. The others were raised by tutors."

She made the spring circuit herself, as soon as the roads would carry the wagons, heavy with the child and tired by every afternoon, and the journey became a second, slower kind of campaign. At Mont d'Or she inspected the new angle bastions and the battery on the west spur, the work that had killed Hautemer and learned his lessons afterward, and Rostaing paraded the garrison for her with the clerk's efficiency she had once punished him for lacking, and said nothing at all about the old days except, when she asked, that the men's boots were good and the well was full. At the rebuilt villages of the southeastern marches she sat in new cottages and ate the bread of women whose names were in the pension books, and at Sainte-Florence she opened the hospital of twenty beds and saw the looms running again, four hundred of them, with the twelve-year-old's name carved over the gate beside the charter's date.

Sainterre was the great stop. The city had rebuilt the eastern quarter wider than before, with straight streets and a proper water conduit the aldermen had voted themselves, and the cloth hall stood whole again with its glass replaced. The new council, elected under the charter's law without a riot or a disputed return, met her in the guild regalia, and Coppens, old and greyer but unbowed, presented the city's first peacetime budget in a

speech of such length that even the aldermen began to look at their shoes. The charter was re-sealed in the square where de Key's broadsheets had once blown about, with the Treaty of Heurtois's recognition clause read aloud beside it, so that every person there could hear the king of France himself enrolled among the guarantors of their liberties.

"Ten years from now," Coppens said, walking her through the rebuilt weavers' quarter, "they'll say the charter came down from some old duke in grandfather's time. No one will remember the siege."

"They'll remember the bread price stayed fixed. That's the part that matters." She stopped at the corner where the first stone had struck. "Keep the news sheet going. Cities that read their own accounts don't lose them."

Verhoeven's press, she noted, had sprouted two competitors, and the licensing court was busy, and she counted that a victory too.

* * *

Back at the Haut-Tertre, the last weeks of the pregnancy became the court's whole occupation, whether she permitted it or not. Oriabel had the lying-in chamber ready by Easter, with the tapestries chosen to calm the mind and the midwife installed in the palace like a visiting

general. Lisette ran the intelligence service from a stool beside the bed. Claire came with swaddling cloths and the hard-won knowledge of women who had lost a child, and Sister Margriet traveled from Sainterre at the duchess's own expense and took command of everything medical with a serenity that reduced the court physicians to fetching water.

Thiébaut, who had faced gascons and bombards with perfect composure, was frankly useless and knew it, and spent the time in a flurry of displaced energy: inspecting every guard rotation twice, drafting pointless memoranda on the Lorraine roads, and once, caught in the corridor by Lisette, asking whether the baby would know him if he spent too much of the year at Nancy.

"She'll know your step," Lisette said, "if you'll stop wearing out the floor. Sit down."

The labor began at dusk on the twenty-eighth of April, in a thunderstorm, which everyone over thirty remembered was the weather that attended the great events of the duchess's life, and the midwife and Sister Margriet closed the chamber doors and the court settled in for the ancient, powerless vigil of men in corridors. It was long, and hard, and the child came near dawn, and the cry that went up from the chamber was answered by the bells of the cathedral and then the bells of the lower town, tower after tower, rolling across

the river the way the mourning bells had rolled two years before, in a different key.

It was a girl. Strong, red, furious, with a fine fuzz of dark hair and lungs of remarkable authority. Sister Margriet laid her on Jeanne's chest in the first quiet, and Jeanne looked down at the small, furious stranger and thought, with the clarity of exhaustion: this is what all the ledgers were for.

"Her name," she said, when they brought Thiébaut in, white-faced and trying not to show it, "is Aveline. For my mother. The rest of her names can be settled by the heralds, but the first one is mine."

He sat on the edge of the bed with the care of a man handling ordinance, and looked at his daughter the way he looked at a new gun: with awe, arithmetic, and a private terror. "She has your temper."

"She has nothing yet but opinions. That will be called the ducal temperament." Jeanne shifted against the pillows. "The succession is secure in the female line, the charter law covers it, and the treaty's reversion clauses name her inheritance. I had Foulques check everything twice. She will inherit everything, in her own right, and no one will ever call her a ward."

"No wardships. No locked rooms." He said it like a vow, which it was, the vow they had made in the cloth hall at Sainterre. "I remember."

* * *

She was up too soon, of course; the court said so, the midwife said so, even Thiébaut said so, and she ignored all of them in the measured way she ignored advice she had already discounted, and on the tenth day she had the green case brought to her father's old chamber, with Foulques and Thiébaut and the fire.

The chancellor, thin and careful and restored to his papers, had carried the case like a reliquary. "The sealed full account is in the private archive, madame, as you ordered. These are the originals: the renunciation, the convent order, the threats. What would you have done with them?"

"Open the case. Leave us."

He left, and she sat with Thiébaut by the open window where the spring air came in off the river, and she went through the documents one last time, the handwriting of two dead men and a living one, the machinery of a girl's imprisonment. The renunciation she read in full, the words she had carried like knives for seven years, and they looked different now on the parchment: young, fierce, driven into the paper by a hand that had been shaking.

"He wept signing this. Foulques told me, and I didn't believe it for a long time. I believe it now."

"He did." Thiébaut's voice was quiet. "I have never not believed it, which was the particular difficulty."

She fed the renunciation to the fire first, and then the convent order with its blank date, and then the list of threats, and the three documents curled and blackened and lifted up the chimney in fragments of ash and light. The copies stayed in the archive, because the state needed its memory; the originals, the instruments themselves, she burned, because the people did not.

"Foulques's account remains sealed," she said. "For the historians. I won't have my father remembered as a villain in a pamphlet, and I won't have you remembered as a villain at all. The whole truth, with all its names, for whoever governs after us. The instruments, never again."

He watched the last of the paper go. "And the girl? The fifteen-year-old. What becomes of her?"

"She becomes me. That was always the only possible outcome. She just didn't know it yet." Jeanne closed the empty green case and set it aside. "I thought for years that love was the thing that made you weak, because the first time I felt it, it was used against me. I've had to learn it's the

other way. The weak thing was the silence. Not the loving."

It was the closest she had ever come to the word, and he heard it as the word it was, and did not press for more, because he had learned her grammar in the two years of war. He put his hand over hers where it lay on the table, and they sat like that while the fire ate the past and the town went about its morning below the walls.

* * *

She went down to the cathedral vault on a soft May morning, with Aveline carried by Lisette behind her and Thiébaut at her side, and stood between the two sarcophagi, her mother's small one and her father's great one, and had the conversation she had been preparing for two years.

"I used to think you were the standard." She spoke low, in the way one speaks to the dead, who have all the time in the world. "Everything measured against the high chair and the ledgers. I've kept the ledgers. I've even kept the chair. But I've changed what gets written in them. You recorded victories. I record names. You built a duchy out of marriages and debts and the careful ruin of your neighbors. I've built one out of charters and banks and the city voting its own

taxes. I don't know yet which one lasts longer. I know which one I'd rather be ruled by."

The vault was quiet. Somewhere above, a bell began, and the sound came down through the stone like water.

"You were wrong about him. I want that on the record, even though the record here is just me. He was the best instrument you ever bought and you never knew it, because you thought people were the same as castles, things to be taken and held. He wasn't. Neither was I. The convent order is ash now. I burned it myself. You can keep whatever you think of that; you're dead, and the living get the last word, which is the one rule even you couldn't get around."

Thiébaut said nothing, and Lisette said nothing, and the baby made a small, speculative noise, and Jeanne put out her hand and touched the cold carved face of the sarcophagus the way she had touched the ransomed hand in the first week of the reign.

"Thank you for the Latin and the siege manuals. I'll see that Aveline gets them too, and a great many other things you never thought to teach a girl. Rest. The duchy is in better order than you left it, and that's the only elegy you ever wanted."

They climbed the stairs into the May light, and she did not look back, and the vault door was

closed behind her with the sound of a long account finally settled.

* * *

The summer settled into the rhythm of a reign that had survived its founding crisis and was becoming, by slow degrees, ordinary. The council met at the old hours. Foulques's chancellery turned the emergency machinery into standing law. The news sheet came out every week from three licensed presses. The orphans' school for girls, named for the late duchess, enrolled its second forty, and the bishop's objections were met with the published examination results and faded of their own accord. The Guild of Saint Margaret drilled on Sundays after church, and small girls in three cities announced their intention to grow up to carry crossbows, and were generally indulged.

She visited the orphans' school in June, with Aveline carried before her on a cushion and the whole court in train, because Foulques had asked her to examine the girls in person and publish the results, and she had learned long since that her chancellor's requests were usually commands wearing a veil.

The school occupied the old pilgrim hospital by the eastern gate, a long, light building that smelled of chalk and wax and the herbs the sisters strewed against fever, and forty girls rose when she

entered, in their plain wool gowns, daughters of dead soldiers and burned villages and the siege of Sainterre, curtsying with the precise gravity of people who understood exactly what the place had cost. The eldest, a sharp-featured child of thirteen whose father had died on the wall, read a passage of Cicero and then translated it into the vernacular without stumbling, and a girl of ten did sums on the slate board that would have shamed half the treasury clerks, and Foulques, thin and upright at the mistress's side, wore the face of a man watching a long investment mature.

"They're better at the Latin than the boys' school," Jeanne said to him afterwards, in the garden where the children could not hear.

"They're better at everything, because no one ever told them they were allowed to be bad at it." The chancellor folded his hands. "Madame, I have a request of a different kind. I am sixty-three years old, and the heart has its own calendar. I should like, while I can still teach, to spend two days a week here myself. The chancellery can spare me; Colard is ready, and the archives are in order. Let me be the one who teaches them the law. A girl who knows the law is a girl no man can decide things for, in the words you used when you sentenced me."

"You remembered."

"I remember everything. It is my affliction and my trade."

She looked across the garden at the children at their games, the noise of them rising in the June air, and thought of the convent order with the blank date that had once waited for a girl of fifteen. "Two days. And the school gets a new wing, in the name of the chancellor, since you won't permit it in mine. That's a ducal command; don't argue, I've seen what your arguments cost."

He bowed, and for the first time in her memory the bow was not a courtier's instrument but a man's.

Dolfin went back to Venice for the first time in years and left a factor in his place, with a letter for her that said, in essence, that he had made more money and had more interesting conversations in her dominion than anywhere in his professional life, and that his house's credit would remain open against all reasonable and most unreasonable events. Jean the Bastard, healed of everything except his opinions, went home to Lorraine to keep its roads, and wrote long, scandalous letters that arrived by every post and were read aloud at supper to the court's delight. Claire de Sombernon recovered her manor in the final peace and ran it from a distance with the ferocity of a woman who had decided never to be a refugee twice. Perrin got his spurs at a ceremony in the courtyard, very

pale and very proud, and was attached to the duchess's own household, where his competence with cups became a byword.

And the two of them, the duchess and the duke, settled the architecture of a marriage that had begun as a treaty and become, through the ordinary chemistry of shared danger and kept promises, something the court had no documents for. He spent his seasons between Nancy and the Haut-Tertre, and the roads between the two capitals grew safe and busy and rich, and wherever he was, the letters went back and forth, the state ones in the clerks' hands and the private ones in their own, and the private ones grew longer and less guarded and, in places, foolish, which was perhaps the surest sign.

She kept the connecting door open always now. The key hung on its chain in the jewel casket, a museum piece she showed Aveline once when the girl was old enough to ask what keys were for, and explained, in the simplified version mothers use, that some doors exist to be found open.

The child ruled the nursery with the same absolute opinions she had displayed at birth, and the palace adjusted itself around her the way it had once adjusted around the war. Jeanne nursed her for three months, against the court's advice and with Sister Margriet's backing, and sat through the audiences of that season with her

daughter at her breast and the envoys carefully studying the tapestries, and no one ever quite found the protocol to object. Thiébaut, home from a summer on the Lorraine roads, walked the floor with the baby at the colicky hour and sang her the old Aubecourt songs, the ones from the gallery and the frozen canal, badly and without shame, and Jeanne, pretending to read in the next room, learned them again through his voice.

"She knows you," Lisette said, watching the small fist close around his finger. "They always know the voice that was there in the dark."

"She knows the accounts better already. She screams whenever Colard visits." Jeanne set the letter down. "What she will need, when she's older, is everything we weren't given. Truths delivered on time. A mother who doesn't keep a casket of unsent letters. A father who has never once renounced her in a hall."

Thiébaut looked up from the baby's face, and the old thing passed between them, the memory that no longer wounded but had not vanished, and would never quite vanish, which was correct; wounds that healed without a mark had taught nothing. "She'll have it," he said. "We wrote the charter for a city. We can keep one for a daughter."

They had Aveline christened in the cathedral on a bright July day, with Brive as her godfather and

Claire as her godmother and the whole court in its best, and Coppens came up from Sainterre with a gift of the first cloth woven in the rebuilt eastern quarter, and the bells that had announced her birth rang again, and the lower town got a holiday and a double ration and a story it would tell for a generation: the duchess's daughter, born in a peace her mother had built invoice by invoice.

* * *

The court dined together that evening, the whole strange household the war had made, and Jeanne sat at the high table with her daughter asleep against her shoulder and watched them all the way she watched the ledgers, counting what had survived.

Bride, older and greyer and back on a horse against every physician, was telling the young officers the story of the ford probe for the dozenth time, improving the French numbers as was his right. Jean, stiff-shouldered and incorrigible, had the far end of the table in tears over the Harchies bandits and the brandy-smuggling days. Claire and Oriabel ran the household between them with the smooth ferocity of women who had discovered they agreed about everything that mattered. Perrin, spurred and solemn, sat his first high-table place and blushed when the company drank his health for the cup of wine. Foulques ate little and watched the orphans' school accounts under the

table, because he could not help it. Verhoeven's papers, Dolfin's factors, Rostaing's dispatches from the southern rock, Coppens's interminable letters, the Guild of Saint Margaret's Sunday drills: the invoices of a reign.

Thiébaut leaned close enough that only she heard. "What's the ledger showing?"

"That the most expensive thing in the world is other people, and the only thing that holds a country together." She shifted the sleeping child against her shoulder. "I began with eleven riders in a wet courtyard. I thought rule was a high chair and a seal."

"It isn't?"

"It's a table with room enough for everyone you can't afford to lose." She looked at him, at the grey at his temple and the stiff left arm and the hazel eyes that had watched her from a gatehouse window two years before. "Keep your chair close to mine. That's a standing order."

"It has been since the wedding. You just didn't know you'd issued it."

The hall went on with its noise, and the baby slept through all of it, and outside the summer dusk came down over the river and the walls and the long, repaired, imperfect, peaceful country she had been given in a cart and meant to hand on in a charter.

* * *

On the last night of September, she sat late at the table in her father's chamber, the same table at which she had planned the funeral and the marriage and the war in the first black week of the reign. The ledgers were open, the day's dispatches answered, the child asleep in the next room with Lisette outside the door, and through the open window the autumn air came in off the river, and the bells marked the hour in their long, patient conversation.

She was writing the year's summary, the private one in the hand no clerk copied, and the page was full: the peace, the debt and its redemption schedule, the charters and the schools, the garrisons and the roads, the names of the dead in their book, the names of the living in their offices, the whole complicated estate of a small rich country that had refused to be anyone's easy meal. The fire burned low. The candles stood at their marks.

The door opened without ceremony, and Thiébaut came in from the council side, in his shirtsleeves, with a cup of wine for her and the shoulder held in the slight stiff way it kept in cold weather, and he set the cup down and drew the second chair close to the table, as he had done a hundred times, and reached for the second quill.

"The Mont d'Or returns?" he asked. "I have the figures from Rostaing in my pocket."

"Under the stoneworks line. And don't tell me your shoulder is fine; I can see how you're holding it. Sister Margriet left a liniment; use it or I'll have her write you a lecture."

"Yes, madame." He dipped the quill, and for a while there was nothing in the room but the sound of two pens on the paper and the river outside and the bells, and the long, unremarkable happiness of a government that did not need to raise its voice.

Once, near the end of the second page, she paused and looked up, and found him looking at her, the hazel eyes greenish in the candlelight, the same eyes from the solar and the great hall and a hundred battlefields of paper and powder, and he said, "What is it?"

"Nothing. I was remembering the first night. The gate bell, and the eleven riders, and the new ledger. I thought it was the beginning of a siege."

"It was." He bent back to the page. "This one just has better terms."

She laughed, low, and turned to the book again, and wrote the last entry of the day in her own hand, and below it, in the margin where only the two of them ever looked, she drew the small joined mark they had begun using for the things that belonged to neither ledger alone: the two arms,

Vauréal and Lorraine, intertwined. Then she sanded the page and closed the cover, and the two quills went back into the same cup, and they sat a while longer over the cooling wine, not speaking, while the fire settled and the bells of the peacetime city struck the hour across the dark, slow river.